

Missional Leadership, Mimetic Desire, and a Theology of the Powers

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Abstract

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All ecclesial leadership involves the exercise of power. Theologically speaking, this power can be used legitimately by following Christ’s example of holy love, or illegitimately by following the world’s example of selfish ambition. This thesis seeks to address the ‘fall’ of church leaders to such illegitimate use of power through domineering forms of leadership. The problem of domineering leadership has come to light through the failure and investigation of high profile leaders in recent years. Commentators have identified common characteristics of ‘fallen’ leaders to include pride, manipulation, status-seeking, and kingdom building. When leaders succumb to domineering leadership, people get hurt, Christ is misrepresented, and the witness of the church is damaged. This problem is exaggerated when it comes to missional leadership, which purports to be concerned about visible witness to the kingdom of God. This study seeks to provide a theological diagnosis of fallenness in church leadership, and insight for missional leaders facing these temptations.

The need for missional leaders to be models that people can imitate, and the centrality of being creatures of desire, are themes that have been raised in the missional conversation, but not linked to the Powers. The biblical theme of mission and the Powers (Satan, the demonic, and principalities) has also been raised. This, however, remains largely underdeveloped, especially regarding challenges unique to missional leaders. Linking these themes holds promise for cultivating healthy leaders and life-forming discipleship for mission.

Various missional thinkers draw from Walter Wink’s theology of the Powers. Wink calls the collective work of the Powers the “Domination System”, and when leaders mimic the Powers, not only do they become domineering leaders, they open the church to the demonic. Wink draws on the significance of René Girard, as he is the preeminent scholar on imitation and desire. Girard links imitation and desire to the Powers. Combining their theoretical approaches creates a new way to think through the connection between missional leadership, imitation and desire, and the Powers for the sake of mission. This thesis will address the question: How might a theology of the Powers help missional leaders to practice a spirituality which reshapes their desires for the sake of discipleship, community, and mission?

Drawing on the work of Wink and Girard, this thesis develops an imitation-based conceptual framework that demonstrates how *imitation* and *desire* link missional leaders to the Powers, resulting in patterns of domination. It will be demonstrated that leaders ‘fall’ when they knowingly or unknowingly mimic the Powers due to malformed desire, which leads to unfaithfulness, wreaks havoc in the church, and a dearth of witness. Redeemed leadership is imitating Christ, through which the leader’s desires are reshaped, and the ministry is transformed, through a process of positive mimesis, healthy discipleship, a flourishing church, and a life-giving witness. There is no neutral ground, for *not* to imitate Christ is to imitate the Powers. Missional leadership is ultimately about being an example worth imitating.

Declaration

No portion of the work referred to in this thesis has been submitted in support of an application for another degree or qualification of this or any other university or other institute of learning.

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Dedication

To the V3 Church Planting Movement

Introduction

This thesis seeks to link the ‘fall’ of church leaders to patterns of domination. The temptation to dominate can vary in intensity, and the spectrum of responses range from begrudgingly living under the leader to the removal of the leader. In all such cases, the witness of the church is damaged as people get hurt and Christ is misrepresented. The list of ‘fallen’ pastors looms large and the reasons for such disqualification, from sexual scandals to financial impropriety, continue to grow. Recently, there have been several pastors ‘falling’ from a sense of self-importance and building their ‘own’ kingdom, which are linked to a domineering spirit. Looking at some recent public ‘falls’ of significant leaders in the US, in which they either resigned or were removed from their role, will highlight the problem.

Context of Study

C.J. Mahaney, President of Sovereign Grace Ministries, took a leave of absence in July of 2011 when former colleagues in his ministry charged him with ‘expressions of pride, untreatability, deceit, sinful judgment, and hypocrisy.’¹ In April of 2013, he resigned from his role.

Mark Driscoll, founding pastor of Mars Hill (a megachurch in Seattle) and co-founder of the Acts 29 church planting network, was asked to leave the leadership of Acts 29 in August of 2014, and ‘forced’ to resign from Mars Hill in October of 2014. In his resignation letter, he confessed to ‘past pride, anger, and a domineering spirit.’² Admitting he paid a company, ResultSource, to purchase his book from enough key markets to get him on the *New York Times* best-seller list, speaks to his sense of self-importance.³

In April of 2016, Darrin Patrick, vice president of the Acts 29 church planting network and founding pastor of The Journey (a megachurch in St. Louis), was fired for

¹ Bobby Ross Jr, “Why Pastors Step Down,” *ChristianityToday.Com*, accessed November 21, 2019, <https://www.christianitytoday.com/ct/2011/julyweb-only/sexmoneypride.html>.

² Sarah Pulliam Bailey, “Exclusive: Mark Driscoll’s Resignation Letter to Mars Hill Church,” *Religion News Service*, October 15, 2014, accessed June 20, 2019, <https://religionnews.com/2014/10/15/exclusive-mark-driscolls-resignation-letter-to-mars-hill-church/>.

³ Ken Walker, “Is Buying Your Way Onto the Bestseller List Wrong?,” *ChristianityToday.Com*, last modified 2015, accessed November 25, 2019, <https://www.christianitytoday.com/ct/2015/januaryfebruary/buying-best-sellers-resultsource.html>.

a historical pattern of sin, ‘including manipulation, domineering, lack of biblical community’, and ‘a history of building his identity through ministry and media platforms.’⁴

There are many others who could illustrate this point, but one of the most recent examples is Bill Hybels, who resigned from Willow Creek Community Church (WCCC) on April 10, 2018 amid allegations of sexual misconduct. His story is important for at least two reasons: first, he has hosted a prominent annual conference – the Willow Creek Leadership Summit – which has influenced leaders and pastors worldwide. Secondly, an independent report on his misconduct shows how domineering leadership may also include misconduct, and in some cases, sexual abuse.

The Independent Advisory Group issued a seventeen page report detailing their review process, observations, conclusions, and recommendations.⁵ The first observation stated, ‘Allegations were made in two areas, overlapping at times, sexually inappropriate words and actions in relationship with individuals; abuse of power and position.’⁶ Other relevant observations included ‘descriptions of Bill Hybels’ leadership role as reliant on power, celebrity, and position to implement his personal preferences and personnel management, are widespread.’⁷ His approach to leadership was described as ‘command and control,’ which ‘contributed to executive and leadership turnover.’⁸ ‘Board members expressed recurring difficulty in holding Bill Hybels accountable for his leadership and management style.’⁹ The conclusion of this independent report was that the allegations were credible and that ‘the credibility of the allegations is not based on any one accusation or accuser but on the collective testimony and context of allegations.’¹⁰

There are some common characteristics that this list of high profile ‘fallen’ leaders share: pride, manipulation, seeking status, using status to push an agenda, abuse of power and role, a push to ‘succeed’, and a sense of self-importance. Overall, they

⁴ Kate Shellnutt, “Darrin Patrick Removed from Acts 29 Megachurch for ‘Historical Pattern of Sin,’” *ChristianityToday.Com*, last modified 2016, accessed June 19, 2019, <https://www.christianitytoday.com/news/2016/april/darrin-patrick-removed-acts-29-megachurch-journey.html>.

⁵ Jo Anne Lyon et al., “Independent Advisory Group Report,” 2019, accessed November 11, 2019, <https://www.willowcreek.org/-/media/images/7-0-about/elders2019/iagreport-022819.pdf?la=en>.

⁶ *Ibid.*, 4.

⁷ *Ibid.*, 6.

⁸ *Ibid.*

⁹ *Ibid.*

¹⁰ *Ibid.*, 13.

displayed a domineering approach to leadership. These characteristics fit the three contours of leadership, developed through this thesis: identity, praxis, and *telos*. These terms were primarily developed by Alan Roxburgh.¹¹ Because they can be understood in different ways, it will be important to clarify them. Identity (being) refers to a sense of self and how it is established. Praxis (doing) deals with the practice of leadership as it takes place within the cycle of thought, action, and reflection. *Telos* (becoming) is indicative of the end goal of leadership, both for the leader's life and where they are leading the church. *Telos* signifies the 'true end'. These three contours of leadership have corresponding temptations of image (identity), institution (praxis) and ideology (*telos*), explained through the work of William Stringfellow in the final chapter. But for now, it is important to note that the praxis of the leader seems to be informed significantly by the leader's identity and *telos*.

The reason I am passionate about seeking preventative measures dealing with the problem of domineering leadership in the church is not just because these are heartbreaking stories, nor because I have seen how it damages the witness of the church in my own ministry contexts. Rather, I have felt the grip of power in my own life. Seeking people's applause is a temptation with which I continue to struggle. The passion for this research is borne, not simply to help other missional leaders, but also to be of help to myself.

When leaders 'fall' to domineering approaches, there is typically a flurry of articles that are written by teachers, counsellors, and practitioners, that speak to the reasons for leaders 'falling'.¹² Some reasons given relate to leaders' personal behaviour

¹¹ Alan Roxburgh uses identity and *telos* and work of the leader. Praxis was chosen instead of work. These terms are affirmed by others addressing the dearth of literature in regards to theological reflection on leadership. Alan Roxburgh and Fred Romanuk, *The Missional Leader: Equipping Your Church to Reach a Changing World* (San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2006); Michale Ayers, Ph.D., "Toward a Theology of Leadership," *Journal of Biblical Perspectives in Leadership* 1, no. 1 (Fall 2006): 3–27; Chloe Lynch, *Ecclesial Leadership as Friendship*, 1 edition. (New York: Routledge, 2019).

¹² Roger E. Olson, "Evangelical Superstars and Why They Fall," *Roger E. Olson*, August 30, 2014, accessed June 20, 2019, <https://www.patheos.com/blogs/rogereolson/2014/08/evangelical-superstars-and-why-they-fall/>; Dr. James Emery White, "The Pastoral Mess of 2016," *Crosswalk.Com*, accessed June 20, 2019, <https://www.crosswalk.com/blogs/dr-james-emery-white/the-pastoral-mess-of-2016.html>; Garret Kell, "A Pattern Among Fallen Pastors – Lessons for Us All," *Garrett Kell*, last modified February 20, 2015, accessed June 20, 2019, <http://garrettkell.com/pattern-among-fallen-pastors-lessons-us/>; Eddie Kaufholz, "The Mega-Problem Behind the 'Falls' of Megachurch Pastors," *Relevant Magazine*, October 5, 2016, accessed June 20, 2019, <https://relevantmagazine.com/current16/mega-problem-behind-falls-megachurch-pastors/>; Scott Sauls, "Thoughts on the Rise and Fall of Pastors," *Scott Sauls*, May 23, 2019, accessed June 20, 2019, <https://scottsauls.com/blog/2019/05/23/pastors/>.

and attitude around issues of identity: self-comparison, seeking acclaim, the cessation of a vibrant walk with the Lord, and thinking ‘this could never happen to me.’ Other reasons relate to an unbearable level of stress and pressure on leaders in their relationships with congregations. Scott Sauls writes,

I also think it’s easy to put pastors and other public figures on a pedestal, but when people do this, they turn pastors and public figures into objects instead of subjects, personas instead of persons, celebrities instead of neighbors, untouchable heroes instead of frail image-bearers that we are. This tends to widen the community gap between congregants and their pastors, which in turn isolates pastors significantly. This can be especially true in larger churches.¹³

Beyond articles, there are books that seek to address the problem of the ‘fallen’ leader. In *Pastors at Greater Risks*, L.B. London Jr and Dr Neil B. Wiseman ask pastors to recognize there is a crisis in progress, and offer practical suggestions for attending to their marriage and family life, understanding how to recover from stress and burnout, finding freedom from sexual addiction, and pursuing the practice of personal holiness.¹⁴

Michael Todd Wilson and Brad Hoffman, along with the CareGivers Network, have spent thirty years working to care for ‘fallen’ and hurting pastors, missionaries, and other paid Christian workers. Through collaborative wisdom, they identified three distinct themes of concern for leaders: who the leader is, what the leader values, and how the leader relates. In who the leader is, they addressed the lack of genuine intimacy in relationship with God, spouse, and others, as well as a distorted sense of calling. Building on this foundation, the next level examines what the leader values. Here they address inadequate stress management skills, lack of appropriate boundaries, and the failure to prioritize recreation. Finally, in the top layer, which is how leaders relate, they speak of insufficient people skills and underdeveloped leadership skills.¹⁵

In their report, they address the unique challenges of vocational ministry.¹⁶ Two stressors they highlight relate to the identity of the leader. First, when the congregation tends to put the leader on such a high pedestal, they are considered god-like, and no

¹³ Scott Sauls, “The Plight of the Falling Pastor,” *Christianity Today: Pastors*, accessed November 21, 2019, <https://www.christianitytoday.com/pastors/2016/june-web-exclusives/plight-of-falling-pastor.html>.

¹⁴ H. B. London Jr and Neil B. Wiseman, *Pastors at Greater Risk* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2003).

¹⁵ Michael Todd Wilson, Brad Hoffmann, and Members of Caregivers Forum, *Preventing Ministry Failure: A Shepherd Care Guide for Pastors, Ministers and Other Caregivers* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2007).

¹⁶ *Ibid.*, 16.

longer seen ‘as human beings with feet of clay....’¹⁷ Second, ministers with a personal sense of inadequacy often ‘put on an air of confidence,’ presenting a ‘perfect’ public image.¹⁸ Therefore the identity of the leader, ‘who the leader is,’ is foundational in strategies to prevent abuse.¹⁹ Their study suggests that the symptoms found in high profile leaders are not unique to their levels of influence but seem to be common struggles for leaders at many levels of influence.

The advice given by way of diagnosis and remedy is extremely helpful, as it generally speaks to having a healthier psychology, relationality, and spirituality. However, it is the tip of the iceberg. This thesis seeks a more comprehensive explanation from a missiological perspective. Missional theology begins with the metanarrative of scripture that moves from creation through the fall, to new creation and the *Missio Dei*, which is the work of God in making all things new.²⁰ A critical but often overlooked part of that narrative is how the fall not only affected humanity, but social and cosmic realities as well.²¹ From the garden to Christ’s temptation in the desert, all the way to the beast and dragon in John’s revelation, there are Powers manifest through social realities that actively warp God’s intentions for the world. But the good news is that the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus represents the victory of God over the Powers.²² Understanding how this dynamic shapes the present and dictates the future is why some missiologists have sought to retrieve the biblical

¹⁷ Ibid., 17.

¹⁸ Ibid., 18.

¹⁹ Ibid., 26.

²⁰ Christopher J. H. Wright, *The Mission of God: Unlocking the Bible’s Grand Narrative* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2006).

²¹ Here are some works on the Powers from a distinctly missional point of view. Only the “Power and the Powers” has a chapter on leadership and the Powers. Tom McAlpine, *Facing the Powers: What Are the Options?* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Publishers, 2003); Andrew Hardy, Richard Whitehouse, and Dan Yarnell, *Power and the Powers: The Use and Abuse of Power in Its Missional Context* (Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2015); James V. Brownson et al., *StormFront: The Good News of God* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003); A. Scott Moreau et al., eds., *Deliver Us from Evil: An Uneasy Frontier in Christian Mission* (Monrovia, CA: World Vision International, 2002); Loren L. Johns and James R. Krabill, eds., *Even the Demons Submit: Continuing Jesus’ Ministry of Deliverance* (Scottsdale, PA: Institute of Mennonite Studies, 2006).

²² N. T. Wright, *Jesus and the Victory of God* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 1997); N. T. Wright, *Evil and the Justice of God*, 5/31/13 edition. (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2013); N. T. Wright, *The Day the Revolution Began: Reconsidering the Meaning of Jesus’s Crucifixion* (New York: HarperOne, 2018); Walter Brueggemann, *Truth Speaks to Power: The Countercultural Nature of Scripture* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2013).

language of the Powers in regards to joining God in the plan of redemption toward new creation.²³

This thesis picks up on these incipient arguments, and applies them to leadership, in both its fallen and redeemed states. ‘Fallen’ leadership occurs when leaders forsake the mission of God, in the way of Christ, through the Spirit, moving instead (knowingly or unknowingly) toward imitation of the Powers to achieve their agenda.

This thesis will first demonstrate a link between imitation and the Powers, to explain how leaders that uncritically imitate patterns of power seen in the fallen world, are liable to fall into patterns of domination. Secondly, it will be shown that ‘fallenness’ is driven by malformed desires, and that the shaping of missional desires should be at the heart of leadership formation. After the link between imitation and desire is made, it will be demonstrated that the primary way to reshape the desires of the leader is through imitating how Christ found his identity and telos in God and the mission of God. Finally, as leaders seek to imitate Christ and live their life in God, their desires become reshaped, becoming a positive model for imitation in the church.

When leaders ‘fall’ to a domineering leadership, it does not always lead to a resignation or removal from leadership. But this thesis will argue that domineering leadership leads to rivalry, chaos, and scapegoating in the congregation, and thus a poor witness to the world. Redeemed leadership is reflected in the Apostle Paul’s appeal to the Corinthians to ‘Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ’ (I Cor. 11:1). Thus, the central question this thesis seeks to address is: How might a theology of the Powers help missional leaders practice a spirituality which reshapes their desires for the sake of discipleship, community, and mission?

Method of Study

This thesis is guided by the need for a conceptual framework within missiology as a discipline of practical theology. The meaning of practical theology being adopted here is defined by John Swinton and Harriet Mowat as ‘critical, theological reflection on the practices of the Church as they interact with the practices of the world, with a view to ensuring and enabling faithful participation in God’s redemptive practices in, to, and

²³ Lesslie Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society* (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., 1989); Lois Barrett, “Missional Witness: The Church as Apostle to the World,” in *Missional Church: A Vision for the Sending of the Church in North America*, ed. Darrell L. Guder (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1998).

for the world.’²⁴ Theological reflection on practice lends itself to developing a conceptual framework which can address a practical problem.

Because domineering leadership damages the witness of the church, the goal of this thesis is to make a missiological contribution to the study of missional leadership, from the perspective of a theology of the Powers. Missiology as a methodology, described by Bruce Ashford and Scott Bridger, ‘is a theological discipline, that is undertaken in conversation with Scripture, church history, and the social sciences in consideration of its cultural context.’²⁵ Each of these areas are addressed in this thesis, with emphasis on scriptures and the social sciences relating the Powers in the cultural context of the Euro-tribal Western Church, in particular the North American church.²⁶

Ravitch and Riggan define a conceptual framework ‘as the overarching argument for the work [a thesis] – both why it is worth doing and how it should be done.’²⁷ For Ravitch and Riggan, a conceptual framework not only shapes the argument of the thesis, but provides a methodology for the construction of the thesis. In addition, this approach can ‘provide the researcher with theoretical frameworks to advance the argument beyond where previous researchers have taken it, or to introduce new questions, considerations, hypothesis, or explanations into the inquiry.’²⁸ The framework developed in this thesis will seek to accomplish this task.

This thesis seeks to advance a conceptual framework involving missional leadership, mimetic desire, and a theology of the Powers, with the purpose of shedding new light on the leadership crisis in the church. The hope is that this imitation-based conceptual framework might provide a guide for missional leaders that will enable them to identify specific ways in which the Powers seek to subvert their leadership. Thus, it will help leaders develop a missional spirituality that will ground their identity in God, reshape their telos toward God and his kingdom, and shape their practice of ministry for the good of the other.

²⁴ John Swinton and Harriet Mowatt, *Practical Theology and Qualitative Research* (London: SCM Press, 2006), 6.

²⁵ Bruce Ashford and Scott Bridger, “Missiological Method,” in *Missiology: An Introduction to the Foundations, History, and Strategies of World Missions*, Revised Edition. (B&H Academic, 2015), 16.

²⁶ Euro-tribal is a term developed by Roxburgh and Robinson. Alan J. Roxburgh and Martin Robinson, *Practices for the Refounding of God’s People* (New York: Church Publishing Inc., 2018), 6.

²⁷ Dr Sharon M. Ravitch and Dr J. Matthew Riggan, *Reason & Rigor: How Conceptual Frameworks Guide Research*, Second edition. (Los Angeles: SAGE Publications, Inc, 2016), 8.

²⁸ Ibid.

Developing this imitation-based framework will take a multi-disciplinary approach. Jeanne Stevenson-Moessner paints practical theology as an orchestra ‘of musicians in relationship’, which is different from a ‘soloist’ performance or a ‘guest musician’, because practical theology ‘plays in concert with other disciplines or areas of theology.’²⁹ Because practical theology can dialogue across a wide array of disciplines, from Biblical theology to cultural anthropology, from sociology to emergent science, from psychology to systematic theological reflection, the interlocutors chosen for this study have expertise that spans various fields.

The primary interlocutors will help this study develop into a symphony, as each of them are interdisciplinary themselves. Walter Wink is a New Testament scholar and activist apt in psychology, biblical studies, philosophy, and social ethics. His work on the theology of the Powers demonstrates that leaders will face personal, social, and cosmic temptations that seek to subvert the three contours of leadership, identity, praxis, and *telos*. René Girard is a literary critic, cultural anthropologist, and historian who writes in the fields of theology, mythology, sociology, and philosophy. His mimetic theory demonstrates the link between the Powers and imitation and desire (mimetic desire). Mimetic theory ties together the imitation-based conceptual framework of this thesis.

Argument, Scope, and Limitations of Study

This research addresses the ‘fall’ of leaders to patterns of domination in the church, seeking the root to the problem. As such, the thesis is both theological and missiological, since the life of the leader greatly shapes the formation and witness of the church. The approach taken is to examine the current missional church conversation and provide an imitation-based framework that can contribute to an alternative approach to leadership theory and practice. It is hoped that the fruit of such an approach may stimulate deeper self-reflection among leaders to avoid ‘fallenness’ and to adopt a spirituality that leads to redeemed missional leadership in the church. This will require the development of an imitation-based framework that invites leaders to a spirituality that shapes the three contours of leadership; a spirituality that grounds their identity (being) in the life of triune God, that orients their *telos* (becoming) toward the mission

²⁹ Jeanne Stevenson-Moessner, *Overture to Practical Theology: The Music of Religious Inquiry* (Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2016), 1–2.

of God and new creation, and that ultimately reshapes their praxis (doing) as they seek to imitate Christ in identity formation and telos.

The hypothesis this thesis seeks to confirm is that a robust theology of the Powers enables leaders to better imitate Christ, and resist the temptations common to fallen leadership. Thus, enabling leaders to participate in the life and mission of God through the power of the Holy Spirit, and develop a life worth imitating. The imitation-based framework includes three overlapping elements.



Figure 1. The Imitation-based Framework (Negative Mimesis – Fallen Leadership)

Missional leadership and a theology of the Powers represent the two circles on either end. They are linked through both imitation and desire, or what this thesis calls mimetic desire. Mimetic desire will be a term that Girard develops, and it means that desire is generated by imitating models. Desire is not self-generated but borrowed. Thus, before getting to Girard, imitation and desire will be used. The elements of this framework will emerge in chapter two, when examining Graham Houston's work on I Peter, where he addresses the problem of domineering leadership. Wink and Girard will strengthen the imitation-based framework by deepening and connecting the elements of the framework in chapters three and four. In the final chapter with the help of William Stringfellow, a synthesis of Wink and Girard will take place, through an examination of how the Powers seek to malform the desires of the leader, subverting the missional leader at the three contours of leadership: identity, praxis, and telos. As leaders begin to recognize the subversive ways of the Powers, they will better imitate Christ and develop a spirituality that reshapes their desires toward life in God and new creation. The organizing approach of the chapter order, as well as each chapter, involves the development of the imitation-based framework.

This thesis deals with both power (human power) and the *Powers* (Satan, the demonic, principalities and powers). The Powers as a catch-all term will be capitalized. When speaking to just one aspect of the Powers, such as the principalities and powers, or the demonic, or just the term ‘power’, capitalization will *not* be used.

This study remains focused on its imitation-based framework of missional leadership, mimetic desire, and the theology of the Powers. Yet each element of the framework could be a thesis on its own, so there has been intentionality to not get distracted from the primary argument. The primary interlocutors, Wink and Girard, write on a wide range of themes and topics. It is not the intention of this thesis to address themes of these authors that lay outside of its conceptual framework. Therefore, the imitation-based framework is not only a guide to its argument, but also helps to limit its focus.

In the final chapter, the imitation-based framework will develop an additional element that is implied throughout the thesis. While this thesis invests the majority of its space giving a deeper diagnosis to fallen leadership by exploring a theology of the Powers, it remains incomplete without hinting toward the remedy of redeemed leadership. Thus, one more key circle is needed to complete this imitation-based framework, as illustrated in figure 2. For this thesis will demonstrate that the imitation-framework, when turned on the Powers, points up to Jesus because of his victory over the Powers. He is the specific content of redeemed leadership.

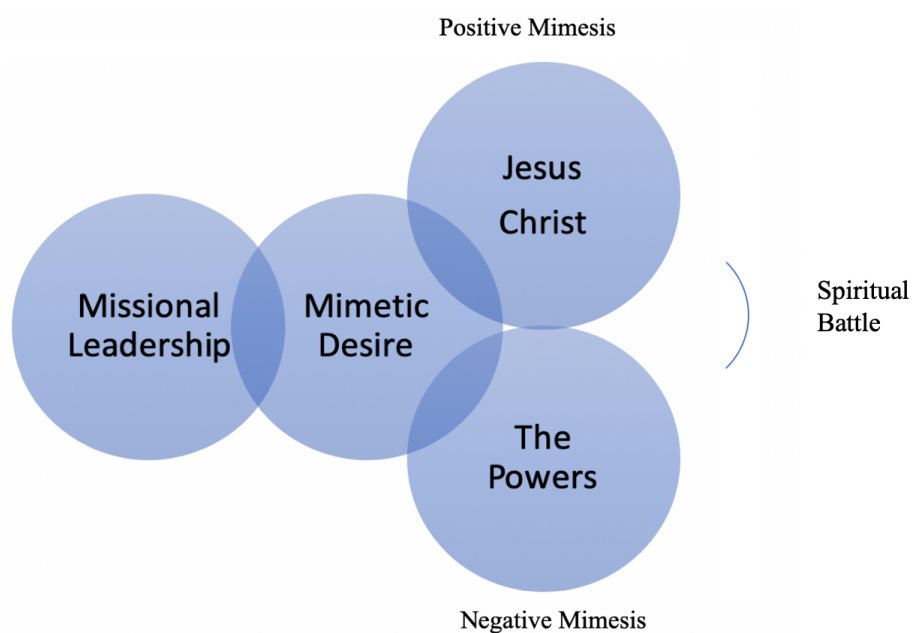


Figure 2. Imitation-based Framework (Positive Mimesis – Toward Redeemed Leadership)

Ultimately, missional leaders are captive to imitation. In the final chapter, this thesis will clarify and sum up the argument making the case that not to imitate Christ, is to imitate the Powers. The spiritual battle is for the heart, soul, and desires of the missional leader.

Outline of Study

Chapter 1 – The Challenge of Missional Leadership

Chapter one establishes the first part of the imitation-based framework (figure 1), the missional leader. Craig Van Gelder defines the term “missional” and Alan Roxburgh develops the concept of missional leadership. Following this, exploring significant themes in missional leadership by bringing other authors into conversation with Van Gelder and Roxburgh reveals not only the need for missional leaders, but a need to address missional leadership with regard to imitation, desire, and the Powers.

Chapter 2 – The Subversion of Leadership

Chapter two examines Graham Houston’s book, *Leading by Example*, where he explores the narrative of I Peter through the lens of domineering leadership in Peter’s day. Through analysis the key elements of the imitation-based framework emerge – leadership, imitation and desire (mimetic desire), and a theology of the Powers. Evaluation demonstrates the need to bring in Walter Wink and René Girard. They develop and strengthen this imitation-based framework (figure 1).

Chapter 3 – Leadership and the Powers

Chapter three strengthens the theology of the Powers. First, Wink’s life and theology of the Powers are explored. An analysis is conducted of his worldview and ground rules, his understanding of the ‘principalities and powers’ in Paul, as well as the nature of the Powers. Finally, this chapter evaluates Wink’s theology of the Powers, demonstrating how it strengthens the links between leadership, imitation and desire (mimetic desire), and the theology of the Powers (figure 1).

Chapter 4 – Leadership and Imitation

Chapter four strengthens the imitation and desire elements of the framework by exploring the nature of mimetic desire. First, this chapter examines the life of Girard and mimetic theory. Then an analysis of mimetic theory regarding missional leadership

is conducted, including a defence of Girard, mimetic desire and the Powers in James, and positive mimesis. Finally, evaluation demonstrates how Girard's theory strengthens and develops the links between missional leadership, mimetic desire, and the Powers (figure 1).

Chapter 5 – Missional Leadership Worthy of Imitation

Chapter five synthesizes Wink and Girard regarding the imitation-based framework with new contributions by Stringfellow. This chapter demonstrates how the Powers of image, institution, and ideology tempt the leader at the three contours of leadership – identity, praxis, and telos – in an effort to malform the desires of the leader, which can lead to domineering leadership and a crisis in the congregation. Suggestions of a catechism for the development of leaders are made, so that missional leaders might engage in positive mimesis by imitating Christ through the Spirit, reshaping the desires of the leader for the sake of discipleship, community, and mission (figure 2).

Conclusion

The conclusion provides a summary of the study, where the purpose, methodology, and argument are reviewed. The significance of the study details the unique contributions this thesis makes. This is followed by recommendations for further study and final remarks.

Chapter 1

The Challenge of Missional Leadership

Domineering leadership in the church is not a current problem, it is a historical problem. Missional theology, in part, has sought to deal with the colonialist and triumphalist approach to mission.³⁰ While missional theology has been helpful, it remains incomplete. To address the problem of domineering leadership, this thesis will argue there is a need to consider a more robust theology of the Powers, seeking a deeper diagnosis of the problem to help missional leaders be alert to how the Powers seek to subvert their leadership.

The goal of this chapter is to probe the first part of this imitation-based framework, the missional leader. This will be done by examining Craig Van Gelder's understanding of the development of the term 'missional' and Alan Roxburgh's understanding of missional leadership. This will be followed by exploring important themes which surface, bringing other voices into the conversation. Finally, a summary of the argument will highlight how this chapter contributes to the development of the imitation-based framework.

Examining missional leadership could be approached in a variety of ways. One way would be to conduct a wide literature review seeking to synthesize the work of those representing the primary missional streams that David Fitch has identified: The Missional Network (TMN), which descends from the Gospel and Our Culture Network (GONC); the Missional Evangelicals; and the neo-Anabaptist Missional (NAM).³¹ Another approach would be to conduct a deep literature review, focusing intently on texts that are both seminal and analytical in nature. This latter method of pursuing a deep review, is preferable for the work of this thesis, for as the missional leadership conversation has developed and new books are released, they tend to elaborate and expand on the themes developed in the seminal work of *Missional Church* (edited by Darrell Guder), which remains a highly influential academic work in missional

³⁰ David E. Fitch, "The Other Missional Conversation: Making Way for the Neo-Anabaptist Contribution to the Missional Movement in North America," *Missiology* 44, no. 4 (October 1, 2016): 467–468.

³¹ Ibid., 467. Fitch considers Craig Van Gelder and Alan Roxburgh to be key representatives of The Missional Network, Alan Hirsch and Michael Frost to be key representatives on the Missional Evangelicals, and himself, Shane Claiborne and Jonathan Wilson-Hartgrove to fit within the neo-Anabaptist Missional, working from the theology of Stuart Murray, Bryan Stone, Stanley Hauerwas, and John Howard Yoder.

theology, as demonstrated by its significant sales and the amount of references and critiques the work inspires.³²

Considering this, the primary interlocutors chosen for this chapter are Van Gelder and Roxburgh, both of whom contributed to *Missional Church*. Van Gelder was chosen because he critically engages *Missional Church*, with the help of Dwight J. Zscheile, in their book, *The Missional Church in Perspective: Mapping Trends and Shaping the Conversation*. This critical engagement not only maps out the evolution of the missional conversation since *Missional Church*, but it also seeks to expand the conversation in ways that intersect with the scope of this thesis. Roxburgh was chosen as he was the primary author of the chapter “Missional Leadership” in the book *Missional Church*, as well as the co-author of other missional books, including *The Missional Leader* with Fred Romanuk.³³ As noted by Fitch, both Van Gelder and Roxburgh are not only part of the original six researchers for *Missional Church*, but through their prolific writing and consulting work with churches and denominations, they have significantly shaped the missional conversation across North America.³⁴

The Nature of Missional Leadership

While one should not overlook the value and contribution of medieval monastic orders, led by the likes of St. Patrick (432 CE) and St. Francis (1209 CE), who kept faithful to mission, for many who lived under Christendom, missiology and ecclesiology were bifurcated and ecclesial leadership was reduced to maintenance mode.³⁵ Darrel Guder defines Christendom as a ‘system of church-state partnership and cultural hegemony in which the Christian religion was the protected and privileged religion of society and the church its legally established institutional form.’³⁶ In addition leadership being reduced to maintenance mode in the midst of Christendom, the melding of the church with the state in Northern Europe opened the church to forces which malformed ecclesial leadership. What will be argued in this chapter is that in the current context, where

³² Craig Van Gelder and Dwight J. Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective: Mapping Trends and Shaping the Conversation* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2011), 2.

³³ Roxburgh and Romanuk, *The Missional Leader*.

³⁴ Fitch, “The Other Missional Conversation,” 467.

³⁵ For faithful monastic orders see: George G. Hunter III, *The Celtic Way of Evangelism: How Christianity Can Reach the West...AGAIN* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2000). Joshua J. Mark, “Monastic Orders of the Middle Ages,” *Ancient History Encyclopedia*, June 24, 2019, accessed July 29, 2020, <https://www.ancient.eu/article/1407/monastic-orders-of-the-middle-ages/>.

³⁶ Daniel L. Guder, ed., *Missional Church: A Vision for the Sending of the Church in North America* (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing, 1998), 6.

missiology and ecclesiology are fused back together, missional leadership is a necessity. It will also be argued that missional leaders not only need a missional theology that informs their practice, but they need a missional spirituality that forms them to be more like Christ, attuned to how the Powers seek to misshape the contours of leadership – identity, praxis, and telos.

In 2010 Roxburgh said, ‘The word “missional” seems to have traveled the remarkable path of going from obscurity to banality in only one decade.’ Van Gelder argues that one of the reasons ‘missional’ has made this journey is because many people use ‘missional’ without a historical understanding of the term. It will be unnecessary to give the historical development of the term as Van Gelder and others have done this sufficiently.³⁷ But, it will be important to briefly review the theological developments that have taken place, by examining Van Gelder’s understanding of the development of the missional church.

The Misshaping of Leadership in the Church

Van Gelder describes how Christians have inherited a church that dichotomized the categories of ‘ecclesiology’ and ‘missiology’. As Van Gelder puts it, ‘Within a Christendom worldview, the church and the world occupied the same location: the social reality of the church represented the same social reality of the world within a particular context.’³⁸ Therefore, mission was something done in other countries. It was assumed there was no need for mission in the West; mission happened elsewhere. As Van Gelder writes, ‘The developments that gave birth to the modern missions movement unfortunately led to the conception of the church and mission as two distinct entities. This dichotomy was fully established within the institutional and organizational life of Protestant Christianity at the beginning of the twentieth century.’³⁹ Michael Goheen’s description of this bifurcation helps to clarify the nature of the problem and the need to reframe the church and leadership:

- Mission and church are separated. There are two different and parallel institutional bodies: groups committed to the missionary enterprise and local congregations who support it.

³⁷ David J. Bosch, *Transforming Mission: Paradigm Shifts in Theology of Mission* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2011); Stephen B. Bevans and Roger P. Schroeder, *Constants in Context: A Theology of Mission for Today* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2004); Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*; Vinay Samuel and Chris Sugden, *Mission as Transformation: A Theology of the Whole Gospel* (Oxford: Regnum Books, 1999).

³⁸ Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*, 19.

³⁹ *Ibid.*, 22.

- This leads to churches without mission and missionary organizations that are not churches. Churches are reduced to their pastoral role and become introverted. Mission organizations carry on their work outside of ecclesial structures.
- The world is divided into the Christian West (home base) and the non-Christian non-West (mission field).
- There is no need for mission in the West. The West is already Christian and therefore only evangelism of individuals is needed. The critical or prophetic challenge to culture is eclipsed by a Christendom mindset and ecclesiology where the church is seen as the broader Christian culture.⁴⁰

Ecclesial leadership has been significantly shaped by the dichotomisation of ecclesiology and missiology. Roxburgh writes, ‘History and culture affect our present understanding of church leadership, and in North America two movements in particular have dramatically informed our present understanding of such leadership rules. They are Christendom and modernity.’⁴¹

From Apostles to Priests

For Roxburgh, the first way that Christendom reshaped ecclesial leadership was leadership moved from apostles to priests. The priestly religious order developed to the detriment of ordinary leadership. ‘Amid this transposition in leadership, then, rank and role increasingly displaced the New Testament experience of gift and charisma.’⁴² The apostolic band of missionary people ‘became a religious organization in which the means of grace were sacramentally communicated through an ordained priesthood and the reign of God identified with the church structures and sacraments.’⁴³ As Christianity became sanctioned by Constantine, and the church and state started to fuse together, ‘the practices and training of the church’s leadership were significantly formed by the assumptions of the empire, even as the empire was itself transformed by the Christian presence at its center.’⁴⁴ This place of privilege helped to institutionalize the church, further distinguishing clergy from non-clergy, where the clergy ‘functioned as a separate order of society’ and ‘membership in the church through baptism was

⁴⁰ Michael W. Goheen, “Historical Perspectives on the Missional Church Movement: Probing Lesslie Newbigin’s Formative Influence,” *Trinity Journal for Theology & Ministry* Vol. 4, no. 2 (Fall 2010): 64.

⁴¹ Alan Roxburgh, “Missional Leadership: Equipping God’s People for Mission,” in *Missional Church: A Vision for the Sending of the Church in North America*, ed. Daniel L. Guder (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing, 1998), 190.

⁴² *Ibid.*, 191.

⁴³ *Ibid.*

⁴⁴ *Ibid.*

concomitant with citizenship in the state. Thus, mission was politicized and the *missio Dei* completed.⁴⁵

Roxburgh notes that the Reformation did not substantially alter this trajectory. The focus on the marks of the church – ‘pure doctrine, pure sacramental administration, and pure discipline’ – simply moved ecclesial leadership from priests to pedagogues, where teaching and preaching became the primary focus for ecclesial leadership.⁴⁶ A noted exception are the Radical Reformers, who refused to be co-opted by Christendom and sought to ‘recover a more apostolic and functional leadership based on neither a priestly-sacerdotal nor pastoral-pedagogue model of leadership.’⁴⁷

From Pedagogues to Professionals

The second shift was modernity. The introduction of the Enlightenment initiated the fall of Christendom, and for Roxburgh, pedagogues gave way to professionals, where leaders became counsellors, managers, and technicians.⁴⁸ He notes that these revised images of ecclesial leadership sought to keep church leadership at the centre of culture, and that the church ‘missed an opportunity to recover a missional identity. The problem with this move was not that it was adaptive to its cultural context but instead that its prime motivation was to regain the center rather than engage the culture with the gospel.’⁴⁹ The professional counsellor approach reduced the gospel by centring on the human potential of private individuals; the manager sought to develop an organization ‘shaped to meet the spiritual needs of consumers and to maximize market penetration for numerical growth,’ while the technician with the ascendancy of technique sought to control outcomes.⁵⁰ He notes that as these professional forms of leadership began to displace older forms, they did so without any critical evaluation, and, as a result, ‘their presuppositions and functionality, drive the agendas of church leadership and become operational ecclesiologies in and of themselves.’⁵¹ The development of missional theology led to a realization of the need to reshape ecclesial leadership.

⁴⁵ Ibid., 192.

⁴⁶ Ibid., 193.

⁴⁷ Ibid.

⁴⁸ Ibid., 194–198.

⁴⁹ Ibid., 196.

⁵⁰ Ibid., 196–198.

⁵¹ Ibid., 198.

The Reshaping of Missional Leadership

When the words ‘missional church’ are used together, it essentially notes the reuniting of missiology and ecclesiology. Van Gelder outlines five primary theological developments that began to fuse missiology and ecclesiology back together. These five developments, including the need to integrate missiology and ecclesiology (church and mission/missions), comprise the roots of the missional church ‘tree’ found in the introduction of *The Missional Church in Perspective*.⁵² They include: a Trinitarian missiology, *missio Dei*, the reign (kingdom) of God, the church’s missionary nature, and a missional hermeneutic.⁵³ Above these roots sits the *Missional Church* book as the trunk, out of which grows the four primary branches describing how the missional conversation has been taking place in North America after the release of *Missional Church*.

Each branch of the missional church tree describes how various authors after the *Missional Church* use the term missional with varying degrees of accuracy. The *discovering* branch reflects the least understanding of missional church; the *utilizing* branch represents an understanding of some of the concepts; the *engaging* branch reflects a fuller understanding; and the *extending* branch represents those who completely understand the six roots and are expanding and extending the missional conversation in positive ways. Keeping this missional tree illustration with the various branches in mind will be important as this thesis will refer to this illustration again after examining the nature of missional leadership.

Besides the reconnecting of church and mission, the first theological concepts developed focus on the identity of God. A Trinitarian missiology and *missio Dei* speak to the social and sending nature of God, emphasizing that the starting point for mission is God, and the church participates in his mission to the world. The concept of *missio Dei* had two primary strains, one which emphasized God working through the church, the other God working in creation and the church joining that effort. The missionary nature and identity of the church was also accented.

Not only was there a growing understanding of the identity and nature of God and the church, there was also a widening understanding of the nature of the Good News, through the quest for the historical Jesus.⁵⁴ The central message of Jesus’s teaching – the availability of the kingdom of God – became the growing consensus.

⁵² Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*, 11.

⁵³ Ibid., 17–40.

⁵⁴ Ibid., 27–29.

‘The focus on the reign of God, with its already/not yet dimensions, was foundational for broadening the focus of missional theology...’⁵⁵ God was not just interested in saving individuals; there was also a social and cosmic aspect to the good news. Finally, Van Gelder mentions a missional hermeneutic. It was ‘a transition from a “theology of mission” to a “mission theology,” where the larger framework of Scripture was beginning to be viewed from the perspective of the mission of God.’⁵⁶

It is within this historical context that Roxburgh seeks to speak to the nature of leadership, and the ways in which ecclesial leadership needs to be reshaped. The church would have to recover practices alien to its current experience.⁵⁷ Leadership is about ‘re-forming a collection of consumer, needs-centered individuals to live by an alternative narrative.’⁵⁸ This ‘alternative’ narrative involves eschatology, the already-not yet reign (kingdom) of God. The telos reshapes the identity of the church, and the work of leadership ‘takes seriously the creation of a covenant community as sign and foretaste, agent and instrument of the reign of God.’⁵⁹ He uses the metaphor ‘pilgrim people’ because the church’s identity ought not be defined in static terms, but by its direction, which has both missionary and eschatological dimensions.⁶⁰

Roxburgh makes a solid case for this community to contain a centred-set as well as a bounded-set. The centred set gives new people an invitation to join a journey shaped by the reign of God; the bounded set within the centred set is a covenant community whose identity as a pilgrim people shapes an alternative way of life.⁶¹ Leadership involves understanding that the telos of the world is the reign of God. This narrative in turn shapes the missional nature of the church and shapes the work of leadership in its context. ‘Missional leaders would focus their time, energy, and thinking on the formation of this covenant people’... engaging in ‘spiritual disciplines of a common life, disciplines of learning, and disciplines of mission.’⁶² The centred-set requires leaders to know how to welcome others on this journey and engage mission contextually, while the bounded-set requires the ability for leaders to form missional orders, that is, communities of sent people, shaped by the reign of God.⁶³ He notes,

⁵⁵ Ibid., 28.

⁵⁶ Ibid., 33.

⁵⁷ Roxburgh, *Missional Church*, 199.

⁵⁸ Ibid., 200.

⁵⁹ Ibid., 204.

⁶⁰ Ibid.

⁶¹ Ibid., 207.

⁶² Ibid., 208.

⁶³ Ibid., 211.

‘this can only happen as leaders themselves participate in such orders.’⁶⁴ Modelling is an important concept for Roxburgh, pointing to Lesslie Newbigin’s idea that Jesus did not sit in the headquarters and send the disciples out, but led them into battle, saying ‘follow me’.⁶⁵ Thus, ‘the location of the leadership in this process is at the front,’ leading the congregation toward the telos – life in God and God’s reign.⁶⁶

For Roxburgh, this leadership task requires a plurality of leaders. He points out the fact that the church needs apostles, prophets, and evangelists to come alongside pastors and teachers. He notes that ‘apostolic, missional leadership will be learned through apprenticeship within communities.’⁶⁷

When addressing how missional leadership will be formed, he suggests it relates to a deep sense of vocational call, the development of character, and academic and intellectual competency, so that the missional leader would be ‘biblically informed and theologically grounded.’⁶⁸ Finally, there is an essential need to develop skills for communal spiritual formation.⁶⁹

In their book *The Missional Leader*, Roxburgh and Romanuk, after examining the context and challenge of missional leadership and offering tools to help leaders, explore the shape and work of the missional leader. The shape of the missional leader speaks to the self-identity of the leader, which they consider foundational. ‘Self-identity is the foundation on which everything else is constructed.’⁷⁰ They consider the leader’s maturity, trust, and integrity to be of first importance. The work of the leader, which involves cultivating people, forming mission environments, and engaging context, depend entirely upon the *identity* of the leader.

Not only is identity important, but the telos is important, as it helps to shape the identity of the leader. They warn leaders not to ‘borrow its categories for leadership from other arenas and impose them on its life. To do so is to borrow a purpose and end that are not shaped out of this fundamental participation with God.’⁷¹ The chief end of the missional leader is to be found in the life of God, which in turn shapes the identity of the leader as well as the work of the leader. All three work together as ‘leadership is

⁶⁴ Ibid.

⁶⁵ Ibid., 219–220.

⁶⁶ Ibid., 212.

⁶⁷ Ibid., 214.

⁶⁸ Ibid., 213.

⁶⁹ Ibid.

⁷⁰ Roxburgh and Romanuk, *The Missional Leader*, 115.

⁷¹ Ibid., 118.

about identity formed out of knowing the *telos*, which in turn can be known only from participating in the life of God.’⁷² Roxburgh makes the case that when leaders borrow from business or corporate governance, the character and identity of the leader moves away from being formed as God’s person in the world for the good of the world.

Together, Van Gelder and Roxburgh form an understanding of the nature of missional leadership and why the missional church needs missional leadership. Van Gelder carefully chronicled the theological developments taking place in the 20th century in a profoundly helpful way. It became clear that the concepts of identity and *telos* were central to understanding these theological developments. The identity of God is emphasized regarding the Trinitarian missiology and the *missio Dei*, the reign of God speaks to the *telos* of new creation, both of which shape the identity of the church as a sent people. The identity of God and the church also shapes leaders’ hermeneutical approach to scripture, and the *telos* shapes the scope of the mission. Understanding the historical development of these terms brings important context to the conversation.

Roxburgh provides an important review of how ecclesial leadership has historically been misshapen by Christendom and modernity, and then points to the importance of how the *telos* of leadership shapes the identity of the leader which in turn shapes the praxis of the leader. He puts emphasis on the character of the leader and his or her identity and encourages them to find their *telos* in God.

Significant Themes in Missional Leadership

After Van Gelder explored the roots of the missional church tree, which reunited missiology and ecclesiology, he felt the need to revisit the *Missional Church* book to point out the underdeveloped concepts, concepts that seem in conflict with each other, as well as seeking to address themes not addressed.⁷³

Regarding Trinitarian missiology, Van Gelder and Zscheile believed it was a mistake not to bring the social Trinity into the conversation, and thought there was a lack of attention to the Holy Spirit in some chapters. They make the case that those in the discovery and utilizing branches should move from imitation of God to participation, and they call for the church to have a more positive view of the culture/world. Some of these themes need to be explored at greater depth. First, it

⁷² Ibid.

⁷³ Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*, 42.

would be important to mention something that was unintentionally minimized in Van Gelder's own critique.

Missional Spirituality and Leadership Formation

As Van Gelder offered his constructive critique of underdeveloped concepts and unresolved theological issues there is near silence regarding missional spirituality. When it comes to recalling the theological developments in which the missional church is rooted, there is no mention of missional spirituality. This is not the fault of Van Gelder since his work in the first chapter was simply to recall the historical development of the missional church and identify the theological concepts that make up the roots of the missional church tree. He, undoubtedly, did this work carefully. Yet, he did have an opportunity to name this absence in his own assessment of the underdeveloped concepts and failed to do so. It should be mentioned that the six roots of missional church tree are vital theological concepts that both Van Gelder and Zscheile believe ought to be embodied realities, not just theological understandings that stay in one's head. In addition, the identity of the people of God takes proper precedence, as the sequence of the being, doing, and organizing of the church is spelled out. 'The church *is*. The church *does* what it is. The church *organizes* what it does.'⁷⁴ Yet, missional spirituality was overlooked.

Though missional spirituality was not specified as an unaddressed theme in the historical conversation, making the spiritual disciplines more missional was given some space in the final chapter of the book, under the book's framework of extending and expanding the missional conversation.⁷⁵ While giving space to missional spirituality in the extension of the branches of the tree is important, it also serves to minimize missional spirituality. This thesis will seek to demonstrate the importance of missional spirituality in helping leaders overcome a domineering spirit. Missional spirituality is not simply a branch, nor a root, but the very soil in which the missional church tree ought to be planted. Otherwise the status, value, worth, and ultimately, identity of the leader might be found in how well they understand and embody the roots of missional theology as opposed to being grounded in the Trinitarian life of God, embedded in the height, depth, width, and length of God's love (Eph. 3:14-19). While missional spirituality did not figure prominently in Van Gelder's work, at least in this critical

⁷⁴ Ibid., 64.

⁷⁵ Ibid., 148–154. Part 2 of the book is entitled "Perspectives That Extend the Missional Conversation".

review, this is starting to change for many thinkers.⁷⁶ However, this is not being done with a view to the work of the Powers.

The Identity and Character of the Leader

For Roxburgh and Romanuk, the self-identity of the leader is foundational; the work of the missional leader depends on the character of the leader. Considering the growing list of ‘fallen’ pastors, this point must not be diminished. Yet stressing the character of the leader isn’t unique to Christians or in need of revelation. In critiquing how leadership in the modern business world has created a CEO approach to leadership, especially in megachurches, Fitch warns of danger when ‘Jesus becomes a leadership principle applicable across all working environments’ as John Maxwell seeks to do with *The 21 Irrefutable Laws of Leadership*.⁷⁷

Maxwell makes the point that leadership is essentially the same, no matter what occupation one has. Whether, ‘you’re looking at citizens of ancient Greece, the Hebrews of the Old Testament, the armies of the last two hundred years, the rulers of modern Europe, the pastors in local churches, or the business people in today’s global economy, leadership principles stand the test of time. They are irrefutable.’⁷⁸ While character is typically understood as important in all fields, Fitch makes the point that when ‘there is no direct link between character formed in Christ and what it means to pastor his church’ there is no conflict in inviting Bill Clinton to speak at the Willow Creek Leadership Summit for pastors, as he did in 2000. David Staal of the Willow Creek Association said, then, ‘who is better qualified than the president of the United States to talk about leadership?’⁷⁹ Fitch cautions that ‘the implicit bottom-line understanding here is that leadership principles are not determined in specific ways by

⁷⁶ After the publication of *The Missional Church in Perspective*, here are some resources that have been developed in this area of need: (note there is also a book edited by Zscheile) Roger Helland and Leonard Hjalmanson, *Missional Spirituality: Embodying God’s Love from the Inside Out* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2011); Dwight Zscheile, ed., *Cultivating Sent Communities: Missional Spiritual Formation* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2012); David E. Fitch, *Faithful Presence: Seven Disciplines That Shape the Church for Mission* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2016); Nathan A. Finn and Keith S. Whitfield, eds., *Spirituality for the Sent: Casting a New Vision for the Missional Church* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2017).

⁷⁷ David E. Fitch, *The Great Giveaway: Reclaiming the Mission of the Church from Big Business, Parachurch Organizations, Psychotherapy, Consumer Capitalism, and Other Modern Maladies*, Reprinted edition. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2005), 75.

⁷⁸ John C. Maxwell, *The 21 Irrefutable Laws of Leadership: Follow Them and People Will Follow You*, 2nd edition. (Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2007). xx-xxi.

⁷⁹ Fitch, *The Great Giveaway*, 75.

the person and work of Jesus Christ that demand allegiance to him in order to make sense.’⁸⁰

For Roxburgh, self-identity is not left undefined. Character is rooted in the narrative and telos of God. ‘In the Christian story, the *telos* of human life is neither to fulfill oneself in the modern sense of the individual nor the drive to self-actualization or even self-differentiation. Our *telos* is to know God... To know God is to know the good.’⁸¹ When considering the nature of missional leadership, allowing the narrative of God to shape our approach to leadership is needed, for Scripture reveals aspects of the world that would not be understood otherwise. Leadership in the church ought to be distinct from what is seen in the world. For Roxburgh, one’s telos shapes who one is and one’s leadership:

...it has everything to do with answering questions about the nature and meaning of leadership in the church. Before anything else, leadership is about our identity as people who are participating in God’s life and given work to be done in the world. Leadership is about identity formed out of knowing the *telos*, which in turn can be known only from participating in the life of God. Therefore, leadership is fundamentally about forming character and living a life shaped by virtue.⁸²

Roxburgh solidly grounds missional leadership in Christ and the life of God. He demonstrates the ability to discern how leaders can become misshapen, but what remains undeveloped is helping missional leaders understand how the Powers seek to subvert leadership, and a corresponding spirituality that can withstand the Powers’ attack. While showing an awareness of the work of the Powers throughout his writing, direct references are less frequent.⁸³ He recognizes that ‘any missional leadership must face the temptation to reduce the life of the church solely to abilities and skills offered by the principalities and powers’ and that leadership requires a spirituality that allows leaders to faithfully follow Christ. Yet he does not give concrete ways for leaders to name and unmask the powers, thus leaving leaders vulnerable. It should be mentioned that, as Roxburgh gets to the work of the missional leader, the spiritual formation of an alternative community is the highlight. The imitation-based framework presented here is designed to help the formation of missional leaders, with the presupposition that leadership has its own unique challenges specifically related to the Powers. This is seen in the temptations that Jesus faced in the desert at the start of his ministry, where his

⁸⁰ Ibid.

⁸¹ Roxburgh and Romanuk, *The Missional Leader*, 117.

⁸² Ibid., 117–118.

⁸³ Roxburgh, *Missional Church*, 185–186.

identity, aims, and methods were tested. The instructions Paul gives Timothy regarding the appointment of leaders are also telling: ‘A church leader must not be a new believer, because he might become proud, and the devil will cause him to fall (I Tim. 3:6 NLT).’

Missional Leadership and the View of Culture/World

Van Gelder and Zscheile extend the missional conversation in the second half of their book, where they make the case that the missional church needs to view culture and the world in more positive ways. ‘At stake is how culture and world are to be viewed, are they to be viewed primarily in positive terms or in negative terms?’⁸⁴ Part of their argument is related to how the *missio Dei* relates to the reign of God. Van Gelder mentions that there are basically five variations of how these terms relate.

The five variations are broken into the specialized, generalized, and integrated views. Because of how it relates to this thesis, it will be important to examine this closer. The specialized views of *missio Dei* and the reign of God include two variants; first, that ‘the church embodies the reign of God’, secondly, that ‘the church witnesses to the reign of God.’⁸⁵ The generalized option includes two variants as well; first, that ‘God’s mission unfolds through secular history’, secondly, ‘God’s mission unfolds in the midst of secular history.’⁸⁶ The fifth view is found within the integrated view, which Van Gelder prefers: ‘the church participates in God’s continuing creation and redemptive mission.’⁸⁷ Van Gelder is seeking to point out how different chapters in *Missional Church* emphasize different views, adding to the confusion of the missional conversation. Variations on the specialized, generalized, and integrated views of *missio Dei* and the reign of God “leads to confusion regarding how God works in the world in relation to the church and to the reign of God.”⁸⁸ For Van Gelder, it seems apparent that adopting the integrated view leads one to have a more positive view of culture and the world.

Their essential argument is that cultures, while not neutral, are tied to creation. Therefore, the work of the church is to discern, with the help of Scripture, where God is at work in the world through his Spirit and join Him in his redemptive work in the

⁸⁴ Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*, 60.

⁸⁵ *Ibid.*, 56.

⁸⁶ *Ibid.*

⁸⁷ *Ibid.*, 57.

⁸⁸ *Ibid.*

world. In this they seek to de-centre the church and increase appreciation for the work of the Spirit, with the hope of cultivating a humble church, less vulnerable to colonialism and triumphalism. In tying culture to creation, they write:

The Trinity is the key to engaging theologically with creation and culture. In deep Trinitarian collaboration, God creates the world and all that is in it, calls a people (Israel) to show forth God's vision for human community, enters fully into human culture in the incarnation to redeem humanity, and actively moves to renew, inspire, rebuke, reconcile, and bring creation to its fulfillment. The world is by no means godforsaken, but rather charged with God's presence and movement and redeemed at the greatest cost: the cross.⁸⁹

Because God is at work in the world through his Spirit, the church's role is to discern his work and join him, dismissing a negative view of the world, favouring a more positive view of culture/world. It should be noted they make no attempt to distinguish between culture and world, and often use them together as culture/world.⁹⁰ This picture is painted in contrast to the classic anabaptist inspired vision that is given in chapter five of *Missional Church*, which 'portrays the church as a contrast society within a fallen world' where the role of the church is 'to develop an alternative culture to that of the world.'⁹¹

The heart of their argument is that the church ought to join what God is already doing in the world through his Spirit, and that our posture should value 'the themes of reciprocity, mutuality, and vulnerability' found in the inner life of the Trinity. As they write, 'These themes also shape the missional church's engagement with culture and the world. To view the world as a place of hospitality (as in Luke 10) is to recognize the gifts that lie within it to be shared – gifts that inform and enrich our own experience and understanding of the gospel.'⁹² While arguing for a more positive view of culture/world, they do not pretend that the church should see it uncritically. They write, 'It is important to remember that culture is part of creation. Culture in all its diversity as such, is infused with the promise of God's creative presence and the Spirit, and at the same time liable to distortion through human sin.'⁹³

While they aim to cultivate a humbler church and emphasise how God is at work in the world, Van Gelder and Zscheile seem to minimize what William Stringfellow describes as 'the ubiquity of the fall', which involves not just people made

⁸⁹ Ibid., 136.

⁹⁰ Ibid., 60.

⁹¹ Ibid., 59.

⁹² Ibid., 133.

⁹³ Ibid., 136.

in the image of God, but social and cosmic realities.⁹⁴ For Stringfellow, to minimize the fall is to live in an illusion without hope of true redemption. Stringfellow sought to ‘view the world with unflinching, resilient realism’ recognizing the fall is greater than human sin.⁹⁵

While Van Gelder and Zscheile give a helpful history of the development of culture, noting that it is a ‘highly contested’ concept with its ‘complicated history,’ it seems a mistake to make culture and world synonymous. One is a concept developed recently through anthropology, the other a concept developed through Scripture.⁹⁶ In not taking the time to define the word ‘world’ and their desire for the church to view the world and culture more positively, Van Gelder and Zscheile put greater emphasis on the positive ways Scripture uses ‘world’, with just a hint of caution regarding the ways the Scripture talks about ‘world’ negatively. For example, after a long, eloquent, argument of God’s work in the world, they write, ‘it is liable to distortion through human sin.’⁹⁷ Their lack of definition for the Biblical concept of ‘world’ adds to the confusion of their argument.

A Theology of the Powers Brings Realism and Hope

Walter Wink, in his trilogy on the Powers, presents a nuanced view of ‘world,’ distinguishing between the good world God has made (creation), the world that he loves (people), and the world as ‘human sociological realms that exist in estrangement from God (the Powers).’⁹⁸ With a robust theology of the Powers, one can have a view of creation and redemption that is both hopeful and realistic. René Girard, as a cultural anthropologist, will make the case that all cultures are fallen. He also provides hope for redemption. As leaders in the church have a more robust theology of the Powers, they will have greater clarity on how to view culture and the world.

The need to understand the Powers is evident in the work of Newbigin, who is widely recognized as the father of the missional church movement, and who inspired

⁹⁴ William Stringfellow, *The Politics of Spirituality* (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2006), 3.

⁹⁵ Ibid.

⁹⁶ Scott Aniol, “Toward a Biblical Understanding of Culture,” *Artistic Theologian*, October 31, 2012, accessed November 3, 2019, <http://artistictheologian.com/journal/at-volume-1-2012/toward-a-biblical-understanding-of-culture/>.

⁹⁷ Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*, 136.

⁹⁸ Walter Wink, *Engaging the Powers: Discernment and Resistance in a World of Domination*, The Powers v. 3 (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 1992), 51.

the writing of *Missional Church*.⁹⁹ Van Gelder does not give much attention to the Powers in his critique of *Missional Church*, and is critical of the sole chapter that emphasizes the Powers (though its treatment of the Powers is underdeveloped), primarily because of how the fallenness of the world is accented, leading to a more negative view of the world, and a seemingly more limited understanding of the mission Dei.¹⁰⁰ Yet Newbigin devotes an entire chapter to the theme of the Powers in his ground-breaking book, *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*. His chapter entitled, “Principalities, Power and People” heightens awareness of how the fall included not just people, but social and cosmic realities. Reflecting on this neglected theme that finds prominence in Scriptures, he writes,

I refer to the whole mass of teaching in St. Paul’s letters about what are variously called principalities, powers, dominions, thrones, authorities, rulers, angels, and other names. With these we must also look at what the Gospels have to say about hostile spiritual powers, about Satan, and about what the Fourth Gospel calls “the ruler of this world.” If I am not mistaken, most scholarly readers of the New Testament in the past 150 years have regarded all this language as something which we have grown out of... The domination of a reductionist materialism, which supposed that when we had discovered the atomic and molecular and biological facts about any phenomenon we had explained it, has prevented us from discerning the realities that Paul and other New Testament writers are talking about, and they are realities... we find such words on almost every page.¹⁰¹

Newbigin saw the necessity of understanding the work of the Powers when thinking about culture and the world, making the case for how the Powers are a prominent theme in the New Testament. A renewed academic interest in the Powers took place after World War II because of the need to explain its horrors. A theology that tended to have a more positive view of the world had led much of the church to be complicit with Hitler.¹⁰² Meanwhile those who led the resistance – like Bonhoeffer and Barth – were most alert to the Powers. It seems wise to develop theology from those who have demonstrated faithfulness in their lives, especially in contexts which test one’s faith. The primary interlocutors for this thesis were chosen with this criteria in mind. While Newbigin’s treatment demonstrates a solid understanding of the Powers

⁹⁹ Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*, 18; Michael W. Goheen, “Historical Perspectives on the Missional Church Movement: Probing Lesslie Newbigin’s Formative Influence,” *Trinity Journal for Theology & Ministry* Vol. 4, no. 2 (Fall 2010): 62–84.

¹⁰⁰ Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*, 59–60.

¹⁰¹ Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*, 200.

¹⁰² Arthur C. Cochrane, *The Church’s Confession under Hitler*, 1st Edition edition. (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster Press, 1962).

and the importance of tending to them, his acknowledged debt to Wink is evident.¹⁰³ Thus the importance of engaging Wink on the Powers.

When it comes to God-world-church understandings, Van Wyngaard gives insights into the life of David Bosch, in his context of South African Apartheid, where the Powers of racism reigned. He states that for Bosch ‘any ecclesiology that withdraws from society, on the one hand, or becomes indistinguishable from society on the other hand,’ is not a missionary ecclesiology, and that ‘the constructive argument for a missionary ecclesiology always takes into account the society in which we are to be church.’¹⁰⁴

Newbigin registers similar sentiments in his statement, ‘The most important contribution which the Church can make to a new social order is to be itself a new social order.’¹⁰⁵ It is evident that the Powers of racism shaped Bosch’s careful understanding of the nature of the relationship of God-world-church, or should it be said God-church-world. The evidence suggests that one’s social location influences how alert one is, as well as how much weight one gives to the Powers. In addition, those who pay too little attention to the Powers are more likely to fall under the influence of the Powers, unaware.

Roxburgh demonstrates an understanding of how the Powers work by drawing attention to how false narratives and an uncritically adopted telos can misshape a leader’s identity and work. He seems more inclined to be shaped by the Anabaptists than Van Gelder and noted how the Radical Reformers were able to resist being co-opted by Christendom. He emphasizes that the central work of the missional leader is forming the people of God for a missional future. He insightfully quotes Alan Kreider, who traces the changes of the ‘meaning and means conversion’ from the early church to the time of Charlemagne.¹⁰⁶ ‘Conversion, which had made Christians into distinct people – resident aliens – now was something that made people ordinary, not resident aliens but simply residents.’¹⁰⁷ He notes how this shift changed the focus of leadership during Christendom, ‘from formation of a people as an alternative society of God’s

¹⁰³ Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*. x.

¹⁰⁴ George Van Wyngaard, “The Public Role of the Christian Community in the Work of David Bosch,” *Missionalia* 31 (April 1, 2011): 161.

¹⁰⁵ Lesslie Newbigin, *Truth to Tell: The Gospel as Public Truth* (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., 1991), 81.

¹⁰⁶ Roxburgh and Romanuk, *The Missional Leader*, 210.

¹⁰⁷ Alan Kreider, *The Change of Conversion and the Origin of Christendom*, Reprint edition. (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Pub, 2007), 90.

future to oversight of orthodoxy, proper administration of the sacraments, and regulation of spiritualized and privatized ethical practices increasingly disconnected from any biblical or theological understanding of *ecclesia* as the people of God.¹⁰⁸ Yet Roxburgh doesn't help the missional leader to name, unmask, and engage the powers, to use Wink's language.

The Powers crave ultimate devotion. They have developed systems, structures, and institutions that speak to the longings people have, so that people might fully give themselves over to them. The Powers are not satisfied until they have complete devotion. In time, they demand ultimate allegiance to the point that people are willing to sacrifice anything and everything for them. The concept of mimetic desire, which will be introduced with Girard, demonstrates the need for missional leaders to develop an approach to leadership in view of how the Powers seek to subvert missional leaders.

Missional Leadership and Imitation

After making the case that the church in the West would do well to learn from the church in the East in regard to the social Trinity and the social (not just sending) nature of God, Van Gelder and Zscheile assert that those in the discovering branches and utilising branches, which have the least understanding of the roots of the missional tree, put too much emphasis on a 'mere *imitation* of God's life and mission'.¹⁰⁹ They give two reasons for the need to move 'from imitation to participation.'¹¹⁰ 'First the stress on human agency. It is up to us to realize the perfect trinitarian model of community or to enact the life of Jesus through our own performance.'¹¹¹ They mention that this doesn't take our personal and corporate sin seriously enough. 'Second, God's own Trinitarian involvement in the world... is rendered largely irrelevant. Mission is something humans do, rather than primarily an attribute of God in which humans (and the church) participate.'¹¹² With the goal of correcting the imperialist and colonialist tendencies of the past and present, they are seeking to help those who have a renewed focus on Christology to have a more 'fully trinitarian understanding of Christ.'¹¹³

¹⁰⁸ Roxburgh and Romanuk, *The Missional Leader*, 120.

¹⁰⁹ Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*, 110.

¹¹⁰ *Ibid.*, 119.

¹¹¹ *Ibid.*, 110–111.

¹¹² *Ibid.*, 111.

¹¹³ *Ibid.*

The Minimization or Maximization of Imitation?

While the larger argument has merit in the sense of fully participating in the life of God and appreciating the work of the Trinity, minimizing the imitation of Christ holds potential dangers. First, one of the underlying assumptions Van Gelder and Zscheile seem to make is that imitation is limited to external behaviour. Per Girard, humans are imitative by nature, but the primary way people imitate is internally, through desire. Leaders will either imitate Christ as exemplar of the *missio Dei*, or Satan as exemplar of fallenness and rebellion. Instead of minimizing imitation, this thesis claims that the best starting point for participating in the full life of the Trinity is to imitate Christ. As leaders imitate Christ, not simply by their behaviour, but primarily through their desires, as Girard states, leaders will desire the Father as Jesus desires the Father. And as leaders participate in the life of God, their desire to imitate Christ is increased. Also, as leaders seek to imitate Christ, they will also depend on the power of the Spirit, as Christ did. For the leader, true imitation leads to participation. In addition, participation can also lead to greater imitation, both inwardly with our desires, and outwardly through our actions. But without a concrete, incarnate Christ to imitate, leaders could easily co-opt the language of the “Spirit” to justify domineering leadership.

Fitch, in his desire to bring the neo-Anabaptist perspective into the missional conversation alongside The Missional Network (TMN), and the missional evangelicals (MEs), offers some strengths and weaknesses to the missional stream identified with Van Gelder.¹¹⁴ Fitch recalls that following WWII there were two criticisms being debated regarding past Western missionary endeavours: ecclesiocentrism and christocentrism. Ecclesiocentrism was blamed for ‘perverting mission into a form of cultural colonialism.’¹¹⁵ Christocentrism, charged that the church in the West was ‘overly focused on the second person of the Trinity to the exclusion of the other two persons of the Trinity in terms of God’s work in the world.’¹¹⁶ In addition, ‘This focus worked to locate salvation in a past (somewhat static) event of God’s work in Christ...This served to detach God from being active in the world today.’ Some (most notably missiologist J.C. Hoekendijk) even argued ‘that such Christocentrism was colonialist in impulse. It was the means by which other religions were excluded from salvation.’¹¹⁷ Each stream of the missional conversation is seeking to deal with the

¹¹⁴ Fitch, “The Other Missional Conversation,” 467.

¹¹⁵ Ibid., 468.

¹¹⁶ Ibid., 467–468.

¹¹⁷ Ibid., 468.

church's improper use of power.¹¹⁸ Fitch is seeking to answer the question: how can this best be done?

He is on point when noting Van Gelder's missional stream (TMN) deals with Christocentrism by 'prioritizing the Spirit's work in the world, and the church finds its location in the world through discerning the Spirit.'¹¹⁹ Here, in regard to ecclesiocentrism, they decentre 'the church within the mission of God.'¹²⁰ Thus God-world-church is their preferred order of relationship.¹²¹ Fitch believes that the strength of this missional stream consists in its ability to lead churches into deep engagement with their context. 'They have shaped a new praxis for cultivating imagination in churches for the way God works in the world.'¹²² Yet, he locates their weakness in their strength. 'The intense focus on the Spirit's work in the world, and locating the church in that work, can separate the discernment of God's work in the world from Jesus Christ. Shifting the starting point of ecclesial imagination... from Jesus Christ (and traditional practices of the church) to the Spirit in the world can leave the church open to losing itself in attempting to see God at work in the world.'¹²³ While giving other critiques, he asks two key questions related to this study: 'Without the social formation of a church in its historical practices, how do we avoid getting caught up and absorbed in the world? How do we check ourselves from taking back the agency of mission from God and putting it on our own backs again?'¹²⁴

The Missional Evangelicals (MEs), the second stream of missional writers that Fitch points out, headed by prolific authors Alan Hirsch and Michael Frost, have been prominent in the missional conversation. They, with the TMN, have *missio Dei* as their starting point, where they seek to overturn ecclesiocentrism with a renewed focus on Jesus. Fitch writes, 'The MEs *prioritize an individual discipleship in the ways of Jesus, from which the church is a result.*'¹²⁵ This is confirmed by how Frost and Hirsch

¹¹⁸ Ibid., 467. Fitch identifies three missional streams. The Missional Network (TMN), represented by Van Gelder and Roxburgh, the Missional Evangelicals (ME) represented by Alan Hirsch and Michael Frost. And finally, the stream he identifies with, the Neo-anabaptist Missional (NAM).

¹¹⁹ Ibid., 468.

¹²⁰ Ibid., 469.

¹²¹ Van Gelder and Zscheile, *The Missional Church in Perspective*, 110–111.

¹²² David E. Fitch, "The Other Missional Conversation: Making Way for the Neo-Anabaptist Contribution to the Missional Movement in North America," *Missiology* 44, no. 4 (October 1, 2016): 469.

¹²³ Ibid.

¹²⁴ Ibid., 470.

¹²⁵ Ibid.

articulate the methodological flow of the missional church. ‘Christology must determine missiology (our purpose and function in this world), which in turn must determine ecclesiology (the cultural forms and expressions of the church).’¹²⁶ For the MEs the church follows mission because ‘ecclesiology is the most fluid of the doctrines. The church is a dynamic cultural expression of the people of God in any given place.’¹²⁷ Thus communities are formed incarnationally in their cultural context.

Fitch believes the MEs strength is in their ability to embody an incarnational approach to mission which can connect to people groups estranged from current forms of church. Fitch considers their weakness to be ‘in their Christocentrism and the individualism that lies at the heart of it... and because this Christology is accessed through the individual encounter, the resultant mission is individualized.’¹²⁸ For Fitch, this results in two weaknesses: first, because ecclesiology follows Christology and missiology, ‘This individualism can undercut the development of a people as an alternative sociality, in a context that can give witness to Christ’s kingdom as a way of life... and the emphasis on incarnational living and church as an afterward development risks undercutting mission.’¹²⁹ The second potential weakness Fitch points out is ‘the personal Jesus can easily become captive to a particular culture. The MEs assume an immediate access to Jesus for individuals if they just open themselves to Scripture.’¹³⁰ For Fitch, the evangelical confidence in the ability to get ‘Jesus right’, as opposed to adopting an enculturated form of Jesus, brings concern of a new type of colonialism. He writes, ‘How do we avoid new colonialism that imposes our Christ on others?’¹³¹ He suggests what is needed is a Christology ‘that has its bearings in a historical social practice, which extends Christ’s real presence corporately, inhabiting and birthing communities unique to each new context.’¹³² Ultimately, the advice he gives to the MEs is that they ‘must avoid the colonialist temptation to universalize [their] own experiences and interpretations of Christ and to make them universal for all contexts.’¹³³

¹²⁶ Michael Frost and Alan Hirsch, *ReJesus: A Wild Messiah for a Missional Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2008), 42–43.

¹²⁷ Alan Hirsch, *The Forgotten Ways: Reactivating Apostolic Movements*, 2 edition. (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2016), 143.

¹²⁸ Fitch, “The Other Missional Conversation,” 471.

¹²⁹ *Ibid.*, 471–472.

¹³⁰ *Ibid.*, 472.

¹³¹ *Ibid.*

¹³² *Ibid.*

¹³³ *Ibid.*

Fitch, in seeking to bring the neo-anabaptist missional stream perspective, answers the ‘problems’ of christocentrism and ecclesiocentrism differently. Fitch recommends an ‘Incarnation-centered Trinitarian theology’ meaning that the incarnation is the ‘focal point for understanding how God works in the world.’¹³⁴ The neo-anabaptist missional perspective starts with the sending Trinity, the difference being,

...the emphasis falls on the Spirit extending the work of the incarnation through the twofold work of the Son into the world. First, there is the work of the Son over the whole world via the reign of Christ (through the Spirit), who now sits at the right hand of the Father as the lamb that was slain (a more specific version of *missio Dei*). In addition there is a second work of the Son through the Spirit extending the continuing presence of Christ via the church as his body in the world. The Incarnation becomes the focal point from which God launches a twofold work of Christ into the world. His reign over the whole world becomes visible via his presence in the church.¹³⁵

One danger of this view that Fitch names is that by locating a ‘special presence of Christ in the practice of the church, the church itself may seek to exert human control over Christ and the benefits of salvation in the world,’ the very critique the Reformation levelled against Roman Catholicism.¹³⁶ In countering this weakness, Fitch says that Christ cannot be controlled. In addition, ‘Christ’s reign in the church can never be triumphalized because the community follows the logic of incarnation: humility, vulnerability, submission to God’s work in the world. Apart from this submission to his work, his vulnerable nonviolent presence in the world, Christ’s power and authority are lost. In this situation there can be no witness.’¹³⁷

To summarise his argument, this Incarnation-centred Trinitarian theology ‘maintains Christ’s center as Lord bringing in the Kingdom (christocentrism) and the centrality of the church as the means of God’s witness (ecclesiocentrism).’ At the same time, it doesn’t limit the work of God to the church, nor lend itself to a sense of triumphalism ‘of a Christocentric church in the world (because he rules as the lamb, non-coercively, as one to whom the church must submit and be present).’¹³⁸

Considering these options, Fitch’s logic is preferred, for the *telos* of the church is to reach the full stature of Christ (Eph. 4:11-13), by the power of the Spirit. Paul does

¹³⁴ Ibid., 473.

¹³⁵ Ibid.

¹³⁶ Ibid., 474.

¹³⁷ Ibid.

¹³⁸ Ibid.

not decentre Christ. In fact, the Spirit is sometimes called the shy member of the Trinity, not in the sense of timidity, but in the Spirit's desire to draw attention to the Son.¹³⁹ Fitch's argument lends itself to recognize the need to *maximize our imitation of Christ* through a historical, communal, ecclesial understanding of Christ, instead of speaking in ways that might minimize this logic. For in Christ, Christians have God in concreteness. This might be why during Hitler's rise in Germany, where the Powers were clearly at work, Bonhoeffer (in his book *Discipleship*) makes a clarion call to imitate Christ. The need of our day, clearly seen in Girard's work, is not to minimize imitation, but to embody it in Trinitarian ways.

The Importance of Leadership as Model

While Van Gelder and Zschiele seem to minimize the imitation of Christ, Roxburgh accents the theme of imitation as he calls leaders to lead in mission and in the spiritual formation of the community by example, having a life worth imitating. In addition, he suggests the best approach for the development of missional leaders is through apprenticeship.¹⁴⁰ When summarizing the role of the leader to lead the congregation toward the reign of God, he writes, 'leadership is a calling that both engages the context with the gospel and leads in the formation of the disciplined community. Being at the front means that the leadership lives into and incarnates the missional, covenantal future of God's people.'¹⁴¹ Regarding apprenticeship, he writes, 'Apostolic, missional leadership will be learned through apprenticeship within communities. Such leaders will learn firsthand how to live out the practices of community formation that require a profound involvement of the self and deep roots in Bible and theology.'¹⁴² Roxburgh points to three positive examples of how this training could take place. There is Bonhoeffer's seminary pre-World War II in Germany, 'where students lived together in covenant community,' the Catholic monastic orders, and John Wesley's 'weekly class meetings around a common set of disciplines and commitments.'¹⁴³ Close proximity gives space for imitation.

This thesis will follow Roxburgh and accent the importance of imitation in developing missional leadership. Through Girard it will be demonstrated that, beyond

¹³⁹ Frederick Dale Bruner, *The Holy Spirit - Shy Member of the Trinity* (Minneapolis: Wipf and Stock, 2001).

¹⁴⁰ Roxburgh, *Missional Church*, 214.

¹⁴¹ Ibid., 212.

¹⁴² Ibid., 214.

¹⁴³ Ibid., 218.

the need for leaders to model methodology and theological understanding, is the need to model a right heart toward God. Because, according to Girard, disciples will model the desires of their leaders. This concept of mimetic desire will be developed in chapter four and brings additional motivation for missional leaders to be an example to those they lead.

The Need for Missional Leadership

Van Gelder and Zscheile, and Roxburgh and Romanuk, make a compelling case that in our post-Christendom context, the need for missional leadership is significant. They make the case that ecclesial leadership needs to be reshaped. The need to move from solo leaders to shared leadership is not just affirmed by each of them but is affirmed by leaders of other missional streams, including the streams represented by Hirsch, Frost, and Fitch.

In a post-Christendom context, Roxburgh makes the case that there is a need to return to a more apostolic approach to leadership, as the pastor/teacher is not sufficient. Hirsch concurs as he writes, ‘Quite simply, a missional church needs missional leadership, and it is going to take more than the traditional pastor-teacher role of leadership to pull this off.’¹⁴⁴ Fitch, Frost, and other voices consider a return to apostolic leadership (Eph. 4:1-16) as an important development, not only in missional leadership, but the missionary shape of the church.¹⁴⁵

Roxburgh asserts that the missional leader is needed to foster a missional imagination for the entire congregation. In other words, missional leadership seeks to unbind the clerical captivity of the church. Ed Stetzer, in a series focusing on the priesthood of all believers, mentions that ‘people create religious hierarchy to outsource their religious obligations.’¹⁴⁶ Missional leadership recognizes a move from professional ‘priests’ to the ‘priesthood of all believers’. The combination of shared

¹⁴⁴ Hirsch, *The Forgotten Ways*, 152.

¹⁴⁵ Michael Frost and Alan Hirsch, *The Shaping of Things to Come: Innovation and Mission for the 21 Century Church* (Peabody, Mass: Hendrickson Pub, 2003); Hirsch, *The Forgotten Ways*; Alan Hirsch and Tim Catchim, *The Permanent Revolution: Apostolic Imagination and Practice for the 21st Century Church*, 1 edition. (San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2012); Alan Hirsch, *5Q: Reactivating the Original Intelligence and Capacity of the Body of Christ*, 1st edition. (100 Movements, 2017); Fitch, *The Great Giveaway*; Fitch, *Faithful Presence*.

¹⁴⁶ Ed Stetzer Bio, “Laypeople and the Mission of God: Part II - Reclaiming the Priesthood of All Believers,” *The Exchange | A Blog by Ed Stetzer*, accessed November 27, 2019, <https://www.christianitytoday.com/edstetzer/2012/august/laypeople-and-mission-of-god-part-ii-reclaiming.html>.

leadership, a re-emphasis of apostolic leadership, and the priesthood of all believers helps decentre the leader in healthy ways.

When it comes to discerning how to think about missional leadership, Roxburgh speaks frequently on how the identity and telos of leadership shape the work of the leader. Additionally, Van Gelder and Zscheile point to how the most significant theological developments of the missional church revolve around the identity of God, the identity of the church, as well as the telos of New Creation, with the emphasis on the reign (kingdom) of God. There is full agreement that identity and telos shape and inform both the work of missional leadership and the leader's posture, so that the ends inform the means. These concepts of the identity (being) of the leader, the telos (becoming) of the leader, and praxis (doing) of the leader, seem to be a helpful way to consider the contours of missional leadership. And the fact that these three dimensions of leadership are affirmed by others who have sought to address the dearth of literature in regards theological reflection on the concept of missional leadership is confirming.¹⁴⁷

However, what is left unaddressed is how the Powers seek to subvert the leader at the contours of leadership. This will be developed in the final chapter, with the help of William Stringfellow. He provides a concrete way for missional leaders to name and unmask the powers that seek to subvert them, a tool that Roxburgh does not provide. This tool will also help us see how the fallen Powers seek to reshape the very desires of the missional leader.

Summary of Argument

The theological developments taking place in the missional church are reshaping ecclesial leadership and providing some help to the challenges of domineering leadership. It has been argued that missional theology in its current state lacks the ability to sufficiently tackle this problem. A framework which considers how to name, unmask, and engage the Powers is needed, as well as a spirituality which can resist the Powers.

With Van Gelder and Zscheile, one sees the unintentional minimizing of missional spirituality. Roxburgh gave significant weight to the identity and character of

¹⁴⁷ Ayers, Ph.D., "Toward a Theology of Leadership"; Lynch, *Ecclesial Leadership as Friendship*; Arthur Boers and Eugene Peterson, *Servants and Fools: A Biblical Theology of Leadership* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2015); Christopher A. Beely and Joseph H. Britton Britton, "Anglican Theological Review - a Quarterly Journal of Theological Reflection" Vol. 91, no. No. 1, Introduction: Toward a Theology of Leadership (Winter 2009): 3–10.

the missional leader, as shaped by the telos of the leader's life in God. While he shows an awareness and intelligence in how the Powers work, he fails to give any tools to the missional leader regarding how to name, unmask, or engage them. The imitation-based framework that this thesis will develop provides a way for leaders to be alert to the Powers and how they seek to misshape their desires, so that they can develop a spirituality to counter their influence.

In their desire to help the church have a more positive view of culture/world, Van Gelder and Zscheile failed to distinguish between the anthropologically generated concept of culture and the theologically developed concept of world. Because they failed to define their terms, they emphasized the positive uses of world, and minimized the negative uses in Scripture. The near absence of a theology of the Powers was evident. With a different approach, Newbigin in *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*, dedicated an entire chapter to the Powers, seeking to help those in the missional conversation understand the prominence of this theme in Scripture. Newbigin cited his dependence on Wink, which is one reason it is important to critically engage Wink's work.

The example of Bosch in the context of the apartheid in South Africa pointed to the idea that one's social location influences the awareness and weight that one gives to the Powers. Roxburgh's use of anabaptist scholar Alan Krieder, reminds us of the richness of the term 'resident aliens', as well as how an errant emphasis on one term or the other can be detrimental to the development of people. It is important for leaders to recognise they were created as earthly creatures, and the telos of new creation speaks against an escapist theology. Yet, the notion of an alien represents the fact that the Powers are at work in the world.

Regarding missional leadership and imitation, it seems that Van Gelder and Zscheile minimize imitation, with a desire to lead people to participate in the life of God and give greater credence to how the Spirit is at work in the world. Fitch pointed out that the missional church conversation was in part an answer to the colonialistic and imperialistic approaches of Western mission, and so each stream of the missional conversation seeks to address the 'problems' of christocentrism and ecclesiocentrism. Van Gelder's stream does so by decentring the church in God's mission and giving more emphasis to the Spirit's work in the world. This seems to cohere with their intentional or unintentional minimizing of the imitation of Christ. Fitch mentions the potential danger of this approach is to 'separate the discernment of God's work in the world from Jesus Christ' and leave the church in the position of losing itself in the

attempt to see God at work in the world.¹⁴⁸ Fitch proposed a Trinitarian view where the Spirit extends the work of the incarnation and reign of the Son and mentions that Christ is not stuck in the past, but lives on through the Spirit, his body, the Church. The incarnation becomes ‘the focal point for understanding how God works in the world.’¹⁴⁹ Consequently, there is no need to minimize imitation of Christ. Instead of moving from imitation to participation, in light of Fitch’s argument, it would be better to say the starting point for participating in the life of the Trinity is to *fully* imitate Christ. René Girard’s understanding of mimetic desire will validate this claim.

Roxburgh reminds us that the leader needs to be a model and that leadership formation should take place as new leaders are apprenticed by experienced leaders. He inherently understands the popular aphorism that more is caught than taught. Houston makes this point in his aptly titled work *Leading by Example*, to be explored in the next chapter.

In conclusion, there seems to be a consensus among Van Gelder, Zscheile, Roxburgh, and Romanuk that identity and telos are important concepts to grasp because of how they shape the work of the church and leadership. Therefore, this thesis will adopt the contours of missional leadership to include the identity, praxis, and telos of the leader. While the plurality of leaders, the importance of apostolic leadership, and the priesthood of all believers is common, what is missing from the conversation is an imitation-based conceptual framework that considers the work of the Powers, and how imitation and desires link the missional leader to these Powers. It would be negligent to overlook how in Jesus’s temptation in the desert, the devil was going after his identity; on two separate occasions he says, ‘If you are the Son of God...’ (Matt. 4:3,6). A well-developed missional theology is vital, but unhelpful if not accompanied by a missional spirituality that is informed by a robust understanding of the Powers. The imitation-based framework that this thesis will develop has, as its goal, to enable missional leaders to develop the kind of life that is worthy of imitation. This framework will validate Albert Schweitzer’s claim, ‘Example is not the *main* thing in influencing others. It is the *only* thing.’¹⁵⁰

¹⁴⁸ Fitch, “The Other Missional Conversation,” 469.

¹⁴⁹ Ibid., 473.

¹⁵⁰ Albert Schweitzer, *Albert Schweitzer Thoughts for Our Times*, ed. Erica Anderson, First edition. (White Plains, NY: Peter Pauper Press, 1975), 51.

Chapter 2

The Subversion of Leadership

In dealing with the problem of domineering leadership, this thesis proposes an imitation-based framework that considers how the unseen spiritual realities manifest through social structures and how they seek to subvert the missional leader through imitation and desire. The hope is that this framework might stimulate deeper self-reflection among leaders to prevent them from ‘falling’ to the subversive work of the Powers, and to develop a spirituality that enables them to live a life worth imitating.

Graham Houston in his book *Leading by Example: Peter’s Way for the Church Today*, in seeking to address the problem of domineering leadership that Peter addressed in his day, provides a way forward. This chapter examines the framework that emerges from Houston’s work, analysing it with the help of other voices, then evaluating the strengths and weaknesses of the framework.

Dealing with Misshapen Leadership in I Peter

With thirty-five years of experience as a Christian leader and New Testament scholar, Houston wrote *Leading by Example*, the third book in a trilogy.¹⁵¹ Houston explores I Peter from a practical theology perspective with a focus on leadership in the church in Peter’s day and how it should inform an approach to leadership today. Though reflecting on the whole letter, his key passage is I Peter 5:1-9, where Peter addresses the same issue this thesis seeks to address: the problem of domineering leadership in the church. Instead of lording it over others as a fellow elder, Peter calls the leaders (elders) of the church to be examples, following the way of Christ. Houston connects the problem of ‘lording it over others’ with leaders’ sinful desires to be in control and build their own kingdom. He then connects these desires with the work of the Powers.¹⁵² Considering the problem of domineering leadership, he mentions how Peter

¹⁵¹ Graham Houston, *Leading by Example: Peter’s Way for the Church Today* (Milton Keynes; Colorado Springs: Paternoster, 2008).

¹⁵² Houston was chosen as a primary source because he is reading I Peter from the perspective of domineering leadership. Other resources include: Paul J. Achtemeier, *Peter I Hermeneia*, ed. Eldon Jay (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 1996); John H. Elliott, *A Home for the Homeless: A Social-Scientific Criticism of I Peter, Its Situation and Strategy* (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock Publishers, 2005); I. Howard Marshall, *I Peter* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 1991); Lauri Thurén, *Argument and Theology in I Peter* (Sheffield, England: Sheffield Academic Press, 1995); Dennis R. Edwards, *I Peter*, ed. Tremper Longman III and Scot McKnight (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Academic, 2017).

calls the elders to be examples by following Jesus' example: to live as resident aliens in the house of Caesar. Because they are part of the household of God, they have a new identity. Based on their new identity they are called to live transformed lives amid suffering so that they might be witnesses of Christ and his way. Houston leverages this key passage to demonstrate how the themes of leadership, example/imitation, desire, and the Powers are found throughout the book of I Peter:

So I exhort the elders among you, as a fellow elder and a witness of the sufferings of Christ, as well as a partaker in the glory that is going to be revealed. Shepherd the flock of God that is among you, exercising oversight, not under compulsion, but willingly, as God would have you; not for shameful gain, but eagerly; not domineering over those in your charge, but being examples to the flock. And when the chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the unfading crown of glory. Likewise, you who are younger, be subject to the elders. Clothe yourselves, all of you, with humility toward one another, for God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.

Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God so that at the proper time he may exalt you, casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you. *Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour.* Resist him, firm in your faith, knowing the same kinds of suffering are being experienced by your brotherhood throughout the world [emphasis added],” (I Peter 5:1-9 ESV).

The Power of Imitation

Houston reminds us that authoritarianism is not a new problem in the church today, as he comments that “‘lording it’ is singled out by Peter as quite a distinct problem, and I believe it is just as destructive to healthy Christian fellowship in the twenty-first century as it was in the first...’ It is Houston’s contention that, when looking at the context of Peter’s letter, the leaders in the first century sought to uncritically imitate patterns of leadership in Asia Minor in the same way leaders today uncritically adopt market-place approaches to leadership in America, leading to similar problems. ‘Then, as now, authoritarianism was a real problem.’¹⁵³ Houston writes,

We shall try to follow Peter in his concern to avoid inappropriate ways of leading in the churches, especially those which are wedded to insights and influences that are not rooted in biblical modes and tend *uncritically to mimic imported cultural patterns, even when they arise from dominant sources* such as ancient Rome or contemporary America, with their attendant control of much of the communication media [emphasis added].¹⁵⁴

¹⁵³ Ibid., 51.

¹⁵⁴ Ibid., 43.

As Houston unpacks the theme of imitation here —especially the temptation for leaders to imitate the leadership styles of their current context uncritically, instead of imitating Christ — he describes how Jesus both modelled and taught his followers that, while the Gentiles exercise authority over them, if they wanted to become great they would need to become a servant, and even a slave.¹⁵⁵ ‘For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many,’ (Mark 10:45 NIV).

Continuing to tie the theme of imitation/example with leadership, Houston considers how Peter appeals to the elders as a fellow elder to do ministry not for their own gain or to dominate others, but to be an example of Christ. Houston speaks to how leaders not only imitate the doing (praxis) of others, but the very being (identity) of others, ‘our theme implies that it is possible to derive appropriate ways of being and doing from the example of others.’¹⁵⁶ He notes, ‘The Greek word for example found here is *typos*, the root of the English word type.’¹⁵⁷ The analogy he uses to describe this meaning is that of a typewriter, when someone hits letters on the typewriter, it leaves an impression, a mark on the paper. ‘Peter is speaking of leading as making an impression on others, or of leaving a mark.’¹⁵⁸

Because leaders leave a mark (impression) on others, they need to think carefully about their approach to leadership. Houston writes, ‘In contrast to lording it over all, Peter promotes the imitation of God in Christ as the only valid approach to leading by example.’¹⁵⁹ It is when leaders follow the example of Jesus that they become ‘good news people.’¹⁶⁰ Indeed, imitation is important both from the perspective of the leader imitating Christ as well as how the example of the leader shapes those who look to them as a model.

Dangerous Leaders Not to Imitate

Houston highlights the fact that leaders will either be good or poor examples. He quotes from John’s third letter: ‘I wrote to the church, but Diotrephes *who loves to be first*, will not welcome us... Dear friend, do not *imitate* what is evil but what is good [emphasis added]’ (3 John 9, 11 NIV).

¹⁵⁵ Ibid., 15.

¹⁵⁶ Ibid.

¹⁵⁷ Ibid.

¹⁵⁸ Ibid.

¹⁵⁹ Houston, *Leading by Example*, 16.

¹⁶⁰ Ibid., 18.

Here the theme of leadership and imitation is mentioned again, but this time it is also linked to the desire of the leader. Houston mentions how Diotrephes' desire to be first is evil and should not be imitated. He writes, 'So lording it, being overbearing, and loving to be first are all aspects of this problem we might term empire-building, which is the very antithesis of true Christian leadership. Yet such behaviour is often condoned and excused today, despite our claims to be part of the one true catholic and apostolic church.'¹⁶¹

Houston considers it likely that Peter wrote this letter in Rome, 'code-named Babylon (5:13),' under Nero's rule, just before he himself was martyred.¹⁶² In this context, Peter felt an urgent need to exhort 'the churches with a series of ethical imperatives, a feature that runs through the letter from 1:13 to 5:11,'¹⁶³ such as, 'do not conform to the evil desires you had when you lived in ignorance... Rid yourselves of all malice and all deceit, hypocrisy, envy and slander... Abstain from sinful desires... Live as free people...'¹⁶⁴

Houston brings up the theme of desire at different points in his book, as he is looking at leadership through Peter's perspective. In touching upon why the book was written, he draws upon Lauri Thurén's work on I Peter. Thurén believed that the 'main purpose of I Peter is to intensify the Christian conviction and commitment of people who are tempted to conform to the surrounding society in one way or another.'¹⁶⁵ Thurén is persuaded that Peter's audience is convinced of the message, but lacks the motivation, or one might say, the desire, to live differently. He asserts that Peter's aim was to give them fresh motivation, partly because of the unjust suffering they had to endure. 'He believes that if he can enhance right attitudes and encourage them to be more steadfast in their convictions, this will produce the desired outcome of changed behaviour and lifestyle.'¹⁶⁶ Houston consistently points out that a key motivation Peter uses, especially amid spiritual warfare, where the church's desires could become malformed, was to point them to Christ as an example. 'In I Peter the starting point is to focus on the attitude of Christ himself, as Paul does in Phil. 2:1-11, and then to

¹⁶¹ Ibid., 4.

¹⁶² Ibid., 10.

¹⁶³ Ibid.

¹⁶⁴ Ibid.

¹⁶⁵ Ibid., 28-29.

¹⁶⁶ Ibid., 29.

exhort Christians not to live out their lives according to evil human desires, but rather to do the will of God.’¹⁶⁷

The Subversive Work of the Powers

Houston links these important themes of leadership, imitation, and desire together, and then connects these themes to the Powers in his chapter “Authorities and Powers”. For Houston, ‘Peter’s warning and advice about the powers of evil, and how to handle them, are integral to his entire message in his letter about the place of suffering in the Christian life, and the standard struggles, which all believers must learn to survive.’¹⁶⁸ Houston believes Peter’s emphasis on the Powers has not been given the attention it deserves.

Houston devotes an entire chapter to the theme of the Powers because of the everyday spiritual warfare the believers face, and the suffering that leaders should expect, being no greater than their Master. ‘[Peter’s] ethical exhortation speaks about real struggles which typify the daily lives of his hearers and himself. Yet he is saying that behind the scenes there is another battle going on, in the spiritual realm. Inhabiting the structures of family, church, and society, as well as invading personal individual experience, there are other authorities and powers at work.’¹⁶⁹ Drawing from the work of Wink, he demonstrates how Peter understood evil at three levels: the personal, social, and ecclesial levels.

The other reason Houston focused attention on the Powers in his book on leadership, is because Peter, like Paul and James, recognized that the Powers seek to subvert the desires of Christian leaders by tempting them to mimic the ways of the devil. He writes,

There are great temptations awaiting all who seek to become teachers and leaders within the churches, and they are held especially accountable to God for the proper exercise of their powers. They dare not mimic the work of the devil and dominate God’s dear one’s but rather must follow Christ’s example of servant-leadership and face up to the reality that ‘power must become incarnate, institutionalized, or systemic’ as Walter Wink says.¹⁷⁰

Here, once again, Houston makes a clear connection between the concepts of leadership, imitation, and the Powers. For Houston, when Satan is brought up in the

¹⁶⁷ Ibid., 83.

¹⁶⁸ Ibid., 84.

¹⁶⁹ Ibid.

¹⁷⁰ Ibid., 95.

context of domineering leadership, it is not a digression, but is ‘part of [Peter’s] strategy of exposing evil in the individual Christians, in the community of faith, and in the pagan world around. “Lording it” is a pattern of behaviour, therefore, which Peter understands to be rooted in the machinations of the devil.’¹⁷¹

Clarifying this pattern, Houston goes on to demonstrate how imitation operates in two different ways. First, the need for leaders to imitate Christ, and second, the need for leaders to be a good model for others in their care. ‘Christian leaders who lord it over God’s people are succumbing to the schemes of Satan, as well as failing to model their ministry on the servant-leadership style of Christ, the Chief Shepherd.’¹⁷²

Expounding on the aforementioned connection between Peter, Paul, and James on the theme of the Powers, Houston highlights Paul’s teaching in multiple places (Eph. 1:21; 3:10, 6:10-20; Rom. 3:38; I Thess. 5:8) as well as James’, specifically in James 3:1-4:7. Noting similarities in how Peter and James close their respective passages: ‘In the same way, Peter’s fellow apostle James, had urged his people to “Submit yourselves to God. Resist the devil and he will flee from you” (Jas. 4:7).’¹⁷³ Houston begins his reflection with James’s understanding that many should not be teachers, because they will have harsher judgement, and then proceeds to write about the role of the tongue.

The tongue can be a vehicle for bitter envy and selfish ambition, warns James (3:14), but where does all this evil ultimately originate? In his first chapter, James had faced up to the weakness of people under temptation and tells them not to blame God for their own evil desires (1:13-15). But now he decides to name the powers which are behind such negative attitudes and actions. Christian leaders should demonstrate their wisdom and understanding, by living good lives in all humility, rather than by worldly wisdom, which ‘does not come down from heaven, but is earthly, unspiritual, demonic. For where you have envy and selfish ambition, there you find disorder and every evil practice [emphasis added],’ (3:15-16).¹⁷⁴

It is here where each of the elements of the imitation-based framework of this thesis emerges and where Houston demonstrates how desire and imitation is at the intersection of leadership and the Powers. In pulling together how the evil desires of envy and selfish ambition lead to the problem of domineering behaviour by church leaders (all inspired by the Powers) he makes clear how these desires end up misshaping the community. ‘The situation in the early church is volatile, and human

¹⁷¹ Ibid., 85.

¹⁷² Ibid., 97.

¹⁷³ Ibid., 85.

¹⁷⁴ Ibid., 86.

pride can lead to quarrels and fights, and push out humble prayer, so that intercessions and petitions remain unanswered by God. Why? You ask with wrong motives accuses James (Jas. 4:3; I Peter 3:6).’¹⁷⁵ From Houston’s study of I Peter, an imitation-based framework emerges that is geared to help with the central problem of domineering leadership. The imitation-based framework in (figure 1) demonstrates how imitation and desire connect missional leadership to the Powers.

Introducing the Imitation-based Framework (Leadership, Imitation, and the Powers)

In Houston’s *Leading by Example*, he skillfully describes how Peter addressed the problem of domineering leadership and suggests that Peter’s advice is relevant to the leadership crisis in the church today. In his study on I Peter, with his key passage of I Peter 5:1-9, Houston uncovers key themes as well as the relationship of leadership to imitation, desire, and the Powers. While Houston develops these themes in a general way, there remains a need to bring them to maturity, tightening the interrelatedness of the different elements and providing an imitation-based framework that reshapes leadership theory and practice. The hope is that this framework might guide missional leaders to be alert to how the Powers seek to subvert their leadership. This section is designed to analyse the various elements of the framework that emerges from Houston’s biblical study of I Peter. In analysis, it will become evident that, in order to strengthen this imitation-based framework, it will be necessary to engage Wink on a theology of the Powers and Girard on imitation and desire (mimetic desire).

The Three Directions of Imitation

When it comes to leadership and imitation, Houston makes several significant points. First, he establishes three different directions in which imitation can take place when it comes to leadership. The first two regard the missional leader and whom they seek to imitate. Leaders can mimic what they see in the world uncritically, or they can imitate Christ. The third direction, which he doesn’t fully develop, is the necessity of leader as an example, because of the impression they leave on others. This area needs clarification and development, as this thesis will argue the ‘impression’ or ‘mark’ that leaders leave on others, especially those who look to them as a model, is enormous.

¹⁷⁵ Ibid.

Analysis will show the need to engage Girard's argument to develop and give depth to this third direction of imitation, as well as providing additional motivation for the necessity of imitating Christ.

Uncritically Imitating Cultural Forms of Leadership

In his work on I Peter, Houston writes, 'What is interesting as we explore Christian patterns of leading connected with Peter is that his discussion in I Peter is clearly related to the stories in which he features in Mark's Gospel.'¹⁷⁶ Jesus made a clear impression on Peter. Jesus called Peter to follow him, not just as part of the twelve, but part of the intimate three, which included both James and John. Houston mentions how Peter has a strong presence in the book of Mark, which was likely written prior to Peter's letter, but in which Peter was not cast as a superhero.¹⁷⁷ His failures and mistakes are evident for all to see, including his desire to build three tabernacles at the Mount of transfiguration and claiming boldly that he would follow Christ unto death, then denying him three times. Peter's weaknesses are not hidden. Houston writes, 'There is no attempt to portray Peter and his friends as larger than life heroes in the Hellenistic traditions which they would have well known and understood.'¹⁷⁸ He concludes by saying 'Whatever Christian leadership is to be like in the apostolic communities, and in the expanding churches in which they planted, it is not rooted in triumphalism.'¹⁷⁹

He contrasts this with the triumphalism he sees in contemporary Western Christian leaders who proclaim themselves and their method of ministry as the answer, and seek to have their model uncritically exported to other situations.¹⁸⁰ He makes significant space in his book to talk about the problem of egotism, of 'selfism' and how this is in contrast to the humility that Peter stresses in the context of leadership when he says, 'God opposes the proud, but shows favour to the humble' (I Peter 5:5b).

Houston confirms what Roxburgh established in his examination of the history of ecclesial leadership. Roxburgh demonstrated how easily leaders tend to uncritically mimic the leadership style of the day, not realizing that a different telos and a different identity of the leader will ultimately lead to an unfaithful praxis. Peter, reflecting on his

¹⁷⁶ Ibid., 16.

¹⁷⁷ Ibid., 172.

¹⁷⁸ Ibid., 18.

¹⁷⁹ Ibid.

¹⁸⁰ Ibid., 25–26.

journey with Jesus, did not point to Roman or religious rulers for people to imitate. The person to whom Peter was confident in pointing people was Jesus, the one who modelled a cruciform love.¹⁸¹

The Priority of Imitating Christ

Houston, in his study of I Peter, confirms Fitch's argument, that the answer to colonialism and triumphalism is not to decentre Christ, but to wholeheartedly imitate him. Peter was reminding people who were undergoing suffering that Christ also suffered for them and left them an example of how to live when facing unjust suffering. Peter lifts Christ up as the concrete example throughout his letter.

Soon-Gu Kwon in his PhD thesis *Christ as Example: The Imitatio Christi Motive in Biblical and Christian Ethics* highlights key figures in the history of the church who made a fresh call for God's people to follow and imitate Christ.¹⁸² Starting with the words of Jesus and moving through the Pauline texts, Kwon focuses on Thomas á Kempis, author of *The Imitation of Christ*, which – next to the Bible – is the most read book in history, for Christians.¹⁸³ This book shaped significant leaders in the church, including John Wesley and Dietrich Bonhoeffer. The strength of this book is á Kempis's focus on union and communion with God, dying to self, and living humbly. Wisdom, in his view, is *how* one lives *not* what one says. This confirms that a good missional theology without a rich spirituality is not sufficient. A strong missional spirituality is needed. Kwon calls this the monastic interpretation of *imitatio Christi*. He then moves to Soren Kierkegaard, in what he labels an ascetic interpretation. 'In the ascetic understanding of the imitation of Christ, Christians are to pursue a slow death to the world as a way of imitating Christ.'¹⁸⁴ Next Kwon examines Bonhoeffer, in what Kwon calls a political interpretation of following Christ. Bonhoeffer wrote *Discipleship* during the rise of Hitler, when the Powers were in full force. For Bonhoeffer,

Discipleship is a commitment to Christ. Because Christ exists, he must be followed. An idea about Christ, a doctrinal system, a general religious recognition of grace or forgiveness of sins does not require discipleship. In truth, it even excludes discipleship; it is inimical to it. One enters into a relationship with an idea by way of knowledge, enthusiasm, perhaps even by carrying it out, but never by personal obedient discipleship. Christianity without

¹⁸¹ Houston, *Leading by Example*, 99.

¹⁸² Soon-Gu Kwon, *Christ as Example: The Imitatio Christi Motive in Biblical and Christian Ethics*, Acta Universitatis Upsaliensis 21 (Uppsala, Sweden: Uppsala University Library, 1998).

¹⁸³ Ibid., 86.

¹⁸⁴ Ibid., 99.

the living Jesus Christ remains necessarily a Christianity without discipleship; and a Christianity without discipleship is always a Christianity without Jesus Christ.¹⁸⁵

Bonhoeffer gives clarity to the importance of following and imitating Christ and demonstrates the need to make a strong call to follow Christ, especially amid the Powers working so visibly. This rich history of calling the church to model Christ continues to capture the interest of scholars today.¹⁸⁶

When it comes to leadership, Houston points out that Peter is aware that some of the leaders (elders) are looking for their models in the wrong places, so he points them to Christ. In the three directions of leadership, the first two address the model that the leaders are seeking to imitate or follow. The third direction addresses those who are being shaped by the leader.

The Power of Imitation

Houston, in his explanation of Peter calling the elders to be an “example,” mentions the word means leaving an impression or mark on others. But he fails to develop this theme. Girard is one of the primary interlocutors for this thesis because imitation is foundational to his project. Girard makes the case that there is only one way to overcome the Powers and that is to imitate Christ. An important contribution that Girard brings to the rich tradition of *imitatio Christi* is his understanding that imitation most profoundly takes place in the area of desires. In this way, it is evident how imitation of Christ leads followers into the life of the Trinity, for as Christ desires the Father, those who imitate him will desire the Father as well. In the same way, as Christ desires and loves the Spirit, those who imitate him will also desire the Spirit. This concept will be important to unpack because, as Houston points out, desire is a theme that is significant for Peter.

¹⁸⁵ Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *Discipleship DBW Vol 4* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 2003), 59.

¹⁸⁶ N. T. Wright, *Following Jesus: Biblical Reflections on Discipleship* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2014); Richard A. Burridge, *Imitating Jesus: An Inclusive Approach to New Testament Ethics*, 1st edition. (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2007); Jason B. Hood, *Imitating God in Christ: Recapturing a Biblical Pattern* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2013); Cornelis Bennema, *Mimesis in the Johannine Literature: A Study in Johannine Ethics* (London: T&T Clark, 2019); Peter James Hedderwick Adam, “The Practice of the Imitation of Christ with Special Reference to the Theology of Dietrich Bonhoeffer.” (Durham thesis, Durham University, 1981), accessed November 14, 2019, <http://etheses.dur.ac.uk/7559/>.

The Pre-eminence of Desire

Houston rightly points out the various places that Peter emphasises the importance of desire. He demonstrates that desire is a central idea in James and reminds us of how Peter's entire letter was written to give motivation to the leaders and other recipients to reshape their desire to imitate Christ. In addition, when talking about leadership, Houston refers to Diotrephes' desire to be first (3 John 1:9) as evil and not something to be imitated. This highlights an apparent link between desire and imitation, as well as the contagious nature of desire. While Houston gives attention to this theme of desire, it lacks the development needed to offer a missional spirituality for leaders. This section will demonstrate *why* desire is at the centre of the conceptual framework with imitation, linking the Powers to missional leadership, and why Girard is needed to develop this concept.

One of the goals of developing this imitation-based framework is to help leaders become aware of their desires, the way that the Powers seek to distort them, and how fully imitating Christ, through embodied practices can reshape the telos of their desires toward God, his kingdom, and his righteousness. While mimetic desire will be taken up with Girard, William Stringfellow will give us the concrete ways the Powers seek to misshape the leader's desire.

James K.A. Smith, in *Desiring the Kingdom*, articulates a philosophical anthropology that understands humanity not simply as people-as-thinkers shaped by ideas, or people-as-believers shaped by faith, but ultimately people-as-lovers, shaped by desire, which is always aimed toward a telos.¹⁸⁷ In seeking to reframe how education takes place in learning institutions, especially those that are confessional, he asks, 'What if education, including higher education, is not primarily about the absorption of ideas and information, but about the *formation* of hearts and desires.'¹⁸⁸ Smith recalls that 'what distinguishes Augustine's two cities (the earthly city and the city of God) is not ideas or beliefs but love.'¹⁸⁹ To make his case in support of Augustine, he reviews some of the reasons education today is often approached with this reductive view of people-as-thinkers, or people-as-believers, instead of people-as-lovers.

¹⁸⁷ James K. A. Smith, *Desiring the Kingdom: Worship, Worldview, and Cultural Formation* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009).

¹⁸⁸ Ibid., 17–18.

¹⁸⁹ Ibid., 46.

Smith articulates how people-as-thinkers, a rationalist or intellectualist picture of humanity, as old as Plato, was revived by Descartes and cultivated through modernity. And while it still tends to dominate a current understanding of human nature, it is ultimately reductive.¹⁹⁰ He believes this rationalist picture of humanity was ‘absorbed particularly by Protestant Christianity (whether liberal or conservative)’ operating on an overly intellectual account of human beings.¹⁹¹ He writes, ‘We could describe this as “bobble head” Christianity, so fixated on the cognitive that it assumes a picture of human beings that look like bobble heads: mammoth heads that dwarf an almost non-existent body.’¹⁹² The problem he cites is that when the church buys into a cognitivist anthropology, pedagogy becomes stunted because of its fixation on the mind without addressing the heart.¹⁹³

This overly cognitive approach to human beings has been contested, especially within the Reformed tradition. Smith describes this move from seeing people-as-thinkers to people-as-believers, saying, ‘In this alternative anthropology, human persons are understood not as fundamentally thinking machines but rather as believing animals, or essentially religious creatures, defined by a worldview that is pre-rational or supra-rational.’¹⁹⁴ With this anthropological understanding ‘What defines us is not what we think – not the set of ideas we assent to – but rather what we believe, the commitments and trusts that orient our being-in-the-world.’¹⁹⁵ While Smith sees this move as laudable, it fails to get to the heart of the matter. The clash of ideas moves to the clash of beliefs, and the person-as-believer still tends to be disembodied and individualistic.¹⁹⁶ In his question on how education is approached today, he writes, ‘Is the “believing” pedagogy really going to look much different from the “rationalist” pedagogy?’¹⁹⁷ He considers both to still be in the *information* paradigm, instead of moving to the *formation* paradigm. While not rejecting the importance of thinking and believing, there is a need for a more robust anthropology, giving a more central place to embodiment.¹⁹⁸

¹⁹⁰ Ibid., 41–42.

¹⁹¹ Ibid., 42.

¹⁹² Ibid., 42–43.

¹⁹³ Ibid., 43.

¹⁹⁴ Ibid.

¹⁹⁵ Ibid.

¹⁹⁶ Ibid., 44.

¹⁹⁷ Ibid., 45.

¹⁹⁸ Ibid., 46.

In opposition to viewing humanity primarily as thinking or believing people, he states, ‘We need a non-reductionistic understanding of human persons as embodied agents of desire or love.’¹⁹⁹ In this Augustinian model of humanity the centre of gravity moves from the head to the heart, and considers ‘noncognitive ways of being-in-the-world.’²⁰⁰ For Smith, as with Augustine, people are ultimately creatures of desire. The anthropological picture of humans that Smith develops is people-as-lovers, whose desires are aimed at a particular telos, a specific vision of the good life. He describes it like this:

Such a picture of human flourishing will have all sort of components: implicit in it will be assumptions about what good relationships look like, what a just economy and distributions of resources look like, what sorts of recreation and play we value, how we out to relate to nature and the nonhuman environment, what sorts of work counts as good work, what flourishing families look like, and much more... Our ultimate love is oriented by and to a picture of what we think it looks like for us to live well, and that picture then governs, shapes, and motivates our decisions and actions.²⁰¹

A vision of the good life captures hearts and imaginations. Smith emphasises that ‘The *telos* to which our love is aimed is not a list of ideas or propositions or doctrines; it is not a list of abstract, disembodied concepts or values. Rather, the reason that this vision of the good life moves us is because it is a more affective, sensible, even aesthetic picture of what the good life looks like.’²⁰² What captures one’s imagination and desire are pictures, which are ‘communicated most powerfully in stories, legends, myths, plays, novels, and films rather than dissertations, messages, and monographs.’²⁰³

Identities Shaped by Desire

Smith articulates a robust philosophical anthropology, in the way of Augustine, that captures the fullness of what it means to be human, and desire is at the centre. Smith maintains that because people are primarily shaped by their desires, ‘what constitutes our ultimate identities – what makes us who we are, the kind of people we are – is what we love.’²⁰⁴ Homing in on the core of the issue, he writes, ‘our identity is shaped by what we ultimately love or what we love as ultimate – what at the end of the day, gives us a sense of meaning, purpose, understanding, and orientation to our being-in-the-

¹⁹⁹ Ibid., 47.

²⁰⁰ Ibid., 46.

²⁰¹ Ibid., 52–53.

²⁰² Ibid., 53.

²⁰³ Ibid.

²⁰⁴ Ibid., 26.

world.’²⁰⁵ For Smith, to be human is to love, to desire, and one’s ultimate love defines one’s identity, because ‘our ultimate love is what we *worship*’.²⁰⁶

As Smith continues with his project, he also seeks to diagnose what shapes desire. He talks about habits, in the way of Alasdair MacIntyre, as love’s fulcrum, and embodied practices as the formation of loves.²⁰⁷ Smith writes about the importance of liturgies as thick practices that shape the identity and telos of people, whether it be the liturgy of the mall or the liturgy of a church service. What is important to note at this point is the case that Smith makes that desire is central to what it means to be human. People become what they love. The desires of leaders form their identities. The aim of their desires, telos of their desires, shape both the identity and the praxis of leaders.

While Smith gives significant wisdom on how desires can become misshapen and reshaped through “secular” and religious liturgies, Girard will make the case from anthropology, mythology, and the Scriptures that what are most formative regarding desire are one’s models.

The Influence of the Unseen Realm

Houston notes that ‘Peter believed that he was struggling against spiritual opposition, as did Paul, and that he needed to prepare his people to engage in spiritual warfare.’²⁰⁸ Christian leaders should expect to suffer unjustly, just as their chief shepherd did.²⁰⁹ Suffering would take place with civil authorities, at home in the family, and within the churches themselves.²¹⁰ The temptation would be to return evil for evil, but Peter pointed them to Christ, who repaid evil with good. It was through prayer and a Christ-like attitude that they could learn to overcome evil.²¹¹ Houston points out that behind the suffering another battle is going on, ‘Inhabiting the structures of family, church and society, as well as invading personal individual experience, there are other authorities and powers at work.’²¹² For Peter, ‘Your enemy the devil prowls around like a roaring lion looking for someone to devour.’²¹³ Peter tells them to resist him, and stand firm in the faith. ‘Peter’s warnings and advice about the powers and evil, and how to handle

²⁰⁵ Ibid., 26–27.

²⁰⁶ Ibid., 51.

²⁰⁷ Ibid., 55–62.

²⁰⁸ Houston, *Leading by Example*, 80.

²⁰⁹ Ibid., 81.

²¹⁰ Ibid.

²¹¹ Ibid., 84.

²¹² Ibid.

²¹³ Ibid.

them, are integral to his entire message in this letter about the place of suffering in the Christian life, and the standard struggles which all believers must learn to survive.’²¹⁴

Houston reminds the reader that Peter was acutely aware of the insidious influence of evil, for in response to Jesus going to the cross, Peter rebuked him, and in turn Jesus rebuked Peter, saying ‘Get behind me Satan!’ (Mark 8:33 NIV). Houston wisely goes to James who has a similar admonition, ‘Submit yourselves, then, to God. Resist the devil and he will flee from you,’ (James 4:7 NIV). James was addressing the teachers of the church and reminding them of the power of the tongue, and not to use it to curse others made in God’s image, but to live good lives ‘in all humility, rather than by worldly wisdom, which “does not come from heaven, but is earthly, unspiritual, demonic. For where you have envy and selfish ambition, there you find disorder and every evil practice” (Jas 3:15-16).’²¹⁵

Houston believes, looking at these two letters holistically, that ‘we see how the problem of domineering behaviours by church leaders is of massive concern to the apostolic teams.’²¹⁶ The battle is clearly with the powers. In an effort to go beyond just an individualistic approach to the Powers, he turns to Wink’s trilogy, observing how the Powers inhabit ‘authorities in the real world, as well as infiltrating the church.’²¹⁷ Because Houston, Newbigin, and others continually cite Wink as authoritative on the Powers, there is a need to engage Wink to better understand the nature of the Powers. This will be done in the next chapter. It is also important to understand the development of the scholastic understanding of the Powers, which this section will provide.

Before Houston moves on from the Powers, he takes ‘a closer look at *exousia* – and demonic domineering’.²¹⁸ This is an important contribution, as it relates to leadership, authority, and the powers. He first discusses two words pertaining to authority that are relevant to this thesis: *exousia* (‘authority’, ‘ruling power’, ‘bearer of authority’) and *katexousiazein* (‘to exercise authority over’, ‘to misuse official authority’, ‘to tyrannize’).²¹⁹ Essentially, ‘*Exousia* denotes the power which may be demonstrated in legal, political, social, or moral affairs, and is always linked with a

²¹⁴ Ibid.

²¹⁵ Ibid., 86.

²¹⁶ Ibid.

²¹⁷ Ibid., 89.

²¹⁸ Ibid., 92.

²¹⁹ Ibid.

particular position or mandate. Such authority can be delegated, and may also be illegally usurped by despots.’²²⁰

In the Septuagint, *exousia* reflected authority given by God, the Lord of history. Houston turns to Otto Betz for an explanation of *exousia* in the New Testament. ‘*Exousia* is that power, authority, and freedom of action which belongs (1) to God himself; (2) to a commission in the last days; to (3) a Christian in his eschatological existence.’²²¹ The first use ‘links God’s ultimate authority with his role as the Lord of history.’²²² Though the Powers continually seek to usurp God’s authority, he is still Lord. The second area Betz addresses ‘has to do with the fact that Jesus has been given *exousia*, in a special way. His earthly ministry uniquely heralds the coming of God’s reign, and announces that evil powers have been dealt with definitively in Jesus’ life, death, and resurrection.’²²³ This is demonstrated in that Jesus had authority to destroy the works of the devil, exorcise demons, forgive sins, and preach with an authority not found among the scribes.²²⁴

Finally, according to Betz, ‘all Christian believers, and not just leaders, have a delegated authority, founded on the reign of Christ as Lord and his disarming of the powers of evil, which entails a vocation of both freedom and service.’²²⁵ Yet, because Christians can be addicted to authority, in returning to Peter’s admonition to the elders not to lord authority over others, Betz gives this word of caution: ‘There is only one Lord, Jesus Christ, and those who “lord it” over Christian congregations or agencies are usurping his authority, just as the heavenly and earthly powers of evil have done throughout history.’²²⁶ Leaders must remember that their delegated authority is only valid when under the authority of Christ, the chief shepherd. And it is given for the flourishing of the community and the wider commonwealth.²²⁷ Therefore, leaders, while tempted to usurp God’s authority, are accountable to God for the proper use of their authority.²²⁸ ‘They dare not mimic the work of the devil and dominate God’s dear

²²⁰ Ibid.

²²¹ Ibid., 92–93.

²²² Ibid., 93.

²²³ Ibid.

²²⁴ Ibid., 93–94.

²²⁵ Ibid., 94.

²²⁶ Ibid., 95.

²²⁷ Ibid.

²²⁸ Ibid.

ones, but rather must follow Christ's example of servant-leadership.^{'229} With this understanding, an analysis of the historical development of the Powers is necessary.

The Rediscovery of the Powers

The language of the Powers has been obscured until recent history. Bill Wylie-Kellerman writes, 'In fact, for most of its history, the gods of this world have blinded the Church to its own scriptures with respect to the "principalities and powers." In the hermeneutical history these terms have been excised, suppressed and obscured.'²³⁰ W.A. Visser 't Hooft and Marva Dawn make the case that the Powers' language 'fell out of use during the time of the Reformation, when various apocalyptic sects made Martin Luther and John Calvin cautious about eschatology.'²³¹ Meanwhile, Wink and Stringfellow locate the loss and hiddenness of the powers in the fourth century with the 'Constantinian Arrangement' when the Church 'became the darling of Constantine.'²³² Wink writes,

Called on to legitimate the empire, the church abandoned much of its social critique. The Powers were soon divorced from political affairs and made airy spirits who preyed only on individuals. The state was thus freed of one of the most powerful brakes against idolatry, although prophetic voices never ceased to be raised now and again anyway.²³³

While the disappearance of the Powers language is located at different times, there is agreement that the rise and fall of Hitler and Nazi Germany brought a renewed scholarly interest in the Powers. The Enlightenment project had failed; theologians needed a more holistic and comprehensive way to articulate the power of evil.

While Amos Yong and Marva Dawn give an excellent history of the literary and theological engagement with the Powers, it is important to note a couple of things

²²⁹ Ibid.

²³⁰ Bill Wylie-Kellermann, "Not Vice Versa. Reading the Powers Biblically: Stringfellow, Hermeneutics, and the Principalities," *Anglican Theological Review* 81, no. 4 (October 1, 1999): 665–682, accessed November 13, 2019, <https://www.questia.com/library/journal/1P3-47298237/not-vice-versa-reading-the-powers-biblically-stringfellow>.

²³¹ Marva J. Dawn, *Powers, Weakness, and the Tabernacling of God* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2001), 4; W. A. Visser 't Hooft, *The Kingship of Christ* (New York: Harper and Brothers, 1947), 15–31.

²³² Wylie-Kellermann, "Not Vice Versa. Reading the Powers Biblically," 665–682.

²³³ Walter Wink, *Naming the Powers: The Language of Power in the New Testament* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress Press, 1984), 113.

before analysing three ontological perspectives of the principalities and powers.²³⁴ Karl Barth and Paul Tillich, two influential theological voices in the 1930s, made it palatable for academics to re-engage and develop a theology of the powers. Barth, at the rise of Hitler and Nazism, was not only the primary author of the Barmen declaration for the resisting church, but also wrote *Church and State* (1938).²³⁵ This book was written to help the Church navigate its life when the State becomes demonic by absolutizing itself, as did Nazi Germany. Barth, agreeing with the reformed theological understanding of the State as part of God's good created order, affirmed the church's need to be *for* the State. Barth provided (through prayer) a way for the church to minister to the State by helping it remember its divine legitimation comes through Jesus, the Lord of Lords. Therefore, when the State seeks self-deification, while the church is to continue to pray for the State and respect its leaders, the church must remain faithful to its Lord above all, and (through passive and active resistance) help the State live up to its divine role.

Tillich named nationalism and authoritarianism as demonic. 'Tillich was acutely aware of the fact and function of the demonic in human existence.'²³⁶ In *The Eternal Now*, he talks about the importance of healing the sick and casting out demons. In his reflection on Romans 7, he identifies Sin's power: 'Paul seldom speaks of sins, but he often speaks of Sin – Sin in the singular with a capital "S". Sin as a power that controls world and mind, persons and nations.'²³⁷

G.B. Caird's, *Principalities and Powers: A Study in Pauline Theology* (1956), is another significant early work, drawn from his lectures at Queen's University in Kingston, Ontario in 1954.²³⁸ And Gordon Rupp, a Methodist minister who famously challenged the charge that Martin Luther was the spiritual ancestor of Hitler, wrote

²³⁴ Dawn, *Powers, Weakness, and the Tabernacling of God*, 1–34; Amos Yong, *In the Days of Caesar: Pentecostalism and Political Theology*, The Cadbury lectures 2009 (Grand Rapids, MI: W.B. Eerdmans Pub. Co, 2010), 134–150.

²³⁵ Karl Barth, *Church and State*, trans. G. Ronald Howe, Church classics (Greenville, S.C: Smyth & Helwys Pub, 1991).

²³⁶ Vernon R. Mallow, *The Demonic: A Selected Theological Study: An Examination into the Theology of Edwin Lewis, Karl Barth, and Paul Tillich* (Lanham, MD: University Press of America, 1983), 102.

²³⁷ Paul Tillich, *The Eternal Now* (London: Scribner, 1963), 20.

²³⁸ G. B. Caird, *Principalities and Powers: A Study in Pauline Theology: The Chancellor's Lectures for 1954 at Queen's University, Kingston Ontario* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Pub, 2003).

Principalities and Powers: Studies in Christian Conflict in History (1952), pointing out the many parallels and similarities between the early church and contemporary times.²³⁹

While others were publishing on this topic in the 1960's, two of the most significant writers were William Stringfellow in the United States and Jacques Ellul in France. Stringfellow will be engaged to bring some clarity to this thesis in the final chapter.

Finally, an academic missionary anthropologist often brought into this conversation is Paul Hiebert. Through his work on critical contextualization he sharpens one's interpretive lens, insisting that everyone comes to Scripture with their socialized selves and ethnocentric glasses, which distorts one's view of the world.²⁴⁰ Near the end of his life he wrote a brief article entitled *Spiritual Warfare and World Views*, where he says, 'If our understanding of spiritual warfare does not see the cross as the final triumph, it is wrong.'²⁴¹ While Hiebert's work is important, Girard, as a cultural anthropologist, was chosen as a primary interlocutor for this thesis, because the focus of his life work was on the Powers, and he ties missional leaders to the Powers through his concept of mimetic desire, thus giving this thesis an original contribution.

Three Ontological Perspectives of the Powers

With this brief history, it is important to analyse three key voices: Clinton Arnold, Rudolf Bultmann, and Hendrick Berkhof. They represent the 'three contemporary interpretations of the New Testament Powers: a traditional (spiritualist) view, a demythologized (reductionistic) model, and a dual-reference option.'²⁴² There are three questions to keep in mind through this analysis: (1) What is the nature of the powers? (2) How do the powers seek to subvert the missional leader? (3) Can the Powers be redeemed or must they be renounced and resisted?

Clinton Arnold

In his work, *Powers of Darkness: Principalities and Powers in Paul's Letters*, Clinton Arnold critiques views of the principalities and powers as impersonal social, economic,

²³⁹ E. Gordon Rupp, *Principalities and Powers: Studies in the Christian Conflict in History* (London: The Epworth Press, 1952).

²⁴⁰ Paul Hiebert, *The Gospel in Human Contexts: Anthropological Explorations for Contemporary Missions*. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009).

²⁴¹ Paul Hiebert, "Spiritual Warfare and Worldviews" (Presented at the Lausanne, Nairobi, Kenya: Lausanne Movement, 2000), accessed July 2, 2020, <https://www.lausanne.org/content/spiritual-warfare-and-worldview>.

²⁴² Yong, *In the Days of Caesar*, 145.

and political structures rather than organized personal spiritual beings led by Satan, whose aim is to lead humanity away from God and oppose the people and work of God.²⁴³ Arnold argues for a traditional three-fold understanding of the nature of evil involving the flesh, the Devil and his entourage, and the World. He sees the sources of evil as interior (flesh), exterior (world), and supernatural (devil).²⁴⁴ As James Beilby and Paul Eddy remark, ‘This triumvirate has become one common way of expressing the primary foci of spiritual warfare.’²⁴⁵ Arnold believes that Paul was a man of his times, and that both he and his first century audience believed in the ontological reality of personal spiritual beings. He states,

I would suggest, that it is erroneous to equate the powers with the structures. As I will argue, we ought to distinguish between the powers of darkness and the structures of our existence. The two categories are ontologically distinct. One is personal, the other nonpersonal; one possesses intelligence and the ability to will, the other does not. Truer to Paul’s letters is to say that the powers exert their influence over the structures of our existence than to make the powers coextensive with the structures.²⁴⁶

Arnold considers the principalities and powers in Paul’s writing to represent personal demonic spirits with ontological reality. This leads Arnold to a classical evangelical approach to spiritual warfare.

Arnold believes that Paul, in his letters, emphasises the powers working to prevent people from becoming Christians and stall Christians character formation. ‘The major issue of concern for Paul, therefore, is not so much the relevance of the powers with regard to social justice, but their implications of salvation history and Christian behaviour.’²⁴⁷ For Arnold, Paul does not direct Christians toward ‘reforming the social or political order.’²⁴⁸ The gospel proclamation is important ‘because it has otherworldly, eternal implications.’²⁴⁹ In Arnold’s analysis, ‘the institutions of this world (*kosmos*) and the structures of the present age (*aion*) are destined to perish.’²⁵⁰ Consequently, as Christians focus on seeing people changed, and to the degree that people are changed, institutions will become more liberating.

²⁴³ Clinton E. Arnold, *Powers of Darkness: Principalities & Powers in Paul’s Letters* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2009).

²⁴⁴ *Ibid.*, 134.

²⁴⁵ James K. Beilby and Paul R. Eddy, eds., *Understanding Spiritual Warfare: Four Views* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2012), 32.

²⁴⁶ Arnold, *Powers of Darkness*, 183.

²⁴⁷ *Ibid.*, 201.

²⁴⁸ *Ibid.*

²⁴⁹ *Ibid.*

²⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, 205.

While Arnold does well in considering the message in its given context, there are several critiques to make. Robert Ewusie Moses, whose PhD dissertation is entitled, ‘Powerful Practices: Paul’s Principalities and Powers Revisited’, critiques Arnold noting, ‘The main deficiency of this approach is that it falls short of offering the church a comprehensive view of the nature and methods of the powers, and arming the church with the adequate tools needed to combat the powers.’²⁵¹ Moses’ indicts Arnold’s understanding of the principalities and powers as simply being personal spiritual beings saying, ‘The church needs to come to terms with the complex and myriad schemes and methods of the powers. In the end, one wonders if the purely personal interpretation of the powers has not itself succumbed to the ‘powers’ of modern individualism and Romanticism.’²⁵²

While Moses seems to miss Arnold’s mention of social structures, he is right to notice that it has trivial importance for him. Arnold has simplified the Powers to only malevolent spirits, whereas Paul seems to include more (Rom. 8:38-39). Berkhof makes the case that ‘Paul observes that life is ruled by a series of Power. He speaks of time (present and future), of space (depth and height), of life and death, of politics and philosophy, of public opinion and Jewish law, of pious tradition and the fateful course of the stars. Apart from Christ, man is at the mercy of these Powers.’²⁵³

In addition, Arnold deals with the reconciliation of the Powers mentioned in Colossians inadequately (Col. 1:25-20). On one hand, ‘all things’ reconciled through Christ in the passage ‘includes the heavenly entities, namely the principalities and powers’ which he basically considers demons.²⁵⁴ Then on the other hand, he writes, ‘Certainly the powers of darkness will not be redeemed in the same sense as Christians and thus experience a reconciliation with God as friends.’²⁵⁵ So while the principalities and powers are at first reconciled, finally, they are not. In agreement with Arnold, the telos of the devil and the demonic seems tenuous at best (Matt. 25:41, Rev. 20:20), but it seems the principalities and powers are redeemable. For under the larger umbrella of the Powers, it seems important to distinguish between the devil, the demonic, and the principalities and powers, partly because the principalities and powers seem

²⁵¹ Robert Ewusie Moses, “Powerful Practices: Paul’s Principalities and Powers Revisited” (PhD diss., Duke Divinity School, 2012), 16.

²⁵² Ibid., 19.

²⁵³ Hendrik Berkhof, *Christ and the Powers*, trans. John Howard Yoder, 2nd ed. (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1977), 22.

²⁵⁴ Arnold, *Powers of Darkness*, 144.

²⁵⁵ Ibid., 164.

redeemable, while the devil and demonic do not. Arnold tries to deal with this tension by saying, ‘the powers will ultimately be brought to their knees before him.’²⁵⁶ The difficulty with this statement is that it does not sound like reconciliation, it sounds like forced submission. In the end, Moses offers insight: ‘Paul’s account of the powers presents us with comprehensive features of reality; and a purely personal interpretation of the powers is too simplistic to capture adequately Paul’s complex presentation of the powers.’²⁵⁷

Rudolf Bultmann

One of the most common interlocutors chosen to engage the theme of the Powers, either in a complementary or contrasting fashion, is Rudolf Bultmann.²⁵⁸ In seeking to translate the Powers for an enlightened and scientific age, he demythologized the powers, choosing to interpret the Powers from an existential point of view.²⁵⁹ Bultmann in *New Testament and Mythology* begins by stating,

The world picture of the New Testament is a mythical world picture. The three-story structures, with the earth in the middle, heaven above it, and hell below it. Heaven is the dwelling place of God and of heavenly figures, the angels; the world below is hell, the place of torment. But even the earth is not simply the scene of natural day-to-day occurrences, of foresight and work that reckon with order and regularity; rather, it too, is a theatre for the working of supernatural powers, God and his angels, Satan and his demons. These supernatural powers intervene in natural occurrences and in the thinking, willing and acting of human beings; wonders are nothing unusual. Human beings are not their own masters; demons can possess them, and Satan can put bad ideas into their heads.²⁶⁰

²⁵⁶ Ibid., 144.

²⁵⁷ Moses, “Powerful Practices,” 19.

²⁵⁸ Earnst Käsemann, “The Eschatological Royal Reign of God,” in *Your Kingdom Come: Mission Perspectives*, Report on the World Conference on Mission and Evangelism, Melbourne, Australia, 12-25 May (World Council of Churches, 1980); Marva J. Dawn, “The Concept of ‘The Principalities and Powers’ in the Works of Jacques Ellul” (PhD diss., University of Notre Dame, 1992); Dawn, *Powers, Weakness, and the Tabernacling of God*; Kabiro wa Gatumu, *The Pauline Concept of Supernatural Powers: A Reading from the African Worldview* (Milton Keynes: Paternoster, 2008); Arnold, *Powers of Darkness*; Yong, *In the Days of Caesar*; James K. Beilby and Paul R. Eddy, eds., *Understanding Spiritual Warfare: Four Views* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2012); Hardy, Whitehouse, and Yarnell, *Power and the Powers*; Esther Acolatse, *Powers, Principalities, and the Spirit: Biblical Realism in Africa and the West* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 2018).

²⁵⁹ Moses, “Powerful Practices,” 20.

²⁶⁰ Rudolf Bultmann, “New Testament and Mythology: The Problem of Demythologizing the New Testament Proclamation (1941),” in *New Testament and Mythology and Other Basic Writings*, trans. Schubert M. Ogden (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress Press, 1984), 1.

As Bultmann continues to share the story of the New Testament and the story of redemption, he speaks of it as myth. He believes that all of this is mythical talk that can be traced back to Jewish apocalypticism and the Gnostic myth of redemption.²⁶¹

Bultmann contends that the New Testament authors spoke mythically, in the language of their context. But now, living in a scientific context, he states that ‘the task of theology is to demythologize the Christian proclamation.’²⁶² For Bultmann, the Enlightenment and the development of science and technology means asking someone to believe in the New Testament world is to split from reality and live untruthfully.²⁶³ ‘We cannot use electric lights and at the same time believe in the spirit and wonder world of the New Testament.’²⁶⁴ He contends, ‘If the New Testament proclamation is to retain its validity, there is nothing to do but to demythologize it.’²⁶⁵

Bultmann then goes on to describe the task at hand. ‘Demythologizing seeks to bring about the real intention of the myth, namely, its intention to talk about human existence as grounded in and limited by a transcendent, unworldly power, which is not visible to objectifying thinking.’²⁶⁶ For Bultmann, to demythologize is to interpret scripture so that it speaks to the existential realities that humanity faces. The purpose is to reveal the truth of the *kerygma* behind the myth. So, when speaking of the principalities and powers, he writes:

The spirit powers represent the reality into which man is placed as one full of conflicts and struggle, a reality which threatens and tempts. Thus, through these mythological conceptions the insight is indirectly expressed that man does not have his life in his hand as if he were his own lord but that he is constantly confronted with the decision of choosing his lord. Beyond that, they also contain the conviction that natural man has always already decided against God, his true Lord, and has let the threatening and tempting world become lord over him.²⁶⁷

The heart of the *kerygma*, when it comes to the Powers, is coming to an understanding that people live in a world that is beyond their control, one filled with

²⁶¹ Ibid., 2.

²⁶² Ibid., 3.

²⁶³ Ibid., 3–4.

²⁶⁴ Ibid., 4.

²⁶⁵ Ibid., 9.

²⁶⁶ Rudolf Bultmann, “On the Problem of Demythologizing (1952),” in *New Testament and Mythology and Other Basic Writings*, trans. Schubert M. Ogden (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress Press, 1984), 99.

²⁶⁷ Rudolf Bultmann, *Theology of the New Testament: Complete in One Volume* (New York: Prentice Hall, 1970), 259.

struggle, temptation, and conflict where they must choose to which lord they will submit their lives.

Bultmann is to be commended for seeking to translate the message of the New Testament regarding Satan and demons for people shaped by a scientific and materialistic worldview, since some have sought to accommodate to the point of disposing of these themes altogether. Kenyan scholar Kabiro wa Gutumu states, ‘demythologization compels interpreters to pay attention to their pre-understandings and assumptions as they read the text within its religio-cultural and socio-political context.’²⁶⁸ He goes on to say,

It is by appreciating the context of production [the time the text was written] that we can re-contextualize the Pauline texts in the context of reception [our current context] without sneaking our default setting into the text and the context of production... So, even if the New Testament can be interpreted today within a particular frame of reference, which may differ radically from what the text initially addressed, this does not mean today’s interpretation is what the text originally meant.²⁶⁹

While it is necessary to contextualize the message of the Bible for another time and another place, it is possible to over-accommodate and lose important truths that are designed to challenge a given worldview. Gatumu reminds us that it is crucial to interpret the New Testament so that the past comes alive, illuminating the present with new possibilities, *but* solid exegesis coupled with reflective hermeneutics is vital.

Moses uses Barth to critique Bultmann, writing ‘Karl Barth detects that the NT writers are less determined by their inherited cosmology than we are by our contemporary worldview.’²⁷⁰ And that while ‘we may label the world picture of the NT authors as “magical,” this “magical” world picture did not prevent the NT authors from taking seriously the efficacy of the powers.’²⁷¹ Quoting Barth:

It would be better for us if we were to learn again with the same fearlessness and freedom to see and to reckon with the fact that even today we still live in a world that has been basically dedemonized already in Jesus Christ, and will be so fully one day. But in the meantime it still needs a good deal of dedemonizing, because even up to our own time it is largely demon-possessed, possessed, that is, by the existence and lordship of similar or, at times, obviously the same lordless forces which the people of the New Testament knew and which have plainly not been broken or even affected, but in many

²⁶⁸ Gatumu, *The Pauline Concept of Natural Powers*, 194.

²⁶⁹ Ibid.

²⁷⁰ Robert Ewusie Moses, “Powerful Practices: Paul’s Principalities and Powers Revisited” (PhD diss., Duke Divinity School, 2012), 26.

²⁷¹ Ibid., 27.

ways intensified and strengthened, by the fact that our view of the world has since those days become a rational and scientific one.²⁷²

Barth is suggesting, ‘if we are to undertake a demythologizing, it should not be a demythologizing of the concept of the principalities and powers in the NT, but rather the myths of modern powers. What is needed, according to Barth, is for Scripture to demythologize our modern world picture, not the reverse.’²⁷³ Esther Acolatse gives the most recent robust critique of Bultmann.²⁷⁴

Hendrick Berkhof

Dawn, Yong, and Moses all point to Berkhof’s book, *Christ and the Powers* (1953) as a work that significantly shaped the on-going conversation on the Powers.²⁷⁵ Motivated by the rise and fall of Nazism, Berkhof sought to explain how that kind of evil could have taken place. Berkhof’s basic argument is that Paul himself, was “in a sense” demythologizing the concept of the powers, ultimately identifying them with the structures of human existence and the invisible reality behind them. The nature of the invisible reality behind the social, cultural, economic, and political structures is more ambiguous for Berkhof. He was an early advocate of recognizing systemic, structural evil, which is one of the ways liberationist theologians understand the Powers. His ideas were later adapted and developed further by John Howard Yoder.²⁷⁶

First Berkhof lays out all the Pauline texts that mention the “principalities and powers.”²⁷⁷ He asks, when Paul uses various terms like principalities, powers, thrones, and dominions whether they relate to their function or names or to something more inclusive. ‘If it be the case that their meanings are distinct, this is never made clear, and is therefore not essential for an understanding of Paul’s message.’²⁷⁸

Berkhof recognizes that the terminology that Paul uses for “principalities and powers” was not his invention but was borrowed from Jewish apocalyptic writings.²⁷⁹ And in the rabbinic writings, ‘Two things were always true of the Powers: (1) they are

²⁷² Karl Barth, *The Christian Life* (London; New York: T&T Clark, 2004), 218.

²⁷³ Moses, “Powerful Practices,” 27.

²⁷⁴ Acolatse, *Powers, Principalities, and the Spirit*.

²⁷⁵ Berkhof, *Christ and the Powers*.

²⁷⁶ John Howard Yoder, *The Politics of Jesus* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1994), 134–162.

²⁷⁷ Rom. 8:38f, I Cor. 2:8, I Cor. 15:24–26, Eph. 1:20f, Eph. 2:11, Eph. 6:12, Col. 1:16, Col. 2:15.

²⁷⁸ Berkhof, *Christ and the Powers*, 15.

²⁷⁹ *Ibid.*, 17.

personal, spiritual beings and (2) they influence events on earth, especially events within nature.’²⁸⁰ But Berkhof doesn’t want us to assume that Paul is retaining this exact meaning. When reading Romans, ‘For I am sure that neither death nor life, nor angels nor principalities, nor present nor future, nor powers nor height nor depth, nor any other creature, will be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus, our Lord’ (Rom. 8:38-39), he states, ‘If we have begun to think of the Powers as angels, or classes of angels, this text is somewhat embarrassing. The angelic names stand here side-by-side with other nouns which certainly do not designate personal spiritual beings.’²⁸¹ He eventually concludes after looking at various lists, that Paul’s emphasis was not on the principalities and powers being personal-spiritual, but rather that the principalities exert great influence over human affairs.²⁸²

Such an understanding is supported in Paul’s letter to the Corinthians when he writes, ‘None of the rulers of this age understood it [hidden wisdom of God]; for if they had, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory (I Cor. 2:8 NIV).’ Berkhof sees the principalities tied to both religious authorities and the Roman state, seeing both the visible authorities and the invisible powers behind them.²⁸³ In continuing to emphasise that the principalities are the social realities, he examines the concept of *stoicheia* found in Col. 2:8, 14 and 20, to which Paul connects the principalities and powers. The principalities to which Paul was concerned people would fall prey ‘are definite religious and ethical rules, the solid structures within which the pagan and Jewish societies of the day lived and moved. In verse 14, these structures are spoken of as the way in which the principalities and powers rule over men; or rather the powers *are* the structures.’²⁸⁴ Berkhof, in seeking to describe the nature of the powers, connects them with human life and events. He finds a similar pattern in Gal. 4:1-11 with the word *stoicheia*, where Paul is warning them not to return back to the miserable forces that enslaved them before their redemption.

While the Jewish apocalyptic circles had angels in mind, Berkhof believed that Paul was broadening the nature of the principalities, pointing out that Paul doesn’t emphasise their angelic nature, as in the list found in Romans 8:38.²⁸⁵ In fact, when discussing the list in this passage, Berkhof questions why angels are even mentioned,

²⁸⁰ Ibid.

²⁸¹ Ibid., 18.

²⁸² Ibid., 19.

²⁸³ Ibid., 20.

²⁸⁴ Ibid., 21.

²⁸⁵ Ibid., 23.

stating that *angelos* simply means God's messengers, and that *angelos* means ordinary human messengers in Luke 7:24, 9:52 and James 2:25. In addition, he asks whether the nature of these angels is good or bad. If good, how does one understand the texts that speak about combat with them or victory over them? If fallen angels, how does one understand that considering the creation, preservation, and reconciliation mentioned in Col. 1:15-20? He states, 'The conclusion is obvious; we must set aside the thought that Paul's "Powers" are angels. Whether they be conceived as persons or as impersonal structures of life and society, they form a category of their own.'²⁸⁶ This is a significant development when it comes to understanding the principalities, one which seems to be adopted by Wink, Ellul, and others.

Moving to Col. 1:15-17, Berkhof makes the point that Jesus is the key to all of creation, and that creation consists of the visible and invisible, the earthly and heavenly. He says, 'Creation has a visible foreground, which is bound together with and dependent on an invisible background. This latter comprises the powers.'²⁸⁷ When he talks about *stoicheia*, the powers are the structures, but as he further contemplates the nature of the powers, they are the invisible reality shaping the social realities. It is important to note that Berkhof believes this invisible reality is not to be seen as either good or fallen angels, because for Paul the powers are not inherently evil. Berkhof talks about them as holding life together, preserving life, and serving as aids and intermediaries, to bind people to God. He believes the powers correspond to the orders of creation. The powers are Christ-created structures designed to give order to life, be it the state, morality, religious rules, or ethics. So, while they can be tyrants, they were designed to bring life.²⁸⁸

Though designed to bring life, humanity experiences them in their fallen state, where they seek to master us. No longer do the powers bind us to God, they separate us from God, seeking to be gods themselves. The powers still fulfil half of their role, preserving society from utter chaos, but 'by holding the world together, they hold it away from God.'²⁸⁹ Berkhof then relates how he experienced the powers at work when Hitler took leadership in Germany as a student in Berlin. He sensed the powers 'in the air' and saw how the powers grabbed a hold of people and separated them from God. He noticed how today,

²⁸⁶ Ibid., 26.

²⁸⁷ Ibid., 28.

²⁸⁸ Ibid., 29.

²⁸⁹ Ibid., 30.

The state, politics, class, social struggle, national interest, public opinion, accepted morality, the ideas of decency, humanity, democracy – these give unity and direction to thousands of lives. Yet precisely by giving unity and direction they separate these many lives from the true God; they let us believe that we have found the meaning of existence, whereas they really estrange us from true meaning.²⁹⁰

Finally, Berkhof addresses the powers in redemption and consummation, where human redemption is not simply being relieved of guilt but being set free from the bondage of the powers, over which Christ triumphed. Berkhof brings attention to the fact that the legal demands and regulations mentioned in Col. 2:13-15 correspond with Jewish and pagan regulations, which are both overcome in Christ.²⁹¹ Not only are the powers disarmed, but Berkhof speaks of their reconciliation in Col. 1:19. He talks about the reconciliation of the powers being a strange thing, because reconciliation is typically thought of as something between people, yet these “creatures” will return to their originally good functions.

Berkhof completes his work writing about the present engagement with the powers. While Christ has disarmed and reconciled the powers, there is the ‘already and not yet’ dimension of engagement; thus the battle continues, as followers of Christ work to help the powers live out their God intended purposes, where nations function on behalf of the people, where the powers are unmasked, where the people of God in the power of the Spirit build multi-ethnic communities where justice and mercy reign and social injustice is resisted.²⁹²

Berkhof’s argument is compelling, demonstrated by the number of thoughtful people who have basically adopted his viewpoint.²⁹³ He makes many contributions. He notices the variety of ways the Powers are talked about in Rom. 8:38-39. He shows how ‘the rulers of the age’ relate to the powers being visible and invisible. He connects *stoicheia* with the powers and makes the case through Colossians that powers are created good, experience fallenness, and are redeemed in Christ. Wink later borrows and develops Berkhof’s convincing argument.

²⁹⁰ Ibid., 32–33.

²⁹¹ Ibid., 37.

²⁹² Ibid., 43–67.

²⁹³ Rupp, *Principalities and Powers: Studies in the Christian Conflict in History*; G. B. Caird, *The Language and Imagery of the Bible*, 1st Edition, 2nd Printing edition. (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster Press, 1980); Markus Barth, *The Broken Wall: A Study of the Epistle to the Ephesians*, First edition Second Printing edition. (Valley Forge, PA: Judson Press, 1959); William Stringfellow, *Free in Obedience* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Pub, 2006); Robert E. Webber, *The Church in the World: Opposition, Tension, or Transformation* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1986); Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*, 200–213.

While Berkhof's work is limited to Paul's view of the principalities and powers, one question left unaddressed is that if fallen angels are not a part of the principalities and powers, where do they belong in Berkhof's understanding? Berkhof had no difficulty acknowledging Satan, as he writes when speaking on the persona of the Powers that 'It is possible that [Paul] paints them with personal traits because he sees them as tools of Satan.'²⁹⁴ It does not appear that Berkhof denies the reality of Satan or demons. He is simply making the case for the Pauline language of principalities and powers to be seen as a completely new creature, the invisible reality behind and connected to the visible reality of social structures. It is helpful to separate out the principalities and powers from the devil and the demonic because their telos is distinctly different. It appears the principalities and powers will be reconciled (Col. 1:15-20), but the devil and his angels seem to have a different telos. Jesus seems to indicate their final doom (Matt. 25:41).

A Dynamic Typology

Hans W. Frei proposed the interplay of two 'often contentious, but necessarily mutually exclusive' approaches to Christian theology.²⁹⁵ One approach gives primary thought to exploring 'theology as a philosophical discipline' within the accepted norms of academia.²⁹⁶ The second approach gives precedence to approaching theology as a discipline within the faith community, an internal self-description.

Frei developed a fivefold typology on the interplay of these approaches. This was adapted by David Ford as a continuum on which to place various modern theologians, who seek to engage contemporary issues through current academic disciplines in conversation with theology.²⁹⁷ I will be using Ford's adaptation to place Arnold, Bultmann, and Berkhof on this continuum, using some of the names developed by Les Oglesby.²⁹⁸

At the end of two contrary poles is type one – *the traditionalist*, who is seeking to reassert traditional theology without regard for the knowledge humanity has gained in the interval, and type five – *the reductionist*, who gives 'complete priority to some

²⁹⁴ Berkhof, *Christ and the Powers*, 24.

²⁹⁵ Ibid.

²⁹⁶ Ibid., 28.

²⁹⁷ David Ford and Rachel Muers, eds., *The Modern Theologians: An Introduction to Christian Theology Since 1918*, 3rd Edition. (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2005), 1–16.

²⁹⁸ Les Oglesby, *C. G. Jung and Hans Urs von Balthasar: God and Evil - A Critical Comparison*, 2 vols. (London: Routledge, 2013).

modern or secular philosophy or worldview, and Christianity in its own terms is only valid insofar it fits in with that.’²⁹⁹

Within the centre of the two opposite poles would be type three – *the correlator*, giving equal weight to theology developed within the church and other disciplines of academia, such as anthropology, sociology, and psychology, with the goal of connecting theology to the modern person in a way that makes sense to them.

Finally, there are the two mediating positions on the continuum, type two – *the interpreter*, who gives priority to Christian theology developed within the community of faith ‘but with serious engagement with its present-day intellectual and cultural context.’³⁰⁰ And type four – *the re-interpreter*, who sees ‘integration with modernity as more important and even essential to modern theology.’³⁰¹ The re-interpreter seeks to develop a theological method in line with modern concepts or current concerns of the day, (i.e. poverty, racism, ecology, oppression, violence, gender).

This typology provides a way to analyse Arnold, Bultmann, and Burkhof. At one end of the spectrum is Arnold, who reasserts what he considers to be the first century understanding of the Powers in continuity with the intertestamental period’s fascination with the angelic world, without giving much regard to what has been learned about systemic evil. He sees the principalities and powers as personal spiritual beings. He may be located at 1.5 on the Ford scale, seeking to be faithful with the text, *without* a strong engagement with the current Western context, aside from the revival of the occult. As a result, Arnold minimizes evil found in social structures and fails to provide what is needed in terms of speaking truth to social realities faced day to day.

Ford places Bultmann on this scale at type four. Bultmann uses existentialism to interpret the scripture starting with the human subject. He does this by demythologizing the Powers, thereby abandoning what may have been the original understanding of the Powers (context of production) in favour of explaining the Powers as a world that is beyond humanity’s control. While this view accommodates the scientific worldview of modernity (context of reception), it minimizes the text in context, and doesn’t fit as well in a post-modern context, where a variety of views of reality are valued.

Berkhof, while seeking to hold tightly to the text of production, sees Paul in ‘a sense’ demythologizing the powers. While Bultmann took a demythologizing approach to the text, Berkhof makes the case that Paul was *in some ways* demythologizing the

²⁹⁹ Ford and Muers, *The Modern Theologians*, 2.

³⁰⁰ Oglesby, *C. G. Jung and Hans Urs von Balthasar*, 33.

³⁰¹ Ford and Muers, *The Modern Theologians*, 5.

principalities and powers. But Berkhof does not simply minimize the principalities to the structure, he gives credence to the invisible spirituality behind the structure. While Berkhof seems uncomfortable with those who emphasise angels, giving more preference to the principalities and powers as structures of society, he never reduces the principalities to just the structure. Because of Berkhof's careful work at understanding the principalities and powers in the context and realities of World War II, he would be classified as a type three, where he is 'devoted to shaping Christian practices and teaching in dialogue with modern philosophies, culture and social practices.'³⁰² Figure 3 places each of these authors on the Ford/Frei continuum.

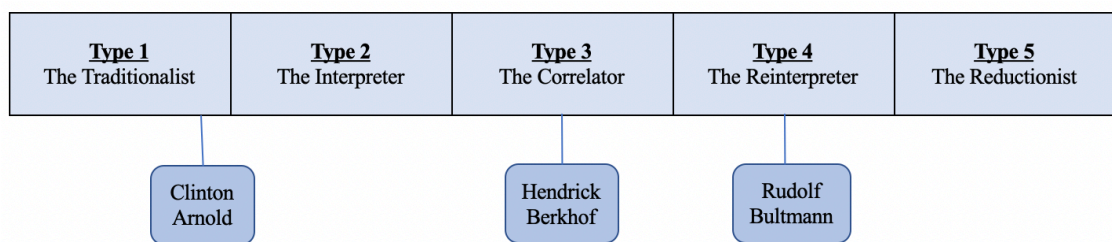


Figure 3. Arnold, Berkhof and Bultmann on Ford/Frei Scale

Houston seems to connect with Arnold, in the sense of how he views Satan and the demonic, and Berkhof and Wink alike, in how he includes structures. Because his engagement with Wink is minimal, and because Wink broadens the discussion of the Powers beyond the principalities and powers in Pauline literature, he will be an important interlocutor to better discern how the Powers seek to subvert the missional leader.

Summary of Argument

In Houston's study of I Peter, with the problem of domineering leadership as his focal point, the key elements of an imitation-based framework emerged – leadership, imitation and desire, and a theology of the Powers. This imitation-based framework has promise in giving a more robust diagnosis to the problem of domineering leadership. This summary will assess the strengths and weaknesses of this developing framework and discern what is needed to strengthen it.

Regarding leadership and imitation, Houston established the three different directions in which imitation can take place when it comes to leadership. The leader has

³⁰² Ibid., 3.

two directions he or she can go when it comes to who to imitate. Leaders can unknowingly imitate the Powers by mimicking what they see in the world uncritically, or, as Houston encourages, they can imitate Christ. The third direction of imitation is that of leaders living as examples because of the influence they have on those who look to them for leadership. The analysis confirmed that the theme of leadership and imitation is significant. Whom the leader chooses to imitate can mean life or death for the leader's own soul. Imitating a leader who loves to be first is not only dangerous, but evil. The dangers of mimicking the latest cultural trend can unknowingly change the telos and identity of missional leaders, thus misshaping their praxis.

The priority of imitating Christ was established as Houston corroborated Fitch's thought that one ought not de-centre Christ, but follow him. This is reinforced by looking at the life of Peter, who understood the highs and lows of his own grace-filled journey with Jesus and not only pointed leaders to follow Christ, but followed Christ to his own cross. A short review looking at key moments in the history of the church and the lives of leaders like Thomas á Kempis, Kierkegaard, and Bonhoeffer bolstered this need to imitate and follow Christ. In addition, while the influence the leader has on their followers was pointed out as significant, this area needs to be developed. It was suggested that Girard's mimetic theory has the potential to add fresh motivation for leaders to discover that the only way to escape the grip of the Powers is by imitating Christ, and that their desires will be imitated by those who look up to them as a model.

Regarding leadership and desire, Houston's hunch of the importance of desire was strengthened, but needed to be developed. Smith, in the footsteps of Augustine, demonstrated the centrality of desire through developing a philosophical anthropology of people-as-lovers, whose ultimate desires shape the core of their identity. Smith made the case that information is not enough for transformation and that transformation requires formation. This solidifies the assertion that missional theology without a deep spirituality is insufficient to deal with the problem of domineering leadership. What is needed is a comprehensive approach to the formation of the leader through a missional spirituality that arrests the imagination of the leader and reshapes the leader's desires.

In addition, the contours of leadership were confirmed and developed. Adding to the argument the importance of identity and telos in the development of missional theology and missional leadership. This demonstrated (and will continue to demonstrate) how desires form the identity of the leader, and the supreme telos of the leader's desires profoundly shape the leader's identity and praxis.

It was affirmed that Girard would be the ideal dialogue partner when it comes to exploring both imitation and desire, as he uniquely combines the two into what he calls mimetic desire. His research has reshaped many fields of study, including theology. Mimetic desire and the mimetic cycle will be explored in chapter four. Stringfellow provides a unique angle on how the Powers manifest themselves to misshape the leader's desires related to their identity, praxis, and telos, which is explored in chapter five.

Regarding leadership and the Powers, Houston's understanding of the Powers' unique work when it comes to leadership formation was insightful. Identifying Peter's warning about the Powers as central to his overall message confirms the importance of this element as part of the conceptual framework. Houston's emphasis on the Powers was affirmed by the recent surge of scholarly interest in the Powers since the rise and fall of Hitler. While Arnold, Bultmann, and Burkhof have significant differences in their understanding of the Powers, there was agreement that there is a battle going on that needs to be better understood. This should raise a yellow flag to those seeking to view the world too positively. They all demonstrated the need to look at other dimensions of the world that are not neutral or positive when it comes to the formation of the leader.

Barth and Tillich helped to start the conversation, both writing about the Powers of ideology, whether it be nationalism or authoritarianism. This might be why ideology is something that Stringfellow highlights in his understanding of the Powers. Arnold, Bultmann, and Burkhof remind us that there is contention regarding the nature of the Powers, as well as the telos and work of the Powers. The exploration of the Powers demonstrated the need to pursue a deeper understanding. This initial look did establish that Houston was correct by not limiting the work of the Powers to the individual, but also included the social and cosmic dimension of the Powers. The importance of contextualization was also noted, as well as the problems of over-contextualization, in regard to Bultmann. The limited focus on the 'principalities and powers' in Pauline literature speaks to the need to engage Wink. Wink and his trilogy on the Powers continues to shape the conversation. His influence in the missional world, as evidenced by Newbigin, makes him an important dialogue partner for this thesis.

Houston alerted us to the importance of understanding authority and power by examining the exousia. He spoke of the proper use and misuse of authority and how this relates to the Powers, which continually seek to usurp God's authority. In the final chapter the importance of the power of the Spirit will be made clear. For the Spirit led

Jesus into an encounter with the devil, and after having shown his faithfulness through the temptations, Jesus left the desert in the power of the Spirit.

The interlocutors chosen to develop this imitation-based framework bring specialities that will strengthen specific parts of the framework. Each have made the Powers central in their corpus of work. This is important, because Houston has demonstrated a link to domineering leadership and the Powers. The contributions of Wink and Girard will provide theoretical and theological depth, as well as practical application.

Wink's exegetically-transposed theology of naming, unmasking, and engaging the Powers provides one of the most in-depth investigations of the Powers to date. This will be explored in the next chapter. His laborious exegetical work, combined with his real-life application, is likely what has made him one of the most cited authors on the powers.³⁰³ It will be important to engage his work with a critical openness. Girard will help to integrate the framework, as he ties together imitation and desire, via mimetic desire. His interdisciplinary diversity enables him to understand culture and the world in a whole new light, as he challenges the underlying assumptions that are often unnamed in the social sciences. Stringfellow contextualizes how the Powers work to subvert the life of the leader.

Wink and Girard will deepen, strengthen, and tighten this thesis' imitation-based framework, while Stringfellow will help with practical application. He offers motivation to missional leaders to find their identity and telos in God and his kingdom, so that their praxis might be lived out under his power and authority. Having laid out the imitation-based conceptual framework, this thesis will now examine the life of Wink and his theology of the Powers.

³⁰³ According to Google Scholar, Walter Wink's works on the powers collectively have been cited 2,531 times. *Naming the Powers* (cited 555 times), *Unmasking the Powers* (cited 354 times), *Engaging the Powers* (cited 1,007 times), *The Powers that Be* (cited 463 times), *When the Powers Fail* (cited 83 times) and *Violence and Nonviolence in South Africa* (cited 69 times).

Chapter 3

Leadership and the Powers

Graham Houston, in his study of I Peter, focused on the problem of domineering leadership in which leadership, imitation and desire, and the Powers, emerged as part of the imitation-based framework. Through analysis, each element was determined to be important, but each needed further development and the interrelatedness of the framework needed to be tightened. Walter Wink was cited by both Houston and Newbigin as influential, and as one of the most cited scholar on the topic of the Powers, it seems fitting to engage him with critical openness in the development of a theology of the Powers.

Introducing Walter Wink

Walter Wink (1935-2012) was born in Dallas, Texas. After publishing 16 books and hundreds of scholarly articles, he died at 76 at his home in Sandisfield, Massachusetts, due to complications of dementia.³⁰⁴ Wink received his PhD in 1963 from Union Theological Seminary in New York City and taught New Testament at Union from 1967-1976. Ultimately he was denied tenure, due to the opening statement in his book *The Bible in Human Transformation* (1973): ‘Historical biblical criticism is bankrupt.’³⁰⁵ This didn’t sit well with his fellow biblical faculty, so they voted his tenure down.³⁰⁶ By ‘bankrupt’, Wink did not mean ‘valueless.’ Rather, he considered it bankrupt ‘solely because it is incapable of achieving what most of its practitioners considered its purpose to be: so to interpret the Scriptures that the past becomes alive and illumines our present with new possibilities for personal and social transformation.’³⁰⁷

Wink had a prophetic word for scholars, who, in his opinion, had not only quarantined themselves from the world of practitioners, but had also given in to an ‘ideology of objectivism,’ where unacknowledged interest and the fiction of ‘detached

³⁰⁴ Douglas Martin, “Walter Wink, Theologian Who Challenged Orthodoxy, Dies at 76,” *The New York Times*, May 19, 2012, sec. U.S., accessed November 16, 2019, <https://www.nytimes.com/2012/05/20/us/walter-wink-theologian-who-challenged-orthodoxy-dies-at-76.html>.

³⁰⁵ Walter Wink, *The Bible in Human Transformation: Toward a New Paradigm in Bible Study*, 2nd ed. edition. (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 2010), 1.

³⁰⁶ Walter Wink and Steven Berry, *Just Jesus: My Struggle to Become Human* (New York: Image, 2014), 115.

³⁰⁷ Wink, *The Bible in Human Transformation*, 1–2.

neutrality,' shaped their perspective.³⁰⁸ He was also concerned about the 'demystification of the text' meaning the loss of the 'numinous,' or the loss of mystery.³⁰⁹ Wink states that objectivism (or intellectualism) is, 'characterized by a complete separation of theory from practice, intellect from emotion,' forfeiting the goal of transformation.³¹⁰ For Wink, 'The historical critical method has reduced the Bible to a dead letter. Our obeisance to technique has left the Bible sterile and ourselves empty.'³¹¹ Consequently, his constructive task was to address these particular critiques.

Wink's first two books detail his hermeneutical approach to Scripture.³¹² This approach is both applied and amplified in his next five books, which covered the Powers.³¹³ His hermeneutic was to address the strong disconnect between the academy and communities of faith, as well as critique the current form of Biblical criticism which assumed an ideology of objectivism and approached the text with detachment, such that the text becomes objectified and the subject unchanged. He writes, 'Such detached neutrality in matters of faith is not neutrality at all, but already a decision against responding. At the outset, questions of truth and meaning have been excluded, since they can only be answered participatively, in terms of a lived response.'³¹⁴ As he paid attention to his life and the text alike, he became more and more an activist.

Wink's early life was shaped by a father who was a strong disciplinarian and a mother whose intellectual prowess pushed him to be a scholar.³¹⁵ These formative relationships profoundly shaped his self-perception and drove him to perfectionism. He reflects on this, writing, 'My deep perfectionism did not arise from any form of indoctrination from fundamentalism. It came straight out of my desperate desire to win my parent's – and God's – love.'³¹⁶ He knew about God's love intellectually; he had

³⁰⁸ Wayne G. Rollins, "An Overview of the Work of Walter Wink," in *Enigmas and Powers: Engaging the Work of Walter Wink for Classroom, Church and World* (Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2008), 4–5.

³⁰⁹ Ibid.

³¹⁰ Wink, *The Bible in Human Transformation*, 4.

³¹¹ Ibid., 3.

³¹² Wink, *The Bible in Human Transformation*; Walter Wink, *Transforming Bible Study: A Leader's Guide* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Pub, 2009).

³¹³ Wink, *Naming the Powers*; Walter Wink, *Unmasking the Powers: The Invisible Forces That Determine Human Existence* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 1993); Walter Wink, *Violence and Nonviolence in South Africa: Jesus' Third Way* (Philadelphia, PA: New Society Pub, 1987); Wink, *Engaging the Powers*; Walter Wink, *Cracking the Gnostic Code: The Powers in Gnosticism* (Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1994).

³¹⁴ Wink, *The Bible in Human Transformation*, 2.

³¹⁵ Wink and Berry, *Just Jesus*, 31.

³¹⁶ Ibid., 28–29.

not internalized it. His early life experiences and the wounds he incurred probably made perfectionism a life-long struggle for him.³¹⁷ When reflecting on his formative years, he recognized his desire to be loved and accepted. He also realized that this desire, if not addressed in healthy ways, could create unhealthy desires. A desire to be loved and accepted can be turned into a desire to accomplish. Not that accomplishment or fruitfulness is a bad desire, but this desire becomes misshapen when done *for* love, instead of *from* being loved. When Henri Nouwen describes the start of Jesus' ministry, he recalls that before Jesus was led into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil, at his baptism Jesus heard a voice from heaven say, 'This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased' (Matt. 3:17). 'These words revealed the true identity of Jesus as the beloved. Jesus truly heard that voice, and all of his thoughts, words, actions came forth from his deep knowledge that he was infinitely loved by God. Jesus lived his life from that inner place of love.'³¹⁸ Identifying as the beloved is an important concept for leaders to digest.

Though Wink was raised Methodist, he went through an atheistic phase as a college student until he heard a message preached on Matt. 6:25-34. He was struck by the promise made in Matt. 6:33 NIV, 'But seek first his kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well.' He decided to put this promise to an empirical test: he believed the promise and wanted to see if God would deliver.³¹⁹ Wink's desire to empirically test God's promises opened him up to new experiences in scripture, and challenged his unconsciously-held rationalist, materialist, worldview. A charismatic encounter with the Holy Spirit would open him to a deeper understanding of God's presence and his own telos. These experiences would ultimately shape his future approach to hermeneutics. In his years serving as pastor, at the ridicule of his ministerial colleagues, he regularly held healing services, where he saw the Spirit physically heal people.³²⁰ For him, the healings in the gospels were not just psychosomatic illness, but real medical diseases.

Wink's activism was shaped by an early experience of racism. As a young boy, living in segregated Texas, Wink witnessed his black friend unjustly accused of starting

³¹⁷ Ibid., 17–19.

³¹⁸ Henri Nouwen, *You Are the Beloved: Daily Meditations for Spiritual Living* (New York: Convergent Books, 2017), 4.

³¹⁹ Walter Wink, "Write What You See: An Odyssey by Walter Wink," *Westar Institute*, accessed November 16, 2019, <https://www.westarinstitute.org/resources/the-fourth-r/write-what-you-see/>.

³²⁰ Wink and Berry, *Just Jesus*, 92.

a dangerous fire that, in fact, Wink himself had lit. Despite Wink trying to convince the authorities that he was to blame, his young black friend was punished. Wink writes, ‘That day I discovered something of what racism is. It just wasn’t fair. How fortunate I was to have had this experience, so that when the Civil Rights Movement came along, I already had in my body a visceral reaction to the mistreatment of people of color.’³²¹

Wink’s contexts and study helped him name, unmask, and engage the Powers. As an adult participating in the civil rights movement, Wink met Martin Luther King Jr and others who would inspire him toward more substantial activism in the future, including spending a season in Chile under the oppressive government of Pinochet and working with the South African Council of Churches in the fight against apartheid. In these different contexts, he ‘became increasingly convinced that non-violence was the only way to overcome the domination of the Powers without creating new forms of domination.’³²² His praxis in seeing the kingdom manifest was guided by his telos. That praxis was non-violent, direct action. These experiences would lead Wink to write his sixth book on the Powers, *Violence and Nonviolence in South Africa* (1987), in which he details the ‘third way of Jesus’ – nonviolent direct action.³²³ Wink’s book helped give courage to the church in South Africa. This is indicated by Peter Storey, the Methodist Bishop of South Africa; Wink would cherish Storey’s response. Storey writes,

Walter Wink’s analysis of the prospects of violence and nonviolence in the anti-apartheid struggle were uncompromising; they left none of us off – proponents of violence and nonviolence alike. He chided us gently for our hypocrisy and impotence and showed us that the true realism lay, as we should have known, not with “fight” or “flight,” but with Jesus and his “Third way” of nonviolent direct action. Informed by the Gospels as well as by the hard math of struggle, Walter invited us to follow the tough advice and the example of Jesus in confronting the powers with a different kind of power. He reminded us of other struggles where the odds were stacked just as heavily against freedom, but where people trained in the Third Way of Jesus had overcome.³²⁴

One of the profound experiences of Wink’s adult life, which deeply influenced his approach to scripture and therefore his understanding of the Powers, was his encounter with Elizabeth Boyden Howes, a Jungian analyst and founder of the Guild for Psychology Studies in San Francisco. Wink’s personal transformation sparked his interest to engage in a Jungian analysis of scripture as well, where he started to

³²¹ Ibid., 36.

³²² Ibid., 140.

³²³ Wink, *Violence and Nonviolence in South Africa*.

³²⁴ Wink and Berry, *Just Jesus*, 147.

recognize and experience the power of the archetypal images found in Scripture. The ‘depth psychology’ that he discovered through Jung and others shaped his hermeneutical approach to Scripture, because for Wink, the purpose of coming to Scripture is that the Bible may read one’s personal and social histories for the sake of personal and social transformation.

For Wink, if one did not know and imitate Jesus, it would be difficult to live humanly in a world dominated by the Powers. Thus, Wink sought to know Jesus more, as Jesus was the key to his own identity.

Walter Wink’s Theology of the Powers

Because Wink’s theology has greatly shaped the conversation on the Powers, including influencing Newbigin, it is important to examine and critically engage his theology. But first an understanding must be identified of Wink’s underlying assumptions regarding his adopted worldview.

Wink’s entire project of the theology of the Powers is built on the foundation of consciously adopting an integral worldview. As Wink says, ‘our perception of the Powers is colored to a great extent by the way we view the world.’³²⁵ Wink contends there have only been a handful of worldviews in the history of the West.³²⁶ First, he names an ancient worldview, where heaven and earth mutually influence each other and are counterparts to each other. It was not only shared by Biblical writers, but also everyone who lived in the ancient world, including the Greeks, Romans, Babylonians, and Assyrians.³²⁷ Then Wink names the spiritualist worldview, which considers the material world evil and heaven and the spiritual as good. This worldview was shared by the Gnostics and Manichees.³²⁸ Finally, the materialist worldview, which became prominent during the Enlightenment, runs counter to the spiritualist worldview; it holds that what is real is what can be detected by the five senses through science. There is no heaven, no God, no soul, the spiritual world is an illusion.³²⁹ Wink discovered that he held this view unconsciously in his early life. The fourth worldview Wink describes as the theological worldview, where ‘in reaction to materialism, Christian theologians invented the supernatural realm. Acknowledging that this supersensible realm could not

³²⁵ Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 3.

³²⁶ Walter Wink, *The Powers That Be: Theology for a New Millennium* (New York: Harmony, 1999), 14–15.

³²⁷ Wink, *Engaging the Powers*.

³²⁸ Ibid.

³²⁹ Ibid., 5.

be known by the senses, they conceded earthly reality to modern science and preserved a privileged “spiritual” realm immune to confirmation or refutation.’³³⁰

Finally, there is the integral worldview, through which he reinterprets a theology of Powers for today. For Wink, ‘This new worldview is emerging from a confluence of sources: the reflections of Carl Jung, Teilhard de Chardin, Morton Kelsey, Thomas Berry, Matthew Fox, process philosophy, and the new physics. It sees everything as having an outer and inner aspect.’³³¹ It takes the ancient worldview seriously, in that while the spiritual resided in heaven, indicating transcendence, the spiritual reality is now the inner aspect of all social reality, ‘an inner realm every bit as rich and extensive at the outer realm’ of the ancient worldview.³³² For Wink, in order to make ‘the biblical data more intelligible for people today’, he believes there is no worldview better to adopt than this one. Though one’s worldview shapes how one sees the world, worldviews are not the gospel for Wink, as evidenced by the fact that the ancient worldview was not unique to God’s people.

Therefore, Wink proposes that the Powers be viewed ‘not as separate heavenly or ethereal entities, but as the *inner aspect of material or tangible manifestations of power*.’³³³ For Wink, the Powers are not mere personifications. The demons that the ancients projected ‘onto the cosmos really are demonic, and play havoc with humanity; only they are not *up there*, but *over there*, in the socio-political entities that make up the one-and-only real world.’³³⁴ Because Wink rejects a materialist worldview, he is not interested in engaging the Powers in the way of Bultmann’s demythologizing project. Wink seeks to reinterpret the Powers within an integral worldview, writing, ‘...the New Testament insists that demons can have no effect unless they are able to embody themselves in people (Mark 1:21-28 par.; Matt. 12:43-45//Luke 11:24-26), or pigs (Mark 5:1-20 par.), or political systems (Revelation 12-13).’³³⁵

Naming the Powers

In his first book of the Powers trilogy, *Naming the Powers*, Wink recognizes that many modern readers are shaped by a materialist worldview: ‘When we read the ancient accounts of encounters with these Powers, we can only regard them as hallucinations...

³³⁰ Ibid., 5–6.

³³¹ Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 5.

³³² Ibid., 6.

³³³ Wink, *Naming the Powers*, 104.

³³⁴ Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 8.

³³⁵ Ibid.

as long as our very categories of thought are dictated by the myth of materialism.³³⁶ He goes on to say, ‘It is as impossible for most of us to believe in the real existence of demonic or angelic powers as it is to believe in dragons, or elves, or a flat world.’³³⁷

Acknowledging the enormous gap between those shaped by a materialist worldview and those shaped by an ancient worldview, he sees the importance of seeking to understand the Powers in their context of origin before transposing that understanding into an integral worldview. His best description of this task is articulated the following way,

The ancients regarded the spiritual Powers as non-material, invisible, heavenly entities with specific characteristics or qualities. These Powers are good creations of a good God, but all of them have “fallen,” becoming more or less evil in intent, and may even be set on the destruction of humanity. They were called angels, gods, spirits, demons, devils. This view was carried by the momentum of Jewish apocalyptic thought right into the New Testament, but Paul has already taken key steps toward “demythologizing” or at least depersonalizing it by means of the categories of sin, law, the flesh and death. I suggest we follow Paul’s lead in this, and attempt to reinterpret the mythic language of the Powers. By this I do not mean to abolish the New Testament myth but to transpose it into a new key. Or, put another way the goal is not “demythologizing” if by that is meant removal of the mythic dimension, but rather juxtaposing the ancient myth with the emerging postmodern (mythic) worldview and asking how they might mutually illuminate each other.³³⁸

One can see Wink’s dependence on Berkhof here. But what Berkhof thought Paul was doing with the principalities and powers Wink seeks to do with every category of the Powers. For Wink, myth is a way to describe ‘the atemporal, cosmic, supernatural aspect of the story’, which he believes permeates ‘every statement made about the Powers.’³³⁹ The mythic ‘is the very framework of the entire notion of the Powers, the means by which they have been brought to language.’³⁴⁰

Wink’s first book is the most technical of the three books, as he seeks to approach his exegetical work by approaching power and the Powers synthetically, looking at all usage in the New Testament in context, as opposed to analytically, writer by writer. His goal is to understand the unconscious presupposition of the writers, how they experienced and described the Powers.³⁴¹ He develops six basic rules from his initial exegetical work, which become an interpretive lens for Wink:

³³⁶ Wink, *Naming the Powers*, 4.

³³⁷ Ibid.

³³⁸ Ibid., 104.

³³⁹ Ibid., 103.

³⁴⁰ Ibid.

³⁴¹ Ibid., 7.

1. The language of power pervades the whole New Testament
2. The language of power in the New Testament is imprecise, liquid, interchangeable, and unsystematic.
3. Despite all this imprecision and interchangeability, clear patterns of usage emerge.
4. Because these terms are, to a degree, interchangeable, one or a pair or a series can be made to represent them all. [He mentions exceptions to this rule, when the context brings clarity.]
5. These Powers are both heavenly and earthly, divine and human, spiritual and political, invisible and structured.
6. These Powers are also both good and evil.³⁴²

Later in the book, he adds a seventh, foundational interpretive rule gained from his exegetical work, which produces the interpretive lens by which he will engage the text. It is this:

7. ‘Unless the context further specifies (and some do), we are to take the terms for power in their most comprehensive sense, understanding them to mean both heavenly *and* earthly, divine *and* human, good *and* evil powers. No other conclusion would be consistent with the results of our word studies...’³⁴³

One benefit of Wink painstakingly excavating the key words related to power and the Powers, is that he did this in the context of when the text was written, prior to reinterpreting the Powers for an integral worldview. Because of this his word studies related to power and the Powers, are instructive. Reflecting on these word studies, he observes, ‘In biblical studies, word studies are the equivalent of field exploration and mineral classification in geology. Very little may seem to have been revealed in the field, yet when all the finds have been plotted, it is possible to view the whole map and predict where oil, or copper or iron might be discovered.’³⁴⁴ Wink sets out to examine the identity of the ‘principalities and powers’ considering the same passages that Berkhof examined and coming to similar conclusions.³⁴⁵ This will be explored further in the next section.

Unmasking the Powers

In his second book *Unmasking the Powers*, Wink explores the invisible forces that determine human existence. While acknowledging that the modern, materialist

³⁴² Ibid., 7–12.

³⁴³ Ibid., 39.

³⁴⁴ Ibid., 99.

³⁴⁵ I Cor. 2:6-8, Rom. 13:1-3, Rom. 8:38-39, I Cor. 15:24-27a, Col. 2:13-15, Col. 1:16, the seven references to *stoicheia* “elements”, Col. 2:9-10, Eph. 2:1-2, Eph. 6:12 and Eph. 3:10

worldview has no place for Satan, demons, angels, and the gods. Wink believes that the reality to which this language pointed (in the ancient world) is real but resides in a cosmology and worldview that was predominant in that day. For Wink, cosmology is not the gospel, and the ancient worldview simply determined how the message was spoken and understood. When the materialist worldview became the dominant myth of the West, some abandoned the faith, while others dismissed science. Instead, Wink interprets the Powers in a ‘new, postmaterialist cosmology.’³⁴⁶ He seeks to recover the common terminology that a materialist worldview avoided. He examines Satan, demons, the angels of the churches, the angels of nations, the gods, the elements of the universe, and the angels of nature, and *translates this terminology into an integral worldview*. The most relevant for this study will be Satan, demons, and the angels of churches, because, in analysis, it will be shown that the lack of distinction between these leads to error and proves unhelpful.

Satan

Wink’s diagnosis of Satan is more unconventional than traditionalist. He speaks of Satan as both a servant of God with a potential path to redemption, as well as the evil one. Wink does not hold that Satan was the snake in Genesis’ based on his contextual appearance in the Old Testament. He writes, ‘We are not accustomed to thinking of Satan as God’s servant. But when Satan makes his late appearance in the Old Testament, that is precisely what he is.’³⁴⁷ For Wink, Satan only makes three appearances in the Old Testament, by name. In 2 Sam. 24:1, where Satan enacts God’s will ‘by visiting wrath on disobedient mortals.’³⁴⁸ In Zach. 3:1-5, Wink sees Satan as an overzealous prosecuting attorney, not demonic.³⁴⁹ Finally, in the prologue of Job, Satan is in the company of the sons of God when they present themselves before the Lord. ‘Here again, Satan is not a fallen angel but a fully credentialed member of the heavenly court.’³⁵⁰ While Wink concedes that Satan goes beyond prosecution to entrapment saying ‘excessive zeal for justice always becomes satanic,’ his diagnosis is that, ‘Job’s Satan, in short, while no friend of Job’s, is in fact humanity’s best friend,

³⁴⁶ Wink, *Unmasking the Powers*, 6.

³⁴⁷ *Ibid.*, 12.

³⁴⁸ *Ibid.*

³⁴⁹ *Ibid.*, 13.

³⁵⁰ *Ibid.*

who lures God into a contest that will end by stripping God of the projections of the oppressors.³⁵¹

Wink believes that Satan is misunderstood by most and that God acts through Satan to do his dirty work, seeing Satan as the shadow side of God. He states, 'God alone is supreme: Satan is thoroughly integrated into the godhead in a wholly non-dualistic fashion. Satan is not evil, or demonic, or fallen, or God's enemy. This adversary is merely a faithful, if overzealous, servant of God, entrusted with quality control and testing.'³⁵²

In addition, Wink sees redeeming qualities of Satan in the New Testament.³⁵³ When Jesus says to Peter 'Get behind me, Satan' (Matt. 16:23b), Wink writes, 'Satan is God's sifter, the left hand of God, whose task is to strain out the impurities in the disciples' commitment to God.'³⁵⁴ It is Wink's belief that Satan is the servant of the living God in this instance, doing things that Jesus himself was unable to do with Peter. He writes, 'Satan is depicted here as able to accomplish something that Jesus had himself been unable to achieve during his ministry.'³⁵⁵

In both testaments, Wink sees Satan as a servant of God and the evil one, the determining factor of how Satan is constellated is a person's 'responses to the satanic occasion.'³⁵⁶ Wink holds that 'Israelite religion originally had no place for Satan. God alone was the source of everything, good or ill. As Yahweh was ethicalized, good and evil were differentiated within the godhead, and Satan became the prosecuting attorney in the heavenly council.'³⁵⁷

Demons

When it comes to demons, Wink seeks to 'reconcile two contradictory views of the origin of the demonic.'³⁵⁸ One view, held by liberation theologians, Marxists, and other social theorists, is that persona pathology is due 'to oppressive structures of power.'³⁵⁹

³⁵¹ Ibid., 13–14.

³⁵² Ibid., 14.

³⁵³ Wink takes a redemptive view of Satan in the following passages: I Cor. 5:1-5, I Tim. 1:20, Matt. 4:1-11, Luke 4:1-13, II Cor. 12:1-10, I Cor. 7:5, Eph. 4:26-27, James 4:26-27, Jude 8-9 and II Peter 2:10-11.

³⁵⁴ Wink, *Unmasking the Powers*, 14.

³⁵⁵ Ibid., 15.

³⁵⁶ Ibid., 32.

³⁵⁷ Ibid., 31.

³⁵⁸ Ibid., 41.

³⁵⁹ Ibid.

The other view held by many in the U.S. is that while structures may contribute to the personal, it is ultimately ‘the consequence of personal developmental malfunctions.’³⁶⁰ Thus, one emphasizes the demonic as outer and the other as inner. It should be no surprise that Wink’s integral worldview synthesized these two polarized views. He states, ‘The demonic is not then merely the consequences that follow in the wake of self-idolizing institutions; it is also the spirit of that institution itself into those whose compliance the institution requires in order to further its absolutizing schemes.’³⁶¹ Therefore, the inner demonic feeds the outer demonic, and the outer feeds the inner.

While seeing the inner and outer as important manifestations of the demonic, in unmasking the demonic he makes some distinctions. There are three primary demonic manifestations: ‘outer personal possession, collective possession, and the inner personal demonic.’³⁶² He describes the three this way:

By outer personal possession I mean the possession of an individual by something that is alien and extrinsic to the self. By collective possession I mean the possession of groups or even nations by a god or a demon capable of bending them into the service of death. And by the inner personal demonic, I mean the struggle to integrate a split-off or repressed aspect that is intrinsic to the personality, an aspect that is only made evil by its rejection.³⁶³

Wink examines the various ways the demonic shows up in scripture, taking seriously the effects it has on its victim(s). Table 1 summarizes important aspects of the three ways the demonic manifests itself, and the appropriate response.³⁶⁴

Table 1. Wink’s Responses to the Demonic

Manifestation	Description	Biblical Text	Remedy
Outer Personal	One person bears the brunt of the collective demonism	Mark 5:1-20	Exorcism, deliverance of a person or institution from its bondage to demonic evil
Collective	Diabolical possession <i>en masse</i> , divinizing some moral above God	Eph. 2:1-3	Symbolic acts of social protest through the ritual act of exorcism, unveiling ideological blindness
Inner Personal	The unintegrated aspect of the self, rendered grotesque from suppression or rejection	Mark 7:14-23	The shadow side must be owned and transformed

³⁶⁰ Ibid.

³⁶¹ Ibid., 42–43.

³⁶² Ibid., 43.

³⁶³ Ibid.

³⁶⁴ Ibid., 41–68.

Ultimately, he speaks of a type of demythologized understanding of the demonic to counteract ‘the tendency to personify demons as little beings in the sky’ and a *remythologizing* of the demonic to mean ‘the psychic or spiritual power emanated by societies or institutions or individuals or sub-aspects of individuals whose energies are bent on overpowering others.’³⁶⁵ Discernment is needed, for the remedy for the outer personal and collective is a type of exorcism, while the inner personal needs to be owned and transformed.

For Wink, there is no room for abdicating personal responsibility by blaming Satan or the demons. For example, he says many in Germany during World War II let themselves be possessed.³⁶⁶ When speaking of the rise of Nazism, Wink writes, ‘they treat demons as if they were disincarnate spiritual beings in the air, rather than the actual spirituality of Nazism. The demonic was inseparable from its political forms: the Hitler Youth, the SS, the Gestapo, the cooperation of the church, the ideology of Aryan racial purity, and the revival of Norse mythology.’³⁶⁷ For Wink, ‘The demonic was the interiority of the German state made into an idol. The demon was the Angel of Germany having turned its back on its vocation.’³⁶⁸

Understanding Wink’s perception of the Powers requires one to recognize that they represent the mythic in scripture, in that Satan is regarded as a snake and a dragon. These mythic characters have a reality beyond Bultmann’s demythologizing project. Wink follows what he believes to be Paul’s methodology, demythologizing some things. Then with an integral worldview, he also seeks to remythologize the Powers by recognizing that the Powers are the inner, invisible, spiritual reality found in any organization or institution, whether that be a club, corporation, church, or nation. If one seeks the transformation of an organization, it doesn’t just happen by changing the people who hold different offices of power, but the spirituality of the institution must also be confronted.

Angels of Churches

Wink was first confronted with the angels of Churches in 1964, when he was teaching some teens the book of Revelation in the church he was serving in Hitchcock, Texas. He recognized that John addresses the churches differently than Paul. Paul would

³⁶⁵ Ibid., 68.

³⁶⁶ Ibid., 54.

³⁶⁷ Ibid.

³⁶⁸ Ibid.

typically write to the entire congregation. For example, ‘To the church in Corinth,’ while in the Apocalypse of John, John addressed his words to the angels of the churches.³⁶⁹ It would be easy for Wink to agree with many in the 1960’s, that *angelos* simply meant messenger, as the word could be applied to humans as well as heavenly agents. Recognizing these as human agents would have fit his worldview better at that time in his life. But Wink writes, ‘I could not help but noticing that elsewhere in the book, John never alludes to any such leaders. He himself seems to be the spiritual guide of these seven churches. And everywhere else that the term “angel” appears in the Apocalypse, it unambiguously refers to heavenly messengers.’³⁷⁰ Beyond that, ‘John receives these letters in a heavenly vision which is itself mediated by an angel (Rev. 1:1).’³⁷¹

Because Jewish and Christian literature of the time spoke of guardian angels over nations, nature, and individual people, and because early Christian theologians held to these being heavenly angels, as opposed to human messengers, Wink felt compelled to interpret these messengers as angels. Of course, with his integral worldview, and because John addresses each angel as a single entity, ‘responsible for the churches’ care,’ it ‘would appear that the angel is not something separate from the congregation, but must somehow represent it as a totality.’³⁷² The angel for Wink is the actual spirituality of the congregation, ‘As the corporate personality or felt sense of the whole, the angel of the church would have no separate existence apart from the people, But the converse would be equally true: the people would have no unity apart from the angel. Angel and congregation are the inner and outer aspects of one and the same reality.’³⁷³

Wink then gives possible ways for one to discern the personality and vocation of the angel of a congregation. He starts with the visible, the outer, to discern the invisible or inner heart of the church. For instance, ‘all values, prestige needs, aesthetics, and class status of a congregation will be projected into brick, board and stone.’³⁷⁴ Some of the other outer manifestations that Wink considers are the class, ethnic background, education, and age of the congregation, the structures of power, how the congregation handles conflict, high or low liturgies, as well as the inwardness

³⁶⁹ Ibid., 69.

³⁷⁰ Ibid., 70.

³⁷¹ Ibid.

³⁷² Ibid.

³⁷³ Ibid.

³⁷⁴ Ibid., 74.

or outwardness of the congregation. These realities often continually shape the direction of the church or organization; though leaders change, often the personality of the organization remains the same. For Wink, the outer manifestations can shed light on the inner nature of the congregation, and he considers the angel of the church to incorporate both the visible and invisible realities of the church. Every collective entity, including the church, for Wink, ‘has continuity through time as an angel.’³⁷⁵

After understanding the personality of the church, Wink addresses how the vocation of the church determines how demonic or angelic the church happens to be. ‘The angel of the church becomes demonic when the congregation turns its back on the specific task set before it by God and makes some other goal its idol.’³⁷⁶ Notice the goal of the Powers here is idolatry. Wink points out that God uses John as a messenger to the angel of the churches and reminds us that the angel is not the agent of change, but Christ, through his Spirit. He states, ‘In the final analysis only Christ as the Spirit of the whole church can change a church, and only the renewed presence of that spirit can bring the churches into line with their supreme vocation. Only as changes in personnel, programs, and relationships take place in congruence with that vocation will genuine transformation take place.’³⁷⁷

In the remainder of the book, Wink writes of the angels of nations, the gods, the elements of the universe, and the angels of nature. For Wink, as with the church, the angel of a nation is the ‘inner spirituality of the social entity itself.’³⁷⁸ And while nations can help bond a diverse group of people, nationalism has an ‘irresistible tendency toward idolatry. In the name of this idol whole generations are maimed, slaughtered, exiled, and made idolaters. One hundred million lives have been offered on the altar of this Moloch thus far in the twentieth century...’³⁷⁹ Just like the angel of churches, one needs to discern the personality and vocation of the angel of the nation, for angels tend to abandon their God-given vocations and lift themselves up as ultimate.

In this trilogy, Wink recovers the importance of the Powers and how they shape reality. While Wink’s project differs from Bultmann, it also (admittedly) differs from the first century understanding of the Powers. Wink believes, ‘We cannot simply revive

³⁷⁵ Ibid., 79.

³⁷⁶ Ibid., 78.

³⁷⁷ Ibid., 81.

³⁷⁸ Ibid., 88.

³⁷⁹ Ibid., 87.

that ancient worldview without jettisoning much of what humanity has gained in the interval since. But we can reinterpret it. We can and must seek to recover in it the eternal truth revealed through its characteristic thought-forms, images, and presuppositions.³⁸⁰ Wink believes the Powers are to be understood mythically: they are snakes, dragons, and four-headed creatures, the things of myth, so rather than embarking on a demythologizing journey (though he does this somewhat), he seeks to re-mythologize the Powers for those shaped by later worldviews. For Wink, the Powers are not just structures, as some liberation theologians might say, and they are not dis-incarnate spirits as fundamentalists might believe, *rather they are the real spirituality embodied in concrete organizations, including the church and nations.*

Engaging the Powers

In the final book of the trilogy, *Engaging the Powers*, Wink addresses one of the most pressing questions facing the world today: ‘How can we oppose evil without creating new evils and being made evil ourselves?’³⁸¹ For Wink, to engage evil in the world today as well as to develop a social ethic from a New Testament perspective requires an understanding of the Powers. He chooses the term ‘engage’ as opposed to ‘confronting’ or ‘combatting’ or ‘overcoming’ because, for Wink, the Powers are created good; though fallen, they must be redeemed. He writes, ‘It is precisely because the Powers have been created in, through, and for the humanizing purposes of God in Christ that they must be honored, criticized, resisted, and redeemed.’³⁸²

The Powers have an outer physical manifestation: the organization or institution, officers and offices; they also possess an inner spiritual reality, the heart and personality of an organization or church. ‘The Powers, properly speaking, are not just the spirituality of institutions, but their outer manifestations as well. The New Testament uses language of power to refer now to the outer aspect, now both together, as I have shown in *Naming the Powers*.’³⁸³

The Powers are not a personification of the nature of the institution for Wink, but the real spiritual ethos. While Wink tends to think of the Powers as impersonal entities, he writes, ‘I have bracketed the question of metaphysical status of the Powers, and I’ve instead treated them phenomenologically – that is, I have attempted to

³⁸⁰ Wink, *Unmasking the Powers*, 172.

³⁸¹ Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 3.

³⁸² Ibid., 10.

³⁸³ Ibid., 3.

describe the experiences that got called “Satan,” “demons,” “angels,” and the like.³⁸⁴ For him, demons are ‘the actual spirituality of systems and structures that have betrayed their divine vocations.’³⁸⁵ Wink calls this the Domination System. The Domination System is when ‘an entire network of Powers become integrated around idolatrous values. And I refer to “Satan” as the world encompassing spirit of the Domination System.’³⁸⁶ For Wink, demons have no existence apart from actual institutions. So, while he doesn’t attempt to solve the metaphysical issue and prefers ‘to regard them as the impersonal spiritual realities at the center of institutional life,’ he nonetheless weighs in on the issue throughout his work.³⁸⁷

The Domination System

Wink first describes the Domination System when he demonstrates that the myth of redemptive violence is the spirituality of the modern world, grounded in the *Enuma Elish*, where creation is an act of violence, where evil precedes good, and order is established by disorder.³⁸⁸ This myth goes by various names – ‘The Babylonian creation story, combat myth, the ideology of zealous nationalism.’³⁸⁹ He calls it the myth of redemptive violence, the first articulation of ‘might makes right.’³⁹⁰ For Wink this is the dominant myth in contemporary American culture, believed more than Judaism or Christianity.³⁹¹ In the myth of redemptive violence, ‘the survival and welfare of the nation are elevated as the highest earthly and heavenly good. There can be no gods before nation. This myth not only established a patriotic religion at the heart of the state, but also gives that nation’s imperialistic imperative divine sanction.’³⁹² This myth is the spirituality of militarism and is religious in nature, for ‘one can only go to war religiously.’³⁹³

³⁸⁴ Ibid., 8.

³⁸⁵ Ibid.

³⁸⁶ Ibid.

³⁸⁷ Ibid., 9.

³⁸⁸ Ibid., 14.

³⁸⁹ Ibid.

³⁹⁰ Ibid.

³⁹¹ Ibid., 17.

³⁹² Ibid., 26.

³⁹³ Ibid.

Defining the Terms - World (Kosmos), Aion (Age), Sarx (Flesh)

The Greek words *kosmos* (world), *aion* (age), and *sarx* (flesh) are the terms that the writers of scripture used to name the domination system, and by naming it, they could strip it 'of its invisibility and legitimacy.'³⁹⁴ Wink points out that when the word "world" is seen in the New Testament, it encompasses several meanings. It has positive connotations, as in 'universe, the creation, humanity, planet earth, the theater of history.'³⁹⁵ It is also used negatively, as when it 'refers to *the human sociological realms that exist in estrangement from God*,'³⁹⁶ For instance, when Jesus talks about the kingdom of this world as opposed to the kingdom of God. Because the term "world" has so many different meanings, Wink finds it helpful to translate it one way when referring to creation and people, whom God loves, and another way to refer to that which is estranged from God. Wink suggests that if the term 'System' is used when referring to the world that is opposed to God, it would bring some light to the naming and unmasking of the Powers.

For example, when the Pharisees challenge Jesus' authority to attack their religious order, he responds, 'You are of this world; I am not of this world' (Jn 8:23). Because Jesus is using the word 'world' negatively here, 'System' might clarify things, and not be as open to misinterpretation. 'You are of this System, I am not of this System.' If someone mistakes the world to mean that which God has created to be good, it would make Jesus an otherworldly, non-human gnostic when he says, 'I am not of this world.' But when System is used it is obvious that Jesus is not rejecting the good world that he has made, but the Domination System that sees Jesus as a threat, because he testifies against it, that its works are evil.³⁹⁷

Paul when writing to the church in Ephesus speaks of the existing System as a living death. The Phillips translation reads, 'You were spiritually dead all the time that you drifted along the stream of this world's ideas of living, and obeyed its unseen ruler' (Eph. 2:1). Or, as Wink writes, using some of the key Greek terms in translating the second part of the sentence: "'You walked according to the *aion* of this *kosmos*.'" This *kosmos* is the prevailing world-atmosphere that we breathe in like toxic air, often without realizing it.'³⁹⁸ For Wink, the Domination System 'penetrates everything,

³⁹⁴ Ibid., 51.

³⁹⁵ Ibid.

³⁹⁶ Ibid.

³⁹⁷ Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 52.

³⁹⁸ Ibid., 53.

teaching us not only what to believe, but what we can value and even what we can see.’³⁹⁹ And the presiding spirit of the Domination System is Satan. Wink translates, ‘I will no longer talk much with you, for the ruler (*archon*) of this System (*kosmos*) is coming. He has no power over me: but I do as the Abba has commanded me, so that the System may know that I love the Abba. (John 14:30-31).’⁴⁰⁰

The other important term to understand if leaders are to learn how to name, unmask, and engage the Powers is *aion*. It is often interchangeable with *kosmos* and translated ‘world’. Instead of indicating the structure of reality, it indicates the flow of time. ‘Any major time period in the total temporal flow can be categorized as *aion*.’⁴⁰¹ Wink puts it this way:

The present world-period, however, is under the power of evil. Here again, as with *kosmos* the term *aion* takes on a unique sense in some New Testament passages. Thus the *kosmos* can be called “the present evil epoch (*aion*)” (Gal. 1:4), organized under Satan, “the god of this world-period (*aion*)” who “has blinded the minds of the unbelievers, to keep them from seeing the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ” (2 Cor. 4:4).’

In the same way that John uses *kosmos* to unmask the Domination System, uncovering the world system, Paul uses *aion* to speak of the Domination Epoch. Redeeming the time is not so much about being more efficient, but unmasking and engaging the oppression that has been taking place generation after generation under the current Domination Epoch. For Wink, ‘Evil in history was not always present; it had an origin in time. Likewise, evil will not always exist; it has an end time, when “this *aion*” is superseded by “the *aion* to come (Matt 12:32). Thus, like “world, “time” is good, fallen, and must itself be redeemed.’⁴⁰²

The final term Wink seeks to clarify is *sarx*. Again, as with *kosmos* and *aion*, the term *sarx* (flesh) has both positive and negative connotations, depending on the context. Positively it can refer to the physical body, the self, human beings, or humanity in general. Negatively, especially found in Paul, it is ‘in reference to the self in its alienated mode. Living life “according to the flesh” (*kata sarka*) denotes the self externalized and subjugated to the opinion of others.’⁴⁰³ This will be important to remember when engaging Girard.

³⁹⁹ Ibid.

⁴⁰⁰ Ibid., 57.

⁴⁰¹ Ibid., 59.

⁴⁰² Ibid., 59–60.

⁴⁰³ Ibid., 61–62.

Wink continues to describe the alienated self: 'It is the self socialized into a world of inauthentic values, values that lead it away from its own centeredness in God. It is the beachhead that the Domination System establishes in our beings... it is the pursuit of the values of the Domination System.'⁴⁰⁴ The most succinct way that Wink describes *sarx* in its negative connotations is 'dominated existence' by which he means 'a life lived according to the dictates of the Domination System.'⁴⁰⁵

Each of these three terms are reflected as good in creation, though they become fallen and need redemption. God seeks to redeem bodies, time, and the world system, which for Wink speaks to the nature of the Domination System. In *Engaging the Powers*, Wink paints a picture of God's Domination-Free Order as it relates to domination, equality, purity and holiness, racism/ethnocentrism, family, law, sacrifice, nonviolence, women, children, healing, and exorcism. Then he looks at how to engage the Powers non-violently through the example and teaching of Jesus, and through prayer, praise, and life in the Spirit. The final element needing to be examined to get a sense of his theology of the Powers is that they were created for good, are fallen, and can be redeemed.

The Powers are Good, Fallen, and Can Be Redeemed

For Wink, the good news is, 'that God not only liberates us from the Powers, but liberates the Powers as well.'⁴⁰⁶ Looking to the hymn of the cosmic Christ in Col. 1:16-17, where the Powers are described as having been created in, through, and for Christ, he suggests that the New Testament articulates that 'evil is not intrinsic, but rather the result of idolatry.'⁴⁰⁷ Thus the drama of scripture is found in three simultaneous acts: the Powers are good, the Powers are fallen, and the Powers will be redeemed.⁴⁰⁸

The Powers are good in that, as the Colossians hymn indicates, they are God's creations, made to serve 'the humanizing purposes of God in the world.'⁴⁰⁹ These powers are economic, political, and social structures needed for life to be lived. As Wink puts it, 'They are not demonized as utterly evil; they are the good creations of a good God, and God, in the Genesis story of creation, creates no demons.'⁴¹⁰ While

⁴⁰⁴ Ibid.

⁴⁰⁵ Ibid., 62.

⁴⁰⁶ Ibid., 65.

⁴⁰⁷ Ibid.

⁴⁰⁸ Ibid.

⁴⁰⁹ Ibid., 66.

⁴¹⁰ Ibid.

institutions are needed for human survival, and it is appropriate for them to be concerned about their survival, the danger comes when their survival becomes ultimate. Here institutions become demonic.

While the Powers are good because they were created by God, that doesn't mean that God endorses any particular economic or political system. As Wink writes,

This simultaneity of creation, fall, and redemption means that God at one and the same time upholds a given political or economic system, since some such system is required to support human life; condemns that system insofar as it is destructive of human actualization; and presses for its transformation into a more humane order. Conservatives stress the first, revolutionaries the second, reformers the third. The Christian is expected to hold together all three.⁴¹¹

While the Powers are good, they are fallen and capable of radical evil. Wink has four significant points in regard to the doctrine of the Fall. Here is the best summary of his understanding:

I submit (1) that the doctrine of the Fall provides an account of evil that acknowledges its brute reality while preserving the sovereignty and goodness of God and creation; (2) that it is not just a temporal myth and thus did not simply happen "once upon a time," but is also a structural aspect of all personal and social existence; (3) that the doctrine of the Fall frees us from delusions about the perfectibility of ourselves and our institutions; and (4) that it reminds us that we cannot be saved from the Powers by anything within the Power System, but only by something that transcends it.⁴¹²

The depth of the Fall tempers expectations for Wink about what is possible on this side of the new heavens and new earth. For 'The Powers are at once and the same time ordained by God and in the power of Satan.'⁴¹³ While the Powers can be made to serve human purposes in a good way, they are still fallen and in need of redemption. Fallenness is the fact that all live under the sway of the Domination System.⁴¹⁴ It is important to note that for Wink, 'there is in Scripture no account of the creation of demons. Unlike the Powers, the demonic is not a constituent part of the universe. Its emergence is always an event in time, the consequence of wrong choices.'⁴¹⁵ Institutions become demonic when they pursue idolatrous goals. 'But what has become perverted in time can be redeemed in time.'⁴¹⁶

⁴¹¹ Ibid., 67.

⁴¹² Ibid., 69.

⁴¹³ Ibid., 70.

⁴¹⁴ Ibid., 72.

⁴¹⁵ Ibid.

⁴¹⁶ Ibid.

The redemption of the Powers for Wink means taking both the personal and social seriously. The personal cannot be reduced to the social, as some liberationist theologians and philosophers believe, because ‘no structural change will, of necessity, produce good or transformed people. I have considerable sympathy with conservative groups in the mainline American denominations who fault church leadership for ignoring evangelism altogether or redefining it as struggles for social existence.’⁴¹⁷ For changed people who are reconciled with God and moving toward transformation, is for Wink, the very core of the gospel message.⁴¹⁸ And social change tends to happen when an individual or individuals stand up to unjust systems. While human misery is caused by institutions, these institutions are maintained by people.

Wink thinks all evil cannot be wholly subscribed to social, political, or religious systems because in the narrative of Genesis, the first fall is that of Adam and Eve. ‘Human sin is ontologically prior to all social systems and structures. Therefore, it cannot be reduced to social determinism, but is an act of willful rebellion against God (Genesis 3).’⁴¹⁹ The second fall that Wink notes is that of angels, saying ‘there is a rupture in the very spirituality of the universe (Gen. 6:1-4). Human sin cannot therefore account for all evil. There is a “withinness” or spirituality in things that is capable of covetousness and insatiable greed.’⁴²⁰ The fall of humans and angels are then followed by the fall of nations, where the systems and structures live their divine path through their idolatrous goals and hurt the people they were made to serve. Wink: ‘Together, these three mythical tableaux from Genesis provide a vast panorama for contemplation. They prevent us from reducing people to society or society to people, the spiritual to the structural or the structural to the spiritual.’⁴²¹

Consequently, while the personal cannot be reduced to the social, it is also true that the social cannot be reduced to the personal as some fundamentalist Christians might believe. Structures have their own laws, independent of individuals. And all companies, governments, and churches live in (some under) the Domination System ruled and shaped by the evil one.

Jesus is not just Saviour of souls, but of the world. Therefore, Wink, throughout his writings, maintains that both evangelism and social justice go hand in hand;

⁴¹⁷ Ibid., 74.

⁴¹⁸ Ibid.

⁴¹⁹ Ibid., 77.

⁴²⁰ Ibid.

⁴²¹ Ibid.

transformation and redemption must involve both personal and social together. Part of the churches' evangelistic task, as Wink reminds us, is 'proclaiming to the Principalities and Powers in the heavenly places the manifold wisdom of God (Eph. 3:10). And that means addressing the spirituality of actual institutions that have rebelled against their divine vocations and have made themselves gods.'⁴²² The Powers are good but the Powers are fallen; yet the hope is that because of the life, death, and resurrection of Christ, they will be redeemed, through personal and social transformation.

Wink's Theology of the Powers and Missional Leadership

Wink has served the church by giving us the most comprehensive understanding of the Powers to date, one which is commendable to the Western Academic milieu, and experientially relevant in the face of evil today. His account of the Powers brings some apprehension to Van Gelder and Zscheile's positive view of the culture/world. The goal of this analysis is to gain a better understanding of the nature and work of the Powers, and how that might inform an approach to missional leadership. While Wink gives us much to digest, this section will explore his worldview and ground rules, which are foundational to his project, followed by exploring themes relevant to this study.

Worldview and Ground Rules

First, Wink exegetes the text in context, to understand what the Powers meant to the original recipients. He then transposes this understanding into what he considers to be the prevailing worldview of today, an integrated worldview. His desire was not only to make the Powers palatable to those unconsciously steeped in a materialist worldview, but to demonstrate the need for all to recognize the spiritual dimension of reality. For if one is going to be able to join God in the renewal of all things, living into the telos of new creation, engaging the Powers is unavoidable. In this Wink was successful.

Wink would be the reinterpreter on the Ford/Frei scale, someone who sees 'integration with modernity [or postmodernity] as more important and even essential to modern theology.'⁴²³ Wink sought to do the hard work of contextualizing the message in today's Western context. Wink points out that worldviews are not the gospel but that 'Worldviews determine what we are allowed to believe about the world.'⁴²⁴ This also

⁴²² Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 85.

⁴²³ Ford and Muers, *The Modern Theologians*, 5.

⁴²⁴ Wink, *The Powers That Be*, 22.

applies to his current worldview. Translating the Powers to an integrative worldview was his primary theological task, yet he failed to give us all the presuppositions he was working with when describing this worldview.

When *The Powers that Be* was released, the popular version of his trilogy, he formally named the integrated worldview as panentheism, in contrast to pantheism. He writes, ‘In this worldview, soul permeates the universe. God is not just within me, but within everything. The universe is suffused with the divine. This is not pantheism, where everything is God, but panentheism (*pan*, everything; *en*: in *theos*, God), where everything is in God and God in everything.’⁴²⁵ Some might dismiss Wink for this but John Cooper, a classical theist, who has done a major work in this area describes the history, complexity, and variations of panentheism today.⁴²⁶ He finds shades and varieties of panentheism in Jonathan Edwards, Tillich, Moltmann, and Pannenberg. Today, some explicitly identify with it, like Moltmann and Wink, others, in his opinion, are implicit, like Pannenberg.⁴²⁷

Roger Olson writes about the complexity of defining panentheism today. ““Panentheism” is a somewhat flexible and evolving concept. When someone says “panentheism” or “panentheist” I ask what they mean. The term has no definite, universally agreed on definition. I no longer take it for granted.”⁴²⁸ For Olson, the affirmation of *creation ex nihilo* is ‘minimally necessary for a robust biblical and theologically sound doctrine.’⁴²⁹ Olson makes note that the classic text for the panentheist, is Paul’s quotation of the Greek poet: ‘For in him we live and move and have our being,’ (Acts 17:28 NIV). Yet Olson states that this is directly preceded by, ‘The God who made the world and everything in it is the Lord of heaven and earth and does not live in temples built by human hands. And he is not served by human hands, as if he needed anything’ (Acts 17:24 NIV). It is important to consider this in the analysis of Wink’s work, for as Wink himself has said, worldviews limit what one can believe.

⁴²⁵ Ibid., 20.

⁴²⁶ John W. Cooper, *Panentheism--The Other God of the Philosophers: From Plato to the Present*, Reprint edition. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2013), 26–30.

⁴²⁷ Ibid.

⁴²⁸ Roger E. Olson, “What’s Wrong with Panentheism?,” *Roger E. Olson*, August 7, 2012, accessed November 20, 2019, <https://www.patheos.com/blogs/rogereolson/2012/08/whats-wrong-with-panentheism/>.

⁴²⁹ Ibid.

One of the ways Wink's worldview seems limiting is his understanding of the angels of churches. For Wink, the angel is not an external reality, but the internal spirituality of the church. But the scriptures indicate angels have appeared in exterior manifestations. The writer of Hebrews encourages hospitality, saying, 'Do not forget to show hospitality to strangers, for by doing so some people have shown hospitality to angels without knowing it' (Heb. 13:2 NIV). Wink gives some helpful wisdom on the spirituality of the church, which can be discerned by looking at the outer and inner realities. But to internalize angels to the soul of the church flattens the storyline of Scripture. What would the story look like without the angel speaking to Mary, without angels singing at Jesus' birth? What would the narrative look like without the angels that ministered to Jesus in the wilderness, without the angel at Jesus' gravesite? What would the throne of God be like without the seraphim and cherubim and the myriad of angels singing praises?

Not only should one question this worldview, but Wink's fourth rule of interpretation, which states that the terms relating to the Powers are, to a degree, interchangeable, doesn't seem evident, though he does note there are exceptions. Marva Dawn writes,

Though the terms *arche*, *dunamis*, *exousia*, *thrones*, and *kuriotes* occur interchangeably on lists in the Scriptures, it seems that there are some differences between them and words for angels (*angelos*) and demons (*diamonia*) – names that often seem specifically to signify supernatural beings. Wink's mixing together of all the terms confuses the meanings of these two sets, though these biblical usage suggest some precision in its choices from the two kinds of terms. Thus, Wink's proposition 4 – that all terms are interchangeable and that one or more can represent them all – seems to be in error.⁴³⁰

While there seem to be some cracks in the foundation of his argument, it is important to realize that he still brings much value to the Powers conversation. As this analysis proceeds, it would be helpful to be alert to Wink's worldview and the exceptions to his fourth rule.

Understanding the 'Principalities and Powers' in Paul

When it comes to discerning the nature of the principalities and powers in Paul, New Testament scholar Andrew Lincoln poses two important questions.

One question is, What reading, to the best of our knowledge, most adequately explains the force of the language about the powers for the writer and readers in

⁴³⁰ Dawn, *Powers, Weakness, and the Tabernacling of God*, 14.

the context of the first century CE? The other is, given the first-century reference of the language of the texts, how many contemporary interpreters best provide a reading that appropriates that language for their own time and setting? Obviously, while the first question will be of significance to all students of early Christianity, the second will be of concern primarily for those for whom the New Testament forms an important resource for critical appropriation in the construction of a contemporary Christian theology and ethic.⁴³¹

Wink separated exegetical work, in discerning texts' meaning in the context of production, from the hermeneutical work of appropriating the text in the context of reception. His exegetical work holds great value as does his hermeneutical work. While Lincoln applauds people like Clinton Arnold and his approach to exegesis, he finds fault with their approach to hermeneutics. He says, 'While their concern for accurate exegesis is to be applauded, their own confusion about the relation of exegesis and contemporary appropriation may be as great as those they criticize.'⁴³² Lincoln sees much value in appropriating the Powers as structures and ideologies, because Christians have always sought to reapply the text for their time and place.⁴³³ While he picks up on some flaws in the exegesis of Berkhof and Wink, he considers their interpretations and reapplication of the Powers as a gift, more than a concern.⁴³⁴

Lincoln, along with others, recognizes that understanding the nature and work of the Powers is part of the larger problem of 'human life in the face of evil' and that the authors of scripture are more interested in offering solutions to evil than explaining the mystery of its origin or becoming absorbed in debates about 'exousiology.'⁴³⁵

While Lincoln agrees with Arnold's exegesis, he give three alternatives to appropriate the language of the principalities and powers today: '(a) the relevant texts were referring to supernatural forces in their original communicative situation and this worldview is to be accepted and reasserted now' (this is essentially what Clinton Arnold seeks to do), '(b) the texts were referring to supernatural forces then but are best appropriated in terms of ideologies and societal structures now, or (c) the texts were referring to both supernatural and human or earthly forces then and so can be

⁴³¹ Andrew T. Lincoln, "Liberation from the Powers: Supernatural or Societal Structures?," in *The Bible in Human Society: Essays in Honour of John Rogerson*, ed. M. Daniel Carroll R., David J.A. Clines, and Philip R. Davies (Sheffield, England: Sheffield Academic Press, 1995), 337.

⁴³² Ibid., 352.

⁴³³ Ibid.

⁴³⁴ Ibid.

⁴³⁵ Ibid., 352–353.

appropriated in terms of the later now in continuity with the original meaning of the texts.⁴³⁶

Lincoln considers option (a) untenable in the face of fully engaging the Powers today, and at the time of his writing, he felt like proponents of (c) had failed to make their case strongly enough.⁴³⁷ He personally held to a variation of option (b):

... this simply involves seeing an analogy between the function of the powers then and of ideologies and institutions now. Analogy, of course stresses significant similarities but also allows for differences. It is certainly not claiming any one-to-one correspondence between the original and the appropriation. But making this analogy could also be seen in terms of remythologization. Those who wish to go further, however, by saying that what in their experience Paul and his followers called principalities and powers is the same as what in our experience we encounter as ideologies and social structures, are more clearly involved in demythologizing and claiming some one-to-one correspondence in experience between the original and appropriation.⁴³⁸

Lincoln's approach seeks to be faithful to the context of production and sees much value in having a broader approach to hermeneutics than Arnold by valuing the contribution of Berkhof and Wink. Still, this author finds compelling recent exegetical scholarship that supports the third option. In particular, Chris Forbes' exegetical work on the principalities and powers, which refers to them as both spiritual agents as well as ideologies and social structures.⁴³⁹ Forbes' both/and characterization makes a strong case that 'Paul's description of the "spiritual world" combines elements familiar from the rest of the New Testament (angels and demons) with his own less personal, more abstract concept of "principalities and powers".⁴⁴⁰ Forbes argues that while Paul never takes angels and demons off the radar, in terms of frequency and theological development he takes more interest in the principalities and powers,' closely related in his thought to 'the Law, Sin and Death, and the "elements of this world"'.⁴⁴¹ Forbes successfully argues,

That the distinctive concepts expressed by Paul's 'principalities and powers' language are best understood against the background of popular Middle Platonism, particularly as it is expressed in Philo and Plutarch. Rather than 'demythologizing the demonology of his apocalyptic heritage, Paul saw a

⁴³⁶ Ibid., 348.

⁴³⁷ Ibid., 349.

⁴³⁸ Ibid.

⁴³⁹ Chris Forbes, "Paul's Principalities and Powers: Demythologizing Apocalyptic?," *Journal for the Study of the New Testament* 23, no. 82 (July 1, 2001): 61–88.

⁴⁴⁰ Ibid.

⁴⁴¹ Ibid., 88.

continuum between pure abstractions ('height and depth', Rom. 8:39), personifiable abstractions ('principalities and powers') literary personifications ('Law, Sin and Death') and 'actual' personal spiritual beings. Such a view has its roots in Greek thinking going back as far as the fifth century BCE, and still current in the popular Platonism of the first and early second centuries. In his understanding of 'principalities and powers', Paul is working creatively between the angelology and demonology of his Jewish heritage, and the world-view of the thoughtful Greco-Roman philosophical amateur.⁴⁴²

This understanding of the principalities and powers gives credence to the work of Arnold, Berkhof, Wink, and Lincoln, while issuing a correction to each of them. Seeing the principalities and powers from a both/and perspective (both as spiritual agents and social structures), as opposed to an either/or perspective, brings a greater continuity between the exegetical and hermeneutical task. While Arnold's view speaks to the majority world (the global south), and Berkhof and Wink appeal to those living in the plausibility structure of the Western milieu, Forbes' exegetical work demonstrates in a comprehensive way how Paul was inspired by the Holy Spirit to speak to the reality of how the Powers are encountered in different contexts.

There is no need for scholars to hold a disenchanted worldview where angels and demons are reinterpreted as structures, or as the inner spirituality of an organization alone. In fact, holding this idea gives an incomplete view of the forces that work against the leader. By nature it limits the kind of practices needed to fight the fight of faith.⁴⁴³ Thomas R. Yoder Neufeld, in his commentary on Ephesians, helpfully points out that the many descriptions of spiritual realities in 6:12, 'are intended to be shorthand for the myriad of powers, great and small, personal and impersonal, individual and systemic, that resist the saving activity of God among humanity'⁴⁴⁴

Neufeld gives a helpful reminder that this terminology speaks to how these Powers shape the atmosphere of the world today. Understanding that the Powers involve spiritual entities as well as ideologies and social structures, Neufeld stresses how Paul encourages God's people as a collective community to put on the full armour of God as a concrete communal practice to resist the Powers.

⁴⁴² Chris Forbes, "Pauline Demonology and/or Cosmology? Principalities, Powers and the Elements of the World in Their Hellenistic Context," *Journal for the Study of the New Testament* 24, no. 3 (March 1, 2002): 51–73.

⁴⁴³ Robert Ewusie Moses, "Powerful Practices: Paul's Principalities and Powers Revisited" (PhD diss., Duke Divinity School, 2012).

⁴⁴⁴ Thomas R. Yoder Neufeld, *Ephesians: Believers Church Bible Commentary* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 2002), 296. Reference: (Lincoln: 445; Yoder Neufeld, 1997:122-4 [Powers]

The primary way the Powers manifest themselves in the Western world is through social realities like ideologies and institutions. Still, when traveling to continents like Africa, Latin America, and some parts of Asia, the missional leader will likely fail to minister to these cultures adequately without a comprehensive understanding of the Powers, including Satan, demons, the flesh, and world systems.⁴⁴⁵ Given the increasing diversity in Western cultures, a lack of solid contextualization may prohibit leaders from ministering to every people group living in the West as well.

Robert Ewusie Moses points out that the New Testament writers ‘have a message that demands epistemological transformation, and thus, is a scandal to all who have not experienced this epistemological transformation.’⁴⁴⁶

Analysing Wink’s View of Satan

Wink espouses an interesting view of Satan. While analysis will show that his view of Satan’s telos is precarious, he is right to note that Satan is a developing character in the Biblical story, without much attention in the Hebrew text.⁴⁴⁷ Following Bernhard W. Anderson’s overview of *Sin and the Powers of Chaos*, Susan Garrett gives a brief overview of biblical perspectives on Satan and Evil from Genesis to Revelation.⁴⁴⁸ When it comes to people understanding evil and suffering in the world, the beginning of the story emphasizes the fault being on ‘humans’ misuse of their God-given freedom and their consequent guilt and punishment. In Revelation, by contrast, the focus is no longer merely on sin, but on the wider dimensions of the evil that corrupts the cosmos. In Revelation the serpent has become ‘the archenemy of God, the leader of the hosts of chaos, who foment a rebellion that spreads through the whole creation.’⁴⁴⁹ Garrett mentions that at the heart of Mosaic covenant theology, evil and suffering were the consequence of human failure.⁴⁵⁰ In Daniel’s time, the apocalyptic writers ‘provided “a new understanding of the radical power of evil.”’⁴⁵¹ ‘To symbolize this tyranny of evil in society and in history, the book of Daniel reaches back into the mythic heritage that

⁴⁴⁵ Moses, “Powerful Practices”; Kabiro wa Gatumu, *The Pauline Concept of Supernatural Powers: A Reading from the African Worldview* (Milton Keynes: Paternoster, 2008).

⁴⁴⁶ Moses, “Powerful Practices,” 26.

⁴⁴⁷ Susan R. Garrett, *No Ordinary Angel: Celestial Spirits and Christian Claims about Jesus*, 1st edition. (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2008), 113.

⁴⁴⁸ Ibid., 103–138.

⁴⁴⁹ Ibid., 112.

⁴⁵⁰ Ibid., 113.

⁴⁵¹ Ibid., 114.

ancient Israelites shared with their neighbors.⁴⁵² Then there was a shift to Satan.

Garrett explains,

The story of Satan's emergence in the late pre-Christian era as archfiend of God and God's people is intricate and difficult. Over the course of centuries, Jews had reflected on various adversary-figures known from ancient myths about combat by God (or the gods) with divine enemies. These myths circulated throughout the ancient Near East and were preserved both in independent narratives and in snippets scattered throughout the Hebrew Scriptures. Adversary-figures from these myths included the rebellious angels of Genesis 6:1-4 and of subsequent legendary retellings, the dragon Leviathan, the arrogant rulers of Isaiah 14 and Ezekiel 28-32, a character named Belial (from a Hebrew word meaning "worthless, useless, productive of disorder"), and the archfiend from Zoroastrian religion (known as Angra Mianyu or Ahriman). In the third or second century BCE, ideas about these adversary figures began to merge with and shape developing views on the character of *satan* (a Hebrew word meaning "accuser" or "adversary") as known from Job, Zechariah, and I Chronicles.⁴⁵³

Garrett mentions that at the time that Genesis was written, 'the archfiend Satan was not yet in view, but as centuries passed interpretations of Genesis 3 changed.'⁴⁵⁴ This is confirmed by Biblical theologians John and Harvey Walton, while the historical development of Satan is confirmed by Lincoln.⁴⁵⁵

By the time of the New Testament, Jesus describes Satan as the thief who 'comes only to steal and kill and destroy' (Jn 10:10). Therefore, it seems unhelpful when Wink characterizes Satan more positively in the New Testament. Though God in his sovereignty can use the devil for his own purposes, this should not be confused with the fact that Satan is clearly defined as humanity's enemy whose ultimate mission is to kill, steal and destroy. As Gregory Boyd writes, "It is one thing to say that God in his sovereign wisdom is able to put Satan's evil activity to good use, and quite another thing to say that Satan carries out God's good purposes by engaging in his evil activity.'⁴⁵⁶

Girard's understanding of Satan corresponds better to the revelation offered in scripture. Wink's view of Satan leans more heavily on Carl Jung than it should, as Jung believed that God would be better understood as Quaternity, instead of Trinity. Les

⁴⁵² Ibid., 115.

⁴⁵³ Ibid., 115–116.

⁴⁵⁴ Ibid., 117.

⁴⁵⁵ John H Walton and J. Harvey Walton, eds., *Demons and Spirits in Biblical Theology: Reading the Biblical Text in Its Cultural and Literary Context* (Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2019), 128–147; Lincoln, "Liberation from the Powers: Supernatural or Societal Structures?," 349–352.

⁴⁵⁶ Gregory Boyd, "Response to Walter Wink," in *Understanding Spiritual Warfare*, ed. James K. Beilby and Paul Rhodes Eddy (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2012), 80.

Oglesby, quoting Jung, said ‘Christ and the devil appear as equal and opposite, thus conforming to the idea of the “adversary”’. This opposition means conflict to the last, and it is the task of humanity to endure this conflict until the time or turning-point is reached where good and evil begin to relativize themselves.’⁴⁵⁷ For Jung, the devil represented the shadow side of God, and humanity along with the Holy Spirit would help resolve the tension between the brothers - Christ and the anti-Christ [Satan].⁴⁵⁸ This dependence on Jung is seen throughout Wink’s writings, though Satan as the spirit of the domination system is a place Wink views Satan more darkly. Wink seems to have hope for Satan’s redemption, when he writes, ‘Then perhaps, if we can live through that dark interval between Satan’s death and resurrection, we may yet see Satan functioning again – as a servant of the living God!’⁴⁵⁹ This seems contrary to the *telos* that Jesus gives to Satan and his demons (Matt. 25:41; Rom. 16:20, Rev. 20:10).

Understanding the Demonic

Wink’s view of the demonic seems to better reflect Revelation, and his analysis of the different manifestations of the demonic and their remedies was helpful. Still, conflating the demonic with the institutions seems in error. His distinction of the demonic from the principalities and powers that will be redeemed is vital. He writes,

Where the Powers are the good creations of a good God, by contrast, there is in Scripture no account of the creation of demons. Unlike the Powers, the demonic is not a constituent part of the universe. Its emergence is always an event in time, the consequence of wrong choices. An institution becomes demonic when it abandons its divine vocation for the pursuit of its own idolatrous goals. But what has become perverted in time can be redeemed in time.⁴⁶⁰

Pentecostal scholar Amos Yong would have some agreement and disagreement with Wink on the demonic. He believes the Powers in their fallen state are ‘susceptible to demonic manifestations.’⁴⁶¹ He clarifies this in three sub-theses: first, ‘that the demonic has no ontological reality of its own but is rather a perversion of the goodness of the orders of creation – or, put alternatively, since the demonic is not created by God, it does not possess its own being...’⁴⁶² In this he agrees with Wink. Barth affirms this Augustinian claim. Secondly, ‘that the demonic is, nevertheless, objective as

⁴⁵⁷ Oglesby, *C. G. Jung and Hans Urs von Balthasar*, 139–140.

⁴⁵⁸ *Ibid.*, 127–143.

⁴⁵⁹ Wink, *Unmasking the Powers*, 11.

⁴⁶⁰ Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 72.

⁴⁶¹ Yong, *In the Days of Caesar*, 162.

⁴⁶² *Ibid.*

emergent reality, parasitic, and dependent upon certain configurations of the material, institutional, and organizational structures of powers, but yet irreducible to the sum of its constituent parts...⁴⁶³ This seems to veer slightly from Wink and seems stronger than Barth's idea of "nothingness". Yong's Pentecostal background and phenomenological studies testify to the reality of the demonic.⁴⁶⁴ Finally, 'once emergent, the demonic manifests as a force of destruction wielded in and through the fallen and disordered powers, appearing in ways to suggest the powers have become transcendental realities, "larger" than what they are, certainly overreaching their authority, and seemingly personal and intentional in their destructive capacities.'⁴⁶⁵ Taking these three statements collectively, institutions of various sorts, in their fallen state, are susceptible to the 'emergence of demonic trajectories.'⁴⁶⁶ 'If and when this happens, governments become tyrannical, nations become anarchic, economic systems become unjust, and social systems foster death instead of life.'⁴⁶⁷ Dawn writes about how churches, too, can be and act as fallen powers, which would make them susceptible to the same demonic trajectory.⁴⁶⁸

The Importance of Stoicheia

In *Naming the Powers*, Wink examines the word stoicheia in the seven places it's found in the New Testament, noting that it is used in the following ways.

- The ABC's, the elementary or first principles of faith – Heb. 5:22, and Gal. 4:9 in part
- The constituent elements of the physical universe – 2 Peter. 3:10, 12
- The basic constituents of religious existence common to Jews and Gentiles alike (rituals, festivals, laws, beliefs) – Gal. 4:3, 9; Col. 2:20
- The first elements or founding principles of the physical universe – Col. 2:8⁴⁶⁹

For Wink the theological issue that emerges for Paul in relation to stoicheia, 'focuses on the problem of idolatry.'⁴⁷⁰ Paul warns the Colossians that if they are captivated by 'hollow and deceptive philosophy, which depend on human traditions

⁴⁶³ Ibid., 162–163.

⁴⁶⁴ Amos Yong, *The Spirit of Creation: Modern Science and Divine Action in the Pentecostal-Charismatic Imagination*, Pentecostal manifestos (Grand Rapids, MI: W.B. Eerdmans Pub. Co, 2011), 173–225.

⁴⁶⁵ Yong, *In the Days of Caesar*, 163.

⁴⁶⁶ Ibid.

⁴⁶⁷ Ibid.

⁴⁶⁸ Dawn, *Powers, Weakness, and the Tabernacling of God*, 73–88.

⁴⁶⁹ Wink, *Naming the Powers*, 77.

⁴⁷⁰ Ibid.

and elemental spiritual forces of the world rather than on Christ,' they are in danger (Col. 2: 8). Wink writes,

What is most basic to existence begins to be worshipped, either overtly or, as more than often happens, unconsciously, as people abandon themselves to religious practices or philosophical ideals or ideological principles. When that happens, the *stoicheia* become functional gods, and their devotees are alienated from the One in and through and for whom even these most basic things in existence were created.⁴⁷¹

John Howard Yoder confirms this in his work *The Politics of Jesus*. Supported by the work of Berkhof, he categorizes this understanding as, 'religious structures (especially the religious undergirdings of stable ancient primitive societies); intellectual structures (-ologies and -isms); moral structures (codes and customs); and political structures (the tyrant, the market, the school, the courts, race and nation).'⁴⁷²

Yoder makes the case that humanity cannot live without these structures because it is a part of the good created order. 'But these structures fail to serve us as they should. They do not enable humanity to live a genuinely free, loving life. They have absolutized themselves and they demand from the individual and society unconditional loyalty. They harm and enslave us. We cannot live with them.'⁴⁷³ They are in need of God's redeeming work.

What is central to note is how Wink points out that Paul's concern is the problem of idolatry. Idolatry is a significant theme for William Stringfellow. While many in the West consider idols a thing of the past, Stringfellow exposes this fallacy by naming the popular idols common to daily existence: 'religion, work, money, status, sex, patriotism...'⁴⁷⁴ He describes idols as imposters of God. When human beings seek to justify themselves, offer themselves, and give tribute to their chosen idols, they end up in bondage to death. The result is that idolatry 'defies God and dehumanizes men.'⁴⁷⁵ *Stoicheia* correlates with some of the ways that William Stringfellow will conceptualize the Powers in today's vernacular, the ideas of ideology and institution. This will be explored further in chapter five.

⁴⁷¹ Ibid.

⁴⁷² Yoder, *The Politics of Jesus*, 142–143.

⁴⁷³ Ibid., 143.

⁴⁷⁴ William Stringfellow, *Imposters of God: Inquiries into Favorite Idols*, Reprint. (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Pub, 2006), 6.

⁴⁷⁵ Ibid., 9.

The Domination System

This critical analysis of Wink has increased the awareness of the ubiquity of the Powers and unmasked how they subvert God's purposes and intentions. He writes,

Surveying all the data covered, it is amazing that this has been so consistently overlooked. On every page of the New Testament one finds the terminology of power: those incumbents, offices, structures, roles, institutions, ideologies, rituals, rules, agents, and spiritual influences by which power is established and exercised. The language and reality of power pervade the New Testament because power is one of the primary ways the world is organized and runs. No human activity can be described without recourse to this language.⁴⁷⁶

This is significant in that, as will be seen in the next chapter, when leaders of any institution or organization (including church leaders) rest their authority on false transcendence, they are susceptible to the demonic abuse of their authority and power.

Wink talks about the Powers being created good, having fallen, and that they can be redeemed. But if there is no distinction between Satan and the demonic, which seem unredeemable, and the principalities and powers, which are created good, then the redemption of the Powers that Paul writes about in Col. 1:16 would be confusing. Yoder, Stringfellow, Yong, Berkhof, and others believe that the subcategory of the principalities and powers are distinct from Satan and the demonic. As Yong writes, 'the powers are creations of God ordained for his purposes, but the powers are fallen, and in their fallen condition susceptible to demonic manifestations, but the powers can be redeemed.'⁴⁷⁷ This makes the most sense of the texts on the principalities and powers in Paul. Especially when one considers the Greek words that are used in Col. 1:16, in Wink's analysis of the verse, prior to his reinterpretation of the Powers.

The key words in Col. 1:16 are *thrones* which 'refers less to the inhabitant than to the location of power in a symbolic 'place' that outlasts its incumbents. We speak of the county *seat*, the judge's *bench*, the *chairperson*, the *oval office*, meaning in each case the authority invested in an office regardless of its current occupant.'⁴⁷⁸ *Dominions (kyiotétes)* refers to those 'over which the "thrones" preside or hold sway...It is the "sphere of influence" which the "throne" possesses, whether visible (the actual land or area ruled) or invisible (its capacity to influence other Powers by threat or persuasion).'⁴⁷⁹ *Principalities (arché)* specifies the person in office, 'not the

⁴⁷⁶ Wink, *Naming the Powers*, 99.

⁴⁷⁷ Yong, *In the Days of Caesar*, 162–163.

⁴⁷⁸ Wink, *Naming the Powers*, 65.

⁴⁷⁹ Ibid.

person as such but the person-in-office, the agent-in-role.’⁴⁸⁰ Finally, there are authorities (*exousiai*) which Wink says refers to the way in which authority is maintained. ‘These are the invisible and visible authorizations and enforcements that undergird the chair. Legitimations would include the laws, rules, taboos, mores, codes, and constitutions by which power is licensed, and all the customs, traditions, rituals, manners, etiquette, and ideologies by which is it rationalized, justified and made habitual.’⁴⁸¹ Thus his paraphrase of Col. 1:16 is,

For within his [the Cosmic Christ’s] wisdom every power in the universe has been created, those in heaven and those on earth, those visible and those invisible – whether seats of powers or spheres of influence, whether incumbents-in-office or legitimations and sanctions that keep them there – all these social and spiritual structures of reality are stamped with his imprint and exist solely to serve his purposes.⁴⁸²

Wink, according to his fourth rule, suggests all the Powers in this passage, but as Dawn points out, angels and demons are of a different nature, and demons, or Satan, are not listed in this heavily debated passage, which confirms the idea that the principalities and powers are redeemable, but not Satan, nor the demonic.

In addition, it is important to note that any institution, organization, corporation, or government has these elements of power and authority mentioned in this passage, including the church. Thus, this passage becomes significant in understanding the nature of power and authority in the church as well.

Summary of Argument

As a scholar and activist, Wink sought to name, unmask, and engage the Powers. This was not just something he wrote about, but something he actively lived. His project is best understood as taking the text seriously in its context of production and seeking to transpose it to the context of reception. So instead of articulating the Powers in an ancient worldview, he translates them into an integral worldview, where there is an inner and outer dimension to the powers. The outer represents the visible aspects of an organization or institution, including the building, officers, offices, and people, and the inner is the invisible part of the organization, the spirituality or soul of the institution. Much understanding can be gained from Wink’s work. But some ideas need to be

⁴⁸⁰ Ibid.

⁴⁸¹ Ibid., 66.

⁴⁸² Ibid.

discarded, namely his panentheistic worldview, which seems to flatten the narrative regarding angels and the demonic, and lead to a misunderstanding of Satan.

Regarding leadership and the powers, the primary contribution that Wink makes to this thesis, is that he alerts the missional leader to the pervasive work of the Powers. He has elevated the awareness of the Powers and helped to bring this theme into discussion in the academy. As Newbigin writes, ‘Walter Wink in his series of volumes on the principalities and powers has helped us to see afresh the relevance to our situation of the Biblical language of the powers. It is not true, Wink reminds us, that the Church’s message is addressed only to individual people.’⁴⁸³

By defining some key terms like world, epoch, and flesh, he clears up the ambiguity found in the work of Van Gelder and Zscheile. Wink demonstrates how the Powers work at every level possible, from the personal, to the social, and the cosmic. This will correspond to Stringfellow’s articulation of the Powers in chapter five. There is no escaping the influence of the Powers. They are at work through all the ideologies that unconsciously hold people captive and in the various institutions and organizations in which leaders participate. In this way, Satan earns his title of being the ‘god of this world’, for his influence is cosmic in nature. Lincoln confirms how ideologies hold people in bondage, from which they need to be redeemed.⁴⁸⁴

An understanding of the Powers alerts missional leaders to the ubiquity of the fall, and to the need to name, unmask, and engage the Powers that seek to subvert them. The all-pervasiveness of the Powers should stimulate the missional leader to be cognizant of all the forces at work against them, and motivate his or her need to develop a spirituality in Christ, through the power of the Spirit. As Lincoln writes, ‘The real value of Wink’s work, and the same holds true of Ellul’s, lies not in its basis in exegesis of the Pauline principalities and powers, but in its ability to provide a penetrating and profound phenomenology of present powers of evil in the light of the gospel and an inspiring vision of the spirituality needed to engage such powers.’⁴⁸⁵ Thus, Wink has accomplished the work needed for this imitation-based conceptual framework: demonstrating the central importance of a missional spirituality robust enough to counter the subversive work of the Powers.

Regarding missional leadership and imitation, Wink’s life and work demonstrated the need for leaders to imitate the praxis of Christ; the only alternative

⁴⁸³ Newbigin, *Truth to Tell*, 74.

⁴⁸⁴ Lincoln, “Liberation from the Powers: Supernatural or Societal Structures?,” 351–352.

⁴⁸⁵ *Ibid.*, 347.

being to mimic the Powers. He points out how liberation theologies tend to mimic the Powers by engaging those in power with the same means: the use of force. The focus on imitating Christ helps leaders to recognize that the way of Jesus is radically different from the way of the world. Wink's efforts in combating racism in South Africa and willingness to put himself at risk in Selma demonstrate his willingness to follow Christ, even if it meant suffering.

Wink's work on the Powers and thoughts on imitation also brought support to the underlying premise of this thesis, that fallenness is imitating the Powers in their submission to Satan, which is bondage to idolatry and leads to dishonouring God and dehumanization. Meanwhile, redemption is imitating Christ in his submission to the Father, which is freedom from idolatry and leads to honouring God and human flourishing. Wink devotes an entire chapter to René Girard, showing the strength of his discovery of mimetic desire, which is the theme of the next chapter.

Regarding leadership and desire in Wink's life, his desire to achieve was based on his desire to be loved. It was emphasized that when leaders seek to accomplish *for* love, instead of *from* being God's beloved, it leads to a malformation of desire. Nouwen reminded us that prior to Jesus being led by the Spirit into the wilderness to confront the devil, that the words of his Father at his baptism named him as his beloved. Jesus was grounded in a spirituality which enabled him to resist imitating the devil, by not taking on his desires. Instead, Jesus sought to do the will of him who sent him. Thus, Wink gives much strength to the imitation-based framework being developed in this thesis, and the relevance of praying, 'deliver us from the evil one' (Matt. 6:13).

In conclusion, when leaders live under what Wink has properly labelled the Domination System and end up mimicking the Powers, they become domineering in their leadership. Through Wink, this thesis developed a theology of the Powers recognizing the need to name, unmask, and engage them at a personal, social, and cosmic level. The temptations leaders face requires a holistic response that deals with their identity, praxis, and telos. Girard will focus on the idea of mimetic desire, which combines the concepts of imitation and desire. James K.A. Smith made the case that human beings are not simply people-as-thinkers shaped by ideas, or people-as-believers shaped by faith, but ultimately, people-as-lovers, shaped by desire. Girard establishes this truth in profound ways.

Chapter 4

Leadership and Imitation

In articulating a theology of the Powers, Wink understands that when missional leaders live under the domination system they inevitably become domineering in their leadership by mimicking the Powers. Girard will further that understanding by highlighting how when missional leaders have the wrong model, they unwittingly end up mimicking the Powers. Understanding mimetic theory will enable missional leaders to live out the resurrection life through imitation of Christ and become a model worth imitating. Girard will strengthen the imitation-based framework by linking imitation and desire (mimetic desire) to a theology of the Powers. After introducing Girard, this chapter will examine and then analyse mimetic theory, thus completing the framework this thesis advances.

Introducing René Girard

René Girard (1923-2015) was born in Avignon, France on Christmas day, his full conversion to Christian faith took place on Easter of 1959, and after writing over 20 books and a plethora of articles, Girard died at 91. As an academic, Girard's research and work spread across many disciplines including history, philosophy, sociology, psychology, anthropology, and theology. Not only did Girard engage the literary works of Dostoyevsky and Shakespeare, he critically engaged Freud, Nietzsche, Darwin, Lévi-Strauss, and others.⁴⁸⁶ Girard served on the faculties of Indiana University, Duke University, Bryn Mawr College, and State University of New York, before becoming the Andrew B. Hammond Professor of French Language, Literature, and Civilization at Stanford University (1981-1995). Besides having two earned doctorates, one in France and one in the United States, he received six honorary doctorates from universities in the Netherlands, Belgium, Italy, Austria, Canada, and the UK.⁴⁸⁷

While receiving many distinguishing awards, his election in 2005 to the Académie of Française, known informally as *les immortals* (consisting of forty

⁴⁸⁶ This is in direct contradiction to Whitehouse's claim 'Girard's assumptions are derived principally from his analysis of medieval and modern French literature, both of which carry their own cultural assumptions...' Some of his other critiques will be addressed later in this chapter. Richard Whitehouse, Andrew Hardy, and Dan Yarnell, "More Recent Approaches to Spiritual Conflict," in *Power and the Powers: The Use and Abuse of Power in Its Missional Context* (Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2015), 26.

⁴⁸⁷ Wolfgang Palaver, *René Girard's Mimetic Theory*, 1 edition. (East Lansing, MI: Michigan State University Press, 2013), 309–312.

members, including Voltaire, Jean Racine, and Victor Hugo), was his greatest achievement.⁴⁸⁸ Though he regularly identified as a cultural anthropologist, his theological relevance can be measured by the significant contemporary theologians who have critically engaged his corpus in their written work, including John Milbank, Rowan Williams, Miroslav Volf, Sarah Coakley, and Hans Urs von Balthasar.⁴⁸⁹ His ongoing legacy, by which his work continues to shape conversations with economists, literary critics, philosophers, political scientists, psychologists, theologians, and others, persists in the Colloquium of Violence and Religion (COV&R), founded in 1990 by those shaped by Girard's theory.⁴⁹⁰ The stated purpose of this annual symposium is 'to explore, criticize, and develop the mimetic model of the relationship between violence and religion in the genesis and maintenance of culture.'⁴⁹¹ Girard's influence continues to widen, even after his death.

Coming to America in 1947 was a significant event in Girard's life. Biographer Cynthia Haven writes, 'That event in 1947, he said, made everything else possible. René is an American phenomenon, as much as a French one. Without America and the bigger vision it offered after the war, there would have been no books, no theories, and no academic career.'⁴⁹² Girard met his wife Martha in the United States and 'the stability and contentment of the 64-year marriage cannot be underestimated in supporting his very long, very fruitful career.'⁴⁹³ Another significant event Girard mentions is his conversion to Christianity.⁴⁹⁴

A defining moment for Girard occurred as he, a cynical sceptic in the 'spirit of the atheistic intellectuals' of his time, experienced first an intellectual, then a deeper conversion to Christ and the Church.⁴⁹⁵ As Girard studied the lives and works of

⁴⁸⁸ Ibid.

⁴⁸⁹ Grant Kaplan, *René Girard, Unlikely Apologist: Mimetic Theory and Fundamental Theology* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2016), 1.

⁴⁹⁰ René Girard, *The Girard Reader*, ed. James G Williams (New York: Crossroad Publishing Company, 1996), 5.

⁴⁹¹ Ibid.

⁴⁹² Cynthia L Haven, "What Was the Most Important Moment in René Girard's Life? 'Coming to America,' He Said.," *The Book Haven*, January 20, 2016, accessed December 3, 2019, <http://bookhaven.stanford.edu/2016/01/what-was-the-most-important-moment-in-rene-girards-life-coming-to-america-he-said/>. See also, Haven, *Evolution of Desire*, 47.

⁴⁹³ Ibid.

⁴⁹⁴ René Girard, "Epilogue: The Anthropology of the Cross," in *The Girard Reader*, ed. James G Williams (New York: Crossroad Publishing Company, 1996), 262–288; René Girard, *When These Things Begin: Conversations with Michel Treguer*, trans. Trevor Cribben Merrill (East Lansing, MI: Michigan State University Press, 2014), 128–133.

⁴⁹⁵ Girard, "Epilogue: The Anthropology of the Cross," 283. Some call this second conversion experience sacramental, as he formally connected with the Catholic church.

Stendahl, Cervantes, Flaubert, Proust, and Dostoevsky, he realized that what characterized their ongoing influence was a type of conversion reflected in their writing.⁴⁹⁶ The conversion experiences these authors had were not necessarily of a religious nature or change of faith, though they were for some, including Dostoevsky and Girard himself. Yet, while Girard's conversion experience was both intellectual and religious, he discusses a broader understanding regarding these authors. He says, 'Conversion is a form of intelligence, of understanding,' it is both a process and event.⁴⁹⁷ This is evident to Girard in Dostoevsky's *Notes from the Underground*. Girard asserts that, 'What Dostoevsky says to the laissez-faire philosophers is that, in a world as empty of transcendence as ours now is, if people are left to their own devices, many of them will choose the underground.'⁴⁹⁸ It is in 'the underground' that mimetic desire reigns. Divested of transcendence, people invest in an immanent framework where they look for experts to imitate and find themselves entrapped in the mimetic cycle. For 'the negation of God does not eliminate transcendency but diverts it from above to below.'⁴⁹⁹ Idolatrous imitation of the neighbour becomes the rule in the underground. Pride increases; and humility is resisted.⁵⁰⁰ Girard puts it this way,

The more our ego-centeredness increases, the more likely it is to turn into an underground "other-centeredness" that is not "altruistic" in the slightest, even though it often masquerades as altruism. Mimetic desire is failed selfishness, impotent pride that generates the worshipful imitation of idols unrecognized as such, because they are hated as much as they are revered. The modern world insidiously brings back forms of self-enslavement from which Western society had largely excepted during the Christian centuries.

The more Dostoevsky explores the underground, the more aware he becomes of this dark "satanic" dimension of modern life. In *Demons* and *The Brothers Karamazov* he explicitly interprets the fascination for obstacle/models as demonic possession and the psychology of the underground turns to demonology. This is no surrender to irrationality but a denunciation of it.⁵⁰¹

⁴⁹⁶ Ibid., 284.

⁴⁹⁷ René Girard, Pierpaolo Antonello, and João Cezar de Castro Rocha, *Evolution and Conversion: Dialogues on the Origins of Culture* (London; New York: Bloomsbury Academic, 2017), 45.

⁴⁹⁸ René Girard, *Resurrection from the Underground: Feodor Dostoevsky*, ed. James G. Williams, trans. James G Williams (East Lansing, MI: Michigan State University Press, 2012), 82.

⁴⁹⁹ Robert Doran, "René Girard's Concept of Conversion and the 'Via Negativa': Revisiting 'Deceit, Desire, and the Novel,'" *Religion & Literature* 43, no. 3 (2011): 170–179.

⁵⁰⁰ Girard, *Resurrection from the Underground*, 84.

⁵⁰¹ Ibid.

For Girard, there is only one way to escape, or experience resurrection, from the underground, and that is through Christ – imitating Christ as opposed to imitating Satan. He says, ‘If we do not imitate Jesus, our models become the living obstacles that we also become for them.’⁵⁰² Dostoyevsky’s Christian symbolism was important for Girard’s own conversion, from the deathbed conversion of Stepan Verkhovensky in *Demons*, where Verkhovensky discovers his own foolishness and turns to the Gospel, to the concluding chapters of *Crime and Punishment* and *The Brothers Karamazov*. ‘This is the existential conversion that is demanded by a great work of art.’⁵⁰³

It was when Girard penned the final chapter of his book *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel* that he underwent his own conversion experience. Girard says,

In autumn 1958, I was working on my book about the novel, on the twelfth and last chapter that’s entitled “Conclusion.” I was thinking about the analogies between religious experience and the experience of a novelist who discovers that he’s been consistently lying, lying for the benefit of his Ego, which in fact is made up of nothing but a thousand lies that have accumulated over a long period, sometimes built up over an entire lifetime.

I ended up understanding that I was going through an experience of the kind that I was describing. The religious symbolism was present in the novelist in embryonic form, but in my case it started to work all by itself and caught fire spontaneously. I could no longer have any illusions about what was happening to me, and I was thrown for a loop, because I was proud of being a skeptic. It was very hard for me to imagine myself going to church, praying and so on. I was all puffed up, full of what the old catechisms used to call “human respect”. Intellectually I was converted.⁵⁰⁴

Girard describes his conversion experience to Christ in two stages, an intellectual conversion of the mind, followed by a spiritual conversion of the heart. His second conversion experience took place after a cancer scare. As Girard was preparing for Lent his anxiety over it increased to the point that he was unable to sleep; finally, it was revealed to him by his doctor on Ash Wednesday that he was completely healed. Ash Wednesday was a true celebration for Girard. He says, ‘I’ve never known a holiday to compare to that day of deliverance. I thought I was dead, and, all at once, I was resurrected.’⁵⁰⁵ He was grateful that his intellectual conversion took place before this, otherwise he would say, ‘If it would have occurred afterwards, I would have never truly believed. My natural skepticism would have convinced me that my faith was a

⁵⁰² René Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2001), 40.

⁵⁰³ Girard, “Epilogue: The Anthropology of the Cross,” 284–285.

⁵⁰⁴ Girard, *When These Things Begin*, 129.

⁵⁰⁵ *Ibid.*, 131.

result of the scare I had received.’⁵⁰⁶ This prepared him to reconcile himself with the Church so that he and his entire family could truly celebrate Easter, in Christ.

Like any new convert, Girard wanted others to experience the reconciliation he experienced. In an interview with James G. Williams, he is asked whether he favoured, in a pluralist society, ‘converting all non-Christians to Christianity?’ His response was, ‘Jesus said, “I am the way, the truth, and the life,” and he told his disciples to go into the world and make converts. If we give that up, are we still Christians?’⁵⁰⁷ Girard was an academic apologist and thought that anyone who did not share their faith, had not found the truth. In an interview, he says, ‘I think the Christians who do not want to share their faith do not really believe. The fear of religious tyranny is an anachronism, a false issue which puts political correctness ahead of truth. I believe there is a truth, and the only way of telling it is by connecting with people.’⁵⁰⁸

It was in his work, *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World*, where he clearly expressed his Christian faith. Though Girard was careful not to unnecessarily offend those to whom he was seeking to reveal the truth, as Haven writes, ‘His conversion would be a costly personal decision. It closed off an audience; it alienated potential readers and fans. Yet, he never backed away from what he understood, in startling moments of clarity, to be the truth.’⁵⁰⁹ His conversion shaped the remainder of his life and writing. After a short reflection on his life, this thesis will seek to understand how Girard connects the missional leader to the Powers via mimetic desire.

Understanding René Girard’s Mimetic Theory

While Girard’s mimetic theory stretches its reach from the origins of humanity to the apocalypse, this thesis focuses particularly on how Girard links imitation and desire (mimetic desire) to the Powers. Doing so gains a theological perspective that illuminates leadership theory and practice.

⁵⁰⁶ Ibid.

⁵⁰⁷ Girard, “Epilogue: The Anthropology of the Cross,” 286–287.

⁵⁰⁸ Ibid., 287.

⁵⁰⁹ Cynthia L Haven, *Evolution of Desire: A Life of René Girard* (East Lansing, MI: Michigan State University Press, 2018), 119.

The Scandal of Mimetic Desire

Girard believed that the genius novelists declared truths about human nature better than present day social and human sciences.⁵¹⁰ Through their works, he discovered that desire is central to what it means to be human, in particular mimetic desire. Girard discovered this truth in the novelist and deepened his conviction through his study of anthropology and mythology. In *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, he writes about how the power of desire is reflected in the tenth and longest commandment given. The prohibition against people desiring the objects of their neighbour's reveals that 'our neighbor is the model of our desires.'⁵¹¹ This is what Girard calls mimetic desire. Mimetic desire is when the disciple imitates the desire of their model. In other words, desire is not spontaneously generated by autonomous selves, desires are borrowed through our models. Humans desire what their models desire. If the example's model is sufficiently distinct, either socially or historically, there is no danger of what Girard calls *mimetic rivalry*. Mimetic rivalry is when the disciple and model compete for the same object of desire. When this presents no danger, because of the distance of the model historically or socially, Girard calls this *external mediation*. For example, if the model lives in a different time in history, this will avert any potential of rivalry. A king and a pauper, because of their social distance, are in no danger of rivalry. However, the closer the social distance the model is to the disciple, *internal mediation* is at work, and the greater the danger of mimetic rivalry. Internal mediation is much more likely in the setting of the church, where the proximity of the disciple and pastor are closer.

Because Girard is the doctor of desire, there are several other terms he develops to distinguish between types of desires. *Acquisitive mimesis* takes place when the desire for an object is borrowed from the disciple's model. This could be illustrated by children playing in a room. There may be one hundred toys in the room, but, because acquisitive mimesis is at work, everybody wants to play with the same toy. What holds even greater danger is what Girard labels *metaphysical mimesis*, which takes place when 'the desiring subject wants to become his mediator; he wants to steal from the mediator his very being....'⁵¹² The closer the distance between model and disciple, the more the disciple's desire is aimed at the model's very being. Girard observes that the

⁵¹⁰ Michael Kirwan, *Discovering Girard* (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, Inc., 2005), 40.

⁵¹¹ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 10.

⁵¹² René Girard, *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel: Self and Other in Literary Structure*, trans. Yvonne Freccero (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1998), 54.

best writers put acquisitive mimesis in the background and metaphysical in the foreground. He states, 'Dostoyevsky by a stroke of genius places the mediator in the foreground and regulates the object to the background. At last novelistic composition reflects the real hierarchy of desire.'⁵¹³

What Girard discovers in his first book, starting with Stendhal and reaching new heights with Proust and Dostoyevsky, is that denial of God does not eliminate transcendency, it simply diverts it to one's neighbour.⁵¹⁴ Girard calls this *deviated transcendency* 'the false sacred,' which is a highly contagious *ontological disease*. Girard illuminates the psychology and metaphysics of the underground as he explores the work of Dostoyevsky in *Resurrection from the Underground*.⁵¹⁵

Pride is the 'primary psychological (and before long metaphysical) motor which governs all the individual and collective manifestations of the underground life.'⁵¹⁶ It is pride that blinds people and causes them to conceal mimetic desire and their own ontological sickness. In other words, if a person's identity is not grounded in God, it will by necessity be grounded in and enslaved to the other. People will seek to find vertical transcendency in the other. As Girard writes, 'Either we are innocent of all metaphysical desire or else that desire possesses us so completely that we are entirely unaware of it.'⁵¹⁷ In *The Possessed*, Girard points out that the characters are enslaved in the mimetic trap of the underground, where the disciple depends on the other for his or her very sense of being.

Through envious imitation of the model, the disciple desires what the model desires; when the model's desires cannot be shared or will not be shared, the model becomes an obstacle or *scandal* (stumbling block) to the disciple. While there is a difference between the model and the disciple at this early stage, eventually these differences reach a vanishing point where the progressive and mutually reinforcing mimesis between model and disciple lacks differentiation, making them *doubles* of each other, where they become so obsessed with each other and possessed by each other that they begin to mirror each other's emotions and actions. As Girard puts it, 'If the model himself becomes more interested in the object that he designates to his imitator as a result of the latter's imitations, then he himself falls victim to his

⁵¹³ Girard, *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel*, 45.

⁵¹⁴ *Ibid.*, 59.

⁵¹⁵ Girard, *Resurrection from the Underground*.

⁵¹⁶ *Ibid.*, 23.

⁵¹⁷ Girard, *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel*, 258.

contagion. In fact, he imitates his own desire, through the intermediary of the disciple. The disciple becomes model to his own model, and the model, reciprocally, becomes disciple of his own disciple.⁵¹⁸

When the disciple and model become *mimetic doubles*, desires intensify, and because they both see value in the object of desire, there is more and more reciprocity of desires. Eventually they become *monstrous doubles*, where each becomes the other's rival, leading to an outbreak of violence. Mimetic rivalry can become so intense 'that rivals denigrate each other, steal the other's possessions, seduce the other's spouse, and finally, they even go as far as murder.'⁵¹⁹ In other words, if the tenth commandment is observed, 'the four commandments that precede it would be superfluous.'⁵²⁰

For Girard, mimetic desire is the principle, but not the only reason, for violence. The fragility of human relationships is due to the fact that people are creatures of imitation. Girardian scholar Scott Cowdell writes, 'This escalation toward mimeticism's terminal phase begins when status, prestige, or honor becomes the sole desired object.'⁵²¹ *Prestige rivalry* invariably leads to conflict.⁵²² Applying this concept to leadership will be done in the next section.

Jesus speaks to mimetic rivalry when he talks about scandal. 'The words that designate mimetic rivalry and its consequences are the noun *skandalon* and the verb *skandalizein*.'⁵²³ For Girard, what has escaped the notice of humanity since the foundation of the world, because mythology consistently conceals it, is the way mimetic desire leads to mimetic rivalry and eventually to a mimetic crisis. Scandals multiply; envy, jealousy, and hatred spread among communities like a contagious disease.⁵²⁴ A model becomes a scandal to the disciple when he becomes an obstacle to the disciple's desire, which has been borrowed from the model. 'Scandals are so formidable that to put us on guard against them, Jesus resorts to an uncharacteristic hyperbolic style: "If your hand scandalizes you, cut it off; if your eye scandalizes you, pull it out" (Matt. 18:8-9)'.⁵²⁵

⁵¹⁸ René Girard, Jean-Michel Oughourlian, and Guy Lefort, *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2002), 299.

⁵¹⁹ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 11.

⁵²⁰ Ibid.

⁵²¹ Scott Cowdell, *René Girard and Secular Modernity Christ, Culture, and Crisis* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2013), 23.

⁵²² Ibid.

⁵²³ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 16.

⁵²⁴ Ibid.

⁵²⁵ Ibid., 17.

For Girard, when Jesus says, ‘Scandal must come’ (Matt. 18:7), he is not being fatalistic, but realistic, in that mimetic rivalry is unavoidable. However, Jesus also says, ‘Woe to the one by whom the scandal comes’ (Matt. 18:8). Girard writes,

Jesus would not be astonished that his teaching is not recognized. He has no illusion about the way in which his message is received. To the glory that comes from God, invisible in this world, the majority prefer the glory that comes from humankind, a glory that multiplies scandal as it makes its way. It consists in gaining victory in mimetic rivalries often organized by the powers of this world, rivalries that are political, economic, athletic, sexual, artistic, intellectual...and even religious.⁵²⁶

Girard wisely points out that there is no field from which mimetic rivalry is absent, including the religious domain. While scandals must come, woe to the one by whom they come, for the scandal between individuals gives birth to more scandals. Thus, *mimetic rivalry* gives way to *mimetic contagion*, and leads to a *mimetic crisis*, which will now be explored.

Recognizing the Mimetic Cycle

To understand how Girard understands Satan and the Powers, there is a need to understand the cycle of mimetic violence, or what Girard labels the *mimetic cycle*.⁵²⁷ Girard talks about the mimetic cycle in three steps: first, there is the mimetic crisis, second, the scapegoat mechanism (or single victim mechanism), and finally, temporary tranquillity, unity, and reconciliation found in the community, resulting from the expulsion of the victim. The simple flow looks like figure 4:

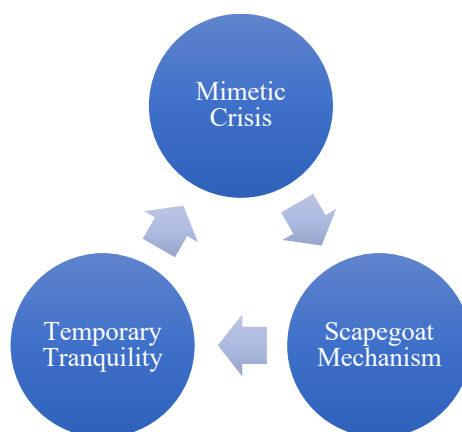


Figure 4. The Mimetic Cycle

⁵²⁶ Ibid.

⁵²⁷ Ibid., 32.

While the basic flow is simple, some further details explain the mimetic cycle with more precision. First, a summary of the complete mimetic cycle is helpful. It begins when mimetic desire leads to a scandal and mimetic rivalry, then as the scandals within the community become contagious, they have a snowballing effect, creating a *mimetic crisis*, where there is a war of *all against all*. The community is now at risk of self-destruction if there is no relief to this mounting violence. Thus, at the climax of the crises, the *scapegoat mechanism* is enacted, where the community automatically, randomly, and unconsciously, unanimously selects a victim. The war of all against all, resolves through the *all against one*, the scapegoat. The scapegoat is not only considered the sinner and the cause of the crisis, but also the saviour, the reason for the instant reversal of the crisis and the newfound tranquillity of the community. This *temporary tranquillity* is enjoyed by the community until the cycle begins again.

After exploring the literary giants in whose work he discovered mimetic desire and mimetic rivalry, Girard turned his attention to cultural anthropology. After ten years of reading and research, seeking to understand the dynamics of sacrifice, and the origin of myth, rituals, and prohibitions, he released the ground-breaking works, *Violence and the Sacred* and *The Scapegoat*. There, he expounded upon his fundamental discovery and explained the scapegoat mechanism.

Essentially, in archaic (pre-state, non-legal) societies, when a mimetic crisis broke out, the scapegoat mechanism would be enacted as a way to establish and maintain social order. As Girard says, ‘When unappeased, violence seeks and always finds a surrogate victim. The creature that excited its fury is abruptly replaced by another, chosen only because it is vulnerable and close at hand.’⁵²⁸ While Thomas Hobbes and Girard held many things in common, their point of departure was how each thought the mimetic crisis was resolved. Hobbes implies that the violence could be appeased by a ‘reasoned social contract between combatants,’ while Girard, through his study of anthropology, including the fieldwork of Godfrey Lienhardt and Victor Turner, came to the conclusion that the mimetic crisis was more likely resolved through the sacrifice of the surrogate victim.⁵²⁹ As Girard writes, these scholars ‘portray sacrifice as practiced among the Dinka and the Ndembuas a deliberate act of collective

⁵²⁸ René Girard, *Violence and the Sacred* (Baltimore, MD: The John Hopkins University Press, 1979), 2.

⁵²⁹ Kirwan, *Discovering Girard*, 38.

substitution performed at the expense of the victim and absorbing all the internal tensions, feuds, and rivalries pent up within the community.’⁵³⁰

The sacrifice of the scapegoat ‘serves to protect the entire community from its own violence, it prompts the entire community to choose victims outside itself.’⁵³¹ The sacrificial victim in archaic societies had particular marks, it was typically the minority, the marginalized, or the weak who became victims: ‘prisoners of war, slaves, small children, unmarried adolescents, and the handicapped; it ranges from the very dregs of society, such as the Greek *pharmakos*, to the king himself.’⁵³² But, as noted here, the victim could be the king, as the key to choosing the sacrificial victim is that the victim is someone who is both inside and outside of the community, not fully integrated into the community.⁵³³ There is an element of distinction and separation that the victim tends to display. So, while the weak or handicapped are separated by their marginalization, the king is isolated from the community by his position at the centre of the community.⁵³⁴ The essential characteristic of the victim is that there is an element of separation between the community and the victim. ‘Between these victims and the community a crucial link is missing, so they can be exposed to violence without fear of reprisal. Their death does not automatically entail an act of vengeance.’⁵³⁵ The sacrifice of the falsely accused victim, being human or animal, serves to ‘quell violence within the community and to prevent conflicts from erupting.’⁵³⁶ The effects of the sacrifice lead to tranquillity returning to the community.

The contagious power of mimetic desire is described in the Passion narrative with one crucial difference. While myths hide the insidious nature of the mimetic cycle, ‘by suppressing or disguising collective murders and minimizing or eliminating the stereotypes of persecution in a hundred different ways’, the Passion of Jesus reveals and thus disarms the work of the Powers by making public what was concealed from the foundation of the earth.⁵³⁷ Girard writes,

Before Christ and the Bible the satanic accusation was always victorious by virtue of the violent contagion that imprisoned human beings within the systems of myth and ritual. The Crucifixion reduced mythology to powerlessness by exposing violent contagion, which is so effective in the myths that it prevents

⁵³⁰ Girard, *Violence and the Sacred*, 7.

⁵³¹ Ibid., 8.

⁵³² Ibid., 12.

⁵³³ Ibid.

⁵³⁴ Ibid.

⁵³⁵ Ibid., 13.

⁵³⁶ Ibid., 14.

⁵³⁷ René Girard, *The Scapegoat* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1989), 165.

communities from ever finding out the truth, namely, the innocence of their victims.⁵³⁸

Martin Kähler describes Mark's Gospel as a Passion narrative with an extended introduction, and Girard writes, 'In the Gospels all themes lead to the Passion.'⁵³⁹ In other words, the reason the gospels spend time on the Passion is because it is revealing a truth so central that it needs the details and length to make its point. For much of Jesus' ministry, he enjoyed the favour of the crowds, even to the point of his entry into Jerusalem. But suddenly, the crowds turn against him and 'its hostility becomes so contagious that it spreads to the most diverse individuals.'⁵⁴⁰ Girard mentions how this violent hostility against Jesus united all against him: Herod and Pilate, representing Rome, and the Jewish leaders who, through a mockery of a trial, convicted Jesus. In so doing, they incited the people to the point that even the disciples could not withstand the mimetic contagion of the crowds. Even though Pilate was warned by his wife, through her dream, and desired to spare Jesus, his surrender to the wishes of the crowd demonstrates 'the omnipotence of mimetic contagion. What motivates Pilate, as he hands Jesus over, is the fear of a riot.'⁵⁴¹

It was not just the Roman and Jewish people who were caught in the mimetic contagion, but the thieves on the cross along with the disciples themselves who were possessed by the mob mentality. As Girard notes, when Peter, 'the rock,' is thrown into the crowd, 'he is unable to avoid its hostility. If the first of the disciples, the rock on which the Church will be established succumbs to the collective pressure, how will the others around Peter, just average people, be able to resist?'⁵⁴²

While some commentators use psychology to suggest that Peter's impressionable and impulsive temperament gives the most explanatory power to Peter's threefold denial of Christ, Girard believes this minimizes the revelation in the Passion event. 'In refusing the mimetic interpretation, in looking for the failure of Peter in purely individual causes, we attempt to demonstrate, unconsciously of course, that in Peter's place we would have responded differently; we would not have denied Jesus.'⁵⁴³ Girard mentions how the Pharisees used a similar ploy when building tombs

⁵³⁸ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 138.

⁵³⁹ *Ibid.*, 19.

⁵⁴⁰ *Ibid.*

⁵⁴¹ *Ibid.*, 20.

⁵⁴² *Ibid.*, 19.

⁵⁴³ *Ibid.*, 20.

for the prophets their fathers killed, declaring they would not have done so themselves. But, Jesus admonishes their self-justifying actions. As Girard writes,

The children repeat the crimes of their fathers precisely because they believe they are morally superior to them. This false difference is already the mimetic illusion of modern individualism, which represents the greatest resistance to the mimetic truth that is re-enacted again and again in human relations. The paradox is that the resistance itself brings about the reenactment.⁵⁴⁴

In this, the mimetic cycle is in plain view, not just through the great literary giants and anthropological studies, but in the Gospels themselves, though with a different twist. Because Jesus is declared innocent by the Father raising him from the dead, the mimetic cycle that has been in operation since the foundation of the world is revealed in the death and resurrection of Christ. Jesus becomes the willing scapegoat, exposing the scapegoat mechanism. Since Cain and Abel, mimetic desire has led to mimetic rivalry, which eventually becomes a mimetic crisis. Next, a falsely accused victim is sacrificed, followed by temporary tranquillity. For Girard, this mimetic cycle, seen in the founding murder, reveals the one who was a murderer from the beginning – the devil (his Greek title), or Satan, which is his Hebrew name (John 8:44).⁵⁴⁵

The Demystification of Satan

Unlike most modern theologians, who scarcely give this figure any attention, Girard does not shy away from writing about Satan and his surrogates, and through his use of mimetic theory, seeks to demystify the devil. Early Girard speaks of the demonic briefly in *Deceit, Desire and the Novel* (1961), and even more in *Resurrection from the Underground: Feodor Dostoevsky* (1963), as Dostoevsky's *Demons* spoke of the demonic as well. Middle Girard writes about Satan in *Job: The Victim of His People* (1985). He covers the principalities and powers as well as scandal in *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World* (1978) and devoted entire chapters to Satan and demons in *The Scapegoat* (1982). In later Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning* (1999), is devoted entirely to this figure. Girard followed it up with an interview and a few chapters on the theme in *The One by Whom Scandal Comes* (2001).⁵⁴⁶ Girard attended to Satan and the Powers as the New Testament does. His understanding of Satan and Satan's relationship to the mimetic cycle is the heart of mimetic theory; it

⁵⁴⁴ Ibid.

⁵⁴⁵ Ibid., 32.

⁵⁴⁶ Dates of all books reflect when they were first published in French. Each of the books were later translated and published in English.

could be said that the overarching theme of Girard's work is exousiology, albeit from a cultural-anthropological angle which shapes his theology. This thesis is the first to explore this aspect of Girard with some depth while seeking to apply it to missional leadership.

For Girard, the core decision that anyone needs to make is: Who will I ultimately imitate? 'God and Satan are the two supreme models: "arch models".'⁵⁴⁷ As imitative beings, people will either imitate God or imitate Satan. Girard says, 'If we listen to Satan, who may sound like a very progressive and likeable educator, we may feel initially that we are "liberated," but the impression does not last because Satan deprives us of everything that protects us from rivalistic imitation.'⁵⁴⁸ For Girard, progressive educators eschew prohibitions as unnecessary, believing they can be transgressed without danger. However, Girard believes that prohibitions are designed to deter the mimetic cycle.

The devil seeks to seduce leaders to follow the wide road that leads to destruction, which is the route to mimetic rivalry and crisis, the road that leads to violence and scapegoating. If Christ is not the leaders' primary model, then leaders will find their primary models in the other. Jesus recognized this, which is why Jesus is unlike any guru. For as Girard says, most gurus point their disciples to themselves, a person with *no model*, but Jesus only did what the Father did, or said what the Father said. For if mimetic desire is true, desiring the Father is the only way for Jesus to escape negative mimesis and rivalry.⁵⁴⁹ When leaders' primary model is in the other, they will start to borrow the desires of their model, and then their model often becomes an obstacle (scandal) to them, thus becoming their rival. For Girard, Satan is linked to scandal, and in fact is 'obstacle *par excellence*.'⁵⁵⁰

Now, if Jesus was tempted in all ways, he must have also been tempted to take a person as his primary model instead of the Father. But, who might he be tempted to imitate? Maybe one of his closest disciples, Peter, James, or John? In fact, Mark and Mathew in their Gospels say that after Jesus spoke of his Passion – his suffering, death, and resurrection – that Peter rebukes Jesus for saying he would suffer and die. Jesus responds to his good friend Peter with a scathing rebuke of his own, 'Get behind me Satan! You are a stumbling block [*scandalon*] to me; you do not have in mind the

⁵⁴⁷ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 40.

⁵⁴⁸ Ibid., 32.

⁵⁴⁹ Ibid., 13.

⁵⁵⁰ Girard, Oughourlian, and Lefort, *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World*, 419.

concerns of God, but merely human concerns' (Matt. 16:23). Girard notes that he was not the first to relate Satan to scandal, it was Jesus himself.⁵⁵¹

What does Jesus indicate by calling Peter Satan? Is Peter possessed by Satan in the sense witch-hunters understood?⁵⁵² For Girard, the key to understanding this text is how Satan is tied to Jesus' teaching on scandal, which speaks to mimetic desire and mimetic rivalry. Girard summarizes it like this:

Disappointed by what he takes to be the excessive resignation of Jesus, the disciple tries to breathe into him his own desire, his own worldly ambition [human concerns]. Peter invites Jesus, in short, to take Peter himself as the model of his desire. If Jesus were to turn away from his Father to follow Peter, he and Peter both would quickly fall into mimetic rivalry, and the venture of the kingdom of God would melt away in insignificant quarrels.⁵⁵³

Girard sees Satan as the 'master of all mimetic tricks.'⁵⁵⁴ He identifies two types of texts in the Gospels relating to Satan. In one set of texts, Satan is 'entirely deconstructed' by being equated to the mimetic principle. Like in the present text, Matthew tells us that Peter's concerns were basic to humans - 'merely human concerns.' Girard writes, 'Here Peter becomes the sower of scandals and reaps the whirlwind of mimetic crises.'⁵⁵⁵ But, Girard points out that Satan also appears in a supernatural role when Jesus meets him in the desert and gives a similar rebuke: 'Get behind me Satan' (Luke 4:8). While Satan is personified in this text, Girard notes, 'he still appears as the mimetic obstacle and model – the violent principle underlying all forms of earthly domination and all forms of idolatry, who tries to divert toward himself the adoration that is strictly due to God alone.'⁵⁵⁶

One of the central texts for Girard's understanding of Satan is Jesus' question, 'How can Satan cast out Satan?' (Mk 3:23 ESV). All three of the synoptic gospels share this parable, as Mark calls it (Mk 3:22). For Girard, the parable has a double meaning. The first meaning seems obvious to all, including the Scribes in Mark and the Pharisees in Matthew, who are engaging Jesus. But, the second meaning Girard gives is only comprehended by those who have ears to hear and eyes to see (Mk 13:1-14).⁵⁵⁷

⁵⁵¹ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 33.

⁵⁵² Girard, *The Scapegoat*, 194.

⁵⁵³ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 33.

⁵⁵⁴ Girard, Oughourlian, and Lefort, *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World*, 419.

⁵⁵⁵ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 33.

⁵⁵⁶ Ibid.

⁵⁵⁷ Girard, *The Scapegoat*, 193.

One of the reasons Girard believes Jesus speaks in parables and metaphors is because ‘All human language, and other cultural institutions, in fact, originated in collective murder.’⁵⁵⁸ So if Jesus is going to communicate to people who have only lived under the mimetic trap (as only through Jesus’ death and resurrection is the mimetic trap unveiled), he must use their language and understanding in order to communicate truth that can ultimately liberate them from the universe in which the god of this world dominates.

To set the scene, Jesus has just cast out a demon, and while the crowds were amazed, the scribes accused him of casting out demons by Beelzebub, the prince of the demons.

And he called them to him, and said to them in parables, ‘How can Satan cast out Satan? If a kingdom is divided against itself, that kingdom cannot stand. And if a house is divided against itself, that house will not be able to stand. And if Satan has risen up against himself and is divided, he cannot stand, but is coming to an end (Mark 3:23-25 ESV).

The first understanding Girard draws from the text is the truth that is understood by all: that a kingdom, or a house, that is divided, cannot stand. Simply enough, one can then draw the conclusion that if Satan is casting out Satan, then he cannot stand. But, the deeper understanding he begins to probe is the parabolic understanding. If in fact Jesus is casting out demons by the power of Beelzebub, why would the Scribes and Pharisees have difficulty with this? For this would mean the ruin of Satan’s kingdom. But of course, the text tells us that Jesus cast demons out by the spirit of God, and thus the kingdom of God is upon them.

Girard sees in this parable the disclosure of the mimetic cycle, where Satan’s ultimate power is his ability not only to create *disorder*, but to create *order* as well, when Satan casts out Satan. In other words, Satan, the one who sows scandal through mimetic rivalry, creating a mimetic crisis, is the same one who uses mimetic contagion to have the crowd spontaneously and unanimously choose a scapegoat to cast out, thus creating temporary order again. Girard writes,

Because of this extraordinary power [of creating disorder and order], Satan is the prince of this world. If he could not protect his domain from the violence that threatens to destroy it, even though it is essentially his own, he would not merit the title of prince, which the Gospels do not award him lightly. If he were purely a destroyer, Satan would have lost his domain long ago. To understand why he is the master of all the kingdoms of this world, we must take Jesus at his word: disorder expels disorder, or in other words Satan really expels Satan. By

⁵⁵⁸ Ibid.

executing this extraordinary feat, he has been able to make himself indispensable, and so his power remains great.⁵⁵⁹

But, Jesus sees an end to Satan's unique ability to sow disorder and temporary order, thus he states earlier in Luke, 'I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven' (Lk 10:18 NIV). Girard understands that Satan's fall corresponds with Jesus's death, for it is in Jesus's willingness to be the final scapegoat that he reveals the mimetic cycle and the scapegoat mechanism. It is the voluntary nature of Jesus' sacrifice that reveals what has been hidden from the foundation of the world. Satan is revealed as the 'accuser', who falsely accuses innocent victims like Job. Because the 'violence of the cultural order is revealed in the Gospels', the scapegoat mechanism has been revealed. Thus 'expulsion of violence by violence, is rendered useless by the revelation.'⁵⁶⁰ For Girard, the revealing of the scapegoat mechanism means that cultures that have been penetrated by this gospel revelation have enough people to recognize how scapegoating works. In this way, Satan's rule is coming to an end, because through Christ and his willingness to become the scapegoat, humanity has now gained the intelligence of the victim. Because the Passion of the gospels reveal that Jesus was the innocent one, cultures penetrated with the gospel can no longer unanimously scapegoat people in the same way that has been done throughout history. Thus, as the parable says, ultimately Satan cannot continue to stand. His kingdom is coming to an end. Girard puts it this way:

The kingdom of Satan corresponds to that part of human history almost entirely governed by the single victim mechanism and the false religions it produces. The mimetic concept of Satan enables the New Testament to give evil its due without granting it any reality or ontological substance in its own right that would make of Satan a kind of god of evil. Satan does not "create" by his own means. Rather he sustains himself as a parasite on what God creates by imitating God in a manner that is jealous, grotesque, perverse, and as contrary as possible to the upright and obedient imitation of Jesus. To repeat, Satan is an imitator in the rivalistic sense of the word.⁵⁶¹

For Girard, 'The devil, or Satan, signifies rivalistic contagion, up to and including the single victim mechanism. He may be located within the entire process or in one of its stages.'⁵⁶² Girard demonstrates that the mimetic cycle and its connection to the devil is not just revealed in the synoptic gospels, but also in the Gospel of John,

⁵⁵⁹ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 35.

⁵⁶⁰ Girard, *The Scapegoat*, 189.

⁵⁶¹ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 44–45.

⁵⁶² *Ibid.*, 43.

which describes the consequences of mimetic rivalry in Jesus's dialogue with those who disputed Jesus' identity, people who claimed to have God as their Father:

Jesus said to them, 'If God were your Father, you would love me, for I have come here from God. I have not come on my own; God sent me. Why is my language not clear to you? Because you are unable to hear what I say. *You belong to your father, the devil*, and you want to carry out *your father's desires*. He was *a murderer from the beginning*, not holding to the truth, for there is *no truth in him*. When he lies, he speaks his native language, for he is a liar and the father of lies' [emphasis added] (Jn 8:42-44 NIV).

On what basis is Jesus saying to these descendants of Abraham that neither Abraham nor God is their father, rather that their real father is the devil? The devil is their father on the basis that they *mimic the devil's desires*. For Girard, our arch-models are God or Satan. 'If we do not imitate Jesus, our models become the living obstacles that we also become for them. We descend together on the infernal spiral that leads to generalized mimetic crisis and ultimately, to the mimetic state of all against one.'⁵⁶³

People are creatures of imitation. As people made in God's image, leaders' freedom is choosing whom they will imitate. Not to imitate Christ is to imitate the devil, and if leaders imitate the devil, they will live entrapped in the mimetic cycle where scandals proliferate to the point of a crisis. Historically, before Christ, this led to the single victim mechanism, the murdering of the scapegoat.

This mimetic cycle is connected to the devil, a murderer from the beginning, and the accuser who uses false accusation to get the mob to lynch the innocent scapegoat. The Apostle Paul himself was complicit to murder, thinking he was doing the work of God; he discovered he was persecuting Jesus, living a lie. Girard gives his most detailed understanding of Satan in this passage:

The devil's 'quintessential being,' the source from which he draws his lies, is the violent contagion that has no substance to it. The devil does not have a stable foundation; he has no *being* at all. To clothe himself in the semblance of being, he must act as a parasite on God's creatures. He is totally mimetic, which amounts to saying *non-existent as an individual self*. The devil is also the father of lies; in certain manuscripts, he is the father of 'liars', because his deceitful violence has repercussions for generation after generation in human cultures. These cultures remain dependent on their founding murders and the rituals that reproduce them.⁵⁶⁴

When Girard is asked if he believes Satan exists and is a real being, he says, 'I follow traditional medieval theology on this point, which refuses to ascribe being to

⁵⁶³ Ibid., 40.

⁵⁶⁴ Ibid., 42.

Satan. This is a logical and consistent position, but not an obligatory one.⁵⁶⁵ Girard in another interview states, ‘There is no article of the Creed that says, “I believe in Satan and so forth.” We say, “I believe in God.” I do not believe in Satan.’⁵⁶⁶ Girard is paradoxical when he talks about Satan, as is seen in this final statement, ‘So the greatest ruse of Satan is to convince us that he doesn’t exist. But the next best ruse is to convince us that he exists.’⁵⁶⁷

A Founding Murder as the Foundation of Culture

Girard notes how origin myths from around the world speak of how culture and institutions emerge from a founding murder, the scapegoat mechanism. Comparative mythologist, Mircea Eliade, who is not given to many generalizations, and is more descriptive than explanatory in his approach, attests to this worldwide phenomenon, though it is Girard who gives it explanatory power.⁵⁶⁸ Through his study of anthropology, Girard makes the case that sacrificial ritual, the re-enactment of the original founding murder, has been foundational in developing human societies.⁵⁶⁹ Girard reminds us that this concept of murder being the foundation for culture is not just in origin myths, but in scripture as well. Starting with Genesis and stretching to the Gospels, this reality is affirmed. The Genesis account of Cain’s murder of his brother, Abel, is not just another founding myth for Girard, but ‘the biblical interpretation of all founding myths. It recounts the bloody foundation of the beginnings of culture and the consequences of this foundation, which form the first mimetic cycle narrated in the Bible.’⁵⁷⁰

Other founding myths hide human complicity in violence, deflecting responsibility to the gods and the false sacred, to which people must give sacrifices and engage rituals to maintain the peace of their communities. Meanwhile, the Hebrew scriptures *reveal* aspects of the mimetic cycle, starting with Cain, but it is *not fully* revealed until the Passion narrative. Girard reminds us that, in Genesis, the concept of enemy brothers looms large: Cain and Abel, Jacob and Esau, Joseph and his brothers.

⁵⁶⁵ René Girard, *The One by Whom Scandal Comes*, Studies in violence, mimesis, and culture series (East Lansing, MI: Michigan State University Press, 2014), 53.

⁵⁶⁶ Steven E Berry and Michael Hardin, *Reading the Bible with René Girard: Conversations with Steven E. Berry* (Lancaster, PA: JDL Press, 2015), 75.

⁵⁶⁷ Ibid.

⁵⁶⁸ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 82–83.

⁵⁶⁹ Ibid., 95.

⁵⁷⁰ Ibid., 83.

Within the enemy brothers' mimetic desire leads to mimetic rivalry and mimetic crisis where one becomes a scapegoat. This is the pattern of founding myths throughout human societies. For Rome, Remus is murdered by his brother Romulus. Cain and Romulus, the murdering brothers, become the founders and fathers of cultures. The death of Abel leads to Cain founding the first city in scripture, one he names after his son Enoch; the death of Remus leads to Romulus founding the city of Rome.

While the stories of Cain and Abel and Remus and Romulus have much in common, Girard reminds us that the significant difference is that in the Roman myth, Romulus, while regretting his action, is ultimately justified in killing his brother. 'His status is that of a sacrifice and High Priest; he incarnates Roman power under all its forms at one and the same time. The legislative, the judiciary, and the military forms cannot yet be distinguished from the religious; everything is already present within the last.'⁵⁷¹ But, in contrast, while having similar powers granted him, the scriptures paint [Cain] as a 'vulgar murderer.'⁵⁷² As Girard says, 'The fact that the first murder precipitates the first cultural development of the human race does not in any way excuse the murderer [in] the biblical text.'⁵⁷³ While the Hebrew scriptures outshine the comparative myths of their day in revealing the murderer and the innocent victim, the mimetic cycle is not completely revealed until the Gospels. This is where Jesus reveals what has been hidden since the foundation of the world.

Jesus, in the Gospels of Matthew and Luke, refers to the murder of the prophets. Luke mentions 'the blood of the prophets that have been shed since the beginning of the world, from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah' (Luke 11:50-1 NIV). Girard notes that the final link in this list of prophets is Jesus, as his crucifixion resembles the innocent victims that have gone before him.⁵⁷⁴ This is confirmed in Girard's reading of the parable of the murderous vine-growers (Matt. 21:33-41). Each time the landowner sends his servants to collect his fruit, the tenants collectively gang up on them, beating one, killing another, and stoning a third. 'Each violent expulsion is the completion of a mimetic cycle. The last messenger is the Son, expelled just like all the preceding messengers and finally murdered.'⁵⁷⁵

⁵⁷¹ Girard, Oughourlian, and Lefort, *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World*, 146–147.

⁵⁷² Ibid., 147.

⁵⁷³ Ibid.

⁵⁷⁴ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 85.

⁵⁷⁵ Ibid., 43.

For Girard, cultures are founded on murder, starting with Cain. Myths conceal this violence, while the Hebrew Scriptures reveal it in part, and the Gospels in full. Girard understands why Christians distrust sovereign states that were founded on murder, and so, instead of calling the Roman Empire and Herodian tetrarchy by name, ‘the New Testament usually calls upon a specific vocabulary, that of ‘principalities and powers.’⁵⁷⁶

The Principalities and Powers

For Girard, the principalities and powers are closely associated with Satan, yet distinct. ‘Though not identical to Satan, the powers are all his tributaries because they are all servants of the false gods that are the offspring of Satan, that is, the offspring of the founding murder.’⁵⁷⁷ Girard is struck by how many names the New Testament uses to designate these ‘ambiguous entities’ and divides them into two groups. ‘Expressions like “powers of this world,” “kings of the earth,” “principalities,” etc. assert the earthly character of the powers... on the other hand, expressions like “princes of the kingdom of the air,” “celestial powers,” etc. emphasize the extraterrestrial “spiritual” nature of these entities.’⁵⁷⁸ For Girard, these two groups of names represent the same entities in different but complementary ways. He believes the New Testament writers sought to clarify ‘the combination of material power and spiritual power that is the sovereign reality stemming from collective founding murders.’⁵⁷⁹ The physical and spiritual realities point to the same entity, but they refer to differing dimensions, thus human language cannot express this well. Language ‘does not command the necessary resources to express the power of bringing people together that false transcendence possesses in the real, material world, in spite of its falsity and imaginary nature.’⁵⁸⁰

What is insightful from Girard regarding the principalities and powers is that, while based on the transcendence of Satan, they are not categorically evil: ‘It is the transcendence on which they are based that is diabolical.’⁵⁸¹ So, there are some redeemable elements regarding the principalities and powers. For Girard, the principalities and powers have ‘governed humanity since the world began.’⁵⁸² They can

⁵⁷⁶ Ibid., 95.

⁵⁷⁷ Ibid., 96.

⁵⁷⁸ Ibid.

⁵⁷⁹ Ibid., 97.

⁵⁸⁰ Ibid., 97–98.

⁵⁸¹ Ibid., 98.

⁵⁸² Girard, Oughourlian, and Lefort, *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World*, 190.

appear as positive forces that help maintain order and prevent communities from destroying each other, or as obstacles revealing and concealing the fullness of revelation.⁵⁸³ He sums up his understanding of the principalities and powers saying,

We can better understand the New Testament idea of the powers if we relate it to what is still, in my view, the best of the anthropological theories of social life, Emile Durkheims' concept of "social transcendence." The great sociologist found in primitive societies a fusion of the sacred and the social that comes quite close to the basic paradox of the powers and principalities.⁵⁸⁴

For Girard, the principalities and powers are the 'social phenomena that the founding murder created,' expressed in physical reality through earthly rules, and expressed in spiritual reality through the social realities that typically seek to cover up human complicity to violence.

Disarming the Principalities and Powers

Since sovereign states like Rome were founded on murder and violence, and because some of the early Christians experienced the same fate as their Master, Christians found subversive ways to talk about the Roman Empire and the spirituality behind it, namely the principalities and powers. The dual reference that Girard gives to the principalities and powers as earthly and celestial has been widely adapted.⁵⁸⁵ The contribution that Girard makes to this dual reference to the principalities and powers is his explanation of how they gain their transcendent spirituality from the false transcendency of the mimetic cycle, which for him is Satan. For in the mimetic cycle the scapegoat is first demonized, but after the community is reconciled and experiences temporary tranquillity, the scapegoat is divinized. In fact, for Girard, the development of monarchies occurred when there was a delay in the killing of the scapegoat. When the victim was chosen and 'set aside' for sacrifice, there was already a 'sacredness' about them. As their sacrifice was delayed, if the victim gathered enough followers, they began to be revered, looked up to, and given high status. In this way, the false sacred created a spirituality and power behind the human entity, all based on the false transcendency of the mimetic cycle. For Girard, all human cultures and institutions are founded on this mimetic cycle. It is his way of describing the Fall.

The triumph of the cross, according to Girard, is that Jesus becomes the willing scapegoat. In Jesus's death, like every other scapegoat, the mimetic contagion of the

⁵⁸³ Ibid., 191.

⁵⁸⁴ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 99–100.

⁵⁸⁵ Yong, *In the Days of Caesar*, 148.

crowds entrapped even Jesus's disciples, so that *all* came against the *one*. The work of Satan was happening again, just as it had since the foundation of the world. Thus, all hope was lost on 'good' Friday.

Of course, that is not the end of the story. What makes this mimetic cycle different from all the rest in the history of the world, is that Jesus is shown to be the innocent victim. For the Father raised him from the dead, exposing Satan and his work, the mimetic cycle, which in turn disarms the principalities and powers. It reveals the violence and false transcendency by which the principalities and powers gained their power and authority. Girard reminds us that some would claim that the Passion narrative is mythology just like all other mythology, because like in all mythology, the single victim mechanism is the source of the divine, the one who was demonized becomes divinized. However, the Passion narrative is not like other myths. Girard explains, 'If the transference that demonizes the victim is powerful enough, then the reconciliation is so sudden and complete that it appears to be miraculous and triggers a second transference superimposed on the first one, the transference of deification.'⁵⁸⁶

Yet, in this Passion narrative, there is no guilt attributed to Jesus, 'thus his divinity cannot rest on the same process as mythic deifications.'⁵⁸⁷ In addition, in mythology the victim is *unanimously* lifted to the level of divinity, but in the gospel narrative, it is not the mob that recognizes Jesus as the Son of God, but the rebellious *minority*, the disciples, who witness his resurrection. 'This dissident minority has no equivalent in the myths.'⁵⁸⁸ Jesus's death on the cross, and his resurrection, reveal what has been concealed from the foundation of the world, 'the founding murder and the origin of human culture.'⁵⁸⁹ The truth triumphs through the cross. 'Though ordinarily the accusation nails the victim to a cross, here by contrast the accusation itself is nailed and publicly exhibited and exposed as a lie.'⁵⁹⁰ As Paul puts it in his letter to the Colossians:

God made you alive with Christ. He forgave us all our sins, having cancelled the charges of our legal indebtedness, which stood against us and condemned us; he has taken it away, nailing it to the cross. And having disarmed the powers and authorities, he made a public spectacle of them, triumphing over them by the cross (Col. 2:13b-15 NIV).

⁵⁸⁶ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 123.

⁵⁸⁷ Ibid.

⁵⁸⁸ Ibid.

⁵⁸⁹ Ibid., 125.

⁵⁹⁰ Ibid., 138.

Girard's Mimetic Theory and Missional Leadership

As this thesis critically engaged Wink, a theology of the Powers was developed. Girard has now linked imitation and desire to the Powers, completing the imitation-based framework. Now it will be important to engage Wink in the areas of leadership, mimetic desire, and the Powers, as well as to look at an undeveloped concept in Girard: leadership and positive mimesis. Girard displays how the framework gives a new approach to leadership theory and practice. But first, there must be some response to those who dismiss Girard as unimportant in this conversation.

In Defence of Girard

Richard Whitehouse levels against Girard the critique that 'he does not address the classical spiritual warfare texts...', and that 'in Girard's case a theory is brought to the text rather than being read out of that text.' Additionally, for him, 'Girard's assumptions are derived principally from his analysis of medieval and modern French literature both of which carry their own cultural assumptions; it is kind of a literary-cultural "double whammy"!'⁵⁹¹ Thus, he dismisses Girard from the conversation.

Regarding Whitehouse's first critique, that Girard does not address the classical warfare texts, it should be noted that, though Girard was not a theologian by training or vocation, he dialogued with and contributed to the theological field as a cultural anthropologist.⁵⁹² Girard was chosen for this study because of the explanatory power that he gives to Satan's agency in the world, Girard's contribution to understanding the principalities and powers, and his unmatched ability to tie mimetic (envious) desire to the Powers. His ability to marry anthropology and theology in a way that matches reality provides a robust approach to leadership and the Powers which, if left unaddressed, leaves this field of study more barren. In addition, Walter Wink, the most cited person on the Powers, and one to whom Newbigin and other missional leaders show their indebtedness, says of Girard in *Engaging the Powers*, 'Even if aspects of Girard's overall thesis fails to convince, his understanding of mimetic rivalry and conflict and of the scapegoat are among the most profound intellectual discoveries of our time, and will remain permanent contributions to our understanding of the meaning of Jesus' crucifixion.'⁵⁹³

⁵⁹¹ Whitehouse, Hardy, and Yarnell, "More Recent Approaches to Spiritual Conflict," 26.

⁵⁹² Scott Cowdell, *René Girard and the Nonviolent God* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2018), 85.

⁵⁹³ Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 155.

Another critique of Whitehouse's is that Girard's theory primarily hangs on a limited number of French novelists with similar backgrounds and cultural assumptions. Because Girard's three discoveries appeared in print starting with mimetic desire, it is often assumed that Girard was not working with any knowledge of the scapegoat mechanism or the revelation that scripture brings in his early work. Cowdell rightly remarks, 'I have come to realize that all three elements are to some extent present from the beginning for Girard, so that these discoveries should not be strictly linked to the order of their appearance in a series of major publications.' It ought to be evident that Girard was attuned to the revelation of scripture prior to the printing of his first book, *Deceit, Desire and the Novel* (released in 1961) because his two-stepped conversion took place by Easter of 1959. It was the Christian symbolism that caught Girard's attention as well as the novelist's use of scripture, often in their conclusions.⁵⁹⁴ For Girard, the best of the genius novelists were those who identified the problem, but also came to a proper conclusion. 'Truth is active throughout the great novel but its primary location is in the conclusion. The conclusion is the temple of truth. The conclusion is the site of the presence of truth, and therefore a place avoided by error.'⁵⁹⁵ Girard ends his first book with the conclusion from *The Brothers Karamazov*, where the words 'memory, death, love, and resurrection are found in the mouths of the children.'⁵⁹⁶ Here the hope of the gospel is addressed.

It should be remembered that Girard himself said, from his first book to his last, that they were all written as, 'more or less explicit apologies of Christianity.'⁵⁹⁷ In addition, his theory did not simply rest on his first book, though it should be noted that the five authors, while including three French novelists – Proust, Stendhal, and Flaubert – also included a Russian and a Spaniard – Dostoevsky and Cervantes. But, Girard's theory was developed and confirmed throughout his writing career and study in various disciplines.

Girard clearly understood his role as academic apologist. In his correspondence with Raymund Schwager on April 17, 1978, in answer to Schwager's desire for Girard to engage theology even more, his response describes his vocational calling.

I also understand that you are disappointed not to find in my work the development of certain appropriately religious themes, but I think that this is properly your domain, not mine. Given my background (and) my intellectual

⁵⁹⁴ Girard, *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel*, 309–314.

⁵⁹⁵ Ibid., 307.

⁵⁹⁶ Ibid., 314.

⁵⁹⁷ Girard, Antonello, and de Castro Rocha, *Evolution and Conversion*, 150.

roots in modern critical thought, my research necessarily has to remain in the continuing context of that critical tradition... This should no doubt make it accessible not only to many people, but to the sorts of mind [*certaines esprits la meme famille*] for centuries totally shut off, you could say, from anything that touches directly or indirectly the Judeo-Christian tradition.⁵⁹⁸

This call remained with Girard for his life. In one of his later dialogical books, he was asked why he did not drop his pursuit of the social sciences for all its atheistic assumptions. Part of his response was, ‘If you postulate the a priori truth of religion from the start, your reasoning would have a far weaker apologetic value.’⁵⁹⁹ Girard seems to have had a vocational call. He started his pursuit by accident, through literature, but the scapegoat mechanism took ten years of research in anthropology, ethnology, and mythology (which spans many cultures and time periods). And like most, all of Girard’s learning informed his understanding and experiences, including his first two earned degrees.

Whitehouse’s final critique is more common: that ‘in Girard’s case a theory is brought to the text rather than being read out of that text.’⁶⁰⁰ While there are several books that address this issue, Girardian scholar and Anglican theologian Scott Cowdell’s contribution merits attention.⁶⁰¹ Cowdell addresses the issue with honesty. He is aware of common misreadings of Girard, as well as those parroting old critiques which do not fit the middle or late Girard. Cowdell recognizes that Girard was willing to change his mind, as when he recognized that sacrifice could be used positively. This speaks to Girard’s humility as a scholar. Cowdell acknowledges Girard’s methodological paradox, ‘in which theological claims appear to be both primary and secondary in his project.’⁶⁰² He also notes that ‘Girard regards his thesis as being “in line with all the great dogmas, [while] it endows them with an anthropological underpinning that has gone unnoticed.”’ Cowdell writes, ‘in an unusual juxtaposition – and one that eludes many of Girard’s critics – social science and scriptural revelation are linked in mimetic theory.’⁶⁰³ So while Girard does read the scripture with a mimetic heuristic, he recognizes that there are some things in scripture that cannot be explained

⁵⁹⁸ Cowdell et al., *René Girard and Raymund Schwager*, 55.

⁵⁹⁹ Girard, Antonello, and de Castro Rocha, *Evolution and Conversion*, 150.

⁶⁰⁰ Whitehouse, Hardy, and Yarnell, “More Recent Approaches to Spiritual Conflict,” 26.

⁶⁰¹ Cowdell, *René Girard and the Nonviolent God*; Kaplan, *René Girard, Unlikely Apologist*; Palaver, *René Girard’s Mimetic Theory*; Raymund Schwager, *Must There Be Scapegoats: Violence and Redemption in the Bible* (New York: The Crossroad Publishing Company, 2018).

⁶⁰² Cowdell, *René Girard and the Nonviolent God*, 87.

⁶⁰³ *Ibid.*, 86.

in terms of 'his social-scientific approach,' like the Resurrection.⁶⁰⁴ For Girard, 'The Resurrection is not only a miracle, a prodigious transgression of natural laws. It is the spectacular sign of the entrance into the world of a power superior to violent contagion.'⁶⁰⁵ In another place Girard writes, 'There can be no mimetic theory of the Resurrection. The Resurrection is either an invention of religious propaganda or the source of truth. From both a structural and dynamic point of view, the anthropological and theological significance of the Resurrection is so coherent that it is very difficult to imagine that it could be an invention.'⁶⁰⁶

In Girard's efforts to widen the reception of the gospel, he never 'surrenders his methodological paradox.'⁶⁰⁷ But his orthodoxy is seen when he despairs that Christianity looks for the latest fashionable ideas. He writes,

What's most pathetic is the incipiently modernized brand of Christianity that bows down before everything that's most ephemeral in contemporary thought. Christians don't see that they have at their disposal an instrument that is completely superior to the whole mishmash of psychoanalysis and sociology that they conscientiously feed themselves. It's the old story of Esau sacrificing his inheritance for a plate of lentils.⁶⁰⁸

Cowdell notes that Schwager, 'offered this sharp rejoinder to anyone accusing Girard of reducing Christian faith to mere knowledge of a social process.'⁶⁰⁹ Schwager stated 'Since [Girard] expressly believes in the true divinity and humanity of Christ, the working of the Holy Spirit in history, and even the virgin birth, and since he attributes central importance to Christ's cross and salvific activity, such broad sweeping criticism rules itself out of court.'⁶¹⁰ However, Cowdell understands there is still a tension in Girard's work, 'introducing a doubt into his reception by theologians.'⁶¹¹ So in his book, he continues to make persuasive arguments on why Girard ought to be well received.

Girard was always willing to talk to people who were sceptical of his theory and of Christianity. One such dialogue takes place in the book *When These Things Begin*, where a recorded conversation between Michel Treguer and Girard was printed. Girard

⁶⁰⁴ Ibid., 88.

⁶⁰⁵ Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 189.

⁶⁰⁶ Girard, *The One by Whom Scandal Comes*, 67.

⁶⁰⁷ Cowdell, *René Girard and the Nonviolent God*, 91.

⁶⁰⁸ Girard, *When These Things Begin*, 74.

⁶⁰⁹ Cowdell, *René Girard and the Nonviolent God*, 86.

⁶¹⁰ Raymund Schwager, "Christ's Death and the Prophetic Critique of Sacrifice.," *Semeia; an Experimental Journal for Biblical Criticism* (1985): 110.

⁶¹¹ Cowdell, *René Girard and the Nonviolent God*, 87.

acknowledged the power of scripture when answering Treguer's scepticism, by saying, 'What I am saying is that Christianity reveals its power by interrupting the world in all its ambiguity. It gives us an understanding of human cultures that is incomparably better than that offered by the social sciences.'⁶¹² While Girard consistently followed his calling as a cultural anthropologist with the goal of reaching those outside of the church, his third major discovery – the power found in the revelation of scripture – took place before he penned his first book. And without Christ, there is no mimetic theory.

Finally, the value of Girard's contribution to this thesis is exhibited as Houston links imitation and desire with the Powers in his work on I Peter and subsequent engagement with the shared themes of James. To further demonstrate how the scriptures themselves teach that mimetic desire is connected to the Powers, this thesis will engage New Testament scholar Scot McKnight, through his commentary on the book of James.

Leadership, Mimetic Desire, and the Powers in James

First it must be said, that McKnight at no time refers to René Girard nor is he in his bibliography. This is his work, in conversation with other New Testament scholars who have studied James. The passage in James that reveals how mimetic desire and the Powers are connected is James 3:1-4:12, in particular, James 3:13-4:9, but the larger area needs to be considered for the sake of giving context. While this review is brief, it makes the necessary point. After reviewing ten outlines of James that other scholars developed, McKnight follows in the footsteps of Richard Bauckham, and outlines the passage this way:

- 6. General exhortation for teachers (3:1-4:12)
 - 6.1 Teachers and the tongue (3:1-12)
 - 6.2 Teachers and wisdom (3:13-18)
 - 6.3 Teachers and dissensions (4:1-10)
 - 6.4 Teachers, the community, and the tongue (4:11-12)⁶¹³

McKnight's summary of 6.1, *teachers and the tongue* is that 'James is concerned about the teachers in the messianic community, and his concern is with their tongue – he advises them not to pursue teaching and to guard their tongues. Why? Because the tongue's impact is disproportionate to its size.'⁶¹⁴ James is pleading with

⁶¹² Girard, *When These Things Begin*, 120.

⁶¹³ Scot McKnight, *The Letter of James* (Grand Rapids, MI: W.B. Eerdmans Pub. Co, 2011), 55.

⁶¹⁴ *Ibid.*, 296–297.

these teachers to ‘realize the incongruity of being one who blesses God and at the same time curses humans who are made in God’s likeness.’⁶¹⁵ The crucial part to see in this text, is that praise for God and cursing of people were coming out of the same mouth, which reveals a significant problem. One can see how the teacher likely has a scapegoat whom they are cursing. James says this ought not to be so. As McKnight writes, ‘A better way is the way of wisdom, and the proper goal of the teacher is neither control nor curse but wisdom.’⁶¹⁶

In exploring 6.2, *teachers and wisdom*, McKnight writes, ‘The speech patterns that most concerned James, speech that like a spark sets the messianic community on fire with destructive forces, are about envy, ambition, and boasting (3:14-16).’⁶¹⁷ The problem that James was uncovering is described in the verses to which McKnight points. ‘But if you harbor bitter envy and selfish ambition in your hearts, do not boast about it or deny the truth. Such “wisdom” does not come down from heaven but is earthly, unspiritual, demonic. For where you have envy and selfish ambition, there you find disorder and every evil practice’ (3:14-16 NIV). Envy, which tradition considers a deadly sin, is mimetic desire, as will become evident as the passage progresses.

McKnight notes James’ question, ‘Who is wise and understanding among you’ (3:13a)? This rhetorical question was not to identify ‘who are such persons, as to describe such persons’ as his answer reveals.⁶¹⁸ McKnight notes, ‘James’s description will not permit the teacher to think his or her mastery of theology or exegesis is sufficient to pass muster. What passes muster for James is behaviour shaped by humble wisdom.’⁶¹⁹ This speaks to the issue addressed earlier in this thesis, that a good grasp of missional theology, if not reflected in a changed life, is insufficient. James answers his question saying, ‘Show by your good life’ (3:13b). McKnight writes, ‘he does not tell the good teacher to be wise, but to manifest good works in wisdom.’⁶²⁰ The leader, or the teacher, ought to have a pattern of life that reflects good works.

McKnight, in exegeting James, then describes the problem, the communal impact, and the source of false wisdom followed by the potential for true wisdom. The problem is the leader having envy and selfish ambition in his or her heart. ‘In two verses James will reveal that the leader marked by “ambition” creates disorder in the

⁶¹⁵ Ibid., 297.

⁶¹⁶ McKnight, *The Letter of James*, 297.

⁶¹⁷ Ibid., 298.

⁶¹⁸ Ibid., 299.

⁶¹⁹ Ibid.

⁶²⁰ Ibid., 301.

community (3:16). Sophie Laws has a notable definition of the term: “unscrupulous determination to gain one’s own ends.”⁶²¹ McKnight writes ‘Zealous, ambitious teachers, because they are concerned with their own reputation and the power that comes to those with cognitive skills, both boast (cf. Jer 9:23-24) and deny the truth.’⁶²² James says proclamation requires performance in one’s life. James points to the source of false wisdom, in that it comes from below, it is ‘earthly, unspiritual, demonic’. James is now linking envious desires to the work of the Powers. The effects of a leader caught in the mimetic trap are described by McKnight.

James...is neck-deep in a pastoral problem of immense proportions. Those who are designed to follow Jesus, to live a life of loving God and others, and to live out of the will of God are being fractured into bits by teachers who abuse their authority, seek to establish their reputations, and frame everything so as to enlarge their own borders, and James knows that the messianic community is at a crossroads. Either is gets back on track or it will disintegrate into ineffective witness and missed opportunity. The options are two: either the teachers pursue a wisdom that comes from God (see 3:17-18), or they continue on their reckless, destructive path, which comes from Gehenna and the evil spirit-world. Such a spirit-world distorts human community and institutionalizes injustices.⁶²³

While the communal impact of the problem of envy and selfish ambition is noted here, McKnight notes that the concrete manifestations of envy and selfish ambition are not named until 4:1 ‘What causes fights and quarrels among you? Don’t they come from your desires that battle within you?’ McKnight writes, ‘Zeal [envy] and ambition break loose moral anchors, on the part of teachers, their followers, and their opponents, so that control and dominance become the guiding lights.’⁶²⁴ As McKnight works through this passage in James, it becomes clear how mimetic desire is tied to the Powers. This is not just a link that Girard gives us from his study of anthropology, but James, the half-brother of Jesus gives us before Girard. Girard gives anthropological evidence and explanatory power to what James reveals to us.

McKnight reminds us that James encourages the teacher or leader of the community to live from wisdom that comes from above, not below. ‘Wisdom transcends cognitive mastery of facts and information. It is skill in living according to

⁶²¹ Ibid., 304.

⁶²² Ibid., 305.

⁶²³ Ibid., 308.

⁶²⁴ Ibid., 309.

God's moral order... The wise person lives in God's world in God's way with God's people and so enjoys the blessing of the only wise God.'⁶²⁵

McKnight then moves to 6.3 *Teachers and dissention*. He notes that the origin of the division is in the malformed desires of the leaders. Then he addresses the 4:2 'You desire but do not have, so you kill.' While McKnight is not looking at this from a Girardian perspective, it becomes obvious this is the scapegoat mechanism in action. When McKnight talks about this verse he translates the 'conflicts and disputes', as 'warring and swording', an outright battle, and explores if James is talking about literal murder here.⁶²⁶ McKnight ends up siding with theologian Ralph Martin who writes, 'Since James and his community were situated in a Zealot-invested society and since it is quite conceivable that (at least) some of the Jewish Christians were former Zealots (cf. Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13), the taking of another's life is not out of the realm of possibility for church members as a response to disagreement.'⁶²⁷ McKnight after further arguments writes, 'There is very little to suggest that these texts speak of anything but actual murder.'⁶²⁸ McKnight notes the nature of the teacher's desire which James has concerns about. He names the teacher's desire 'for power, control, and partisanship.'⁶²⁹ 'James has teachers in mind, and their problem was loose tongues used to abuse individuals and divide the community.'⁶³⁰

McKnight goes on to write that disputes and conflicts come from the desires of the teachers. 'James pushes them to consider the origins of their behaviors in their own craving desires for power and control. He pushes further and says, evidently, that their craving desires lead to murder and to the disputes and conflicts in the messianic community.'⁶³¹

McKnight then addresses the issue that leaders do not have what they want because they do not ask, and even when they ask, they do so with wrong motives, for their own pleasure. He does not take this as hedonistic pleasures, because it is the same word as 4.1, 'their zeal [envy], ambition, craving, and desires shaped everything they did. They wanted self-glory and power, not wisdom... Their prayers, instead of being

⁶²⁵ Ibid., 310.

⁶²⁶ McKnight, *The Letter of James*, 328.

⁶²⁷ Ralph P. Martin and John D. W. Watts, *James, Volume 48*, ed. David Allen Hubbard and Glenn W. Barker (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Academic, 2015), 144.

⁶²⁸ McKnight, *The Letter of James*, 326.

⁶²⁹ Ibid., 323.

⁶³⁰ Ibid.

⁶³¹ Ibid., 328.

directed at gaining wisdom, explored and sought to increase their own consuming zeal and ambition for power.⁶³²

McKnight then points out how James considered these teachers adulterers, because of their friendship with the world, drawing out what James says, ‘Friendship with God = enmity with the world, and friendship with the world = enmity with God.’⁶³³ McKnight suggests that what James is addressing here, in the immediate context, is that friendship with the world ‘would have to include the zeal [envy], ambition, craving, and desires for power and control in the messianic community. Perhaps murder is in mind as well (4:2).’⁶³⁴ Then McKnight insightfully says, ‘The immediate context then would suggest a variation on what Jesus said to his disciples about wanting to lord it over others as the Gentiles do (Mark 10:35-45)... In context, then, James’s focus is on accusations against the teachers and leaders for creating chaos in the community by yearning for lordship.’⁶³⁵

In expounding on how God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble, for McKnight, what grace refers to ‘is the grace of his gift of forgiveness to those who repent.’⁶³⁶ For this is what James calls them to do in the final leg of the passage, 4:7-10.

McKnight lists the commands for the divisive, naming ten imperatives in the passage as

1. *Submit* yourselves therefore to God
2. *Resist* the devil, and he will flee from you.
3. *Draw near* to God, and he will draw near to you.
4. *Cleanse* your hands, you sinners,
5. and *purify* your hearts, you double-minded
6. *Lament*
7. and *mourn*
8. and *weep*
9. *Let* your laughter *be turned* into mourning and your joy into dejection.
10. *Humble* yourselves before the Lord, and he will exalt you.⁶³⁷

When examining this passage, McKnight considers the similarities of this passage with I Peter 5:5-9, and the striking parallels they have, pointing to ‘(1) humility, (2) citation of Proverbs 3:34, (3) the need to be humble before God, and (4) a call to resist the devil.’⁶³⁸ He then offers a stunning insight. ‘One parallel does not a

⁶³² Ibid., 330–331.

⁶³³ Ibid., 333.

⁶³⁴ Ibid., 334.

⁶³⁵ Ibid., 334–335.

⁶³⁶ Ibid., 342.

⁶³⁷ Ibid., 345.

⁶³⁸ Ibid., 347.

catechetical pattern make, but it is at least worthy of consideration to wonder if this language did not emerge from the catechetical tradition of the early churches for leaders, teachers, and those aspiring to be such.⁶³⁹

The last point to make is how McKnight notes how James ties the mimetic desires of the leader to the devil. He writes, ‘If the emphasis so far has led us to think in terms of anthropology, James now brings into the discussion a cosmic force at work in the divisiveness of the community leaders. The desires that yearn toward envy are animated, at least in part, by “the devil.”’⁶⁴⁰ Thus, McKnight demonstrates how James ties the envious desires of the leaders to the devil. McKnight also notes that ‘Resisting the evil one was an important theme in Judaism and early Christian catechesis.’⁶⁴¹ Though it is important to note that McKnight points out that James, ‘perhaps less than only Jesus in the New Testament, emphasizes human responsibility.’⁶⁴²

Girard’s writing as an academic apologist began with mimetic desire, as discovered through the genius novelists. He then developed the concept of the scapegoat mechanism through his study of anthropology and mythology. Then he went to the gospels to demonstrate how Jesus reveals this mimetic cycle. While he self-identified as a cultural anthropologist, and sought to do theology from an anthropological position, he expected that theologians would do it from their own exegetical perspective. It seems that McKnight in his exegesis of James justifies the linking of mimetic desire to the Powers. If this is the case, then the text is seemingly teaching exegetically what Girard discovered through his study of literature and anthropology, as well as his anthropological approach to theology.

The study of James by McKnight provides evidence of what Cowdell writes regarding the methodology of Girard. He mentions how Girard thought it was important that “the religion of the Incarnation should be an anthropology as well as a theology. Incarnation means man and God together.” Hence, in an unusual juxtaposition – and one that eludes many of Girard’s critics – social science and scriptural revelation are linked in mimetic theory.⁶⁴³ This supplies at least one response to Whitehouse’s critique on Girard’s reading his theory into the text. He certainly does read the Bible with a mimetic heuristic, which in this case brings great

⁶³⁹ Ibid.

⁶⁴⁰ Ibid., 348.

⁶⁴¹ Ibid.

⁶⁴² Ibid.

⁶⁴³ Cowdell, *René Girard and the Nonviolent God*, 86.

value. Being aware of others' presuppositions as well as one's own is important for the scholar, for as Wink reminds us, no one comes to the text with complete objectivity. But there is another critique of Girard which must be addressed.

Leadership and Positive Mimesis

One of the common critiques of Girard is that while he consistently and deeply develops the concept of mimetic desire in all of its horrific forms, which are seen in reality, there is little development of how mimetic desire can be positive. Willard Swartley writes, 'Girard speaks of positive mimesis. But, overall Girard says relatively little about this, although at numerous points he speaks of good mimesis and occasionally commends Jesus as the good model. Usually, Girard focuses simply on mimetic desire, which for him is desire that leads to rivalry.'⁶⁴⁴ Thus, on at least two occasions, there were conferences to help rectify this lack. The conference on René Girard and Biblical Peace Theology, held at Associated Mennonites Biblical Seminary in June of 1994, and the Colloquium on Violence and Religion (COVR) which took place at Saint Paul University in Ottawa, Canada in 2006. The various contributions to these conferences, have subsequently become books.⁶⁴⁵

Petra Steinmair-Pösel's contribution unfolds through the meta-narrative of creation (mimetic desire and creative grace), the fall (conflictual mimesis and original sin), and Christ (grace and positive mimesis). In God's good creation, mimetic desire, as 'the openness of the human person to what is human and divine, has its theological counterpart in the capacity for transcendence which is given to the human person as creational grace.'⁶⁴⁶ He projects that at the beginning, mimetic desire is good, but can be easily twisted. He relates negative mimesis to original sin, where acquisitive mimesis 'aims at taking the place of the model – ultimately taking the place of God.' Rivalry and violence become the consequence. While 'positive mimesis is based upon God's prevenient grace'.⁶⁴⁷ Grace comes in the person of Jesus Christ. For Jesus

⁶⁴⁴ Willard M. Swartley, "Discipleship and Imitation of Jesus/Suffering Servant: The Mimesis of New Creation," in *Violence Renounced: René Girard, Biblical Studies, and Peacemaking*, ed. Willard M. Swartley (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 2000), 218.

⁶⁴⁵ Willard M. Swartley, ed., *Violence Renounced* (Telford, PA: Scottdale, Pa: Pandora Press, 2000); Thomas Ryba and Vern Neufeld Redekop, eds., *René Girard and Creative Mimesis* (Lanham, MD: Lexington Books, 2013).

⁶⁴⁶ Petra Steinmair-Pösel, "Original Sin, Grace, and Positive Mimesis," in *René Girard and Creative Mimesis*, ed. Vern Neufeld Redekop and Thomas Ryba (Lanham, MD: Lexington Books, 2013), 229.

⁶⁴⁷ *Ibid.*, 230.

desired the Father, and his relation to his Father ‘had become the innermost core of his own self-expression and of his own person’, quoting Józef Niewiadomski.⁶⁴⁸ He connects the grace given to Jesus to his participation with the Father and Spirit, recognizing that Jesus borrowed his desires from the Father. Unlike Adam, the second Adam’s ‘image of the Father is not that of a rivalrous God, who wants to withhold something from God’s creatures but is that of a loving Father who wants to give Godself as a present.’⁶⁴⁹ In addition, Jesus as a concrete man is ‘not an autonomous subject imitating the Father by virtue of his own efforts but by virtue of the Holy Spirit given to him.’⁶⁵⁰ ‘By means of his life and death and the sending of the divine Spirit after his ascension, Jesus – the *homo perfectus* – the undistorted image of God, makes possible a new, undisguised experience of God and consequently also new inter-human relationships, relationships which don’t follow the structure of antagonistic mimesis.’⁶⁵¹ Because of the grace of Christ, a new form of relationship is possible, positive mimesis, ‘because of the new image or rather the *new experience of God*, which Jesus communicates by means of his own life and acting.’⁶⁵² There is now available for all humanity a new ‘*quality of imitation*, a quality that does not lead into mimetic conflicts, because it doesn’t arise from an attitude of scarcity but from the experience of gratuitous forgiveness and from newly bestowed possibilities for life.’⁶⁵³ This new quality of imitation does not take aim at replacing the model, or replacing God. ‘*Positive mimesis doesn’t aim at replacement but at gratuitous participation – ultimately participation in the divine life.*’ For Steinmair-Pösel, the foundation of positive mimesis is the gratuitous reception of the gift of God’s grace and the willingness to pass on what one has received. When the Eucharist becomes the centre of the community, a place of receiving and thanksgiving, its positive mimesis can be realized. But in the context of human institutions, it can only be realized in a ‘very fragile and fragmentary way.’⁶⁵⁴

New Testament professor Willard Swartley, in his chapter on *Discipleship and Imitation of Jesus*, seeks to ‘show that major strands of NT teaching are directed specifically to: transformation of desire that enables a positive *non-acquisitive*

⁶⁴⁸ Ibid., 228.

⁶⁴⁹ Ibid.

⁶⁵⁰ Ibid.

⁶⁵¹ Ibid., 228–229.

⁶⁵² Ibid., 229.

⁶⁵³ Ibid.

⁶⁵⁴ Ibid.

mimesis... [and] to show how foundational and ubiquitous this idea is in the New Testament.⁶⁵⁵ He sees in the New Testament a stream of exhortations that repudiate ‘mimetic desire that generates rivalry and in turn leads to violence.’⁶⁵⁶ And a call in the New Testament canon which is grounded in the event of Jesus’ cross, ‘an event that exposes and, from Jesus’ side, manifests the freedom and power of new creation.’⁶⁵⁷ He writes,

If the Girardian thesis is correct, that mimetic rivalry is the generative power behind the scapegoating mechanism that led to Jesus’ violent death, and if Jesus’ life-death breaks this spiral of violence empowered by rivalry – the thesis I will argue – then it should be possible to show exegetically that Jesus’ teaching on discipleship and the early church’s imitation (later called *imitatio Christi*...) function as antidote to aspirations of rivalry.⁶⁵⁸

Following the long tradition of *imitatio Christi*, Swartley first examines Paul’s use of imitation, then its wider use in the New Testament. It should be noted that Paul called the community to imitate him and others as they imitate Christ. Thus, they are not like Girard’s gurus, who are only self-referential in their call to imitate. He then examines the gospel narratives that emphasize the call to follow Christ, as noted earlier by Bonhoeffer. He ends by including an even wider set of language around identifying with Christ, participating in his life, death, and resurrection, as what it means to live ‘in Christ’. The lists of the vices of the flesh and virtues of walking in the Spirit were emphasized in this. While he takes this order of presentation, he cautions, ‘The atonement is the precondition theologically and practically for all imitation “in Christ,” and identification or correspondence *paraenesis*. The potential of a new *mimesis* rests on God’s inauguration of a new creation reality through the cross and, most significantly, the resurrection of Jesus Christ.’⁶⁵⁹

In his essay, Swartley emphasizes that many of the imitation passages relate to people leading a cruciform life: a non-retaliatory life where violence is met with love instead of evil. Where they willingly suffer instead of participating in the scapegoat mechanism. Often Paul asks people to follow the leadership team: Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy, ‘You became imitators of us and of the Lord, for you welcomed the message in the midst of severe suffering with the joy given by the Holy Spirit. And so you

⁶⁵⁵ Swartley, “Discipleship and Imitation of Jesus/Suffering Servant: The Mimesis of New Creation,” 219.

⁶⁵⁶ Ibid.

⁶⁵⁷ Ibid.

⁶⁵⁸ Ibid., 220.

⁶⁵⁹ Ibid., 221.

became a model to all the believers in Macedonia and Achaia' (I Thess. 1:6-7 NIV). Positive mimesis is taking place here, where imitation of good models leads to others becoming models themselves. Here we see the multiplication of disciples of Jesus. Following the suffering servant means to participate mysteriously in the death and resurrection of Christ, being willing to suffer like Christ suffered. 'Their suffering certified their character, as those who did not mimetically counter-respond but experienced typologically the fate of Jesus.'⁶⁶⁰ Imitation was having the same mind of Christ, by doing nothing from selfish ambition or empty deceit, but rather considering others more important, demonstrated by willingness to enter a self-emptying kenotic life, like Jesus (Phil. 2:4-8). Jim Foder makes a good case that mimesis and participation are not mutually exclusive. 'Rather discipleship means maintaining these two central ideas in motion, keeping both in elliptical orbit around one another. If Christian mimesis is unavoidably participatory, so too participation in God's life proves inescapably mimetic – for the simple reason that we only know what it means to participate in God's life by imitating the pattern set forth in the Son.'⁶⁶¹ In conclusion and summary, Swartley writes,

A mimesis pattern lies at the heart of NT thought. Any theology or ethics of the NT should make this point foundational, but few do. Just as world culture generally manifests energy via mimetic desire, so life in the kingdom of God, the new creation, is animated and empowered by a mimetic model. The key difference is that the lead Model is the new Adam precisely because he was tempted with the acquisitive mimesis in all ways such as we are but did not yield to that mimetic pattern that generates rivalry and violence. Jesus as faithful Servant of the Lord has opened up for us a new world of hope and potential; we are saved by his transforming our desire then to follow in his steps and be conformed to his image.⁶⁶²

Summary of Argument

Girard makes his primary contribution to the argument of this thesis by linking mimetic desire to the Powers, providing the completion of the imitation-based framework for a new way of approaching leadership theory and practice. The mimetic cycle provides insight into how Satan uses the envious desires of leaders to create chaos and

⁶⁶⁰ Ibid., 222.

⁶⁶¹ Jim Fodor and Willard M. Swartley, "Christian Discipleship as Participative Imitation: Theological Reflections on Girardian Themes," in *Violence Renounces: René Girard, Biblical Studies and Peacemaking* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 2000), 257.

⁶⁶² Swartley, "Discipleship and Imitation of Jesus/Suffering Servant: The Mimesis of New Creation," 239.

scapegoating in a community. A defence for the need to engage Girard on this crucial topic was made, showing that the foundation of his study is based on a broad number of disciplines including the revelation of scripture. It was shown through McKnight that James already made the connection of envious desire, leadership, and the Powers. Thus, both James through McKnight and Peter through Houston confirm these links. McKnight hinted at the similarity of James and I Peter and suggested they may have acted as a catechism 'for leaders, teachers and those aspiring to be as such.'⁶⁶³ Girard's lack of positive mimesis was addressed with the help of Steinmair-Pösel and Swartley. Now this thesis will consider how Girard adds to the imitation-based framework.

Regarding leadership and the Powers, Girard links imitation and desire to the Powers via mimetic desire. By unveiling the mimetic cycle and tying it to Satan, the insidious nature of the Powers' work from the foundation of the world comes into view. Girard gives explanatory power to why Satan is the god of this world, as his cosmic influence through the founding murders is disclosed as the foundation of the culture and institutions built from these cultures. Therefore, when leaders look uncritically to culture and the world for their approach to leadership, they can unknowingly open themselves up to demonic influence. Girard not only ties mimetic desire to the Powers but gives the leader concrete ways to discern if the Powers are at work in their lives. When leaders find themselves concerned about status, prestige, and honour, it ought to alert them to this work of the Powers. When a leader is tempted to scapegoat someone made in the image of God, it ought to alert them to the work of the Powers. When one discerns envious desires in their heart or selfish ambition, it ought to alert them to the work of the Powers in their life and the potential of dissension and chaos that might happen in the congregations they serve. Finally, Girard discloses how Satan uses pride in a leader's life to make them blind to their own envious desires, often concealed by self-justification.

Regarding leadership, Girard's understanding of mimetic desire provides a theoretical framework with practical implications, which will be developed now. In the context of a congregation, if there are emerging leaders who look to the lead pastor as their model, and if the lead pastor desires to hold *the title* of the lead pastor (as opposed to the work of the lead pastor) this poses a threat. If the leader either develops or inherits a structure where they choose not to share this leadership role, this leader becomes a scandal (obstacle, stumbling block) to any who look to them as their model.

⁶⁶³ McKnight, *The Letter of James*, 347.

According to mimetic theory, what happens subconsciously is disciples capture the desire of their model, and they start to desire the title of lead pastor and the prestige that they feel comes from that title. In turn, the lead pastor senses this person desires the title, which increases their desire for the title, eventually leading to mimetic rivalry, often to the bewilderment of those caught in the mimetic trap. Mimetic desire creates antagonists out of the disciple and model, who previously were at peace with one another. As mimetic rivalry increases and scandals develop with other disciples, it can lead to a mimetic crisis, where everyone finds themselves against everyone, all against all, bewildered why this would be the case.

As tension builds in a congregation, where there is much ‘quarrelling and disputes’, as James writes, to the point of a mimetic crisis, there is a need to release the tension. Unknowingly and somewhat haphazardly, someone marginal or a marginalized group becomes the scapegoat. On the other hand, the scapegoat could also be the person at the top, the king, or in this case the lead pastor. Applying Girard’s mimetic leadership to the missional leader has much potential to help leaders recognize the poison of envious desire.

Regarding leadership and positive mimesis, this concept is underdeveloped in Girard. But others who have been influenced by Girard have met this lack. While the leader’s awareness of the Powers working through mimetic desire (negative mimesis) is helpful to alert the leader to the Powers’ work, positive mimesis holds promise for how imitation of Christ, through the power of the Holy Spirit, promotes a flourishing congregation. This was observed through the meta-narrative provided by Steinmair-Pösel and the exegetical work of Swartley.

Having developed a theology of the Powers through Wink and connecting imitation and desire to the Powers through Girard, the concluding work will seek to bring a synthesis. This will be done with some contributions by William Stringfellow, who helps reveal how the principalities and powers misshape the leader at the three contours of leadership – identity, praxis, and telos.

Chapter 5

Missional Leadership Worthy of Imitation

In the attempt to deal with the problem of domineering leadership, this thesis identified the need to develop an imitation-based framework linking missional leadership, mimetic desire, and the Powers. Critical engagement with Walter Wink developed a theology of the Powers, and engagement with Girard tied mimetic desire to the Powers.

In this chapter, William Stringfellow provides a way to apply the framework concretely to missional leadership. The Powers of image, institution, and ideology seek to tempt the leader at the three contours of leadership – identity, praxis, and telos – in order to malform the leader’s desire. Malformed desires can lead to domineering leadership and a mimetic crisis in the congregation. This chapter will conclude with a better alternative, by suggesting a potential agenda for how the missional leader can engage positive mimesis by imitating Christ through the Spirit, reshaping the leader’s desire for the sake of discipleship, community, and mission.

Introducing William Stringfellow

William Stringfellow’s life spans close to six decades (1928-1985), in which he wrote 15 books and scores of theological articles.⁶⁶⁴ His seminal work on the Powers was *Free in Obedience* (1964). It was this book that seeded Wink’s desire to write on the Powers. His most comprehensive and influential work on the Powers was *An Ethic for Christians and Other Aliens in a Strange Land* (1973). In his formal education, he pursued his passion for the gospel and politics. He studied at Bates College, the London School of Economics, and received his law degree from Harvard Law School. While most of his Harvard classmates served the elite in Manhattan, Stringfellow called East Harlem his home (1956-1962) for six years, where he lived in a rat-infested, one-bedroom apartment. As a lawyer, he represented prostitutes, the poor, and those at the margins of society.⁶⁶⁵ Today Stringfellow would be described as an early missional practitioner who understood the importance of incarnational living. He knew that if he were to serve those in the ghetto, he needed to ‘experience the vulnerability of daily

⁶⁶⁴ William Stringfellow, *A Keeper of the Word: Selected Writings of William Stringfellow*, ed. Bill Wylie Kellerman (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., 1996), 3.

⁶⁶⁵ William Stringfellow, *A Simplicity of Faith: My Experience in Mourning* (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2005), 127.

life,' becoming poor to meaningfully connect with the poor.⁶⁶⁶ It was while living in Harlem that Stringfellow came face-to-face with the principalities and powers, which were often the institutions that were supposed to be serving those living in East Harlem. He writes,

In that urban ghetto my daily routine of cases and causes forced me to contend with death institutionalized in authorities, agencies, bureaucracies, and malfarious principalities and powers. Slowly I learned something that folk indigenous to the ghetto know: namely, that the power and purpose of death are incarnated in institutions and structures, procedures, and regimes – Consolidated Edison or the Department of Welfare, the Mafia or the police, the Housing Authority or the social work bureaucracy, the hospital systems or the banks, liberal philanthropy or corporate real estate speculation. In the wisdom of the people of the East Harlem neighbourhood, such principalities are identified as demonic powers because of the relentless and ruthless dehumanization that they cause.⁶⁶⁷

As mentioned earlier, one's social location influences how alert one is to the Powers as well as how much weight one gives them. The Powers became a life message for Stringfellow. Through his desire to live incarnationally in the difficult circumstances in which the majority of the world lives, Stringfellow came to understand that one's view of the 'world' is often based on the point from which they view it. What he had learned academically became empirically verified as he journeyed from Harvard to Harlem. Reflecting on Stringfellow's significant influence, Wink writes,

As I look back over that completed project [The Trilogy on the Powers] and now having read through most of his opus (a few books for the first time), I am able to see how very deeply I owe the strengths of my series on the powers to him and how its weaknesses reveal my failure to take him more seriously. (I also realize how much of his thought I had internalized without giving him sufficient credit).⁶⁶⁸

The Work of the Principalities and Powers

Stringfellow complements, and offers a concrete means by which one may apply the work of Wink and Girard, as his articulation of the principalities and powers correspond to the three contours of leadership. Marva Dawn considers the most difficult work in interpreting the Powers is the need to appropriate the language of the

⁶⁶⁶ William Stringfellow, *My People Is the Enemy: An Autobiographical Polemic*, 1st edition. (New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston, 1964), 53–54.

⁶⁶⁷ William Stringfellow, *Instead of Death: New and Expanded Edition*, New, Expanded edition. (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Pub, 2004), 5.

⁶⁶⁸ Walter Wink, "Stringfellow on the Powers," in *Radical Christian and Exemplary Lawyer*, ed. Andrew W. McThenia Jr. (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock Publishers, 2006), 25–26.

first century into today's vernacular. In her research on the Powers in the work of Jacques Ellul, she writes, 'Probably the most thorough correspondence between the biblical concept of "the principalities and powers" and its experience in contemporary life is articulated in the works of William Stringfellow.'⁶⁶⁹

Stringfellow abbreviates the principalities and powers simply as 'principalities.' Following Stringfellow, this terminology will be employed in this chapter. He thought that an understanding of the principalities had been lost to those inside the church, but better understood by those outside the church. This was confirmed for him when he observed students from the Harvard Business school living 'among the great corporate and commercial principalities...display an awareness, intelligence and insight between principalities and human beings, while the Harvard Divinity students considered the language and reality of such entities as archaic.'⁶⁷⁰ Stringfellow declared, 'Medieval demons are not dead, for demons are indeed the ministers of death. They were not exorcised in the building of the city. They still exist there.'⁶⁷¹

For Stringfellow, the principalities are large in number, and comprehensive in variety. 'According to the Bible, the principalities are legion in species, number, variety, and name.'⁶⁷² The principalities for Stringfellow seem to include all of reality, aside from God, people, and animals. He lists some of the principalities in scripture, which include 'powers, virtues, thrones, authorities, dominions, demons, princes, strongholds, lords, angels, gods, elements, spirits.'⁶⁷³ He also writes of the 'serpent, dragon, lion, beast,' making mention of how the practice of naming principalities such as nations and institutions as animals continues today, 'the bear is Russia, the tiger represents Princeton, the donkey the Democratic Party, the pig the Police.'⁶⁷⁴

Stringfellow lists the many names mentioned in scripture so that there is an understanding of what human beings are up against living in a fallen world. He realized that some may consider these terms old-fashioned, peculiar, or unusual, so he transposed them according to their current realities so that none would miss their significance.

⁶⁶⁹ Marva J. Dawn, "The Concept of 'The Principalities and Powers' in the Works of Jacques Ellul" (PhD diss., University of Notre Dame, 1992), 74.

⁶⁷⁰ Stringfellow, *Free in Obedience*, 50–51.

⁶⁷¹ Ibid., 26.

⁶⁷² William Stringfellow, *An Ethic for Christians and Other Aliens in a Strange Land*, Reprint edition. (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Pub, 2004), 77.

⁶⁷³ Ibid., 78.

⁶⁷⁴ Ibid.

They include all institutions, all ideologies, all images, all movements, all causes, all corporations, all bureaucracies, all traditions, all methods and routines, all conglomerates, all races, all nations, all idols. Thus, the Pentagon or the Ford Motor Company or Harvard University or the Diners Club or the Olympics or the Methodist Church or the Teamsters Union are all principalities. So are capitalism, Maoism, humanism, Mormonism, astrology, the Puritan work ethic, science and scientism, white supremacy, patriotism, plus many, many more – sports, sex, any profession or discipline, technology, money, the family – beyond any prospect of full enumeration. The principalities and powers *are* legion.⁶⁷⁵

As one can see from this list, churches are not immune to the Powers. Dawn has an entire chapter on “Churches Being and Acting as Fallen Powers”.⁶⁷⁶ This was something Wink addressed as well. An important characteristic of the principalities for Stringfellow is that they are independent creatures, not instituted by people, but in the original created order of God, and their vocation is to worship God and serve human beings.⁶⁷⁷ But in their fallen state their purpose has been inverted, so now they seek to be god and possess human beings.⁶⁷⁸ For Stringfellow, those who think they can engage the principalities by human power are under an illusion. For in their fallen state they ‘claim autonomy from God, but in truth they are held captive to the power of death and seek to dehumanize people who are created to exercise dominion over them and all of creation.’⁶⁷⁹ In other words, they become idols.

People must contend with the conflicting claims of the powers, for each one demands ‘loyalty, service and worship.’⁶⁸⁰ Each principality is in competition with the others, engaging in warfare with each other for the loyalty of the people.⁶⁸¹ People in their everyday lives are encircled ‘by a great constellation of principalities,’⁶⁸² be they the principalities of profession, family, or nation.⁶⁸³ When they usurp the place of God and become idols, what was created to be good becomes demonic. Principalities work by making promises that through them people will find truth, meaning, and fulfilment.⁶⁸⁴ When reflecting on the vocational training that takes place in medical

⁶⁷⁵ Ibid.

⁶⁷⁶ Dawn, *Powers, Weakness, and the Tabernacling of God*, 73–122.

⁶⁷⁷ Stringfellow, *Free in Obedience*, 52.

⁶⁷⁸ Stringfellow, *An Ethic for Christians and Other Aliens in a Strange Land*, 82.

⁶⁷⁹ Ibid., 80.

⁶⁸⁰ Stringfellow, *Free in Obedience*, 60.

⁶⁸¹ Ibid., 60–61.

⁶⁸² Ibid., 61.

⁶⁸³ Ibid., 60.

⁶⁸⁴ Ibid., 63–64.

schools, engineering, the military, or his own experience at Harvard Law school, Stringfellow observes the relentless indoctrination that takes place. For example, at Harvard they sought to indoctrinate the students, himself included, to conform ‘quickly and thoroughly to that prevailing stereotype deemed most beneficial to the profession and to its survival as an institution.’⁶⁸⁵ He was astonished to see how eagerly many of his peers completely surrendered to the process, ‘often squelching their own intelligent opinions or creative impulses in order to conform or to appear to be conforming.’⁶⁸⁶ Stringfellow continues, ‘Initiation into the legal profession, as it is playing out at a place like the Harvard Law School, is, as one would expect, elaborately mythologized, asserts an aura of tradition, and retains a reputation for civility. All of these insinuate that this process is benign, though, both empirically and in principle, it is demonic.’⁶⁸⁷ While he respected the intellectual vigour at Harvard, Stringfellow was ‘appalled by the overwhelming subservience of legal education to the commercial powers and the principalities of property.’⁶⁸⁸ He also thought ‘that justice is a suitable topic for consideration in practically every course’ but ‘it was seldom mentioned, and the term itself evoked ridicule, as if justice were a subject beneath the sophistication of lawyers.’⁶⁸⁹ Stringfellow recognized that, as people submit themselves to the principalities, imitating their ways, they become servants of death.

The most decisive clash with the principalities and powers was between Christ and the principalities, both Israel and Rome. ‘The ecclesiastical and civil rulers who accuse, try, condemn, and execute Christ act not essentially for themselves as individuals, but as representatives, indeed, as servants – of the principalities.’⁶⁹⁰ While Stringfellow has many words to describe the principalities and powers in today’s vernacular, the three primary ways he describes them are image, institution, and ideology.

Principalities as Image, Institution, and Ideology

Image is a common principality, for each person is accompanied in their life by an image.⁶⁹¹ Stringfellow gives the example of Marilyn Monroe: there is Marilyn Monroe,

⁶⁸⁵ Stringfellow, *A Simplicity of Faith*, 126.

⁶⁸⁶ Ibid.

⁶⁸⁷ Ibid., 126–127.

⁶⁸⁸ Ibid., 128.

⁶⁸⁹ Ibid.

⁶⁹⁰ Stringfellow, *Free in Obedience*, 49–50.

⁶⁹¹ Ibid., 54.

the person, and Marilyn Monroe, the image. Two distinct identities claiming the same name. While the person of Marilyn Monroe is long dead, the image continues to exist, possibly more alive today than ever. Public image is a principality, in that while it bears one's name, it exists independent of a person. Public image lies beyond one's control, and is in conflict with persons until they fully give themselves over to the image itself.⁶⁹² Image desires full devotion. The principality demands 'that the person of the same name give up his life as a person to the service and homage of the image. And when that surrender is made, the person in fact dies, though not yet physically. For at that point he is literally possessed by his own image.'⁶⁹³

Institutions are principalities as well, for they seek ultimate allegiance. One of the primary ways that people look for meaning in their life is through work, which typically takes place in some kind of institution. But for Stringfellow, the fall is pervasive, and includes all institutions, including the church, which can get caught up with its own fame and fortune. The guiding moral principle of any institution, be it a university, a corporation, a church, or a union, according to Stringfellow, is its own survival. 'Everything else must finally be sacrificed to the cause of preserving the institution, and it is demanded by everyone who lives within the sphere of influence – officers, executives, employees, members, customers, and students – that they commit themselves to the service of that end, the survival of the institution.'⁶⁹⁴ When the institution exists for itself, it seeks all who are in its domain to surrender their lives so that the institution lives on. While promising benefits, it is ultimately an invitation to bondage.⁶⁹⁵ Dawn sees this dynamic in pastors who often focus more on comparing how many people come to their meetings as opposed to seeking justice for the poor. She writes, 'Both the concern for "church growth" and the concern for survival (which sometimes are the same thing) lead to many of the tactics of fallen powers, such as competition, the overwhelming pressures on church leaders to be successful, reduction of the gospel for the sake of marketing and so forth.'⁶⁹⁶ When a church or any institution gets into survival mode, and the desire for security in their own power, they are more likely to imitate the Powers, instead of having faith and patience in God's promises (Heb. 6:12).

⁶⁹² Ibid., 55.

⁶⁹³ Ibid.

⁶⁹⁴ Ibid., 56.

⁶⁹⁵ Ibid., 57.

⁶⁹⁶ Dawn, *Powers, Weakness, and the Tabernacling of God*, 75.

Probably the most recognized principality today is that of ideology, though most do not realize how ideology enslaves them. Ideologies are the countless ‘-isms’ that seek to take people, especially leaders, captive. While it seems obvious to many that communism, fascism, racism, and nationalism are ideological principalities and powers that dehumanize people, it is less likely, in Stringfellow’s opinion, for Americans to recognize humanism, capitalism, rationalism, and democracy as powers.⁶⁹⁷ But all ideologies are principalities, for they each have common characteristics, namely they have absolutized themselves and demand from the individual and society unconditional loyalty.

Ideologies have their own accounts of sin and redemption. For example, ‘Marxism asserts that it reveals and upholds the secret of history: that the destiny (literally, salvation) of all men and all nations is to be found and fulfilled in the ascendancy and dominion of Marxism in the world.’⁶⁹⁸ Like every principality, ideologies claim sovereignty. They give a sense of meaning and significance to each person; in the case of Marxism, it ‘requires of men, institutions and nation an unequivocal and militant obeisance, a sacrifice of all other supposedly lesser causes and rights to the idol of Marxism.’⁶⁹⁹

Stringfellow goes on to point out how Americans are persistently and perpetually assailed with the idea that their ultimate significance ‘depends upon the mere survival of the American nation and its “way of life.”’⁷⁰⁰ Hence, survival of the nation becomes ultimate and worthy of devotion, service, loyalty, and if need be, physical sacrifice. ‘The pre-eminent factor in terms of which, it is claimed, men will find their own justification is in service to the nation, in the offering of all other things for the sake of national survival.’⁷⁰¹ Ultimately, service and devotion to the principalities and powers is service to the god of this age; it results in bondage to idolatry and dehumanization.

It is important to realize that, for Stringfellow, the principalities of image, institution, and ideology often share characteristics of each other, so they shouldn’t be sharply distinguished. For example, there is Hitler the person and the image, but there are some aspects of ideology and institution bound up in his name. In the same way,

⁶⁹⁷ Stringfellow, *Free in Obedience*, 57.

⁶⁹⁸ Ibid.

⁶⁹⁹ Ibid.

⁷⁰⁰ Ibid., 58.

⁷⁰¹ Ibid.

nations as institutional powers tend to be combined with ideological principalities, like America with capitalism and democracy or Russia and China with communism.

The principalities that Stringfellow has articulated correlate with the three contours of leadership, as seen in table 2. The principality of *image* relates to *identity*, the principality of *institution* relates to the *praxis* of the leader, the principality of *ideology* relates to the *telos* of the leader, all of which align with their ultimate desires. Just as Stringfellow mentions that these principalities are interconnected and shouldn't be sharply distinguished, the identity, praxis, and telos of the leader also overlap and interconnect.

Table 2. The Contours of Leadership and the Principalities

Contours of Missional Leadership	The Principalities and Powers
Identity	Image
Praxis	Institution
Telos	Ideology

Through Stringfellow a clarity develops in precisely how the Powers seek to hold the missional leader captive in the contours of leadership. It is now necessary to provide a synthesis of Wink, Girard, and Stringfellow, tracing the development of the imitation-based framework, reflecting on its significance.

Reflecting on the Imitation-based Framework

Through study of the missional conversation it became evident that there is a need for an approach to leadership theory and practice that links missional leadership, mimetic desire, and the Powers. The expectation was that this imitation-based framework would address the problem of domineering leadership more robustly. As missional leaders and those they train understand this framework, the hope was that they will be better equipped to develop a spirituality that reshapes their desires toward God, his kingdom, and his righteousness. The central question of this thesis is: How might a theology of powers help missional leaders to practice a spirituality which reshapes their desires for the sake of discipleship, community, and mission? Before moving to suggested leadership practices, here is a summary of the ground covered thus far.

In chapter one, the development of missional theology demonstrated the need for missional leadership. Van Gelder called attention to the missionary nature of God and the church, speaking to the importance of *identity* and how the scriptures and reign

of God illustrate the narrative arc of scripture from creation to new creation – the telos. Roxburgh spoke to the centrality of the identity of the leader and the importance of the telos of God and new creation in guiding the leaders work, or praxis. From these authors the contours of leadership emerged. The importance of plurality in both leadership and gifting continues to be an important development in missional leadership. This is significant because, as Girard demonstrated, when a model desires something that either can't or won't be shared, there is a greater chance of mimetic rivalry, which can devolve into the mimetic cycle.

In chapter two, when reviewing Houston's work on I Peter dealing with domineering leadership, the imitation-based conceptual framework for this thesis emerged. Houston gave this thesis the three dimensions in which imitation can take place with the leader, who the leader imitates – the world or Jesus, and who imitates the leader as their model. This aligned with Girard's mimetic theory in chapter four, where it was discovered that, in the ultimate sense, there are two arch models for the leaders: Satan and Jesus. When leaders uncritically mimic leadership principles from the world (as estranged from God), or when they look to the wrong model, they can fall into the mimetic trap of Satan, and come under what Wink calls the Domination System, where their praxis inevitably becomes domineering, as they mimic the Powers, leading to the scandal of leadership. The scandal of leadership takes place when the leader, often unknowingly, scandalizes those who look to the leader as a model. If their desires are malformed, and they desire *to be* the lead pastor, those who look to them will find themselves with this desire as well. This leads to rivalry, where the leader becomes a scandal (obstacle) to the disciple getting what he or she desires, resulting in chaos and scapegoating.

James K.A. Smith draws attention to the centrality of desire, making a case that the desires of the leader are the most significant thing about them, following in the path of Augustine. The centrality of desire is not only prominent in Girard but is the foundation of his work and tied to the theme of imitation. The importance of desire, and how envious desire and selfish ambition are the source of disorder and every evil practice, was seen in McKnight's exegetical study of the letter of James in chapter four. McKnight put forth a comparison of James and I Peter, as did Houston, demonstrating the tie of mimetic desire to Satan.

In chapter three, through Wink's life and work, it was discovered that his desire to achieve in his early life was based on his desire to be loved and accepted, signalling the danger of leaders seeking to accomplish *for* love, instead of *from* being loved. Henri

Nouwen, reflecting on Jesus being able to successfully face the temptations of the devil in the desert, emphasized that Jesus's identity was grounded in his Father's words, that he was his beloved son. Wink demonstrated, through his life, the importance of knowing and imitating Jesus, showing how it would be difficult to live humanly in a world dominated by the Powers apart from Jesus's example. He noticed that people, in their desire to eliminate evil, are likely to mimic the very evil they seek to eliminate. Wink stressed the importance of imitating the practice of Christ in non-violent direct action. His desire to seek first God, his kingdom, and his righteousness, led him to be a kingdom activist. He named and unmasked racism in South Africa fruitfully, taking a peace-making approach to engaging the Powers. Stringfellow, in his corpus, named and unmasked racism and nationalism in America, providing Wink motivation for his entire project.

Through Girard, the concept of mimetic desire was developed, linking imitation and desire to the Powers. Humans are imitative by nature. The question is what power is the leader imitating, the Powers or Christ, for this will determine their desires and subsequent praxis. Stringfellow pointed out that when a church or organization is in survival mode, a yellow flag for leaders, it is more likely to imitate the Powers. While Girard developed mimetic desire, he left positive mimesis relatively undeveloped. But those who have been shaped by his life and his writings have made significant contributions to this area of study. Steinmair-Pösel demonstrates the potential of positive mimesis from the narrative arc of creation, the Fall, and Christ. On this trajectory, through the grace of Christ, an undistorted view of God is available, which makes possible a new experience of God and a new form of relationship as people participate in the divine life. When the Eucharist is celebrated as a place of receiving and thanksgiving, positive mimesis is possible, though because of the Powers manifest through human institutions, it is likely to be realized provisionally. Swartley made a strong case for how major strands of the New Testament are directed at the transformation of desire through good models who were following Christ, which enables a positive mimesis to take place, as with the Thessalonians. They followed Paul, Timothy, and Silvanus, and became positive models themselves to believers in Macedonia and Achaia (I Thess. 1:6-7). Swartley also demonstrated the transformational nature of Jesus's teaching on discipleship and the early churches development of *imitatio Christi*. He emphasized that many imitation passages relate to leading a cruciform life, where believers participated in the suffering of Christ as they sought to overcome evil with good, rather than mimicking the ways of the world. This

aligns with Wink's overall project in *Engaging the Powers*, where he outlines an approach to mission that engages evil without 'creating new evils and being made evil ourselves.'⁷⁰²

Regarding the Powers, Newbigin illustrated the pervasiveness of the Powers in the New Testament; something also found in the work of Arnold and Berkhof. In critical engagement with Wink, this thesis developed a theology of the Powers showing how they work from personal, social, and cosmic perspectives. The necessity to name, unmask, and engage the invisible forces that determine human existence was established. This was further developed with Stringfellow, where this thesis named and applied his understanding of image, institution, and ideology to the three contours of leadership. Wink's explanation of the outer personal, collective, and inner personal demonic provided unique remedies. He also helped to identify the Domination System, as 'an entire network of Powers becoming integrated around idolatrous values' and considers Satan the spirit of the Domination System.⁷⁰³ For Wink the most believed myth in contemporary American culture is the myth of redemptive violence, which is nationalism becoming absolute. Stringfellow named, unmasked, and engaged nationalism as well, offering practical help through his understanding of how institutions and ideology work. Wink's definition of the world provided the nuance necessary to understand both its positive (relating to people and creation) and negative (referring 'to the *human sociological realms that exist in estrangement from God*.'⁷⁰⁴) dimensions in scripture. This would include the principalities and powers in their fallen state. Creatures large and small seek to misshape the desires of leaders. Thus, Stringfellow speaks of the ubiquity of the fall. Girard's understanding of culture, too, reflects the pervasiveness of the fall. For Girard, culture has been fully enveloped in the mimetic cycle until Christ, thus Satan is referred to as the god of this world. For he was a murderer from the beginning, from Cain and Abel, through the prophets, until Jesus, who fully revealed what was hidden from the foundation of the world. Jesus becoming the willing scapegoat, and his innocence, justified through the Resurrection, signalled the fall of Satan. The mimetic cycle was now revealed and Satan's work laid bare.

For Wink, this *aion* refers to the present Domination Epoch, while *sarx*, flesh, could be positive or negative depending on context. In its negative form, living life 'according to the flesh' 'denotes the self externalized and subjugated to the opinion of

⁷⁰² Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 3.

⁷⁰³ Ibid., 8.

⁷⁰⁴ Ibid., 51.

others.⁷⁰⁵ Girard identifies this as mimetic desire. The negative side of *sarx* can also be described as the alienated self, the self that is socialized within the Domination System and Age, the self that is not centred in God. This would be in line with Stringfellow's articulation of 'image'. Therefore, it is suggested that leaders find their identity in God.

Wink, following Berkhof, characterizes the Powers as being created good, falling, and in need of redemption. This thesis took the point of view that, when considering the Powers in relation to Satan and the demonic, their telos is destruction, in that the God of peace will crush Satan (the cosmic body of sin) under the feet of the church. But the telos of the principalities and powers is redemption in new creation. Wink's word study in Col. 1:16 suggests that while the principalities are in their fallen state and are susceptible to the demonic and under the cosmic power of Satan, it seems these social realities have a path to redemption. Girard distinguished between Satan and the principalities and powers. For Girard, when the principalities and powers (which are redeemable) find their source of authority in false transcendence, which is the mimetic cycle, they become demonic. This would also be true for churches as institutions, or denominations as institutions. The fact that the church is founded on a different kind of murder, one which reveals the false transcendence of the mimetic cycle should prove helpful. But, like Israel, the church is susceptible to imitate the institutions around it instead of Christ. Thus, personal and social transformation are critical for Wink, Girard, and Stringfellow.

Considering Wink's and Girard's work, missional leaders rest their authority and power on false transcendence *when* they live under the sway of the Domination System and mimic its ways. In the context of James this evil is called satanic and demonic; in the context of I Peter it is revealed as satanic. The remedy for leaders and churches that have opened themselves up to the demonic was clarified by McKnight's study of James. Leaders must humble themselves, submit themselves to God, and resist the devil. When dealing with the demonic, repentance is to be drastic and complete. Thus, leaders are called to repentance and need to cleanse their hands, purify their hearts, lament, mourn, weep, and ultimately humble themselves. For God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble. In James, God is also the God of grace, giving leaders the opportunity to humble themselves by repenting of the wrong desires that wreak havoc in the church.

⁷⁰⁵ Wink, *Engaging the Powers*, 51–52.

The imitation-based framework that this thesis has developed could be a resource for missional leaders who desire to develop a catechism for leaders today. In sum, this study has established links between missional leadership, mimetic desire, and a theology of the Powers. The scandal of ‘fallen’ leadership happens when leaders get caught in the mimetic trap.

The Scandal of Leadership

This imitation-based conceptual framework provides a robust diagnosis to the problem of domineering (fallen) leadership. The subtle work of the Powers misshapes the desires of the leader; thus, leaders start to imitate the Powers instead of Christ. For example, when the missional leader becomes possessed by the principality of image, the leaders fall to egotism and become self-centred. The malformed desires of the leader not only lead to a domineering praxis, but also creates chaos in the church. For those who look to the missional leader as a model will mimic the leader’s desires subconsciously. Therefore, if a leader is possessed by his or her image as opposed to bearing the image of God, they can become an obstacle (scandal) to their disciples. If scandals multiply, like McKnight described in James, havoc and dissention befall the church. The doxology of the Lord’s prayer reveals one of the primary ways in which Satan seeks to subvert the missional leader. Traditionally, what comes directly after ‘deliver us from the evil one’ is: ‘for thine is the kingdom, power, and glory forever, Amen.’ The scandal of leadership describes the common characteristics of the fallen leaders examined at the start of this thesis. It occurs when leaders seek to build their kingdom, by their own power, for their own glory.

If missional leaders seek to make a name for themselves (their own glory), if they seek first their reputation, or they seek first the growth of their church instead of seeking first the kingdom, the door has been opened for Satan to work through the mimetic cycle. The mimetic cycle leads to scandals, division, and scapegoating in the congregation as described by Girard and McKnight. The desire for recognition, for titles, and for the applause of people are desires Jesus warned against because he understood how mimetic desire worked. Prohibitions are enacted to try and guard people from experiencing life in the underground, and falling into the mimetic trap. Life in the underground, as Girard describes it, is ruled by pride. Pride conceals and blinds leaders to malformed desires, but they are revealed through dissention in the congregation. Dissention can take place through other rivalries as well. But the

hoarding of power via titles tends to produce the fruit of the underground: infighting, dissention, chaos, and scapegoating.

Image speaks to one's identity. Being possessed by one's image is egotism. It is the false self. It is living in estrangement from God, the negative view of *sarx* that Wink names. It can ultimately lead to leaders wanting to play God in other people's lives. The temptation in the garden was to be like God. If leaders are out for their own gain, if a leader is driven to produce for the sake of their image, and if a leader is riddled with selfish ambition and envious desire, it indicates that this leader has been completely possessed by their image. Living in the day of selfies and online personas intensifies this battle. The principality of image demands that a person give up his or her identity as an image bearer, and fully surrender to the principality of image, which is idolatry.

Stringfellow also describes the principality of *ideology*, which speaks to the *telos* of the leader. Leaders can either seek first God's kingdom, or seek to build their own. David Koyzis, in his book *Political Visions & Illusions*, makes the case that ideology is idolatry because ideologies tend to have their own accounts of sin and redemption. As Goudzwaard puts it, 'The mature ideology is a false revelation of creation, fall and redemption.'⁷⁰⁶ Not only do they have their own soteriology, but they have their own eschatology, their own *telos*, be it capitalism, liberalism, nationalism, or communism.⁷⁰⁷ Like any idol, every ideology seeks ultimate allegiance and promises to save people from some real or perceived evil. The cosmic body of sin represented by the world estranged from God, and the liar and the father of lies, doesn't simply seek to infect people with ideologies one by one, but he likes to work at a cosmic level, where he takes captive the collective mind of nations and complete people groups. Thus, some who identify as Christians in America today get caught up in nationalism, or even white nationalism and heed the chants of 'America first.' The subtlety of how the principality of ideology works is mischievous. Often, without recognising it, the missional leader can be taken captive by the ideology of nationalism, and because the principality of ideology demands all, the leader will begin to put citizenship of country before discipleship to Christ when the ideology becomes an idol. The kingdom of God can get subsumed into nationalism.

⁷⁰⁶ Bob Goudzwaard, *Idols of Our Time* (Sioux Center, IA: Dordt College Press, 1989), 25.

⁷⁰⁷ David T. Koyzis, *Political Visions & Illusions: A Survey & Christian Critique of Contemporary Ideologies*, 2nd edition. (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2019), 16.

Stringfellow talks about the demonic tactics of the principalities and powers. The first is the denial of truth.⁷⁰⁸ ‘The truth is usurped and displaced by a self-serving version of events or fact, with whatever selectivity, diversion, falsehood, manipulation, exaggeration, evasion, concoction necessary to maintain the image, or enhance the survival... of the principality.’⁷⁰⁹ The tactics of the demonic powers tend to be verbal – babel – representing Babylon, seeking to reshape the mind and human consciousness.⁷¹⁰ Doublespeak and overtalk are common ways the principalities subvert the truth with propaganda. ‘These include heavy euphemism and coded phrases, the inversion of definitions, jargon, hyperbole, misnomer, slogan, argot, shibboleth, cliché.’⁷¹¹ ‘War is peace’ is Orwell’s classic. Overtalk is when the ‘volume, speed, and redundancy’ of doublespeak is communicated with such regularity that it incapacitates the hearers.⁷¹² When spoken repeatedly, the doubletalk and overspeak are believed.

One of the ways Girard helps leaders to recognize an ideology is that every ideology has a scapegoat – someone who can be blamed and cast out of the collective whole in order to regain equilibrium. For Freud, it was the father and the law. For Marx, the bourgeoisie and the capitalist. For Nietzsche, it was slave morality.⁷¹³ Ideology scapegoats others and doesn’t allow for reconciliation. The founding murder of America was intertwined with the principality of racism, which is an ideology influencing the collective mind of the nation by the cosmic body of sin. It has manifest itself structurally in many principalities, to the point that, in the words of Eduardo Bonilla-Silva, racism now exists without racists.⁷¹⁴

If a missional leader is captivated by ideologies, it can create divisions in the church. If others look to the leader as a model, they will tend to imitate the leader’s malformed desires, to the point that churches start to scapegoat ‘the other’ and segregate by ideology instead of being the one new humanity for whom Christ’s death made possible. While some Christians in America seem captivated by nationalism and

⁷⁰⁸ Stringfellow, *An Ethic for Christians and Other Aliens in a Strange Land*, 98.

⁷⁰⁹ Ibid.

⁷¹⁰ Ibid.

⁷¹¹ Ibid., 100.

⁷¹² Ibid., 101.

⁷¹³ Girard, Oughourlian, and Lefort, *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World*, 286–287.

⁷¹⁴ Eduardo Bonilla-Silva, *Racism without Racists: Color-Blind Racism and the Persistence of Racial Inequality in America*, Fifth edition. (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2017).

conservatism, progressive liberalism mirrors these actions and in turn scapegoats those who are captive to conservatism. If churches become captive to ideologies, the church simply starts to mimic the world, and thus, no longer remains a faithful witness to God's kingdom. But when the kingdom of God is the telos of the church, there is room for everyone at the table: Jew and Greek, slave and free, male and female, *conservative* and *progressive*. (Gal. 3:36).

Andy Crouch makes the case that ideology always leads to injustice. He observes that when the first section of the Decalogue is violated, resulting in idolatry, it leads to injustice which is represented by the second half of the Decalogue.⁷¹⁵ Crouch observes that both the first commandment and the last commandment start with matters of the heart. 'You shall have no other Gods before me' comes before the tangible command about graven images. Do not desire or long for your neighbour's... comes before the tangible commands of do not steal or do not murder. The first commandment addresses the desire that leads to idolatry, while the final one addresses desires dealing with injustice.⁷¹⁶ They represent the twin sins, which God hates, and against which the prophets persistently warned the Hebrews.⁷¹⁷ Crouch writes, 'both idolatry and injustice, ultimately are about what we love and long to become. Power at its worst and best is a matter of the heart.'⁷¹⁸

If a missional leader is either possessed by their *image* or captivated by an *ideology*, it inevitably leads to the abuse of power in their *praxis*. For the missional leader's identity and *telos* invariably shape their methodology. For example, if a leader is possessed by his or her image, as opposed to living out their vocation as an image bearer, they are engaged in idolatry. This can happen to a leader unknowingly. Regarding the Great Commandment (Matt. 22:37-40), when the first commandment to love God with all one's heart is violated, it naturally leads to violating the second commandment, which is like the first. So instead of leaders using power for the benefit of others, they tend to use it for their own gain, which Peter warns against. Therefore, it is vital for the missional leader to engage in practices that ground their identity in God. Satan doesn't only work through ideologies like nationalism. One of the more shrewd ways he operates is when the church becomes the telos of the leader, as opposed to the

⁷¹⁵ Andy Crouch, *Playing God: Redeeming the Gift of Power* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2013), 115–121.

⁷¹⁶ Ibid., 121.

⁷¹⁷ Ibid., 71.

⁷¹⁸ Ibid., 121.

kingdom of God. While it is appropriate to have concern for the church that one is serving, the church can also become an idol, just like the family can become an idol, and work can become an idol. Idolatry is simply when something good becomes ultimate. This relates to what both Stringfellow and Dawn address when they speak about institutions seeking their own survival, thus becoming demonic. And as demonstrated, idolatry leads to injustice. The abuse of power is a symptom of a deeper problem, idolatry.

Following the Scandalous Way of Jesus

While the Powers persistently seek to subvert the missional leader by misshaping his or her desires in a way that creates scandals in the church, the scandal of leadership can become ‘scandalous’ in a positive way, when a leader opts to imitate Christ in the kenotic way of the cross instead of imitating the ways of the world (Phil. 2: 1-8). This way of leadership is scandalous to some, and for others feels foolish, in the same way the cross was a scandal to the Jew and foolishness to the Greeks. In *The Day the Revolution Began*, N.T. Wright examines the significance of the cross. He says that through the cross of Christ a new power entered the world, one that overcame the Powers. It was the power of suffering love. He makes the case that mission needs to take place in a cruciform way, saying, ‘at the center of any account of Christian mission: *the victory of the cross will be implemented through the means of the cross.*’⁷¹⁹ Yet to those who only know how to lord over others, which is the kind of leadership that ‘gets things done in the real world’, this might seem like foolishness. The Powers persistently, forcefully, and sometimes violently come after the leader, so that the leader might imitate their ways. But the good news is that through the life, death, and resurrection of Christ, the Powers have been exposed, unmasked, and disarmed. They only have as much power as one gives them.

What this thesis is suggesting is that every human being, including missional leaders, are held captive to imitation. Not to imitate is not an option. Missional leaders who know Christ have a choice of who they will imitate. But it should be noted that not to imitate Christ is to imitate the Powers. When leaders imitate the Powers, and their desires are misshapen, they engage in domineering leadership. Thus, the ultimate battle that missional leaders face is the spiritual battle for the heart, soul, and desires of missional leaders, as was seen in the introduction figure 2.

⁷¹⁹ Wright, *The Day the Revolution Began*, 366.

The battle could be summarized by defining fallen and redeemed leadership. Fallen leadership imitates the principalities in submission to Satan, which is bondage to idolatry and leads to dishonouring God and dehumanization. Redeemed leadership imitates Jesus in submission to his Father, which is freedom from idolatry and leads to honouring God and human flourishing. The objective of this thesis was to diagnose the fall of leaders to domineering leadership. The imitation-based framework emerged through a study of I Peter, a framework that was able to give a deeper diagnosis to the problem of domineering leadership by connecting missional leadership to the Powers via mimetic desire (figure 1). The issue is who will the leader imitate? While the contrast between imitating the Powers or imitating Christ has been made throughout this thesis, it has not yet developed the practice of positive mimesis in a detailed way, exploring what can happen when positive mimesis takes hold of a leader and a congregation. While this would take another thesis in itself, it seems appropriate to close with some suggestions on what a catechesis for leaders and upcoming leaders might look like, suggestions that move toward redeemed leadership (figure 2).

If a missional leader is caught in the mimetic trap, it is important to realize that this is a spiritual battle that requires resistance and full repentance, the kind that James writes about. For the problem is not simply abuse of power, but idolatry. If idolatry is the deeper issue, then the heart of the solution is the formation of the leader's identity and life in God. For when a leader loves God with all their heart, soul, strength, and mind, he or she is likely to love the other as themselves. The leader's praxis would reflect imitation of Christ in the power of the Spirit, leading to a suffering love, rather than a praxis that reflects imitation of the Powers and domineering leadership. Historically, missional theology focused on equipping missional leaders theologically, but Van Gelder and Zscheile unintentionally minimized the spirituality of the leader. It was suggested that the spirituality of the leader is better located as the soil for the missional tree as opposed to one of the branches. When leaders are caught up with a Holy love of God, they not only love God with their whole mind, but with all of their being. As Smith indicated, information without formation of desires doesn't address the heart of the problem. When John the Seer wrote to the church in Ephesus, they were regarded as a church that worked hard, persevered in mission, and discerned between true and false apostles. But the issues that threatened their witness and endangered the removal of their lampstand was losing their first love (Rev. 2:1-7). The leader who is worthy of imitation is one who is willing to face the spiritual battle for their heart and

soul and come to recognize that their identity and heart is formed by life in God, rather than by imitating the Powers.

Leadership Worthy of Imitation

Because of the similarities between James and 1 Peter, McKnight suggested they may have served as an early catechism for the development of teachers and leaders. These passages speak to the spiritual battle with Satan/devil. John, in his first letter, presupposes that the path to maturity involves understanding how to overcome the evil one. He writes, ‘I am writing to you, dear children, because your sins have been forgiven on account of his name. I am writing to you, fathers, because you know him who is from the beginning. I am writing to you, young men, because you have overcome the evil one’ (1 John 2: 12-13 NIV). If those young in faith needed to understand how to overcome the evil one, it would certainly seem important for those who are in a position of leading and teaching. When Paul writes to Timothy he advises on the danger of making new converts into leaders too quickly; it could make them proud and cause them to fall into the condemnation of the devil (1 Tim. 3:6). Paul also gives instructions to Timothy regarding deacons, noting that they must first be tested (1 Tim. 3:10).

The majority of this thesis sought to help the leader name and unmask how the Powers are at work in the leader’s life, for when one has an awareness of the laws that govern the ways the Powers work, they are motivated to find a remedy. This section will speak to the remedy. This agenda offers insight into solidifying one’s identity in God’s love, developing good desires, engaging a legitimate use of power, and living into a kenotic spirituality.⁷²⁰ As leaders live in God, their life in God motivates resistance to the Powers. Leaders then imitate a form of power reshaped by holy love.

This section will speak to the contours of leadership – identity, praxis, and *telos*. While all three concepts interrelate, in this section, the work of identity formation will be explored through the lens of Christ’s identity-formation as illustrated in his baptism and subsequent temptation. This will be done with the true *telos* of life in God in mind.

⁷²⁰ Michael J. Gorman, *Cruciformity: Paul’s Narrative Spirituality of the Cross* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2001); Smith, *Desiring the Kingdom*; Henri Nouwen, *The Selfless Way of Christ: Downward Mobility and the Spiritual Life* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2011); Nouwen, *You Are the Beloved*; Philip D. Kenneson, *Life on the Vine: Cultivating the Fruit of the Spirit* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 1999); Fitch, *Faithful Presence*. Henri Nouwen, *The Way of the Heart: Connecting with God Through Prayer, Wisdom, and Silence*, Revised. (New York: Ballantine Books, 2003).

Identity formation is how a leader overcomes the principality of image. Next, the development of healthy desire will be explored through the concept of biography as theology. This will be followed by suggesting a proper praxis of power. Finally, kenotic spirituality will be minimally engaged, recognizing that missional leaders who live in God will find their desires reshaped such that they desire to enter the kenotic life of Christ, becoming leaders worth imitating.

Identity Formation of the Missional Leader

The first need to address is the formation of the identity of the leader. Reflecting upon fallen leaders at the start of this thesis, the common characteristics of fallen leadership involved seeking status, a sense of self-importance, using status to push an agenda, and pride, all of which led to manipulation and the abuse of their power and role. These missional leaders fell to the principalities and powers. Missional leaders can be tempted to find their meaning, significance, and worth through the principalities and powers of image, institution, and ideology, each of which demands ultimate allegiance. But as Stringfellow reminds us, when human beings seek to justify themselves and offer themselves up to their chosen idols they end up in bondage to death. ‘When a principality claims moral pre-eminence in history over a man’s life it represents an aspiration for salvation from death and a hope that service to the idol will give existence a meaning somehow transcending death.’⁷²¹ The scriptures and the creeds tell us that Jesus was fully God and fully human. Susan Garrett reminds us that ‘The first Christians remembered Jesus as one who had faced and endured temptation.’⁷²² As the writer of Hebrews says, ‘For we do not have a high priest who is unable to empathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who has been tempted in every way, just as we are – yet he did not sin’ (Heb. 4:15). Dietrich Bonhoeffer considered the temptations of Jesus as a way to live into the line of the Lord’s prayer: ‘Lead us not into temptation’ (Matt. 6:13). He writes, ‘He who taught the disciples to pray in this way was Jesus Christ, who alone must have known what temptation was. And because he knew he wanted his disciples to pray “Lead us not into temptation.” From the point of view of

⁷²¹ Stringfellow, *Free in Obedience*, 64.

⁷²² Susan R. Garrett, *The Temptations of Jesus in Mark’s Gospel* (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., 1996), 1.

the temptation of Jesus Christ alone can we understand the meaning of temptation for us.⁷²³

Each of the three synoptic gospels mention the temptation of Jesus in the wilderness. It was after the Spirit descended on Jesus at baptism and the voice from heaven said, ‘You are my beloved Son; with you I am well pleased’ (Mk 1:11 ESV), that ‘The Spirit immediately drove him out into the wilderness’ (Mk 1:12 ESV) to be tempted. Greek scholar Gerald Hawthorne mentions the word *drove* ‘indicates at least that the Spirit of God directed Jesus to alter whatever plans he might otherwise have had and to go to this particular place.’⁷²⁴ It is unclear how the Spirit led him to the wilderness, ‘whether by some ecstatic experience... or by a quiet, but strong inner conviction is not stated. But what is stated is that when the Spirit indicated to Jesus that the acceptance of his Servant vocation must lead him into the wilderness, he surrendered his own plans and followed the Spirit’s promptings.’⁷²⁵ The temptation of Jesus is significant. The nature of the temptations is particularly instructive. It is important to note that not only was he led into the wilderness by the Spirit, but ‘Jesus returned to Galilee in the power of the Spirit’ (Lk 4:14 NIV). Before Jesus embarked on his mission, he faced Satan and his temptations with the help of the Spirit. He did not attempt his ministry apart from the power of the Spirit. Hawthorne writes, after reflecting on each of the synoptic gospels,

It is impossible to escape the conclusion that these Gospel writers want their readers to understand that Jesus met and conquered the usurping enemy of God not by his own power alone but aided in his victory by the power of the Holy Spirit. He was fortified in his determination to obey the Father by the strengthening force of the Spirit within him. And it is this same strength that Jesus was able to go forth into Galilee “and to commence a task which include[d] the release of the devil’s captives ([Luke] 4:18;cf. 13:6). Thus at the outset of his ministry Jesus is depicted as overcoming the evil one who stands in opposition to the work of the Kingdom of God ([Luke] 11:19,20)” through the all-sufficient energizing power of the Spirit of God.⁷²⁶

It is important to note that Jesus moved forward in the power of the Spirit with his identity being situated in the Father’s love. As Roxburgh noted earlier, the foundation of missional leadership is the self-identity of the leader. Upon this

⁷²³ Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *Creation and Fall Temptation: Two Biblical Studies*, Reprint edition. (New York: Touchstone, 1997), 115.

⁷²⁴ Gerald F. Hawthorne, *The Presence and The Power: The Significance of the Holy Spirit in the Life and Ministry of Jesus* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Pub, 2003), 137.

⁷²⁵ Ibid., 138.

⁷²⁶ Ibid., 139.

foundation, the ministry stands or falls. The identity of the leader is at the centre of the spiritual battle.

Reflecting on the significance of the story of Jesus's baptism and temptation, is important for a leader's own identity formation, which may be why each of the synoptic gospels mention this event in the life of Jesus. In the conclusion of her study of Mark, Garrett writes, 'Mark emphasizes that followers of Jesus must expect to undergo times of testing. Moreover, for us, as for Christ, the tests will be *real*: the spirit will lead us into the wilderness, into solitude, into abandonment.'⁷²⁷ Helping leaders develop an acute awareness that there is a spiritual battle for their hearts and desires is imperative, as Jesus' trials are archetypal for those who desire to serve as leaders in God's church.

When the devil tempted Jesus in the wilderness, he began his questions with 'If you are the Son of God.' Luke's version ends the devil's questions with 'If you are the Son of God'. This indicates, for both Ellul and Nouwen, that at the core of these temptations lies the issue of *identity*. The battle is for the heart and identity of the leader. It seems that Jesus, in his humanity, needed to develop a sense of self like every other human being. And one's sense of self, according to mimetic theory, is developed through 'the other.' For Jesus, the other was the Father. In responding to healing on Sabbath, Jesus says, 'Very truly I tell you, the Son can do nothing by himself; he can do only what he sees his Father doing, because whatever the Father does the Son also does' (Jn 5:19 NIV). Upon reading this, the modern self, believing itself not to be shaped by others, would object, saying, 'Where is Jesus' creativity? He seems so robotic.' The modern self-made person wonders: Why simply mimic the Father?

If mimetic desire is true, the desires of the leader are borrowed from the leader's models. This would be true for Jesus in his humanity as well. Girard uses the term inter-dividuality to explain the idea that people find themselves in the other. Jesus describes this when he says, 'Believe me when I say that I am in the Father and the Father is in me' (Jn 14:11 NIV). It seems that the key to defeating the Powers for Jesus was mimicking the Father with dependence on the Spirit. As Jesus desired the Father and received the full love and acceptance of the Father, it created in him a desire to respond in love and loyalty to his Father. As he lived in the Word and the Word lived in him, his desire for the Father and his ways enabled him to resist Satan in the

⁷²⁷ Garrett, *The Temptations of Jesus in Mark's Gospel*, 177.

wilderness. All the while, his relationship with the Spirit was manifesting in strength; as Jesus moved forward in ministry, he did so with the Spirit's power.

The struggle of humanity to find identity outside of God results in people finding their identities created by 'the other' or groups of others who are often caught in the mimetic trap of the false sacred. People develop a false self, built on a sense of belonging that tends to exclude or scapegoat another. But the new self, as Cowdell reminds us, is a gift which emerges through a process 'of conversion away from the desires of others toward the desire of Christ – the ultimate other – so the self is created by the influence of his self.'⁷²⁸ When the leader is apprehended and captivated by the love and acceptance of God, this new self is constituted by the loving, self-giving, divine one, who now lives within (Gal. 2:20). As the leader regularly communes with the Father, Son, and Spirit, and as the leader's heart and desires are captured by this unending dance of mutual love and joy in the divine, it overflows into the life of the community. As the leader communes with God, they receive the mind of Christ and prioritize others above themselves (Phil. 2:3-4). As the disciple looks to the leader as their model, the leader serves as a mediator for the disciple's desires and sense of self. As the disciple's desires and sense of self come into being through that mediation, reflecting the inter-dividuality of humanity, the leader's sense of self is subsequently shaped and built through this relationship. The sense of self and the desires of the leader are created in the disciple, and the sense of self and desires of the leader is shaped reciprocally. Therefore, the more the leader edifies disciples, the more they end up edified themselves. This positive mimesis is reflected in the gospel promise that whomever loses their life for Christ or others, will find it (Mk 8:35).⁷²⁹ 'Faith is the trust that puts the other first, and hope is the confidence that by doing so one will receive from the other one's true self.'⁷³⁰

There is only one ultimate source of unending love and joy. Apart from abiding in this source, the leader can do nothing (Jn 15:5). There is no other foundation that can endure the storms of ministry. When leaders are apprehended by God's love, they contribute this suffering power of love to the community. This love is described by the Apostle Paul in his letter to the Corinthians (I Cor. 13:4-7). It is a love that is patient

⁷²⁸ Scott Cowdell, *Abiding Faith: Christianity Beyond Certainty, Anxiety, and Violence* (Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2009), 195.

⁷²⁹ The ideas in the paragraph were shaped by Hamerton-Kelly, but ordered and thought out differently. Robert Hamerton-Kelly, *Sacred Violence: Paul's Hermeneutic of the Cross* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 1992), 165–166.

⁷³⁰ *Ibid.*, 166.

and kind, because there is a deep awareness of the patience and kindness of God. It is *not* a love that envies the other and gets caught in the mimetic trap, for one's sense of self is found in God. It is not proud, and cannot boast, because this radical new life and identity is received as a gift. This love is not self-seeking, because it has discovered the truth that self-seeking love comes back void, while prioritizing the love for the other has a rich return. Love is not easily angered, because the leader has a proper view of the patience of God. It keeps no record of wrongs, because leaders have confidence in their forgiveness and is self-aware of their need for forgiveness. 'Love does not delight in evil but rejoices with the truth. It always protects, always trusts, always hopes, always perseveres' (I Cor. 13:4-7 NIV).

Formation of Desire Through Exemplary Models

As the missional leader seeks an identity formed by God, the leader's selection of models is vital, for this involves the formation of their desires. Mimesis empirically validates the truth that bad company corrupts good character, thus, it is important that the leader find models who seek to imitate Christ by their way of life (I Cor. 15:33). Cowdell writes, 'abiding faith means drawing our being no longer from others who are living under the sway of the false sacred – chiefly under the power of the commodity form and the life agenda it imposes on the modern West – but, rather, from those who have come under the sway of Christ and his non-rivalistic desire.'⁷³¹

Paul's final charge to Timothy (II Timothy) is instructive here. Timothy is the disciple Paul lifted as an example of kenotic living (Phil. 2: 19-24) in the context of leaders who seemed to have fallen into the mimetic trap (Phil. 4:2-3). Paul's charge to Timothy in the context of dealing with people clearly under the sway of the false sacred (II Tim. 3:1-9) is, 'But as for you, continue in what you have learned and become convinced of, because you know those from whom you learned it...' (II Tim. 3:14 NIV). Paul was being self-referential here. This concept of *knowing those* from whom we learn seems important in the current celebrity culture found in the US church. Podcasts of 'famous' preachers sometimes replace flesh and blood leaders on the ground. Congregants of megachurches like Willow Creek, have little to no access to their former leader Bill Hybels. For as the report indicated, Hybels' domineering leadership was felt most acutely and recognized by those in his inner circle, even as

⁷³¹ Cowdell, *Abiding Faith*, 194.

some staff had little proximity to him.⁷³² As the missional conversation developed the value of incarnational living, it would do well to extend this idea to the development of emerging leaders. Mimetic theory demonstrates the dangers of negative mimesis, but also the power of positive mimesis. Perhaps this is why Jesus, while having a public message to proclaim to the crowds, understood the need to devote himself to the twelve. The importance of emerging leaders knowing those from whom they learn is foundational, and the focus of incarnational discipleship seems integral to mission and movement.

Phil Meadows speaks to this issue in his article ‘Making Disciples that Renew the Church’.⁷³³ Meadows contends that if leaders start with the commission to make disciples, instead of trying ‘to do’ church differently, this will lead the renewal of the church. He observes four principles: first, that making disciples leads to vital congregations. Second, authentic worship arises from changed lives. Third, if discipleship with transformation of the disciple is foundational, then real fellowship takes place when people are equipped to live in God’s presence and follow the lead of the Spirit. Fourth, mission takes place through transformative discipleship of multiplying disciples who are alive to God and who by word and deed together help others discover the source of all good things. With discipleship and life transformation prioritized, strategies can follow. Positive mimesis through life-changing discipleship, is reflected in the life of Jesus and his focus on the twelve.

While local learning could be elevated, it seems important to continue to value contributions being made outside the local, both geographically and historically speaking. Theology developed in different historical or cultural contexts enables missional leaders to be more alert to prevailing ideologies that might captivate them in their historical and geographical context. Considering this, it is important to reflect on how to expand beyond the local with wisdom. If leaders consider the life and theology of the authors or speakers, beyond hagiographies, they can better know how seriously to take their theology. While every leader is a cracked pot (II Cor. 4:7), and even Paul had not yet become what he desired (Phil 3:12), Paul’s life did reach the point where he could call with a measure of confidence for others to imitate him as he had imitated Christ (I Cor. 11:1; Phil. 4:9).

⁷³² Lyon et al., “Independent Advisory Group Report,” 6.

⁷³³ Phil Meadows, “Making Disciples That Renew the Church,” 2013, accessed December 17, 2019, <https://urc.org.uk/wtwresources/Making-Disciples-that-Renew-the-Church.pdf>.

Formation of Desires Through Distant Models

In his book *Biography as Theology*, James William McClendon Jr writes, ‘the hope of ethics, both secular and religious, lies in the recovery of what may be called an ethics of character.’⁷³⁴ McClendon considers the prevailing understanding of ethics (which is largely influenced by the Christian realism of Reinhold Niebuhr and the situation ethics of Joseph Fletcher) to be lacking.⁷³⁵ While appreciating the valuable contribution that these authors have made, he writes, ‘The shape of our times suggest that neither one nor the other, nor both together adequately express either the truly human or truly Christian ethical demand of the age waiting to be born.’⁷³⁶ He makes the case that a new approach to ethics is needed for today.

For McClendon, a person’s character is formed by how they see things and how they do things, which is based on the person’s deepest beliefs, or convictions.⁷³⁷ He recognizes that character is forged in the context of community because character is developed in communities of conviction. And within communities of conviction there are people who embody the convictions of the community to such a degree that they become living examples to the point that their lives ‘serve to disclose and perhaps to correct or enlarge the community’s moral vision, at the same time arousing impotent will within the community to better fulfilment of the vision already acquired.’⁷³⁸

He goes on to say that the example of this person may also serve to help the community of faith better discern her own convictions on the doctrines of God, of humanity, and of creation. ‘These convictions, too, may be negated or enlarged, altered or reinforced, by the lives of such significant persons. Such lives, by their very attractiveness or beauty, may serve as data for a Christian thinker, enabling her more truly to reflect upon the tension between what is and what ought to be believed and lived by all.’⁷³⁹ McClendon makes a case that by studying people who live exemplary lives, one can better develop theological convictions, thus his title *Biography as Theology*. ‘By recognizing that Christian beliefs are not so many “propositions” to be catalogued or juggled like truth-functions in a computer, but are living convictions which give shape to actual lives and actual communities, we open ourselves to the

⁷³⁴ James Wm McClendon, *Biography as Theology: How Life Stories Can Remake Today’s Theology*, Reissue edition. (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Publishers, 2002), 2.

⁷³⁵ Ibid., 1–23.

⁷³⁶ Ibid., 14.

⁷³⁷ Ibid., 17.

⁷³⁸ Ibid., 22.

⁷³⁹ Ibid.

possibility that the only relevant critical examination of Christian beliefs may be one that begins by attending to lived lives.⁷⁴⁰ The Apostle Paul, writing to his protégé Timothy, confirmed the importance of biography when he wrote, ‘Watch your life and doctrine closely. Persevere in them, because if you do, you will save both yourself and your hearers’ (I Tim. 4:16 NIV). One caution which must be raised, especially when considering distant models, is the danger of reading hagiographies as opposed to biographies. In his book, McClendon does well to share some of the weaknesses of those he elevates as examples.

Thus, this author examined the lives of Wink, Girard, and Stringfellow as well as their theology, considering the dominant images that shaped their lives. For when doing biography as theology, after identifying a leader worthy of imitation, McClendon attempted to ‘discover dominant images which unlock these biographies... [in order] to harvest some theology in the process.’⁷⁴¹ The images that this author developed for René Girard was ‘Collaborative Truth Seeker’ and ‘Academic Apologist’.

Girard as ‘Collaborative Truth Seeker’ and ‘Academic Apologist’

Girard’s passion to seek and understand truth drove his voracious appetite to learn. Girard valued learning in community through collaboration. Many of his books are done in conversation with other authors. He modelled biography as theology, as he studied both authors and their works. This methodology enabled him to make his first discovery, mimetic desire, for he observed when novelists experienced conversion in their personal lives, it was reflected in their work. Girard studied widely. Haven remarks, ‘Girard’s loyalty was not to a narrow academic discipline, but rather to a continuing human truth: “Academic disciplines are more committed to methodology than truth.”’⁷⁴² Girard was not afraid to challenge some of the underlying assumptions in the various disciplines he studied. His journey to seek truth, wherever it may be found, is highlighted by neuropsychiatrist and psychologist Jean-Michel Oughourlian, who, along with many others, was greatly influenced by both Girard’s life and works. He writes, ‘Intellectual matters aside, I think I share with all the authors of this present work the recognition that my desire as a thinker is mimetic and modelled on René’s

⁷⁴⁰ Ibid.

⁷⁴¹ Ibid., 88.

⁷⁴² Cynthia L Haven, “The Evolution of René Girard,” *America Magazine*, last modified November 16, 2018, accessed December 5, 2019, <https://www.americamagazine.org/arts-culture/2018/11/16/evolution-rene-girard>.

desire, which is to search unstintingly not for subjective truth, but for an objective reality and to recognize it as such whatever the price that has to be paid for this recognition.’⁷⁴³

Regarding Girard being an ‘academic apologist’, Wolfgang Palaver and Scott Cowdell both make convincing cases that demonstrate the heart and desires of Girard to make an appeal to those outside of the faith.⁷⁴⁴ Cowdell notes how in Girard’s correspondence with Schwager ‘he feels obligated to stay within the critical enterprise [cultural anthropology] so that his work can connect with a whole modern audience that is cut off from the Judeo-Christian tradition.’⁷⁴⁵ Cowdell insightfully notes, ‘He is not avoiding the theological so much as serving its apologetic mission of clarifying and teaching the gospel in an unofficial capacity, on another front.’⁷⁴⁶ Cowdell goes on to examine what he considers Girard’s method, ‘in which the scientific and the theological are combined via the incarnational to yield the apologetic.’⁷⁴⁷ Finally, Girard’s apologetic heart is expressed in one of his last books, where he writes, ‘Since the beginning of the “novelistic conversion” in *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel*, all of my books have been more or less explicit apologies of Christianity. I would like this one to be even more explicit. What we are saying will become more understandable with time because, unquestionably, we are accelerating swiftly towards the destruction of the world. Christianity is a founding murder in reverse...’⁷⁴⁸

Wink as ‘Word Made Flesh’, ‘Kingdom Activist’ and ‘Being Human’

The metaphors this author developed for Walter Wink included ‘Word Made Flesh’, ‘Kingdom Activist’, and ‘Being Human’. Wink married theory with practice and intellect with emotion for the sake of personal and social transformation reflecting the Word made flesh. His willingness to risk, and lose, his tenure by challenging the normative approach to scriptural interpretation, which claimed objectivity and detached neutrality, demonstrated the depth of his conviction. His critique of how academics tend to quarantine themselves from practitioners, shaped his desire to write for the

⁷⁴³ Jean-Michel Oughourlian, “My Life with René,” in *For René Girard: Essays in Friendship and in Truth*, ed. Sandor Goodhart et al. (East Lansing, MI: Michigan State University Press, 2009), 54.

⁷⁴⁴ Palaver, *René Girard’s Mimetic Theory*, 228–230; Cowdell, *René Girard and the Nonviolent God*, 94–114.

⁷⁴⁵ Cowdell, *René Girard and the Nonviolent God*, 85.

⁷⁴⁶ Ibid.

⁷⁴⁷ Ibid.

⁷⁴⁸ Ibid., xv.

community of faith as well as the academy. The many testimonies to his life and work confirm that the mark he left on others was one of deep appreciation for a life well lived.⁷⁴⁹

Wink was a kingdom activist as well. The promise that engaged his life was Matt. 6:33 NIV, 'But seek first his kingdom and his righteousness and all these things will be given to you as well.' Seeing God's kingdom manifest itself more on this earth was Wink's telos. Shaped by his boyhood experience of racism, and by Martin Luther King Jr, his praxis in seeing the kingdom manifest was as important as, and guided by, his telos. That praxis was non-violent direct action. While this thesis has critically engaged his theology, and while some might have some theological disagreements with his vision of the kingdom, one would find it difficult to argue with his embodied praxis. His willingness to put his life at risk in Selma, Chile, and South Africa, demonstrate his commitment to see what he calls, God's Domination Free Order (kingdom of God) actualized. Missional leaders would do well to follow Wink's example, recognizing that while Satan and the demonic are irredeemable, the principalities relating to institutions seem to hold some potential for redemption, though likely in more fragmented ways until the coming of the new heavens and new earth. As the missional leader prays for God's kingdom to manifest itself on earth, works should follow. This speaks to the importance of social transformation in conjunction with personal transformation. The telos of the missional leader is both life in God as well as new creation.

The other telos in Wink's life was just to be human through the imitation of Jesus. Wink makes a case that Jesus eschewed any pretentious titles and simply identified as the Son of Man.⁷⁵⁰ All his life Wink sought to know Jesus more, as Jesus was the key to his own identity. He writes, 'I wanted to know who this Jesus really is. The church was my refuge; I learned about Jesus and, by his example, I saw how to live. His example of how to live opened up a new freedom that was felt, if not articulated.'⁷⁵¹ For Wink, if one did not know and imitate Jesus, it would be difficult to live humanly in a world dominated by the Powers.

When Wink reflected on his early life experiences with his parents, he recognized that his desire to be loved and accepted by his parents and God, led to a

⁷⁴⁹ D. Seiple and Frederick W. Weidmann, eds., *Enigmas and Powers* (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2008).

⁷⁵⁰ Wink and Berry, *Just Jesus*, 25.

⁷⁵¹ *Ibid.*, 15.

lifelong struggle with perfectionism.⁷⁵² This desire to be loved and accepted turned into a desire to accomplish *for* love, instead of seeking to be fruitful *from* being loved. This may be why when Paul wrote to the Ephesians, that he prayed that they may know the length, height, depth, and width of Christ's love for them (Eph. 3:14-21). As leaders are caught up with the holy love of God, they are more likely to live in the power of this Spirit instead relying on their own power to accomplish.

Stringfellow as 'Incarnational Parable' and 'Prophetic Witness'

The images developed for Stringfellow were 'Incarnational Parable' and 'Prophetic Witness'. The incarnation shaped Stringfellow's life. His willingness to move to one of the roughest blocks in Harlem after graduating from Harvard Law School to live with and serve the poor and marginalized reflect his commitment to incarnational living. The nature of his residence for the next six years is reflected in the first sentence of his book *My People is the Enemy*, 'The stairway smelled of piss.'⁷⁵³ It was from within this context that Stringfellow did his theology. Gary Commins considered Harlem and the Eschaton the two theological homes of Stringfellow, which 'shed light on every aspect of Stringfellow's thought.'⁷⁵⁴ For Stringfellow 'daily occurrences and ordinary people were the most profound source of theology. Biography and autobiography were, like parables, pregnant with meaning. This, he explained, was congruent with the incarnation.'⁷⁵⁵ Stringfellow sought to discern God's activity in the world and being a living parable of God's Word was Stringfellow's way of doing so. It led to the second metaphor of his life, which was being a prophetic witness.

One of the principalities Stringfellow consistently addressed was the principality of racism, which may be one of the reasons he was asked to speak at the National Council on Race and Religion, about a year after Karl Barth commended Stringfellow to a host of theologians.⁷⁵⁶ Some of the prominent speakers at this gathering of over 650 established leaders, representing 'nearly every religious body in

⁷⁵² Ibid., 17–19.

⁷⁵³ Stringfellow, *My People Is the Enemy*, 2.

⁷⁵⁴ Gary Commins, "Harlem and Eschaton: Stringfellow's Theological Homes," in *Prophet of Justice, Prophet of Life: Essays on William Stringfellow*, ed. Robert Boak Slocum (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock Pub, 1997), 128.

⁷⁵⁵ Ibid., 129.

⁷⁵⁶ Karl Barth, *Evangelical Theology: An Introduction*, Reprint edition. (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1992), ix.

America,' included, Abraham Heschel, Paul Tillich, and Martin Luther King Jr.⁷⁵⁷ Stringfellow was to give a response to Rabbi Heschel. Stringfellow stunned this gathering of leaders; instead of standing on their feet with applause, as they did for Heschel, they stood on their feet with 'boos, jeers and catcalls.'⁷⁵⁸ What was it that Stringfellow said that turned this group of '657 liberals bent on solving someone else's problems' hostile?⁷⁵⁹

First, he dismissed the conference as being 'too little, too late, and too lily white.'⁷⁶⁰ Having lived in Harlem, Stringfellow heard the contempt that the black community had for the white church.⁷⁶¹ He critiqued the leaders of the conference for not having any other black leaders speak, with the single exception of Martin Luther King Jr. Stringfellow thought that white people, especially in the North, failed to comprehend how for generations they had been steeped in a culture of white supremacy 'in education, the law, politics, the economy, in religion' to the point it was just taken for granted.⁷⁶² While the KKK is easy enough to recognize in the South, what is 'much more typical, and much more important, is the less brutal, apparently more benign, but equally oppressive racism shown in the entrenched and practiced paternalism in the overwhelming multitudes of whites.'⁷⁶³ He stated, 'The truth is that this conference represents a mentality... which thinks that the initiative in the racial crisis resides with white folk. But the initiative has passed in the racial crisis in this country from white to black.'⁷⁶⁴

Second, Stringfellow exposed how many people's approach to the issue of racism simply imitated the Powers through the ideology of humanism, which assumes the problem is only located in the human heart and the goal is equality. Stringfellow's robust theology of the Powers gave him a more holistic approach to the issue, and a prophetic edge. Stringfellow reminded all those who were gathering that biblically and theologically, 'the drama of this history takes place amongst God and men and the

⁷⁵⁷ Taylor Branch, *Pillar of Fire: America in the King Years 1963-65* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1999), 21.

⁷⁵⁸ Will D. Campbell, Jimmy Carter, and John Lewis, *Brother to a Dragonfly*, Reprint edition. (Jackson, MS: University Press of Mississippi, 2018), 230.

⁷⁵⁹ *Ibid.*, 195.

⁷⁶⁰ Stringfellow, *My People Is the Enemy*, 136.

⁷⁶¹ *Ibid.*

⁷⁶² Stringfellow, *Imposters of God*, 40.

⁷⁶³ *Ibid.*

⁷⁶⁴ William Stringfellow, "Care Enough to Weep" (presented at the National Conference on Religion and Race, Chicago: Box 7, William Stringfellow Papers, #4438, Department of Manuscripts and University Archives, Cornell University Library, 1963), 2.

principalities and powers, the greater institutions and ideologies active in the world. It is the corruption and shallowness of humanism which beguiled Jew and Christian into believing that men are masters of institution or ideology.’⁷⁶⁵ He goes on to say, ‘Racism is not an evil in the hearts or minds of men, racism is a principality, a demonic power, a representative, image, and embodiment of death, over which men have little or no control, but which works its awful influence over the lives of men.’⁷⁶⁶

As a prophetic witness, Stringfellow sought to name and unmask the principalities of racism and humanism, knowing that until people recognize the nature and work of the Powers, there was no moving forward. Racism is not simply injustice, but idolatry. While the principalities and powers are part of the created order of God, in their fallen state they seek ultimate allegiance. There was just one solution for Stringfellow, one which was met with hostility from this interfaith gathering.

This is the power with which Jesus Christ was confronted and which, at great and sufficient cost, he overcame. In other words, the issue here is not equality among men, but unity among men. The issue is not some common spiritual values, nor natural law, nor middle axioms. The issue is baptism. The issue is the unity of all mankind wrought in the life and work of Christ. Baptism is the sacrament of that unity of all men in God.⁷⁶⁷

This is the statement that caused a stunned silence in that gathering, followed by ‘boos and jeers.’ Stringfellow was no fundamentalist, but he had not fallen to the ideology of liberalism or humanism, thinking that the evil one faces can be managed or controlled through human initiative. His understanding of the Powers allowed him to be a prophetic witness to the world, pointing people to the gospel of Christ that has the power to pull together those that the world has divided. He reminded the people that only in Christ is there a possibility of one, new humanity.

Selfless Leadership in the Praxis of Mission

The agenda to develop a life worth imitating also involves the missional leader understanding that power is a gift. Power can be distorted when used improperly, typically when the leader desires control instead of trusting in the power of the Spirit. But to demonize power only pushes it underground where it eventually emerges in unhealthy ways. Power shaped by love brings life. As Crouch writes, ‘Power is nothing – worse than nothing – without love. But love without power is less than it was meant

⁷⁶⁵ Ibid., 14–15.

⁷⁶⁶ Ibid.

⁷⁶⁷ Ibid.

to be. Love without the capacity to make something of the world, without the ability to respond to and make room for the beloved's flourishing, is frustrated love.'⁷⁶⁸ He continues to write, 'Love transfigures power. Absolute love transfigures absolute power. And power transfigured by love is power that made and saves the world.'⁷⁶⁹ It is important for missional leaders to develop a healthy view of power.⁷⁷⁰

An agenda for developing missional leaders worthy of imitation involves a kenotic spirituality that leads them into mission by the power of love. Having a holy love affair with God is not only the root solution to the root problem of idolatry, but it is this love that motivates people for mission. Paul writes, 'For Christ's love compels us, because we are convinced that one died for all, and therefore all died. And he died for all, that those who live should no longer live for themselves but for him who died for them and was raised again,' (II Cor. 5:14-15 NIV). When speaking of holistic mission in this evil age dominated by the Powers, N.T. Wright speaks of the role of suffering.

Those who are eager for "bringing the kingdom," for social and cultural renewal in our day, can easily forget that the revolution that began on the cross only works through the cross. And those who are eager to "save souls for heaven" are likely to regard suffering simply as something through which most of us some of the time and some of us most of the time will have to pass, rather than as something by means of which the rescuing love of God is poured out into the world. The latter is closer to the mark. "The blood of the martyrs is the seed of the church." This well-known quotation from the African theologian Tertullian, writing around AD 200, reflects the early Christian perception that suffering and dying for the faith is not simply a necessary evil, the inevitable concomitant of following a way that the world sees as dangerously subversive. Suffering and dying is *the way by which the world is changed*. This is how the revolution continues.⁷⁷¹

It is only the love of Christ that propels people on mission with a sacrificial love and a willingness to suffer. The love of God shapes the identity of the missional leader and is the motivating force behind kenotic mission.

⁷⁶⁸ Crouch, *Playing God*, 25.

⁷⁶⁹ Ibid., 45.

⁷⁷⁰ Dawn, *Powers, Weakness, and the Tabernacling of God*; Dan B. Allender, *Leading with a Limp: Take Full Advantage of Your Most Powerful Weakness* (Colorado Springs, CO: WaterBrook, 2008); Crouch, *Playing God*; Roy Kearsley, *Church, Community and Power*, 1 edition. (Farnham, England ; Burlington, VT: Routledge, 2009); Hardy, Whitehouse, and Yarnell, *Power and the Powers*. Kyle A. Pasewark, *A Theology of Power: Being Beyond Domination* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 1993). Henri Nouwen, *In the Name of Jesus: Reflections on Christian Leadership* (New York: Ballantine Books, 1992).

⁷⁷¹ Wright, *The Day the Revolution Began*, 368.

One shining example of kenotic love in the history of the church is Saint Francis. It is important to note that St. Francis is an example from the medieval period of church history, when Christendom reigned. He demonstrates that there has always been a faithful remnant through the ages, who have not bent their knee to Baal. The church today has much to learn from faithful examples like St. Francis, St. Benedict, and St. Ignatius, for each age has their false ideologies, their false narratives that seek to take people captive.

In a post-Christendom era where people are sceptical of power and truth, learning to genuinely embody the good news is imperative. St. Francis lived this kind of life in his day. With the gospels as his rule of life he sought to follow in Jesus's footsteps. He was a peacemaker who loved his enemies, travelled light, welcomed strangers, loved the outcasts, loved the environment, and lived in *communitas*. Francis understood the concepts of reciprocity and *communitas*, which is why he called his order 'Little Brothers'. In naming his order Little Brothers and never becoming a priest, he demonstrated his desire to have no father superior such as was common in religious orders of his time. To Francis, God alone was Father, and all others were brothers and sisters. Francis believed that the only privilege was in having no privilege. He felt that Jesus, being in the very nature God, became flesh and claimed no special privileges. Therefore, if Jesus rejected the privileges of God, how much more should the Little Brothers live in kinship with all people? In his letter to all the faithful he writes, 'We should never desire to be above others, but ought rather to be servants and subject "to every human creature for God's sake." And the spirit of the Lord shall rest upon all those who do these things and who persevere to the end, and He shall make His abode and dwelling in them, and they shall be children of the Heavenly Father whose works they do, and they are the spouses, brothers and mothers of our Lord Jesus Christ.'⁷⁷² Francis would often put himself under the leadership of one of the other Little Brothers, thus he was not only influenced by his Little Brothers, but he influenced them by way of example.⁷⁷³ Eight hundred years after his death, he is memorialized by the three religious orders he inspired, which include at least a million members today, both Catholic and protestant.⁷⁷⁴ What was it about this man that has generated many

⁷⁷² St. Francis of Assisi, *The Complete Writings of St. Francis of Assisi*, trans. Paschal Robinson (Philadelphia, PA: Dolphin Press, 1905), 54.

⁷⁷³ John Michael Talbot and Steve Rabey, *The Lessons of Saint Francis: How to Bring Simplicity and Spirituality into Your Daily Life* (New York: Penguin Group, 1998), 84.

⁷⁷⁴ *Ibid.*, 244.

gracious words? Marina Warner says, ‘The Franciscan spirit continues to be considered by agnostics and atheist, as well as believers, as the most genuine expression of Christ’s teaching ever approved by the Vatican’⁷⁷⁵

Many who study the life of St. Francis have a difficult time understanding him. As the publishers of G.K. Chesterton’s biography of Francis say, ‘He [Francis] was a man who loved women but vowed himself to chastity; an artist who loved the pleasures of the natural world as few have loved them, but vowed to himself to the most austere poverty, stripping himself naked in the public square so all could see that he had renounced his worldly goods; a clown who stood on his head in order to see the world aright.’⁷⁷⁶ C.K. Chesterton suggests that there is only one way to explain a person like this:

And for the modern reader the clue to asceticism and all the rest can best be found in the stories of lovers when they seemed to be rather like lunatics. Tell his life as a tale of one of the Troubadours, and the wild things he would do for his lady, and the whole modern puzzle disappears. In such a romance there would be no contradiction between the poet gathering flowers in the sun and enduring a freezing vigil in the snow, between his praising all earthly and bodily beauty and then refusing to eat, between glorifying gold and purple and perversely going in rags, between his showing pathetically a hunger for a happy life and a thirst for a heroic death. All these riddles would easily be resolved in the simplicity of any noble love; only this was so noble a love that nine men out of ten have hardly ever heard of it... The reader cannot even begin to see the sense of a story that may well seem to him a very wild one, until he understands that to this great mystic his religion was not a thing like a theory but a thing like a love-affair.⁷⁷⁷

St. Francis lived a life worth imitating. His identity was *reformed* by the love of God, his telos, life in God, as well as the kingdom and God’s righteousness. His identity and telos shaped his kenotic use of power as he lived on mission. Thus, his legacy of discipleship continues to this day.

Summary of Argument

Stringfellow has given this thesis a concrete way of seeing how the principalities misshape missional leaders at the three contours of leadership. The synthesis demonstrated how the imitation-based framework can help to shape a catechism for leaders and emerging leaders. Human beings are imitative by nature. They are captive

⁷⁷⁵ Adrian House and Karen Armstrong, *Francis of Assisi: A Revolutionary Life*, Special ed. edition. (Mahwah, NJ: Hidden Spring, 2003), 9.

⁷⁷⁶ G. K. Chesterton, *St. Francis of Assisi* (Mount Pleasant, SC: Arcadia Press, 2019).

⁷⁷⁷ *Ibid.*, 15–16.

to imitation. The central question is who will they imitate. To imitate the Powers is to fall to domineering leadership. To imitate Christ is to model a kenotic spirituality and leadership in the life of mission. When examining the scandal of leadership represented by negative mimesis, it was discovered that at the root of the problem of power abuse is idolatry. Fallen leadership entails the missional leader losing his or her battle with Satan.

Leadership worthy of imitation takes place when the leader is willing to face and overcome Satan, where the leader resists the devil and repents. Then through positive mimesis, the leader forms an identity in the love and acceptance of God. It is this love of God that reshapes the praxis of the leader on mission, helping to model kenotic leadership living. Suffering love and the positive use of power is reflected in missional leaders whose identities are formed by and compelled by God's love. The key to a faithful praxis of power is a leader whose life is characterized by a love affair with God. Thus, the first question a missional leader may want to ask is: Do I have a life worth imitating? The second question is: Do we have a community worth joining? And finally: Do we have a mission worth dying for? But it all starts with the first question. Again, keeping Albert Schweitzer in view, 'Example is not the *main* thing in influencing others. It is the *only* thing.'⁷⁷⁸

⁷⁷⁸ Schweitzer, *Albert Schweitzer Thoughts for Our Times*, 51.

Conclusion

Summary of the Study

This thesis began with the need to develop a robust diagnosis of the problem of domineering leadership in the church, as evidenced from the recent fall of high-profile leaders. Some of these leaders have deeply shaped the ethos of church leadership in North America. The problem of the abuse of power goes deeper than the conventional diagnosis allow. By linking missional leadership to a theology of the Powers via mimetic desire, the thesis has argued for an imitation-based conceptual framework that can provide a more robust diagnosis of the problem and inspire a more faithful way forward. Beginning with the nature and work of the Powers made it possible to diagnose the root cause of fallen leadership as idolatry. Ultimately, the use or abuse of power is reflected in the spiritual battle between the fallen Powers of this world and the redemptive power of the Spirit for the heart, soul, and desires of the missional leader. Humans are captive to imitation, especially through mimetic desire, and there can be no neutrality. While the missional leader has a choice, it was argued that not to imitate Christ is to imitate the Powers. When the missional leader imitates the Powers, it leads to bondage, idolatry, and injustice, manifested by domineering leadership.

Establishing the need for a theology of the Powers, the thesis has argued that talking about the mission of God without a robust theology of the Powers is incomplete and potentially harmful when it comes to thinking about leadership. In light of the argument above, this thesis has argued that without a way to name, unmask, and engage the Powers, the missional leader remains vulnerable to patterns of domination. Instead of engaging in positive mimesis and imitating Christ and his ways, the leader falls into negative mimesis, mimicking the Powers instead. When the missional leader imitates the principalities of image, institution, and ideology in the world, they are often slowly and imperceptibly led into idolatry and the abuse of power in the church.

In an exploration of the history and the development of the missional conversation through Van Gelder in chapter one, this thesis argued that current missional theology is insufficient to diagnose the problem of fallen leadership. By unintentionally minimizing the spirituality of the leader it gives the impression that solutions are found through information or institutional strategy as opposed to spiritual formation. Minimization of the imitation of Christ, as well as the lack of defining both the world and culture added to the problem. However, the contours of leadership given

by Roxburgh and others – identity, praxis, and telos – are extremely helpful.⁷⁷⁹

Roxburgh names the true telos of the leader, and establishes the foundational importance of personal identity, which in turn shapes praxis. But by failing to significantly address the Powers, the missional leader is left vulnerable to their subtle influence.

In chapter two, Houston's study of I Peter provided a biblical approach to addressing the problem of domineering leadership, from which an imitation-based framework for understanding missional leadership has emerged (figure 1). Although Houston's work highlights the concepts of imitation and the Powers, a more systematic approach was required to address the problem of fallen leadership in the church. To accomplish this a more robust understanding of the Powers was needed, as well as a better understanding of how imitation and desire work in relation to them. A systematic integration of these concepts was sought by bringing together the work of Wink and Girard.

Wink establishes a theology of the Powers for the imitation-based framework. Through Wink in chapter three, it was argued that the pervasiveness of the Powers in the New Testament demonstrates the need to understand how they subvert leadership in the church. Wink's argument alerts the leader to the ubiquity of the fall as well as the all-pervasive patterns of domination, and that participation in the mission of God cannot escape a confrontation with the Powers. If missional leaders are to resist succumbing to patterns of domination, and the Spirit of the domination system (Satan), they will need to name, unmask, and engage the Powers. Failure to be intentional about this leads to complicity with the Powers and ends in bondage to idolatry, dishonouring God, and dehumanization.

Girard establishes the link between a theology of the Powers and missional leadership in the imitation-based framework through the concept of mimetic desire. Wink provided a way to understand how the Powers work to subvert the missional leader from keeping the first commandment. Girard's work gets to the heart of the problem by working from the tenth commandment through the lens of anthropology. Drawing on Girard, the thesis argued for the centrality of imitation and desire to the problem of fallen leadership. The scandal of leadership occurs when the missional leader gets caught in the mimetic cycle through malformed desires. Malformed desires of the leader end in rivalry, as the disciple who looks to the leader as a model begins to

⁷⁷⁹ Roxburgh uses identity, telos and work of the leader. Praxis is mentioned by others.

desire what the model desires. As scandals (when the leader becomes an obstacle to their disciples) in the congregation increase rivalry develops into a crisis, leading to the necessity of scapegoating so that the congregation might experience temporary tranquillity. By unveiling the mimetic cycle which has taken place since the foundation of the world, the insidious work of the Powers was revealed. The way in which the Powers generate this crisis of leadership was seen in the book of James, where envy and self-ambition were called out as demonic and satanic. Leaders who engaged in this behaviour were called adulterers. It was argued that there are two ultimate models, Jesus and Satan. Failure to imitate Christ is to imitate Satan. While the Powers conceal the mimetic cycle, Jesus, through his willingness to become the scapegoat, revealed the mimetic cycle for what it is, and in doing so, proclaimed the fall of Satan. Missional leaders can escape the mimetic cycle through the imitation of Christ by understanding how the mimetic cycle works in their lives and the life of the congregation. Jesus exposed the work of the Powers and saw the fall of Satan's ability to hold onto his kingdom. Yet pride continues to blind the mind of some leaders, preventing them from embracing the freedom that Jesus achieved for humanity. Girard's work on mimetic desire supplies the link between missional leadership and the theology of the Powers, completing the imitation-based framework.

Stringellow's work in chapter five, ties together Wink and Girard by applying the imitation-based framework to how the Powers seek to subvert the leader at the three contours of leadership – identity (image), praxis (institution), and telos (ideology). The insidious and crafty work of the Powers persistently work on the leader, often without the leaders understanding. These principalities, under the sway of Satan, subtly seek to possess those in leadership until they are fully enthralled. Submission to image, institution, or ideology, devolves into idolatry. It was argued that even potentially good things, like the church as an institution, can become an idol when the church is in survival mode and when leaders desire to find security in their own way. This idolatry always leads to injustice, the twin evils the prophets continually railed against. When leaders give themselves over to the principalities, it results in an abuse of power. To deal with domineering leadership, it was argued that leaders must understand that there is a spiritual battle for their heart and desires. While knowing the true telos of life in God is vital, without an understanding of how the Powers work, the leader remains vulnerable to their subtle influence. The argument of the thesis implies the need for developing a catechism that will promote leadership formation as the imitation of Christ through positive mimesis. In doing so, leaders form desires and patterns of life

worth imitating. An agenda was given to help leaders ground their identity in God's love and consider ways to shape their desires in a manner which uses their power legitimately, as a gift.

In summary, the imitation-based framework developed in this thesis has linked missional leadership to the Powers via mimetic desire as seen in (figure 1). This has shed light on the subtle ways that Powers seek to misshape the leader's desires, and get them to mimic their ways, providing a deep diagnosis of fallen leadership. The spiritual battle for the heart, soul and desires of the missional leader illustrated in (figure 2), provides a way toward redeemed leadership. Table 3 helps to summarize the argument and connect the various terms used in this thesis, clarifying the findings of this study.

Table 3. Dealing with a Domineering Praxis - Fallen and Redeemed Leadership

Missional Leadership	Principalities and Powers	Fallen Leadership		Redeemed Leadership	
		Desires	Evidenced by	Desires	Evidenced by
Identity	Image	Own glory For prestige For status	Egotism	For God and his glory	Others-Centeredness
Praxis	Institution	Own Power For security To control To survive	Domineering Leadership	For the Spirit's Power and Righteousness	Kenosis
Telos	Ideology	Own Kingdom To be Right	Pride	For his kingdom	Humility

Significance of the Study

This thesis has sought to make a contribution to the field of missiology. The more the church becomes a credible sign and foretaste of God's kingdom through healthy leadership and communities, the more it can genuinely extend a new way of life. A life where people live by faith, are known by their love, and through their lives express a concrete sense of hope for the fullness of new creation. By developing an imitation-based framework that linked missional leadership to the Powers via mimetic desire, this thesis offered a deeper diagnosis to the problem of fallen leadership, and suggested a fresh approach to leadership theory and practice. This thesis has demonstrated the need for leaders to be aware of how the Powers subvert their ministry by captivating their hearts in ways that lead to patterns of domination. Understanding the work of the Powers provides fresh motivation for missional leaders to consider their priorities. Having a solid missional theology without a deep spirituality becomes

counterproductive, if it contributes to neglecting the soul's relationship with God. The imitation-based framework developed here suggests that the first work of the missional leader is the formation of an identity in God. After developing a life worth imitating the leader can develop a community worth joining, with a mission worth pursuing.

This study has argued for a more robust theology of the Powers, relating to missional leadership, which has been underdeveloped in the missional conversation. Though Newbigin spoke to its importance, there has been no work to date which has sought to combine Wink and Girard's understanding of the Powers with any depth. Intertwining a theologian's voice with an anthropologist's has yielded a substantial understanding of the Powers, and the culture of church leadership. In addition, Stringfellow's approach to the principalities of image, institution, and ideology has been uniquely applied to the contours of leadership with engaging the Powers and mimetic theory in mind. Providing an imitation-based framework has the potential to provide practical help to the missional leader regarding how the Powers subvert their leadership and how their leadership might grow through the imitation of Christ.

This is the first study that gives significant attention to the biblical narrative regarding the problem of domineering leadership. While neither Houston nor McKnight seemed aware of mimetic theory, their work implied a connection between desire and the Powers, which was systematised into the imitation-based framework by drawing on Wink and Girard. The thesis is also the first work that significantly brings Girard into the Powers conversation, and is the first time that his own synthesis of the Powers with mimetic theory has been applied to leadership in the church. The explanatory power that mimetic theory gives to the area of desire and its connection to the Powers is extraordinary.

Practically speaking, the imitation-based framework developed has the potential to shape disciplines of catechesis and spiritual formation which alert missional leaders to how desire and the Powers might be at work in their lives and in the life of the congregations they serve. Leaders can be equipped to see signs of negative mimesis, which will help in community formation. Positive mimesis helps leaders recognize potential in discipleship, emerging leadership development, mission, and movement.

Finally, the implications of this study not only justified the centrality of a leader's walk with God, but demonstrated the havoc, divisions, and scapegoating likely to occur when God does not hold first place in the life of the leader. By observing the scandal of leadership and finding the root of the abuse of power in idolatry, fresh motivation is given to missional leaders to prioritize their relationship with the triune

God. In addition, fresh light has been shed on how ideology misshapes the church and creates divisions in the church body, thus damaging the witness of the church. The concept of mimetic desire suggests a fresh approach to the imitation Christ, as well as what it means to be and make disciples. The most significant way a person can imitate Christ is by imitating Jesus' desires for the Father, and his dependence on the Spirit. The implication for making disciples is that discipleship involves the leader's own desires, since those who look to the leader as a model will desire what the leader desires.

Directions for Further Study

In the development of this thesis, the imitation-based framework not only provided shape to the development of the argument, but also helped to limit the scope of this thesis. Yet there are numerous areas that have been identified through the course of this study that could further strengthen the development and practical use of the framework for corollary developments in leadership theory.

First, there are avenues for further development of a theology of the Powers. Regarding Satan, a comparison and contrast of an understanding of Satan could prove helpful from both an emergent and traditional view, using the work of Matthew Croasmun and Hans Urs von Balthasar. Croasmun in his study of hamartiology examines Romans five through eight and identifies the body of sin, the cosmic tyrant of Sin, as Satan.⁷⁸⁰ While Girard demystified and deconstructed Satan, Croasmun reconstructs Satan as a cosmic body, as opposed to a fallen angel. Using the definition of personhood from emergent science, he sees this body of Sin as a cosmic person with a collective mind. This cosmic body of Sin is comparable yet distinct from the cosmic body of Christ. His understanding gives explanatory power to Satan as a figure in the New Testament, and why, though Satan is the arch enemy of Christ, he does not need to engage in enemy love with him. This comparison and contrast of an emergent and traditional view of Satan could also be in dialogue with the emergent view of the demonic initially developed by Amos Yong and further developed by David Bradnick.⁷⁸¹ It could explore an intersection with the developing understanding of

⁷⁸⁰ Matthew Croasmun, *The Emergence of Sin: The Cosmic Tyrant in Romans*, 1 edition. (New York, NY: Oxford University Press, 2017).

⁷⁸¹ Yong, *In the Days of Caesar*; Yong, *The Spirit of Creation*; David L. Bradnick, *Evil, Spirits and Possession: An Emergentist Theology of the Demonic*, Global Pentecostal and Charismatic Studies volume 25 (Leiden ; Boston: Brill, 2017).

Satan across Jacques Ellul's early, middle and late views. Both the emergent and traditional views of Satan coincide with this thesis in that the telos of Satan and the demonic are the same, which challenges Wink's view of Satan, but corresponds with Girard's.

Secondly, through Wink's exegetical word study it was discovered that the demonic and/or Satan were not to be understood as part of the cosmic reconciliation in Col. 1:16. Because of Girard's and Yong's differentiation between the principalities and powers and Satan, this thesis sees hope for the possibility that the principalities and powers may be redeemed. Considering that the reign of God (kingdom of God) widens the scope of mission, further study of the extent to which institutions outside of the church could expect redemption this side of the eschaton would be beneficial, especially in light of an emergent or traditional view of Satan.

As such, a further elaboration of how ideology works in the collective mind of the cosmic body of Sin could be conducted in view of the potential of ideology to misshape leaders and congregations. Currently in the United States, there is a strong division between those unknowingly shaped by nationalism, or even white nationalism, and progressivism or liberalism which is also misshaping the church.⁷⁸² Further research in this area could help missional leaders to deal with disunity. Newbigin and others consider the unity of the church paramount; Jesus, too, speaks to unity and the love of one another in the body as an apologetic the church has to offer the world. Jesus' exhortation is prayed in the context of protecting believers from the evil one (John 17:13-23). In addition, the spiritual formation of leadership could be developed in light of the ideologies of capitalism and socialism.⁷⁸³ Understanding the liturgical power of the mall with an understanding of the market as god could be conducted, demonstrating how these practices misshape the desires of the leader, creating an identity of the leader as consumer and highlighting the ideology of the American dream.⁷⁸⁴ Counter liturgies could be developed that reshape the desires of the leader for God and his kingdom, and reorient the leader to the Christian calendar, the Scriptures, fellowship, and silence and solitude.⁷⁸⁵

⁷⁸² David E. Fitch, *The Church of Us vs. Them: Freedom from a Faith That Feeds on Making Enemies* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2019).

⁷⁸³ Koyzis, *Political Visions & Illusions*.

⁷⁸⁴ Harvey Cox, *The Market as God* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2016).

⁷⁸⁵ Nouwen, *The Selfless Way of Christ*; Smith, *Desiring the Kingdom*; James K. A. Smith, *Imagining the Kingdom: How Worship Works* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2013); James K. A. Smith, *Awaiting the King: Reforming Public Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2017).

Recent books on missional spirituality could be read considering the spiritual formation of leaders in light of the temptations of Christ and the spiritual battle for the heart of the leader.⁷⁸⁶ This could be done in conjunction with James K.A. Smith's work on how thick liturgical practices reshape the desires of leaders and leaders' identity and telos toward God and his kingdom.⁷⁸⁷

Finally, there could be a richer development of how positive mimesis works in the church regarding belonging and community and mission and movement. Gossip and slander signal early stages of scapegoating, which may be why Paul has the harsh recommendation of removing from fellowship those who stir up division after warning them twice (Titus 3:10-11). Understanding mimetic theory and the art of forgiveness in Christian community holds much promise. And looking further at how positive mimesis impacts discipleship and the multiplication of healthy leaders for mission and movement would be beneficial.

Final Remarks

The rich insights gained through these years of study have been a significant help for me personally and for the ministry God has given me. The hope is that both an academic and popular level book will be published based on this research for the health of the leader, and the flourishing of the church for the sake of the world.

The greater hope is that this research would stimulate more writing in the field of missiology which develops this imitation-based framework to help prevent fallen leadership and promote positive mimesis for discipleship, community, mission and movement. As scholars take on the work regarding the suggested directions for further study, the church can become a greater sign, foretaste, and instrument of the kingdom.⁷⁸⁸ As Newbigin writes:

I have come to feel that the primary reality of which we have to take account in seeking for a Christian impact on public life is the Christian congregation. How is it possible that the gospel should be credible, that people should come to believe that the power which has the last word in human affairs is represented by a man hanging on a cross?

⁷⁸⁶ Helland and Hjalmarson, *Missional Spirituality*; Zscheile, *Cultivating Sent Communities*; Fitch, *Faithful Presence*; Finn and Whitfield, *Spirituality for the Sent*.

⁷⁸⁷ Smith, *Desiring the Kingdom*; Smith, *Imagining the Kingdom (Cultural Liturgies)*; Smith, *Awaiting the King*.

⁷⁸⁸ Lesslie Newbigin, *The Open Secret: An Introduction to the Theology of Mission*, Revised edition. (Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing, 1995), 125.

I am suggesting that the only answer, the only hermeneutic of the gospel, is a congregation of men and women who believe it and live by it.⁷⁸⁹

Because redeemed leadership does not come about just by information, but by formation, it seems fitting to end this thesis with a prayer for leaders and the congregations which they serve.

Father,

We yearn to be the church you want us to become. Shape us into something beautiful. We recognize that you are the Potter and we are the clay. Please continue to mould us into the image of Christ.

We want to join in what you are already doing in the world. In our worship and life together, in our ministry and service to others, we want to give people a glimpse of your intentions for the whole world.

Help us to welcome the outcasts, love our enemies, and form a community that is visibly different from the culture around us as a sign of what you are doing in the world.

Help us experience your love and grace, grow in our relationship with Jesus, and experience the power of your Spirit as we offer your good news to others.

In Jesus' name, we pray, Amen.⁷⁹⁰

⁷⁸⁹ Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*, 227.

⁷⁹⁰ Source unknown.

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